Long Ago and Far Away

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/63184246.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

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Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Missing Persons, Shadow Weaver's A+ Parenting, Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Post-Season/Series 05, Implied/Referenced Self-Harm, Interrogation, Torture

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Long Ago and Far Away

by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

It's two years since the fall of Prime and Catra is finally settling into a great life with Adora. Then Lonnie shows up one day to announce something that she's found in the old Horde files. Where Catra comes from.

Based on a drawing by phixie: https://kirazvasili.tumblr.com/post/756827952858251264/catra-and-her-mom-by-phixie

Chapter 1: Chapter One - Catra

Chapter Summary

Catra gets a visit.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra would always remember the day. It was spring in Bright Moon, the war had been over for a little over two years, and she was still as in love with Adora as she had been that fateful day they'd saved the universe with a kiss. She'd been walking back from an appointment with her Listener, feeling a bit introspective as she always did after a long session of working through her trauma but feeling good. She had just got in line at a street vendor in the Bright Moon town square to get herself a cinnamon roll as well as a couple for Adora when she saw Lonnie fast walking down the lane.

"There you are," she said, a bit out of breath. "I got to talk to you."

Catra was smiling but the look on Lonnie's face made it slowly fade as she said, "What about?"

"It's… it's private," Lonnie said.

"No secrets," Catra said. "Come on."

"No, it's not like that," Lonnie replied. "It's… it's not some big secret I just think you should know this and…"

Catra looked at Lonnie, normally so confident in her new position over the remains of the Horde as she helped wind it all down and

help the old troops into a new life, and realized something had her shaken up.

"Alright, but you owe me a roll and you get to tell Adora she's not getting one today."

Lonnie just nodded quickly and Catra got out of the line and followed her over to a little bench sitting off by itself under an arbor full of blooming flowers. Catra sat down but Lonnie still stood, shifting her feet nervously.

"OK, you gotta sit down, please," Catra said. "I don't like you looming over me like that."

Lonnie cracked a smile as she said, "Ah, you said please. Still surprised you don't burst into flames when you do."

"This is what I gave up my cinnamon roll for?" Catra said and Lonnie's smile disappeared as she remembered why she was there.

She sat down next to Catra and pulled a data pad out of her backpack. It was a newer model with the mini-cupcake logo of Dryl on the back and Lonnie fiddled with it for a moment as she said, "OK, so you know we've been digitizing all the old Horde records, right?" Catra nodded as Lonnie didn't pause and kept going. "Well, we've managed to get most of them done but there were gaps in some of them, mostly personnel records, and we've been scouring the place trying to make sure they didn't end up shoved into some back room or something."

Catra held still, wondering where this was all going, as Lonnie pulled something up on her data pad and then turned it so she was sure Catra couldn't see the screen.

"So, what's the big deal?" Catra said.

"We found something about you."

Catra wasn't sure what Lonnie could have possibly have found that could have been worse then what was publicly known. After the war, there'd been lots of investigations and such to make sure that people got the help they needed and atoned for the damage they'd done. Catra had originally been shielded from that but had insisted on her turn when it became obvious that Adora was shielding her. It'd been one of their only really ugly fights after they'd got together but it'd worked out in the end.

"OK, so what's the big deal?" Catra said. "I can't think of anything that'd be so much more awful then what's known."

"It's… shit," Lonnie said as she shifted a little on the bench. "It's not that. It's your personnel record. It didn't really record anything until you were almost a teenager. We found the rest hidden in Shadow Weaver's room and… I… just look I guess."

Lonnie held her data pad out but Catra leaned back like she was being offered rotted meat.

"What is it?"

"It's your mother."

Catra froze. She felt like everything around her was suddenly dimmed except for the held out data pad. She swallowed hard as she stammered out, "My… my mother?"

"Yeah, I've read the file," Lonnie said. "It's… can you just read it? Please?"

Catra reached out, her hand heavy, and took the data pad from Lonnie's hand. She stared at the screen and saw the boilerplate style of just about every Horde file she'd ever seen. There was a photo of her standing up against a gray background at the top but the photo wasn't the one she'd seen in her file before. This one was her as a young child, probably not much older than three or four. Her eyes skipped over the parts at the top recording her height, weight, eye color, and such and skimmed over the part about her being inducted into a cadet creche as well as aptitude

scores. As she scrolled down, a picture came into view of a woman that Catra mistook as herself for a moment until she realized this woman was older then she was at the moment. Then she saw the little kid standing beside her and realized what she was looking at. Catra felt her hands shaking a little as she looked up at Lonnie.

"Her name was Saz," Lonnie said. "It's further down. Shadow Weaver seemed to have kept her own records."

Catra waited for a second and then scrolled down a little more. The boilerplate was gone now and there was text she could tell was written by Shadow Weaver. She couldn't say how, it was typed after all, but just the way it read she could almost hear Shadow Weaver's voice in her head. Catra shook her head and shoved the data pad back at Lonnie.

"Why would you show me this?" Catra hissed as she felt her heart thudding in her chest.

"Because you should know," Lonnie said. "Don't get pissy at me over this, I'm just the messenger."

Catra felt the anger boiling up in her and could feel herself turning to scream at Lonnie when she sank her claws into the wood of the bench and started counting quietly to herself. Lonnie sat and waited. It wasn't the first time she'd seen the reaction from Catra and knew to wait it out. After a moment, Catra relaxed her grip on the bench, the soft sounds of splintering wood the only noise between them, and Catra looked up at the sky for a moment.

"You read the whole thing?" Catra finally said.

"Yep," Lonnie said.

"Is she still alive?" Catra said.

"I don't know," Lonnie said. "Her HID is in the packet Shadow Weaver had but we can't really find much of anything with it,

paper or computerized. Her main file might still be somewhere but, well, she's kind of a ghost in the files."

Catra nodded a little as she thought for a moment about the Horde Identifier Designation number every Horde member had received.

"They're sequential," Catra said. "Did you look on either side of it?"

"Yeah," Lonnie said. "There's missing records on either side so I don't know if it was accident or intentional."

"What do you think?" Catra said, finally looking at Lonnie, her voice sardonic.

"I mean, it's possible," Lonnie said, her voice matching Catra's tone. "I've seen weirder things diving through these records."

Catra snorted as she took a deep breath to fight back the tightness in her chest that threatened to burst out of her eyes.

"She erased it," Catra said. "Why else would she be keeping a private file?"

"I haven't put her on the List yet," Lonnie said. The official name was Missing and Unaccounted for Horde Personnel List but everyone just called it the List and it had the names of ex-Horde soldiers that hadn't been found yet. It wasn't long anymore but the few left on it were considered renegades by people and at least one had already tried to start the war over, though it had only been with a few people and hadn't lasted long. "I can make this disappear if you want."

Catra looked away for a moment before shaking her head.

"No. You've got a job to do."

"Hey, you're an asshole but you're still a friend," Lonnie said. "I don't mind."

Catra gave a little mirthless chuckle as she said, "Yeah, you're an asshole too but thanks, I don't want that."

"Tell you what, I'll hold it for two days. Before you say anything, that's not bending anything, but that'll give you time to talk to Adora about it."

Catra sat and stared out from behind the arbor. A group of kids were playing some kind of hide and seek and tag game through the square, dodging around adults as they did. A few of the adults shouted at them but most of the adults just gave a little head shake and smile as the kids played. Several adults even got into the spirit and shouted out where a kid might be trying to hide, causing shrieks and laughter to ring out. Catra thought about what happened when they'd ever played like that in the Horde and the tears finally came, slow and quiet but they came.

"You… you alright?" Lonnie said, still not used to seeing such naked emotion from Catra.

"Could you… shit, never mind," Catra said, wiping at her eyes.

"No, say it," Lonnie said. "What?"

"Could you… walk me home?" Catra finally said after a long pause.

Lonnie almost made a crack at her about it and then cut herself off as she said, "Sure. Want to get those rolls first?"

"No," Catra said. "Get me the fuck out of here before I break down in public."

Lonnie nodded and the two started walking at a brisk pace out of the square. They followed the path that led away from the square, through the town and then through the trees towards the castle. There wasn't a lot of foot traffic that time of day and Catra was glad because she was having a hard time to hold it together. They stopped at the front to speak to the guards for a moment and asked to have them find Adora and have her come to the room

where Catra and Adora stayed before they went on When they got in the room, Catra flopped down onto a beanbag chair, letting out a long sigh.

"Do you want me to stay?" Lonnie asked.

Catra shook her head but then started nodding before she shook her head again.

"No, no, it's alright. I just need to get Adora here."

Lonnie sat down at a table as she said, "You know this isn't my first time through this."

"I know," Catra said as she wiped at tears. "I just… shit, I don't want to talk about it alright? This isn't like when Rogelio found his parents."

"Yeah, it is," Lonnie said.

"No, it's not," Catra said, sitting up, her voice going hard. "Because he was taken from them when he was too young to remember."

"So?" Lonnie said and was about to go on when Catra interrupted her.

"You said she had a HID," Catra said.

"Yeah," Lonnie said.

"Then that means she was in the Horde. She was a grown adult in the Horde."

Lonnie started to talk and then stopped.

"Yeah, you see it now," Catra said. "How do I know she didn't leave me there?"

"You can't know that," Lonnie said.

"Maybe that's why she didn't leave any information behind."

"Come on, you don't know that's what happened. You're making stuff up now."

Catra flopped back into the beanbag chair with a huff as she said, "Why didn't she come back then?"

Lonnie started to say something when she realized that Catra didn't want a back and forth and shut her mouth. She got up and went to the small kitchen in the room and rummaged around for a moment before coming up with a fluorescent blue fizzy drink.

"You want one?" she said.

"I want something stronger," Catra said.

"It's fizzy drink or nothing," Lonnie said.

"Fine," Catra said. "Strawberry."

Lonnie nodded, grabbed a bottle, and brought it over. Catra twisted the top off and took a long drink of it before huddling in on herself a little.

"I said you don't have to stay."

"And yet here I am," Lonnie said as she sat back at the table.

"I don't need a fucking babysitter," Catra said, her ears laying back a little.

"I'm not babysitting you," Lonnie said. "I'm taking my break from work."

Catra shook her head and just took another drink.

About twenty minutes later, Adora came hustling into the room. She tossed her jacket aside, a green one custom made by the Bright Moon castle tailors for her, and looked around. She saw Catra huddled up in the beanbag chair.

"The guard said it was important, what's going on?" Adora said as she beelined for Catra.

"Don't," Catra said, holding her hand up as Adora got down on the beanbag beside her. "It's not that big of a deal."

Adora turned to look at Lonnie who was rolling her eyes.

"I'll tell her if you don't," Lonnie said.

Catra flipped her off as Adora said, "Tell me what?"

"Lonnie found some old file and she's making too big a deal of it," Catra said.

"Seriously?" Lonnie said. "You're going to be a dick now?"

Catra gritted her teeth, her ears flattening back as she said, "It's not a big deal, really."

Adora gently put her hand on Catra's hand and carefully ran her thumb over the top of it as she said, "It's OK. I'm here for you even if it isn't a big deal."

Catra looked at her and felt the tension ease a little. She took a shuddering breath before she said, "Shadow Weaver had some secret files that Lonnie and her crew found. One of them was about…"

Catra trailed off and Adora scooted over a little closer and Catra moved into her open arms. Adora gave her a gentle kiss between her ears and pulled her close.

Catra sighed as she said, "It was about my mother."

Adora waited to see what else Catra was going to say and when nothing came out, she said, "What about her?"

"She was a Horde member," Catra said.

"OK," Adora said. "Did she… did she do something bad?"

Catra looked at Adora like she was an idiot and not the loving one she normally said as she replied, "She abandoned me to the Horde, so yeah, I'd say she did something bad."

"You don't know that," Lonnie said.

"Why else would I be there!?" Catra snapped at Lonnie. "What other reason would she have?"

"Maybe she was… you know…," Adora said before trailing off.

"You can say killed," Catra said. "But that doesn't make sense because her record has been wiped out and the only person who had anything was Shadow Weaver. Probably to hold something over me or tempt me with."

"What did the file say?" Adora said.

Catra looked away from her and took a drink of her fizzy drink. Adora looked over to Lonnie.

"What did it say?"

"The first part was a basic Horde personnel file for Catra…," Lonnie started to say when Catra cut her off.

"Stop," Catra said. "Just fucking stop, alright? I'm done?"

"Are you really done or are you just being pissy because you're pissed off right now?" Lonnie shot back at her. "We didn't fucking do this to you so how about you being a little bit less of an ass right now."

"Hey, don't talk that way to her!" Adora said.

Catra put a hand on Adora's arm as she said, "No, shit, she's right, she's right."

"Of course I am," Lonnie said.

"Don't push it," Catra replied. "OK, give me the data pad. I'm going to read the rest."

"Are you sure?" Adora said.

"No," Catra said as Lonnie walked over and handed the data pad over. "But we've seen what happens when I ignore stuff or try to run away."

Adora hugged her tight as she said, "You can wait you know. You don't have to know this immediately."

Catra hugged her one handed as she looked at the file and then began to scroll. It wasn't long. From what the file said, Saz had joined the Horde with baby Catra at her side. It didn't say much about her, beyond that she said she came from the edge of the Fright Zone where it butted up against Plumeria. The file had a basic personnel file where it described her proficiency in hand-to-hand combat and piloting, that she'd been assigned to a recon squad, and details like her age and birthday. There were a few comments from Shadow Weaver about her that basically commented on the accuracy of the file and how she didn't think that Saz was someone that posed any problems. Then Catra reached the end. Attached to the file was a single memo.

Saz's recon team have gone missing near the pass into the town of Moraine in the Kingdom of Snows. Overflights show no sign of wreckage or any other signs of team. Called off search, assigned child to Adora's creche.

Catra stared at the memo for a long time. The three cold sentences were all there was to detail the death of her mother and the beginning of Catra's long nightmare in the Horde. Adora had been reading over her shoulder and hugged her tight as Lonnie sat at the table, her arms resting on her spread legs.

"That's it?" Catra finally said.

"There's a photo that's not in the main file," Lonnie said. "It's linked down by the metadata at the bottom."

Catra found the link and clicked on it. A photo popped up of Saz laying down in a Horde bunk reading something, a little smile on her lips as she looked back at a young Catra sprawled across Saz's legs laughing. Catra looked at it for a moment, before closing it and squeezing her eyes shut.

"So, I did some digging and I did find a missing recon squad from that time frame," Lonnie finally said after some silence passed. "It was more like a long range scouting and intelligence squad then what you think of as recon."

"Spies in other words," Catra said as she opened her eyes.

"No," Lonnie said. "They had a uniform and everything. They operated well forward of lines for long periods with little operational oversight. They were something Octavia started and from what I read just going over it real quick because of this, they got disbanded after the loss of what I'm assuming is Saz's squad."

"I wonder why?" Adora said.

"That I know," Lonnie said. "Hordak didn't like it. Reading between the lines, he didn't like the individualism of it."

Catra snorted as she said, "Considering what we know now about Prime and that whole thing, I can see why."

"Well, he broke that," Adora said a little defensively. "Have you asked him about it?"

Lonnie shook her head as she said, "No, I just found that, read it, did some quick background reading, and then came here."

"What do we do? Normally, she'd be on the List wouldn't she?" Adora asked.

Lonnie nodded but didn't answer and Catra said, "Put her on there."

The other two got quiet and looked at her and Catra said, "Listen, I know the List is considered to be renegades but it's not. It's supposed to be missing Horde members and it gets broadcast and everything so if someone is just bopping along doing their own thing, they can realize, 'Oh, I guess I should check in.' Right?"

"Well, yeah," Lonnie said. "But everyone has checked in, mostly. It's been two years after all."

"But it's also for those who may have died," Adora said quietly. "So their next of kin or whatever can check in."

Catra was nodding as she said, "That. That's why I want her on it. Maybe someone knows and they'll see it and let us know."

"OK, I can do it right now," Lonnie said. "I'll clip her photo out so it's just a couple of headshots and attach it with basic information. I won't link it to you."

Catra started to open her mouth and then saw the wisdom in it and nodded.

"OK, do it. I need to know."

Chapter End Notes

> "Hey, don't you already have a multi-chapter fic that you're slow on updating?"
>
> Why yes, yes I do. Listen, I just go where the muse leads and this one hit hard. I haven't forgot about my other stuff but damn if I didn't really feel this one. For those wondering, this does not have any attachment to my big multi-series post-season five works. Not much to say on this one except hey, looks like I may be diving back into my early Horde ideas!

Chapter 2: Chapter Two - Saz

Chapter Summary

Saz moves towards an uncertain future, a baby Catra on her hip.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Saz stopped as she looked across the empty wash in the Crimson Waste and cinched the sling holding the tiny kitten on her side a little tighter. The child shifted a little and opened her eyes to look up at her mother. Saz looked down at her with a smile as she quietly said, "Good evening there, Catra. How're you doing?"

Catra gave a little burbling noise and reached her little pawed hand out at Saz who took a moment to play with them.

"We'll make camp soon, I promise," Saz said, thinking of the camp she was running from. She'd been moving almost non-stop for three days now and she knew she had to rest soon, if for Catra's sake if nothing else. She started singing softly to Catra as she looked around once more before moving down the side of the wash and following the dry stream bed up close to the hillside to stay out of sight. After a little bit, Catra slowly drifted off from the gentle sway and Saz stopped singing. She had plenty of experience moving around in the Waste and she wasn't about to attract more attention then she had to. As the sky started to darken, she found a little rock niche in a bend of the wash. After taking careful stock to be sure it wasn't inhabited by anything that stung, bit, stuck, slashed, or poisoned, she moved inside and sat Catra down on the soft sand.

Catra woke up and looked around. The dark hollow reminded her of home and she looked around trying to figure out where

everyone else was at. When she didn't see anyone she started to scrunch her face up in dismay. Saz saw the look on her face and quickly moved to distract her. After a few minutes, Catra had forgotten about her distress and was playing with a soft toy mouse. Saz moved outside and used the short, heavy machete on her hip to cut a few branches from a tree and then gathered up a few armloads of sticks. When she got back to the little niche, she dug up under a rock and built a tiny fire. Then she went outside in the dark to see if she could see any light. When she was sure that even with her eyes there was no light shining to announce their position, she settled down and started warming some water in the coals. Catra was sprawled out on the sling she'd been carried on, watching the soft flickering coals as she sucked a thumb and fiddled with the toy mouse with her other hand.

"Comfy?" Saz said and Catra turned to her mother's voice before turning back to the flickering coals.

Saz started humming a little tune, as she waited for the water to boil. When it finally boiled, she pulled the can out with a bandanna and poured it into a bowl that she'd dumped some dried out food into. She covered it with her the bandanna and then carefully put it under her shoulder bag so it wouldn't lose heat as fast. Then she lay down next to Catra and started talking to her.

"You're probably wondering what's going on aren't you?" Saz said as Catra rolled over to look at her mother. Catra hadn't spoke her first word yet but Saz couldn't help but feel like the tiny child could already understand her. "The tribe… well, I don't know what to say. We had to go and I've heard there's a group of people in a far off place called the Fright Zone that doesn't care about where you're from."

Catra reached forward to bat at her mother's face and Saz smiled as she caught her hand and gave the little fingers on them a kiss a piece. A little claw curled out for a moment as Saz squeezed at the base of a finger and she gave that a kiss as well.

"Don't be scared," Saz said. "It's a scary name but it's not going to be scary. I bet you'll make all kinds of friends and we'll be happy. And if we're not, well, we can always leave. It's just you and me now and I am going to look out for you."

Catra looked at Saz for a long moment and then gave a little sneeze and Saz smiled as she gave a gentle boop on Catra's nose.

"Want some food?"

Catra went back to playing with the toy mouse as Saz sat up and pulled the bowl out. The dried grains and meat in it had turned into a kind of mush but she knew it wasn't something you really ate for gourmet purposes. She'd eaten it plenty when she'd gone hunting or on a raiding party against another Magicat village in the Waste and didn't really pay much attention to it anymore. It was fuel, pure and simple and the only thing she did extra was sprinkle a little salt on it before spooning some up. She gave a spoonful to Catra, who had been eating solids for a couple months at that point. She split the bowl that way, a little for herself, a little more for Catra, until Catra turned her head away. Saz finished the bowl off, leaving a little bit to try with Catra again but she was full and just kind of laying on the side, her tail flicking back and forth.

Saz finished it up, scrubbing the bowl and spoon with sand before drinking a little bit of water and giving some to Catra as well. She didn't like the sound of the water in the bottle, it was sloshing around way too much, showing the bottle was getting empty and she wasn't entirely sure she knew were the next water source was located. She was way off the rudimentary maps that she of and was going on basic knowledge at this point. She thought she'd check the bends of the dry stream bed in the morning and just keep moving. She sprinkled some sand over the coals to keep it from flaring up and settled down beside Catra, pulling her in close. Catra started purring as she kneaded her hands into her mother's arm.

Saz pulled the sling around Catra to keep her warm and soon the child was asleep again. Saz drifted in and out of sleep, her eyes

flickering open at any noise she didn't like. When the sky finally began to lighten again, she wasn't sure how much sleep she'd actually had but she felt better then she had when she'd settled down the night before so she figured it was enough. Catra was fully awake and was all over the little niche, looking under things and even tried to reach into the coals at one point before Saz pulled her hand back with a little frown and a shake of her head as she gently told her no.

Saz spent a little time obliterating what signs there were of them ever being there, burying the fire deep and packing out what little wood was left, and soon they were walking again. Catra hugged her toy mouse close and quietly spoke to it in baby talk as Saz walked, paying attention to everything around her. She avoided the venomous plants and animals almost without thinking, the whole time looking for signs of water. The day got hot and Catra became grumpy from the heat. Saz gave her sips of water and wiped her face as best she could to keep her as comfortable as possible but she knew that she needed to do something soon.

A little after midday, Saz was hunkered down under the shade of a boulder, looking at a bend in the dry stream bed, and saw what looked like signs of water under a sandstone overhang. She'd been watching the area for over an hour at that point, trying to see, if any, animals approached and if anything or anyone was hiding doing the same. Finally, she crept down and under the overhang to find a little quicksand up against the sandstone. She scooped a bit of sand out and watched as clear water filled the cavity before slowing filling with sand as it fell back. She noticed the moss and a few little flowers were growing and after a little sniff of the water, she was sure it wasn't dangerous.

"Look what we found," Saz said softly to Catra.

Catra peeked over the side of the sling as Saz did her best to carve out a little pool of water and fill their water bottles up. Some sand got in that was to be expected and Saz figured she'd filter it out when she got a chance. Once she had the bottles full, she made sure that Catra drank as much as she wanted before Saz

drank her fill. Then she gave Catra a little bit of cracker to chew on as Saz started moving again.

After a few more hours, she started following the sounds of people she'd been hearing faintly and by nightfall, she was standing over the Valley of the Lost, looking for a way down into the hidden town.

Chapter End Notes

> Here we go! If you're wondering, the bit about the Horde being an accepting place is kind of a headcanon I've had and seen floating around as well. If you notice, the Horde has, for lack of a better term, the more monstrous people in the show (Octavia, Cobalt, Hordak himself, etc) and so there's this headcanon that they were kind of a, "We don't give a flip about who you are or where you're from. We'll give you a home."
>
> I worked around with that in my series about Scorpia's granddaughter and I'm going to borrow some of that for here as well. As to what Saz is running from... well, we'll see.

Chapter 3: Chapter Three - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer finds out about Catra's mother, after she gets added to the List, and comes to find out exactly what is going on and what her and Bow can do to help. Though Catra isn't exactly ready to talk about it fully.
>
> Also, I updated the tags to implied/referenced self-harm. It's a single reference of just a couple of lines, it is not graphic, but I did want to call it out.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Why didn't you tell me they found your mother!?" Glimmer shouted as she appeared in Catra and Adora's room.

Catra jumped to her feet, claws coming out, before she took a deep breath. Adora, who'd had Catra kick off of her to get up without thinking, was coughing as she said, "Damn it, Glimmer! Knock!"

"Who told you!?" Catra said as she reached down a hand to Adora before seeing Adora rubbing her leg. "Uh, sorry."

Adora waved a hand at her to dismiss it as Glimmer said, "No one told me but I get annotated copies of the List any time it's been updated. You don't think a Magicat that looks like you suddenly getting added to it doesn't get me wondering?"

"Well, how do you know it's my mother?" Catra asked.

"Other then you shouting, 'Who told you!?' She looks like you!" Glimmer said.

"I was trying to keep it from looking like it was attached to me," Catra said. "Does she really look that much like me?"

"She doesn't look exactly like you," Adora said.

"OK, maybe it's just me but she is your mother, right?" Glimmer said.

"Yeah, she's my mother," Catra said with a sigh. "At least that's what the files say."

Glimmer looked at her for a moment before going over to hug her. Catra stiffened up a little but then hugged her back as Glimmer said, "I guess Lonnie found it?"

"She did," Catra said as she disentangled from Glimmer and went to sit down at a table. "Found some of Shadow Weaver's old files."

"So what are we doing about it?" Glimmer said.

"What do you mean we?" Catra said.

"Oh please, you know that Bow and I are going to be in on this," Glimmer said.

"Well, we're doing what I planned," Catra said. "We'll just wait to see what's going on."

Glimmer looked a bit disturbed for a moment as she said, "Are you really not going to go and look for your mother? I mean if there was a chance that I could find…"

Glimmer cut herself off and looked away from Catra at the same time that Catra was suddenly taking a deep interest in the floor at her feet.

"I'm not… I'm not trying to…" Glimmer said.

"I know," Catra said as she felt Melog start to trot over to them from the little cubby they had in the corner. "It's…. just…"

"Listen, I just want to help," Glimmer said as she watched Melog curl around Catra, their face downcast.

Catra just shook her head as Adora put a hand on Glimmer's shoulder for a moment before passing her on the way to Catra. Melog looked up at Adora with a frown and Adora froze. Catra looked up, saw Melog's reaction, saw Adora's hurt face, and tried to say something.

"Just… I don't… damn it," Catra muttered under her breath. "Why is this so fucking hard!?" She took a deep breath as Melog chirped at her and she ran her hand down the back of their head and finally managed to speak. "I don't want someone by me right now."

Adora nodded, biting back her response.

"Should I come back?" Glimmer said.

Catra shook her head as she gripped her hands in front of her and Adora could see how tightly she as gripping.

"Don't hurt yourself," Adora said softly.

"Claws are in this time," Catra said as her forearms shook a little as her ears folded down.

It was awkward but after a little bit, Melog uncurled a little and Catra took a deep breath and looked around, her face embarrassed.

"Get that look off your face," Glimmer said. "No one feels sorry for you."

"Shut up," Catra said, looking away with a bit of a grin flickering around her mouth. She reached a hand out to Adora and hadn't even got it half way before Adora was sliding in beside her, Melog chirping a little indignantly as they got pushed aside.

"Sorry, Melog," Adora said as she pulled Catra in close.

"OK, so you had a mother," Glimmer said. "What now?"

"Of course I had a mother," Catra said. "Not all of us were hatched from eggs."

"I will never forgive Dad for showing you that baby costume picture," Glimmer said with an eye roll.

"Listen, I sincerely doubt she's still around," Catra said. "Even if she was, I don't think I want to know because damn, it's been two years now. Has she been hiding under a rock?"

"Maybe she has amnesia and she's in a coma and someone will figure it out that you and her are related and then you'll go in and talk to her and your voice will wake her up," Adora said.

Glimmer and Catra both stared at Adora who stared right back.

"What?"

"You're not allowed to read those books Spinne gives you anymore," Glimmer said.

"It's plausible," Adora said with a huff.

"I love you with all my heart," Catra said, "but no, no it is not."

"OK, ignoring Adora's wild imaginings," Glimmer said, ignoring Adora sticking her tongue out at her, "if you don't want to find her, why did you let Lonnie put her on the List?"

Catra picked at her arm for a second before saying, "Because she's a missing Horde soldier, just like all the others still on the List. Need to know what happened."

Glimmer sighed before saying, "You are so full of it. Seriously, why?"

"It's been like twenty years since she disappeared, someone who actually knows her probably wants to know," Catra said.

Glimmer made a gesture like a blabbering mouth with her hand before saying, "Come on! I might not have known you as long as Adora but I can still tell when you're lying!"

"No you can't!" Catra said.

"I can," Adora said as she leaned over to look at Catra. "Care to tell me why you are?"

"I'm not lying, alright!?" Catra said, her tail flicking in irritation. "I'm just not… I'm just not saying everything, OK? And I don't want to talk about it and I want you to lay off."

Glimmer sat on the floor beside the two of them as she said, "Was that so hard? Using your big girl words?"

"Fuck you," Catra said as she looked away but didn't flinch away when Glimmer patted her ankle a little.

"Let's be honest," Adora said as she hugged Catra a little tighter. "It's been a long time and Shadow Weaver went out of her way to hide it, you're right, nothing is probably going to come of it."

"Is that really you trying to be comforting?" Glimmer said with a sigh.

"Well, it worked," Catra said as she cuddled into Adora's side a little.

"You two, I swear," Glimmer said with a laugh. There was a little break in the talk for a minute and then the three started talking about something else. Bow joined them, Melog bouncing across the room to rub against his legs before following him over to the pillow pit that everyone had moved into.

"You know, I had to finish the rest of your work," Bow said as he slid in beside Glimmer and gave her a kiss.

"You love that stuff though. It's what makes us a good team," Glimmer said.

"Yeah, well, your Dad had to help me."

"Bonding time!" Glimmer said.

"Stop using that excuse," Bow said as he nuzzled at Glimmer's ear and she laughed and pushed him away.

"Could you two get a room?" Catra said.

"We're in a room," Bow said.

"One that I'm not in," Catra said.

Glimmer reached her leg out to push against Catra how shoved her leg away as Glimmer said, "At least you learned to knock."

"I do not want to talk about that again," Catra said.

"OK, change of subject," Bow said, as he felt his face get hot, "do you need some help with the… you know… the List thing?"

Catra rolled her eyes as she said, "Can we not rehash this!?"

"Sorry! I just… I saw it, and just… I wanted to ask you," Bow said.

Catra was quiet for a moment and Bow looked away in embarrassment before Catra finally said, "Listen, there's nothing I want to do, alright?" She paused for a moment before she went on. "I do kind of wonder what she was like, you know, what the whole thing was about… OK, just… just let it go."

Bow looked back as he said, "If you say so."

"I did."

"OK."

"Just let it go!"

"I didn't say anything."

Catra growled a little before she said, "What is it with you!? I want to see her! Is that what you want to hear!?"

"I said I was going to let it go," Bow said.

Catra buried her face in her hands as she muttered something as Adora said, "No one thinks that."

"Shut up," Catra said.

Glimmer just leaned back in Bow's lap as she grinned and said, "Look at you sharing your feelings. Like a Bright Mooner."

Catra snapped her head up as she said, "You take that back."

"Sorry. Not like a Bright Mooner. I should have said… like a princess," Glimmer said.

"That does it!" Catra said as she launched herself at Glimmer, who teleported to the other side of the pillow pit. Catra corrected and launched herself again as Adora and Bow started to shout as the pillows got kicked around and Glimmer grabbed Catra and tried to put her in an arm lock. Catra countered and it quickly devolved into light slapping as the two laughed and finally settled down.

"I can never tell when you two are serious," Bow said as he tossed pillows back in place.

"Well, nothing is on fire or collapsing, so it's not serious," Catra said as Glimmer gave her a little push as Catra went on. "And I guess you do know me a bit better then I'll admit."

Chapter End Notes

> I'm having a ball writing them as young again. I've written the BFS as older adults for so long, it's fun to have them being goofy again.

Chapter 4: Chapter Four - Saz

Chapter Summary

> Saz walks into the Valley of the Lost, ready to take the next step that's needed to keep Catra safe.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Tegris had seen a lot of people walk into the little Horde recruiting station on the outskirts of the Valley of the Lost. Some were hard cases, some were trying to find something new or just different enough from their mundane, and some were on the last leg of a hopeless life but hadn't quite faced that reality yet. Tegris had to admit though, that out of all of those people who came to enlist, they'd never, ever seen someone walk in with a baby in a sling. That was part of an already crowded field of things that Tegrisw was noticing, the other striking one being the look on the Magicat's face, filled with exhaustion but with eyes that still seemed to drink in every little detail. The clothes she wore and gear she carried said deep desert Magicat, which is why they weren't surprised when they caught a glimpse of a dagger in the small of her back when she turned to look over her shoulder briefly before walking up to the table under the flapping canvas awning.

"You recruit for the Horde?" Saz said, taking a moment to speak carefully as she worked to talk in the common language from Bright Moon, a second language for her that she didn't know well.

Tegris nodded as they responded in Magicat.

"I am. Are you… are you looking to sign up?"

Saz let out a little sigh of relief. The person at the table spoke Magicat with a weird inflection but she nodded and responded.

"I am. She comes with me."

Saz lifted Catra up a little, who peered out over the top of the sling at Tegris, fascinated with their pebbly, scaled skin with swirling green and blue colors.

"You know, you… um… you wouldn't be able to…," Tegris said and actually found themselves shrinking back a little at the slight scowl that started on Saz's lips.

"She comes with me."

"Oh, no, it's not that she can't," Tegris said, holding up a hand. "It's just, children generally go into a creche. They have their own education and training."

"You separate them from their parents?" Saz said, her fur bristling a little.

"No, it's not like that," Tegris said. "The Horde takes in a lot of orphans. It's part of the outreach we do. The people who have kids still see them, it's just they spend a lot more time in the creche. One of our main officers, Shadow Weaver, has a baby she looks after and even she spends most of her time in the creche!"

The last part was said at a high speed as Saz stepped a little closer to Tegris but then they calmed down a little when Saz finally sat her bag down and took a seat.

"I'll spend time with her," Saz said, nodding at Catra who was chewing on the toy mouse. "That is not negotiable."

"Of course not," Tegris said. "Wouldn't think of it."

"If anything happens to me…," Saz started to say and then cut herself off.

"The Horde takes care of its own," Tegris said gently. "That includes her."

Saz reached in to gently boop Catra's nose for a moment. Catra batted at her mother's hand and giggled. Saz played with Catra for a moment, not looking at Tegris, as she said, "What do I need to do?"

"To sign up?" Tegris asked to be answered by Saz's brief glance of irritation and Tegris nodded quickly as he went on. "Oh, of course sign up. Well, there's some paperwork, and we'll do a medical check, and of course one for your daughter, and then some questions and tests about what you know and then we'll get you squared away with training and stuff and get you transported to the Fright Zone. Is that alright?"

Saz sat for a moment. Catra had taken her finger and was gnawing at it but it was a gentle playing bite and didn't bother Saz. She wondered if maybe she should go back, that maybe things had cooled down but she stiffed a sigh. She knew what she had done and she didn't regret it but she did at the same time. Catra deserved to grow up with her people but she wouldn't ever get a chance because of what Saz had done and so she'd have to find new people.

"I accept, I accept, I accept," Saz said, looking at Tegris.

Tegris nodded. They'd heard Magicats agree to a deal before and the triple response was part of it.

"Let's get started then," Tegris said as the pulled out the necessary paperwork and started asking questions.

That night, Saz lay in the narrow bed that she'd been given in the little building that Tegris called home and office. The room was small and narrow but it didn't bother Saz. Catra was curled up next to her on the bed, her purrs having faded out as she went to sleep. Catra hadn't like the minor stick of her finger for the blood draw, and had almost drawn her own blood when she'd lashed out

at the healer who'd done it, but Saz had been there to keep her calm. The healer hadn't liked that Saz had laughed at Catra's reaction but she'd rather her daughter be fierce then timid and it was another sign she had that she'd be just that in life. Catra could always be taught restraint Saz figured and besides, she thought, she was still young, she didn't understand getting poked and prodded.

The next morning, Saz did some more tests, some of which included things like running and other physical measurements, and she felt confident enough with Tegris that she'd leave Catra with them while she did them, though she made sure she was always close enough to hear any distress. She struggled a bit when it came some more of the written tests, because they were in Bright Moon's language, but Tegris insisted that at least while they were working, they speak and write in Bright Moon because it was the language all the Horde spoke in common. She was given regular meals, though Tegris warned her that the Horde ate much simpler food then they were eating.

"Food is food," Saz said with a shrug.

"True," Tegris said. "Though the ration bars aren't what I'd call food but it does cover all the essentials."

Saz just gave a nod as she fed Catra, who was sitting on top of the table. Catra turned to Tegris and said something.

"Is she not talking yet?" Tegris said.

"Of course she is. You just heard her," Saz said.

"I mean…, never mind," Tegris said.

After a moment, Saz shrugged as she said, "It takes some time, and either she will or she won't."

Tegris grinned as they said, "That's true. She's certainly curious."

Tegris nodded as she watched Catra pick up a little box full of matches and give it a shake. Saz watched her with a little smile as she said, "She's a good kid."

Tegris didn't say anything as they both watched Catra figure out the clasp of the box and then accidentally dump all the matches across her lap and table. Saz laughed a little at Catra's surprised face and then started showing her how to get the matches back in the box.

"You're doing this for her, aren't you?" Tegris finally worked up the nerve to say.

It was the first time that Tegris had asked the question. There hadn't been any questions about why someone would want to join the Horde but Tegris was usually curious, though they didn't usually get a chance to ask. They thought that maybe Saz wouldn't answer and at first she didn't as she focused on helping Catra pick up a match. Finally though she looked up and answered.

"Yes."

Tegris waited but no other response came and Saz went back to picking up matches.

Chapter End Notes

> OK, so I finally said that Bright Moon is the common language of the planet and that there are others, though I don't really ever show them in my fics (except for Spacebat). As I said before, this isn't connected to my other series so I can do things here that would contradict my "canon" in others but this is something that's headcanon for me. Bright Moon is the main language of the planet and it's because of something I've hinted at before, that Bright Moon used to be a very expansionist kingdom. In other words, Glimmer's ancestors weren't always sweet and kind and there's a reason that the only queen is in Bright Moon.

I know I've said before that I'm not a huge world builder. The whole, "You better be able to explain why coffee is in a story" premise is one I don't really truck with. That being said I do actually kind of like it in a way and that way is how it works with my stories here. It can best be summed up as, "Well, crap, I need to have an idea of how this works." Then I make something up, shake it a little to be sure it doesn't rattle too loudly, and then put it in. The best world building advice I saw was having two levels of detail for something and I do like doing that for the most part. So in this case, the first level of detail is that the language of Bright Moon is the common language of Etheria. The second level is that it's because Bright Moon was expansionist at some point in its past and it got shoved around a lot. You can throw a little more detail in and say that's why, as I said above, there's only one queen and it's in Bright Moon.

When it comes to world building, I also think it's best to not explain it much in the story, if at all. It's fun to talk about in the notes, I'm having a ball right now, but yeah, in the story it bogs it down usually. So in the above, I show that Saz speaks Bright Moon, even though she's a deep desert Magicat who doesn't have much contact with the outside world. Tegris recognizes this, tells her she's going to have to learn to speak it better, and then speaks to her in Magicat. You don't have to know the whole Bright Moon back history that I made up to explain it and honestly, it's not even necessary for me to have made it up but again, that's what I like with my world building. It's fun for me but it's not splattered all over the story.

Anyway, as always, thank you for reading!

Chapter 5: Chapter Five - Catra

Chapter Summary

> It's been a month since Catra put her mother on the Missing and Unaccounted for Horde Personnel List (the List), trying to figure out anything she could and nothing has come in. Now she's sitting around Bright Moon, having a good day, when a little something unexpected happens.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A month had passed since the update to the List had come out and Catra had gone from anxious, to irritated, to bored, and was at the point that she was forgetting about it now occasionally. There'd been some search put into seeing what kind of Magicat community had been in Plumeria at the time, but the few isolated communities that lived there had all said they didn't know anything, that their people hadn't been missing and the few who'd gone to the Horde had been long since identified.

There had also been a flurry of tips that came in but Catra had learned long before that this happened on any major update to the List and they were usually pointless. This time had been nothing different. There'd been rumors of her as a smuggler, rumors that she'd led a rebellion band at one point, that she'd been a cage fighter, that she'd become a hermit, but Catra's favorite had been a report that said Saz had been a secret princess of Half Moon. Considering the Half Moon representative had laughed until Catra had worried they'd be sick at the thought of them having a princess, and annoying Perfuma who'd been in attendance for the meeting, Catra knew that little bit of info wasn't leading anywhere even before the Half Moon representative had confirmed that wasn't a thing. Considering the

hidden kingdom, ruled by a small council, hadn't even revealed itself until a few months after the fall of Prime, Catra tended to believe that wasn't her origins.

Catra had talked with her Listener about it all and they'd batted it back and forth together but Catra felt like nothing much had come of it, though her Listener seemed to think otherwise. Now she was waiting in line again for the cinnamon rolls, thinking about how Lonnie had come up to her the month before, and she was doing her best not to look like she was someone who wanted to talk because as she would put it, the average Bright Mooner would talk to a chair if they were bored and she wasn't in a chatting mood. Though she had to admit, as she handed the person at the little window of the bakery a few coins, she felt good. As she walked away she stopped, feeling utterly silly as she did, and acknowledged the good moment like she had told her Listener she would and almost never did.

She sat down under a spreading tree that overlooked the fountain in the center of the Bright Moon square and watched Adora cross the square with Bow at her side, chatting about something. She felt goofy as she waved at the two but she still did and they waved back as they came over and sat down. Catra handed Adora the bag with the rolls in it as she said, "Official time over?"

"Yeah," Adora said as she took a bite of one of the two cinnamon rolls she had in her hand and kept talking around it as she handed the bag to Bow. "You're going to have to be in the next meeting though."

"You're supposed to wait to talk until after you're not eating to speak you know," Catra said. "Were you raised in the Horde or something?"

Adora rolled her eyes at the joke that was rapidly becoming an old joke between them as Bow said, "You do have to be there though. The next meeting is no proxies allowed. They want everyone giving their input on the new draft."

"Noooooo," Catra said as she took the bag from Bow.

"I thought you liked this strategic stuff," Bow said.

"This isn't strategy, it's diplomacy," Catra said with a grunt as she pulled her roll out.

"You're good at it though," Adora said.

"I know I'm good at it," Catra said. "I'm good at strategy and I'm good at tactics and I'm also good at sitting around the house and sketching stuff. Guess which one is more fun?"

"Well, you still gotta be there," Bow said with a smile.

"OK, but I'm going to be a complete pain in the ass about it," Catra said.

"What's new?" Bow and Adora both said at the same time before bursting out into laughter.

"Sure, mock poor little me," Catra said with a roll of her eyes. Then she noticed someone standing over by the little cafe on the other side of the square, staring at her. The person didn't look particularly happy, but they didn't look particularly mad either and it wasn't the first time that Catra had someone stare hard at her like this person was doing. It wasn't even the first time that day if Catra was being honest but she kept her face neutral as she spoke. "Adora, cafe by the entrance post, lizardfolk with the green and blue skin, we know them?"

Catra had to give Adora credit, she was actually subtle about looking as she replied, "Nope, don't know them. They kinda look like they're from the Waste, might be a tourist."

Bow was looking between the two as he said, "Everything alright?"

Catra grinned as she said, "Just someone overcome with my magnificence."

"You're in a good mood today," Adora said with a laugh.

"Well, you're here," Catra said with a sappy smile before she looked back over and saw the lizardfolk going into the cafe. "They're going in. Probably looking at the king here anyway."

She nudged Bow with her shoulder as Bow rolled his eyes and said, "We're not married, I'm not the king."

"Consort I believe is the correct term," Adora said and Bow laughed.

"Hey, I like consort," Bow said.

"So does Glimmer," Adora said.

"No, she loves me," Bow said with a goofy grin.

"She really does," Adora said with an answering grin.

"OK, can we not get all gooey?" Catra said.

"And there goes the unusual mood," Bow said with a laugh.

Catra tried to look put out but ended up laughing as well. Later that evening, the three of them, along with Glimmer, were sitting in the Bright Moon Cafe in a little side nook, talking about the day, things they'd read or seen lately, and just generally having a good time as the serving staff checked in on them periodically.

"So I hear you're going to have to go in on the Charter discussions," Glimmer said to Catra. "Can't keep giving Adora your proxy."

"Yes," Catra said with as much drama as she could muster.

"What are you complaining about?" Glimmer said. "The last time you were in one, we got a ton moved forward. You're good at this!"

"Because I don't want to deal with it," Catra said. "So I just bust my ass to get things moving so I can go back to not dealing with it."

"If you just put in some time, we could probably wrap it up," Glimmer said.

"I will overthrow your government before I sit in that long," Catra said as she took a long drink of cream soda in front of her.

"Hard to take you seriously with cream all over your lip," Glimmer said with a laugh as Catra grabbed a napkin and wiped her mouth.

"Hey, I can still overthrow you and have my soda," she said and then noticed the lizardfolk from earlier sitting in the middle of the room and trying not to look at them. "Adora, that person from earlier, the lizardfolk? They're in the room."

Everyone at the table turned to look at the person before turning back.

"Think they're dangerous?" Bow said.

"One way to find out," Catra said as she drained her glass and stood up. Adora was right behind her and Glimmer and Bow were on their feet following as Catra walked over and plopped herself down at the person's table.

"OK, I saw you looking at me earlier and I saw you doing the same just a second ago so you better start answering right now or it's going to be ugly."

That's what she wanted to say but she realized as she sat down, they weren't in the Waste, the person hadn't actually done anything except look at four of the most famous people on Etheria, and she realized she was going to look like an utter ass if she didn't recover quickly.

"Um, hey, what's up?"

Catra tripped on the landing as it were.

The person looked at her and then at Adora, Glimmer, and Bow standing awkwardly around and smiled a little.

"I'm not quite as subtle as I thought, I guess," Tegris said. "Uh, I'm not quite sure what to say to you."

"If I did you wrong, listen, um… I'm sorry," Catra said, shifting a little in her seat as she managed to spit out the sorry. "We can try and talk it out."

"It's not like that," Tegris said as they shifted awkwardly themself. "Um, my name is Tegris and I saw the recent List update and… well, I know about your mother."

Chapter End Notes

Damn, I love cliffhangers. Well, when I write them at least. The plot thickens, like a fine gravy. :)

Chapter 6: Chapter Six - Saz

Chapter Summary

Saz waits in Plumeria with toddler Catra, ready to move on to the Horde.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The trip from the Crimson Waste to the Fright Zone took way longer than it should. Before she'd left, Saz had been told by Tegris that since most of Etheria thought that the Waste was empty, that it'd be necessary to craft a story about where she was from and that meant entering from a different area and not telling her fellow Horde soldiers about where she was from. She hadn't had an issue with that, she wasn't going to make friends she told herself, but it'd required Saz to sit on the edge of Plumeria, feeling twitchy with the towering trees around her. Cliff walls, like the ones her former home had been built into, that she was used to towering over her. Boulders were another. Even a few different cactus species loomed but they didn't generally do it in a blanket that blotted out the sky a hundred feet or more over her head. The only trees she was used to that were any kind of height were breakwood trees that grew tall around desert water sources and their leaves changed to a beautiful golden color while their trunks and branches changed a beautiful silver color in autumn but they were weak wood that made poor firewood and only middling lumber.

She was thinking of that now, waiting on the transporation that was supposed to carry her and Catra into the Fright Zone and finally report for duty after two weeks of moving around. She looked up yet again at the branch over her head, feeling a little twitchy about it since breakwood wasn't the safest tree to sit

under but whatever this tree was didn't show any indication of being a problem. Catra sat on the ground, the toy mouse forgotten for the moment as she tried to stalk a bird that sat on the edge of the small clearing they were in. The bird knew she was there, knew Saz was there, and didn't seem to care either way as Catra slowly crept across the clearing with her tiny tail sticking straight up as she tried to be sneaky.

Saz held still and Catra froze as the bird looked at her. Then slowly she shifted a little in the grass, back and forth, before making a pounce. The bird squawked loudly at her before exploding off the ground in a rush of feathers to land on a branch twenty feet off the ground before squawking down again. Catra for her part landed and then immediately came stumbling across the clearing, bawling from the scare of the squawk. Saz picked her up and held her close as she said, "It's alright, you did very well, that's just a crafty bird. Did you want to eat that bird? Did you want to eat it all up?"

Catra's crying ended quickly as Saz cradled her and she looked back up at the bird, it's red and green feathers standing out against the purple of the tree's foliage. The bird squawked again and Catra gave a little hiss at it before cuddling back up against Saz.

"You tell that bird," Saz said as she ran her hand over Catra's head and tickled at her ears, causing them to flick as Catra batted at her mother's hand.

A few minutes later, a Horde soldier in full armor came to the edge of the clearing.

"Saz?"

Saz nodded as she said, "Irtram?"

The soldier shook his head as he said, "Who's Irtram? I'm Harold."

Saz gave a little grin. She'd known the name but wanted to be sure.

"Must be mistaken. You're taking me?"

Harold nodded as he said, "I am. Let's not hang around. Plumeria doesn't really care about us but that doesn't mean they want us running around in plain sight."

Saz swung Catra up on to her shoulders and grabbed the rest of her stuff and followed Harold. The flight on the skiff was exciting at first, the ground rushing past under them thrilling for both her and Catra, but after a little bit, it lost it's luster. Soon, they were flying into a place that reminded Saz a bit of the Crimson Waste, if the Crimson Waste had been covered with busted up old machinery.

As they came in to a landing, Saz saw a stout woman with tentacles standing beside the landing pad. Saz hopped down as she came walking over.

"Recruit Saz, I'm Force Captain Octavia," she said. "Tegris had good things to say about you."

Saz nodded at Octavia as she said a bit hesitantly in Bright Moon, "I'm just doing what I can."

Octavia looked at a file in her hand as she said, "Well, it's good, what you can as you put it. Also, I know you haven't gone through the training yet, but you should know that it's proper to address someone of my rank as Force Captain and to salute when you see them for the first time."

Saz just looked at Octavia for a moment and felt Catra growl a little at the woman.

"Did you understand me?"

"I think so," Saz said.

"You think so what?" Octavia said.

Saz just looked at her before shrugging, a movement she found covered most bases normally.

Octavia's tentacles on the side of her face twitched a little before she said, "Pay attention in training. If you don't understand because of the language, ask."

Again, Saz just shrugged but threw in a nod this time as well.

"Let me show you to your bunk," Octavia said. "We'll need to get your kid into the creche as well."

"She stays with me tonight," Saz said.

"That's not how we…," Octavia started to say and Saz gave a short growl that she cut off.

"She stays with me tonight. It's a new place," Saz replied.

"OK, for tonight though," Octavia said. "I know Tegris explained how we do things here."

"And I explained that I would not just give her up," Saz said. "This is for her."

Octavia grunted and just started walking, giving a hand wave to follow along.

The room that Octavia brought her into was full of people and for a moment Saz hesitated. There were various different kinds of people present and the feathers, scales, skin, and mushroom that was on display was more than Saz had ever seen.

"Sgt. Kedgeree!" Octavia said as she went in.

A woman with fins along the side of her head and iridescent scales came over and gave a salute.

"Force Captain!"

Octavia gave a little grin as she said, "This is Recruit Saz. She's been assigned to you. Get her squared away. The kid stays tonight only."

Kedgeree saluted again and Octavia handed her a sheet of paper before leaving. The rest of the room had quieted down a little and were looking at Saz and Catra as Kedgeree looked them both over.

"Where you from?" she asked.

"Plumeria," Saz said, the lie that'd been worked out.

"What part?"

"Plumeria," Saz said, giving a little growl.

"Hey, it's alright, just asking," Kedgeree said, holding her hands up. "OK, you're bunking with Aleph squad there. Corporal Kit will get you squared away. Any questions?"

"No."

Kedgeree waited but finally just nodded at the flat no and said, "OK, head on over."

Saz walked over to the back corner of the room where an empty bunk sat. A squat woman was waiting by the bunk, the gills under the mushroom cap that was the top of her head shifting a little as she nodded at Saz.

"I'm Kit," she said, holding a hand out. Saz just looked at her.

"Magicats don't shake hands, genius," one of the other squad members said to Kit.

"That true?" Kit said as she retracted her hand.

Saz just nodded as Catra looked around from her perch on top of her mother's shoulders.

"OK," Kit said, pointing at the bunk and the foot locker at the end of it. "These are yours. You gotta keep it properly made and we do inspections at least once a week. Do you know what a chain of command is?"

Saz reached up to touch Catra for a moment as she said, "No."

"It's how it works around here," Kit says. "You got something you need done or a question or whatever, you start with your squad and me, then Kedgeree over there, and then so on. You gotta get permission to go up each level. Works in reverse too. Lord Hordak wants something, he tells the Force Captains, who tell the other officers, who tell people like Kedgeree, who tell me, then I tell you. Got it?"

Saz thought for a second and saw the logic before nodding.

"I do."

"OK, just don't make trouble, you'll be fine. Go ahead and get your stuff put away," Kit said before turning to the squad member who'd told her about Magicats not shaking hands. "And Trooper Basco, since you know so much, I'm assigning Recruit Saz as your partner. Now how about shaking out and getting Recruit Saz her kit?"

Basco rolled her eyes as she said, "Come on, Supply isn't going to have that ready and it'll take forever, especially since they're going to shut down for normal requests in just an hour so you know they'll be pissed if I show up now. Let's do it tomorrow."

Kit grinned as she said, "Nope, Saz needs it now, better get to it or they'll be even more pissed if you show up just minutes before they shut down for the day."

Basco grunted again but she rolled off her bunk, twisting in mid-air and thumping to her feet. She gave a sarcastic salute to Kit and went out the door. Kit introduced her to the other squad member, a little satyr named Snick.

"Pleased," Snick said with a little curtsy, made much easier by their goat legs. "Who's the darling sitting on your shoulders?"

"My daughter," Saz replied.

Snick gave a little wave and Catra pulled behind Saz's head and gave a little rumbling growl.

"She's a fireball, I see," Snick said with a smile. "Heard she's staying with us for the evening. Worried about the creche?"

"She stays with me," Saz said.

Snick nodded as they said, "It's not bad. I have two little ones in there myself. It's tough but they get taught well."

Saz narrowed her eyes as she said, "You have kids?"

"Two," Snick said. "Well, they're Scorpioni kids that were orphaned after the fall of the king but I took them in and when we joined the Horde, along they came. They're pretty grown up now, teenagers, but they'll always be my little bugs to me. She'll cry and fret the first time you drop her off but I promise, she'll get used to it and it's not like you won't ever see her."

Saz didn't say anything and Kit looked between the two before saying, "How about you unpack for now?"

Saz nodded and opened the footlocker. There wasn't much to unpack and after a little bit, she was sitting in the corner next to the bed, playing with Catra. Snick sat across from her and watched, a little smile on their face but not saying anything. Basco came back with her arms full of gear and dumped it onto Saz's bed. She flopped down beside it as Catra crawled over and began to grab at the wrapped packages, her ears faced fully forward at the sound of the rustling paper wrappers.

"OK, Class-A uniform shirts, Class-A uniform pants, Class-A uniform jackets, same in field shirts, pants, and jackets, boots, socks, more socks, even more socks, trust me, you'll want plenty

of socks, get more if you can manage it, underwear, long underwear, shelter half, armor unitard, you wear that under the armor to keep it from chafing, and it does, you'll find out when you get it, belts, webgear…," Basco said, tossing each item to the end of the bed as she went along. Then the two began to unpack, Catra batting at the paper and skittering through it as it fell to the floor. Snick threw a ball of paper and Catra pounced on it before batting it back to Snick to throw again. Even Kit sat down and began to chat with them and Saz felt herself relax, just a little.

Later that evening, after Basco helped Saz reorganize the footlocker so all the new stuff fit along with the things Saz had brought, they'd all settled down and started talking. More to the point, the other three had chatted and Saz had mostly listened but she'd learned a little bit about the people in the Horde and a little bit about her squadmates. It hadn't lasted long as others in the room started settling down and soon Saz was in bed. The bed was hard and reminded her of sleeping out in the desert, sitting on a rock to take advantage of its warmth from the daytime in the frigid night air but it didn't bother her. Catra had curled up in front of her and was sleeping soundly as Saz finally drifted off in the dark of the room, lit only by a few dim red lights.

Saz woke from a dream of sharp teeth in shadows and clawed hands reaching for Catra. She reached out for Catra without even realizing it at first and found nothing. She sat up, looking around the room, her eyes showing everything in sharp detail even in the low light and she didn't see any sign that Catra was there. She felt the bed and the warmth told her that Catra couldn't have possibly have been gone for long. She was quickly on her feet as her nose sampled the air to see if she could catch any sign and immediately followed the faint smell of her daughter out into the hall. She didn't go far though, when she heard a voice and then Catra's confused little meow and Saz was suddenly running down the hall.

Chapter End Notes

I'm updating this one pretty quickly because I'm updating with a new chapter when I finish another chapter. I currently

have three chapters written and in a buffer while I work on the fourth so even if I slip and hit a road block, I can just go to a week at a time update schedule. It's kind of fun, I haven't written like this in a while, where it comes fairly easily and I'm really into the story. Not that I don't enjoy my other stuff but this feels a bit different. Anyway, thank you for reading and I hope you enjoy this update!

Chapter 7: Chapter Seven - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra sits down to talk with the person who says they knew her mother only to find out that things are never that easy.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra sat frozen before she suddenly said, "You knew her!?"

"OK, maybe not knew her," Tegris said. "One of my parents, I'm named for them actually, used to talk about you all the time. Said they were the one who inducted your mother into the Horde and used to talk about how they knew you when you were just an infant. So, well, I came here."

Glimmer, Bow, and Adora all looked at each other for a moment before they looked at Tegris but Catra didn't look around at all, just leaned over the table, laser focused on Tegris.

"What do you know? Where is your parent?"

Tegris' face sagged a little as they said, "I'm sorry, I… I don't know a lot, I was going to check in at the castle tomorrow and report what little I know and Zizi… they didn't make it past Prime's occupation."

Catra slammed her fist into the table, causing the centerpiece and all the little bottles of condiments to jump. A few fell over and rolled around the table as Catra snapped a hand out and stopped one that was heading for the edge. Tegris looked scared as Catra held a hand up and the rest of the room went silent to look over.

"Sorry, shit, sorry, that's just…," Catra said before taking a deep breath and looking around at the room staring at her. "Damn it."

Adora stepped up behind Catra and had a hand on her shoulder before the bottles stopped wobbling. Catra reached up and put her free hand on it as she took a few deep breaths.

"It's something she's working on," Adora said gently to Tegris but loud enough the room could hear. Everyone nodded and went back to their conversations.

"I understand," Tegris said, even though they still looked like they wanted to run. "Um, maybe I can get us something to drink? Or do you want some food?"

Bow smiled at him as he said, "It's alright. Let me go grab someone and I'll get us some snacky stuff. Allergies? Preferences?"

Tegris just shook their head as Bow started off. He gave Glimmer a look and a little sideways head nod. She just gave a little go ahead hand wave and Bow walked over, put his hand in hers and said, "I may need some help, Your Majesty."

"Fine," Glimmer said with a little grunt before following him.

"Were you a Horde member?" Adora said as she sat down.

Tegris shook their head.

"No. Zizi wasn't really either. Well, I think, I don't know, they were a recruiter but I'm not even sure if they were on the Horde's roster. I've never seen their name on the List as far as I know and I didn't know if that's because they didn't, you know, make it or not and just didn't want to say anything. Then I saw Saz and remembered them talking about her and of course, I know about you Force Captain, so… here I am."

Catra did her best not to score the table with her claws as she said, "Don't call me Force Captain. Ever. Just call me my name."

Tegris looked down at her hand clenched tight as they said, "Sorry."

"It's alright," Catra said, her voice still tight. "You didn't know. What did they have to say about her?"

"How it was kind of wild that she had showed up with basically an infant, though they did say you were probably about one years old or so, and she was very insistent that you were to come with her. Said she tested out pretty high on a lot of the stuff the Horde tested for and… I'm not sure what else," Tegris said.

"Where was she from?" Catra said.

Tegris frowned as they said, "That they never said. They didn't talk a lot about that part before they met Mom. We were from Plumeria but Zizi moved us around a lot because, um, well, you all."

Tegris nodded at Bow and Glimmer who'd come back and were sitting down and had heard the last little bit.

"What do you mean?" Bow said.

"Zizi worked for the Horde, how ever that might have been, and we were moving around a lot to stay out of the fighting and away from the Rebellion, er, I mean the Princess Alliance," Tegris responded.

"You can call it the Rebellion," Glimmer said. "I always kind of liked that name."

"Anyway," Adora said before looking at Catra. "The report did say that she came from Plumeria. That must have been where Tegris met her and you."

Catra thought for a moment, her ears flicking before looking up.

"Do you know anyone else who did recruiting like they did?"

Tegris shook their head.

"No. I'm barely eighteen now. It's not like Zizi brought work friends home or anything."

Catra huffed as she sat back.

"I'm sorry, I know it's not much," Tegris said, pausing a moment before going on. "I probably shouldn't have come."

Bow reached over and patted their hand as he said, "No, you did the right thing. Anything is helpful."

Tegris gave him a hesitant smile as Catra sat up a little and said, "Yeah, OK, what he said."

A massive tray full of sweets, veggies, fruit, and assorted other delicacies got put on the table, along with assorted dipping sauces both hot and chilled and other condiments as Bow turned to the server who'd lugged it out and said, "Thanks, Quokka."

The small man twitched his nose at Bow as he said, "Anytime. I'll swing by in a bit."

Tegris' eyes bulged out a little at the massive amounts of food as Catra said, "What did you order, Bow!?"

"The Ultra-Mega Sample Platter," Bow said. "Though they um, added on extra stuff and renamed it."

Adora, who was busy pulling little bits and pieces off the tray onto a plate in front of her, said, "Seriously? What's it called now?"

Glimmer, trying not to laugh, said, "The Adora Special."

Catra burst out laughing at the expression on Adora's face as she was halfway through pushing a crescent roll into her mouth. Bow grinned awkwardly as he nodded his head in agreement and even Tegris managed to break a smile. Adora stopped for a second

before inhaling the crescent roll and responding with, "I guess I'm honored."

Catra gave a little smile and looked at the ceiling for a moment before sitting back up straight.

"OK, listen, I want to ask you some more questions but I just… I don't even know where to start, and maybe now isn't the time," Catra said. "So eat up, but we're not talking about this right now."

Tegris nodded as they stood up and said, "It's alright. I'm going to go on, I'll be in touch and really, I'm sorry."

"It's not your fault," Catra said.

"Do you have a place to stay tonight?" Bow asked.

"Uh, I was going to the hostel," Tegris said.

"Nonsense," Bow said. "Head on up to the castle and tell them I said to put you up in a guest suite. They'll take care of you."

Tegris' mouth fell open a little as they said, "Uh, what?"

"We've got plenty of room," Bow said as Glimmer looked at him with a little smile. "Don't worry about it."

"I… no…," Tegris said.

"Save yourself the hassle and just say yes," Glimmer said. "He's going to be hospitable and he's relentless about it."

Tegris cleared their throat, tried to say something, failed, and then finally just nodded before leaving the cafe.

"You alright?" Bow said to Catra after Tegris was out the door.

Catra was pushing a little bit of cheese around her plate as she sighed and shook her head as she said, "I don't even know anymore. They just were like, 'Oh hey, I know this thing but I don't really know this thing because it was my parent and not me

but they're gone now and I'm going to be really cryptic and useless!' Damn it and of course I'm going to talk to them again and it'll probably just be more of the same!"

"Maybe they'll be helpful," Adora replied. "You did kind of catch them by surprise."

"At least you didn't grab them because you really looked like you were going to grab them and shake them at first," Glimmer said.

"I was not! I just didn't think it through," Catra said, muttering the last part.

"Story of our lives," Adora said.

"No, story of yours," Catra said. "I actually know how to plan things."

Bow shook his head as he said, "No, you don't and neither do you two before you say anything. I'm shocked I don't have gray hair."

"Babe, you're barely in your twenties," Glimmer said.

"The point stands."

"Screw it, I'm not worrying about this all night," Catra said. "Give me that slice of cake there. I'm going to drown my woes."

"They have something stronger you know," Glimmer said.

"And I said the cake," Catra said. "Now come on or it's overthrow time."

Glimmer rolled her eyes as she handed over the little slice of cake as she said, "You can't say that about everything."

Chapter End Notes

> You know, I'm nonbinary, came out a few years ago, and I still learn new things. Like this one. I had no idea what the nonbinary version of mom or dad would be and of course,

there's a million and one options. So WikiHow came in clutch for me and had a list of suggestions and I really liked Zizi. It's got a great mouth feel.

Chapter 8: Chapter Eight - Saz

Chapter Summary

Saz finds Catra in the halls of the Fright Zone and is confronted with some uncomfortable truths.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Saz came around the corner to find Catra sitting in the middle of the corridor, staring at a little blonde girl in front of her who didn't look much older than Catra.

"Kitty? Play?"

Catra turned her head sideways, confused, and backed up a little when the little girl started forward towards her.

"Mouse?" the little girl said, pointing at the toy Catra clutched in her hand. Catra looked down at the mouse and held it closer, her eyes narrowing. The little girl noticed Saz looming in the hallway and backed up a step before waving at her timidly. Saz found herself waving back and then suddenly snapped her eyes up when she saw a dark figure glide out of a side corridor, the mask on the woman's face and the freely floating hair not doing anything to make her presence less ominous.

"Adora, what are you doing out of your bed!?"

Adora jumped a little and turned. Saz couldn't help but notice the fear on Adora's face as the other woman glided up to Adora and then looked at Saz.

"Who are you?"

"Recruit Saz," she replied, doing her best not to snap it out. She was pretty sure that this was the person named Shadow Weaver that Tegris had mentioned, that her squad had told her aboutwhen they were chatting earlier in the evening, and while she didn't seem to be have a rank, Saz knew she was definitely one of the highest authorities in the Horde and her squad had spoken of her with nervous laughter that overlaid real fear.

"Is that yours?" Shadow Weaver replied, pointing at Catra who'd scurried back to Saz and was peaking out from behind her legs.

"She's my daughter," Saz said. It was silent for a moment before she nodded at Adora. "Is she your daughter?"

"Certainly not. She is a foundling and a willful child, doing her best to ignore what mentorship I try and give her," Shadow Weaver replied. "Her creche notified me she was not in bed and I have come out to find her. Why isn't your child in the creche?"

Saz didn't respond, just scooped Catra up off the floor, when Shadow Weaver said, "Recruit, that wasn't curiosity, that was a direct question. Since your hearing doesn't seem to work, I will repeat myself. Why isn't your child there?"

"She hasn't been assigned to one yet," Saz said, trying to think of how to get out of the situation without answering more.

"See to it tomorrow," Shadow Weaver said. "Or I'll speak to Sgt. Kedgeree myself. I will not have your child distracting Adora."

"She wasn't doing that," Saz snapped back. "She's just curious."

Shadow Weaver loomed forward a little over Saz as she said, "I am a superior officer of the Horde and a sorcerer of Mystacor. Do not speak to me in that tone, Recruit, do you understand me?"

Saz just nodded and managed to get out a yes. Shadow Weaver stared hard at her for another moment with Adora peaking out from around her skirts looking at Saz and Catra before turning and gliding off down the hall almost dragging Adora with her.

Catra gave out a little hiss towards where Shadow Weaver had disappeared as Saz gave her a little hug and started back towards the dorm.

"You can't just go taking off like that," Saz said gently. "It's nighttime. That's when we sleep, I know you know this."

Catra looked at her before giving a little yawn that Saz swore was faked but it just drew a little smile from her.

"Yes, you're very convincing," Saz said as she entered the dorm. "Now hush."

Basco was awake when Saz got back to the bunk and was leaning over as she whispered, "Where did you go?"

"That's not your business," Saz whispered back.

"Listen, we're partners so yes, it is my business," Basco said. "I can get in trouble for something you do just like you can with me. This might be new to you but I know how this goes and so I'm asking."

Saz sat on the edge of the bed as she sat Catra down, who circled a few times before settling back on the bunk, and said, "It was nothing. She was restless."

Basco looked at her for a moment before she said, "Why would you ever bring a kid along with you?"

"I have my reasons," Saz said as she sat a hand on Catra who began to purr gently.

"I'm not pushing, just…, I don't know, it's not easy here sometimes," Basco replied. "It's definitely not going to be any easier with a kid along."

Saz didn't take her eyes off of Catra as the purring faded as Catra slipped back to sleep.

"It wasn't any easier where we came from."

"Must be a shitty place."

It took Saz a minute to understand the obscenity before she solemnly nodded and said, "It was a shitty place." Basco stifled a chuckle and Saz looked up at her. "What?"

"Nothing, just the way you said that," Basco said. "See you in the morning."

Basco rolled back from the edge of the bed and Saz heard her breathing go slow and deep after a few minutes. Saz curled around Catra and for the first time felt tears prick her eyes. She was beginning to think maybe she'd screwed up. It would have been easier to just have gone along with what the village had wanted, what the peace treaty had demanded, but she'd seen how that'd turned out before and she'd always swore that if it'd been her child, she'd not have stood for it. Then they'd drawn lots and it'd been her child that'd be given up to keep the peace and she'd run.

She thought of what Basco had said, about maybe the concept of being held responsible for other's actions was a new thing to her but it wasn't. She knew what it meant to be held responsible for things she hadn't even done but were still expected to deal with, just because of her name or her village. Growing up, she'd felt tied to her friends and family because of that, knowing that no matter what happened to her, someone would have her back. She remembered the first time she'd gone on a retaliation raid against another Magicat community and how the older people on the raid had sat down before and talked it out, how they'd made sure she got to have a say, how they'd been sure to acknowledge her fears and been sure she'd been properly kitted out when they'd left, and when they'd come back, triumphant, how much closer she'd felt with everyone at the celebration, how the canyon had felt like it rang extra loud with her shouts of triumph and joy. Looking back now in the dark on the hard bunk, she saw it was the closest she'd ever felt to her family and friends and she just knew she

wouldn't feel that again. She tried to stay quiet with her crying and was sure she was, until she saw Basco's hand drop down and drop a bandanna to her without a word.

Saz stifled the crying then, wiped her eyes with the bandanna, and pulled Catra a little closer in. Then she saw Basco's hand drop down again, give a little thumbs up before disappearing, and Saz felt a little less alone in her self-imposed exile.

Chapter End Notes

> Not much to say here but at least we got a little bit more of why Saz is doing what she's doing.

Chapter 9: Chapter Nine - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora have a heart to heart about the past and the present and how one runs into the other.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra sat close to the fireplace in the small living room in Bright Moon castle, the light from the fireplace the only light in the room as the curtains were drawn closed to keep out the light of the Etherian night. Melog lay curled up at her feet as she ran her hand down their back.

"No, it's alright," Catra said in response to the question Melog had asked. "You got your own life to deal with and I'm doing better. I don't need you by my side all the time."

Melog gave a little chirping reply and Catra gave a little humorless huff of a chuckle.

"Well, yeah, anything is better then when you met me," Catra replied before looking back into the flames for a moment. After a pause she said very quietly, "You know… thank you. For everything. I just… I know I've said it before but really…"

She trailed off and Melog looked up for a moment before silently nudging her with their muzzle. Catra put her arms around them and held them tight before giving a long contented sigh. Melog nudged her again and Catra smiled.

"Yes, it's melodrama hours," she said to them.

Melog chirped and scooted up beside her before giving a long drawn out sigh as they settled in to soak in the warmth of the fireplace. Adora came in a few minutes later to see Melog and Catra both spread out on the hearth, eyes heavy as they both stared into the fire in the dark room. Two sets of eyes flicked towards the door, both sets giving a brief glow as they reflected the light spilling in from the hallway. Adora smiled as she shut the door. The glowing eyes didn't bother her, she'd grown up with Catra after all, but she still remembered the first time Bow had seen them like that. It'd been on Mara's ship Darla late at night shortly after the war. They'd been in orbit for a short weekend, the other princesses on board as well, and Catra had been in the refrigerator getting a snack. She'd just shut the refrigerator when Bow had come in and all Bow had seen were Catra's eyes in the pitch black of the kitchen reflecting the hallway light. Bow's scream had woke up every person on board.

"What are you smiling about?" Catra said, her voice sleepy.

"Thinking about that time on Darla when you scared Bow with your eyes," Adora said as she went over to sit down beside Catra.

Catra chuckled as she scooted over a little so her head was in Adora's lap and then went back to staring into the flickering coals as Melog rolled a little, yawned, and flicked a paw for a moment. Adora gently stroked the top of Catra's head, watching her ears flick when Adora touched the tips of them, and for a moment, it was peaceful. Then Adora saw Melog stick their head up, shift a little until they took up a little less space, and before Catra could say anything Adora said, "What's on your mind?"

"You know I hate when you use Melog like a barometer of my mood," Catra said.

"I'm not guessing your mood but I figured maybe you had something to say."

Catra grunted and rolled over so she was looking up at Adora.

"Just this Tegris thing. I don't know, something feels weird about it all."

"Sure you're not projecting?"

"Can we not with that?"

Catra looked away in irritation as Adora grimaced as she said, "Sorry, but I mean, are you? The whole thing is weird. You never really talked about your mother before, I mean, neither one of us had one but…"

Catra's ears flicked a little as she said, "I know, you used to make up stories about yours all the time, I haven't forgot."

"And you always said it was stupid," Adora said.

"It was," Catra said as she looked away from Adora. "I still did it though."

The last bit was muttered but Adora still heard her and cupped the side of Catra's face.

"I remember you did say something once or twice," Adora said.

"Stupid kid stuff," Catra muttered.

"We were stupid kids," Adora said with a laugh. "Remember that ration bar eating contest?"

"That everyone lost because no one wanted to 'win' that one?" Catra said with a smile. "Yeah, poor Kyle. He won by default and what a prize. Remember Doc saying she'd never seen someone so constipated before?"

Adora laughed as she replied, "We should ask Kyle about that." Then her laughter died and she shook her head. "Then again, maybe not."

Catra's smile disappeared as she said, "Yeah, probably not." The two were quiet for a moment before Catra went on. "You ever notice, when we tell stories from when we were kids now…"

"How Glimmer and Bow look horrified half the time, even though they try and hide it?" Adora said.

"Yeah," Catra said.

Adora nodded as she said, "When I first came here, that happened but I didn't notice at first."

"When did you really start noticing?" Catra said.

"When we were together again," Adora said, hugging her. "I didn't talk much about, well, before, when it was just me."

Catra nodded, remembering sitting up late into the night after the fall of Prime, really catching up, and how it felt like a minefield if there were other princesses there because a simple story could draw horrified looks and comments. The two lapsed into silence as Melog curled up close to the two.

There was a little crackle from the coals and Catra suddenly said, "I used to think my mother was this brave person who fell fighting off a bunch of people to try and save me and my other mother and that's why I was there, because they were both gone and no one knew to come get me. I used to think maybe that she had been badly injured but she'd get healed up and she'd track me down, rescue me, take me away but that little dream died young and the thought that she was dead, that was the comforting one, because then it explained why she didn't show up." Catra sat there, gritting her teeth before she finally spat the rest out like rotted meat. "I didn't ever think she'd fucking join the Horde voluntarily and drag me along, not once, not one fucking time, in all the little dreams I had she never did that because even when I was young, I could see how fucked up the whole thing was after all. So why couldn't she see it?"

Adora couldn't speak because she'd never seen it either, even when it was happening to Catra, not until it was slammed in her face and she tried to swallow and found a lump in her throat.

Catra sat up out of her lap and stalked over to the window, peaking outside for a moment, the colors of the aurora washing over her before she slapped the curtains back into place and leaned forward, her head on the thick fabric up against the window. She stood that way as Melog trotted over to her and sat by her side. She reached down and rested her hand on their head and then stayed still. Adora couldn't think what to say as she felt her hands start to shake a little bit. She got to her feet and took a tentative step towards Catra before stopping, unsure of what to do.

"I hear you moving," Catra said, her voice muffled by the fabric.

"I just…," Adora said, stopping, trying to think of what to say.

"What?" Catra said, turning around.

"Do you still… are you still, you know, mad, about me not…," Adora said before stuttering to a halt.

Catra frowned as she said, "I kinda am, yeah, but fuck, if I'm going to be mad about all of that… I don't know."

Adora hugged herself tight as she looked at the floor and Catra did the same, neither one realizing they were mirroring the other's actions. Melog looked from one to the other before creeping over to Adora and nudging her leg. Adora looked away for a moment before kneeling down and hugging Melog tight. Catra's tail flicked back and forth for a moment before she walked over, slowly, carefully, and knelt down beside the two. Adora reached an arm out and Catra folded into it.

"I'm sorry I didn't see it sooner," Adora whispered.

"It's in the past," Catra said. "It's done. Just… don't… you won't leave me like that again… will you?"

Adora shook her head as she swallowed down the lump in her throat before she managed to croak out, "No, I promise."

"You promise," Catra said, a little rueful smile on her face. "Heard that before."

"You have," Adora said. "I mean it though."

"You do, I know you do," Catra said as she gave Adora a kiss before sprawling out on the floor. "Can we not do this every other day?"

Adora sprawled out beside her as Melog nudged themself up under Adora's arm.

"We don't do this every other day. Just when we get horrible revelations about our past."

"Which is every other day," Catra snorted as she wiped at her eyes.

Adora scooted up beside Catra and put her head on Catra's shoulder as Melog re-positioned next to Catra. Catra wrapped her arm around Adora and stared at the ceiling.

"I sent Lonnie a message about Tegris," Catra said after they'd been lying on the ground for a few minutes in silence.

"What'd she say?" Adora said as she reached up to pick at thread sticking out of a button on Catra's shirt.

"Nothing yet," Catra said. "It's after hours, she probably won't see it until tomorrow at the earliest."

"You think anything will come of it?" Adora said.

"No."

"You saying no because you really think that or because you're being pessimistic?" Adora asked.

"Can't it be both?" Catra said as she reached up and ran her fingers through Adora's hair.

"Seriously, do you really think anything will come of it?" Adora said.

"I am serious," Catra said. "Tegris is a kid. I don't think their half remembered ramblings from their zizi is going to make any difference."

"You never know," Adora said. "Weirder things have happened."

"Yeah, but we shouldn't talk about Kyle's love life like that."

Adora burst out laughing, causing Melog to jump and then let out the noise that passed for a laugh from them as Catra laughed along.

Chapter End Notes

> I mentioned on Tumblr when I was writing this that you start writing about their childhoods, thinking it's all fun and games, and then suddenly it's all ANGST. Because this was supposed to move the plot a bit more than it did but I got into their relationship instead. Which I don't mind. It's nice.

Chapter 10: Chapter Ten - Saz

Chapter Summary

Saz works to try and fit in at the Horde.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It'd been a month since Saz had moved into the Fright Zone. It'd been two weeks since she'd finally been directly ordered in a way she couldn't ignore to have Catra put in a creche. She'd almost run then. She'd been packing quietly on the last night she had Catra in the bunk with her when Basco had leaned over the side of the bunk.

"The Horde hunts down deserters."

The words were quiet, as Basco had learned that Saz had excellent hearing, and so Saz had almost pretended she didn't hear any of it.

"I'll lead the search if you run," Basco said. "I'll have to or they'll assume I helped."

"I'll leave a note that you didn't," Saz finally said.

Basco rolled her eyes and rolled off the bunk, dropping to her feet, and crouching down to wave her fingers at Catra who was watching her from the bunk.

"Listen, it's not like you'll never see her," Basco said. "And you signed a commitment after all. Put in your time and then head on if that's such a big thing."

Saz almost growled. It was the same thing her sister had said to Saz when she'd talked about not letting Catra go. Two days later had found Saz on the run.

"I was told…," Saz started to say and then realized how stupid she'd sound and cut herself off.

"Told what?"

"Nothing."

Saz picked up her dagger off the bottom of her footlocker and pulled the blade out. The steel had a dull gray patina on it but the edge, millimeters wide, shone from where she'd sharpened it.

"If you're going to use that, I'm going to at least get enough screaming in that you'll never get away," Basco said.

Saz grunted in disgust.

"If it was you, I'd use my claws," Saz said as she re-sheathed the dagger and slipped it into her waistband for the moment. She had grown to respect Basco a little over the previous weeks, enough she wouldn't have stabbed her, though nothing like that was the plan. She didn't bother to explain to Basco that claws were only reserved for respected enemies, at least where she came from, because it wasn't something she would have even thought to explain. "I respect you enough for that but it's no matter because I'm not going to hurt you."

Basco blinked for a moment before shaking her head.

"Thanks, I guess."

"You're welcome," Saz said, completely sincere.

Basco watched as Saz finished her packing and then just sat on the edge of the bunk for minute. Catra sat very still, something with the furtiveness of Saz telling her quiet was needed.

"Stop watching me," Saz said.

"I'm telling you, this is a bad idea. Unpack, really, it'll be alright," Basco said. "It's not like you're never going to see her you know."

Saz reached over and ran her hand down Catra's head between her ears. Catra gave a little purr and scooted over closer to her mother and curled beside her. Saz looked at her and let out a long sigh.

"I'm doing this for her," Saz said.

"Running? You think she wants to run all the time?" Basco said.

Saz looked up at her as she said, "I want her to find a place."

"This can be one," Basco said. "It sucks sometimes but you know, you just got to serve out your term. You'll probably even like it. Pretty much everyone stays on after all."

Saz shook her head as she said, "I've made a mistake, coming here, leaving, and…"

She didn't finish her sentence and Basco finally said, "Then you don't want to make another one and run off. Why did you leave wherever it was?"

Saz gave a chopped off snarl and then quickly looked around to be sure no one had woke up to the noise before she said, "People wanted to take her from me."

Basco waited for more and then gave a little nod as she saw the parallels.

"And now you think they're doing the same here."

Saz hadn't but she looked up at Basco as the realization came to her.

"Yes."

"But you had to know what you were joining, right? If we have to roll against the Rebellion, you can't take her into a battle."

Saz didn't like it but she nodded in agreement.

Basco went on as she said, "So you know she has to stay somewhere. Better to get her used to it now, right?"

Saz didn't even nod. She looked at Basco for a long moment before looking down at Catra, who'd gone still and was breathing slowly. Saz shifted a little and Catra's eyes snapped open, taking in her mother and Basco for a moment before closing again. Saz continued to stare at Catra for a few more heartbeats before looking up at Basco.

"Will you…," Saz started to say before trailing off. She hated herself right then as she tried to ask what she had to ask.

"Nothing is going to happen to you," Basco said, guessing what Saz was trying to say. "But yes, I'll look out for her and I'll help you."

Saz's ears flattened back, hating that Basco had guessed what she was thinking.

"Swear it."

"Sure, I swear it."

Saz let out a long sigh and turned to unpacking and then both her and Basco held still for a moment as a quiet voice from the bunk across the way spoke up.

"Glad you two worked that out so we can get some sleep," Snick said.

Saz and Basco both turned to see Snick and Kit were watching them from their bunks. They quickly looked around but everyone else still seemed to be asleep.

"Go back to sleep," Saz hissed quietly.

Snick grinned and gave a thumbs up before closing their eyes and pretended to softly snore. Kit gave a muffled laugh but rolled over and pulled her blanket around her shoulders. Basco helped Saz unpack before squeezing her shoulder, feeling the Magicat's shoulders tense up for a moment before relaxing, and hopping up back up into her bunk. Saz stretched out beside Catra, thinking about what Basco had said and how the other squad members had heard what was happening but stayed silent until things had been decided instead of shouting out that something strange was going on. She flicked a few looks at where Snick and Kit were, just across the aisle between bunks, and noticed they had both gone to sleep. Shortly after that, she was asleep as well beside Catra.

Morning dawned and Catra went to the creche but she didn't go alone or just with Saz. The whole squad went along to check her in, Snick making funny faces at her while Basco stood beside Saz to give her support and Kit, as the squad's corporal, dealt with the creche worker to get it squared away that Saz would be visiting frequently.

Finally, she'd put her into the creche, hugging her tight before giving her a kiss on the forehead and softly telling her in Magicat to be strong and brave and that Saz would see her soon. Catra had seemed to understand and looked around at the other children, most not much older then her, who were all looking at her with interest before looking back at Saz and hugging her again.

Saz had left her there playing with her toy mouse and refused to cry in front of her squad mates, though she'd had to stop at a bathroom for a little bit and noises had come out of it that the other three had pretended not to hear and never brought up with her.

When she went that night, there was a bit of an argument about how she wasn't supposed to actually take her out every night but

a little growling had fixed that bit. The creche worker had mentioned that Catra seemed inquisitive, intelligent, but that she didn't exactly get along well with the others. Saz hadn't minded that and as she'd walked back to her dorm with her squad, she'd cradled Catra in an arm and tickled her stomach as she complimented Catra on her little Horde uniform that matched the one Saz was wearing. And so the next two weeks went past as Saz went through Horde training, finding she was excellent at some tasks, such as fighting and navigation, but woefully behind on others such as technical skills. Snick helped her with that, the little satyr a whiz at such things, and Kit and Basco helped her with other areas she was lacking in. At the end of the month, Saz felt like she was already fitting in and the morning creche visit no longer hurt, and the few times she'd had to do night training and Catra had spent the night in the creche hadn't been too bad.

So at the end of the month, when Kedgeree walked up and called the squadron room to attention, Saz didn't think anything of it. Then Kedgeree had called out in a strong voice, "Recruit Saz! Front and center!"

Saz wasn't sure what was going on but she bristled a little, her ears flattening back just a little, as a thousand scenarios flashed through her mind. She walked forward though and snapped off a salute to Kedgeree. Saz still couldn't quite read Kedgeree's expression and she didn't know if it was the scales, the eyes that rarely blinked, or just her overall attitude but she still stood still.

"Recruit Saz has been with us for a month now! She's been a bit of a handful as Aleph Squad can attest I'm sure."

Kit, Basco, and Snick gave a curt shout and Saz was pretty sure she could tell they were goofing off but still she didn't move, waiting for the rebuke.

"However, she's had excellent results even so and Lord Hordak has noticed!"

The room went even quiet at the mention of the shadowy leader of the Horde and Saz felt herself straighten up a little, quelling any tremor that tried to shake loose.

"Lord Hordak has sent down a commendation for Aleph Squad with how well they've brought their new recruit along," Kedgeree said as she reached into her pocket and came out with new rank insignia. "He has also seen fit to reward Recruit Saz with a promotion ahead of schedule. Trooper Saz, congratulations!"

Kedgeree handed Saz her new insignia, shook her hand, and then had her turn as the whole squadron cheered her. The rest of Aleph Squad came up the aisle to pat her on the back and give her hugs and for a moment, Saz felt aglow, like she was back home at a village fete being cheered for some successful raid. It was then, surrounded by her new friends and being cheered by her squadron-mates, that the doubts she'd been having slipped away a little and she grinned.

Chapter End Notes

I came up with the claw thing only for respected enemies and of course, I immediately thought of all the times Catra fought Adora with her claws. Then I immediately bummed myself out because Catra would be too young to have known that, since she doesn't remember Saz as I mentioned, and which is just one more example of how she's been cut off from her culture.

Chapter 11: Chapter Eleven - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra gets an early morning visitor and then goes to talk with Tegris about what they might remember about their parents and possibly Catra's mother.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra woke up, blinking a little as she wondered why someone was was knocking on the door so early. She rolled over to ask Adora to get the door but she wasn't in bed and looking around the room, she was nowhere to be found. Catra looked at the clock and realized that while it was early for her, Adora was still sticking to her old Horde upbringing and was getting up at ridiculous hours. She'd been slipping over the previous few months, sleeping in a bit more, but that only got her up and running earlier sometimes from some weird misplaced guilt and Catra figured today was probably one of those days. Catra had no guilt about sleeping in herself but the knocking was insistent and so Catra let loose a long toothy yawn as she stretched and let her claws extend for a brief moment before swinging her legs out of bed as Melog burrowed under the covers.

"Fine, stay there, but I know you'll be out for breakfast."

A little chuffing laugh came out from under the covers as Catra stretched and went towards the door, wondering if Adora had forgot her key again. It seemed unlikely, the lock was almost decoration as far as Catra was concerned and besides the Bright Moon guards could let her in, but she figured if it was the case of forgotten key, Adora may be trying to be subtle and not draw attention to it by getting the guard involved. Of course, that didn't stop her from pounding on the door but Catra knew that Adora's

sense of subtle wasn't exactly in line with others. With that in mind, Catra was surprised to open the door and find Lonnie standing there.

"You trying to knock the door down?" Catra said, stifling a yawn.

"I've been knocking for like five minutes," Lonnie said. "I was past polite knocking like two minutes ago. Sorry to have rousted her highness out of bed but you did send me a message."

"Which you could have answered over the data pad," Catra said as she stepped aside to let Lonnie in. "It wasn't that critical. Definitely not so critical that you had to wake me up."

"Yeah, well, I'm not here just to see your smiling face at this hour," Lonnie said. "You said you met someone named Tegris who said they knew about Saz?"

"Just like it said in the message," Catra said as she sprawled out on a loveseat. Then suddenly she processed what was going on and sat up straight. "Why? What's going on?"

Lonnie turned a lamp on next to the loveseat as she sat down in an overstuffed chair beside it, grumped for a moment as she rearranged it so she could sit in it without disappearing into it, and then said, "OK, so Tegris isn't in any missing soldier files because as far as I can tell, they were never a solider."

"I said that," Catra said.

"Just let me finish. OK, so I did find some references to them in a few spots but as far as I can tell, whoever is here doesn't have the correct story. I don't see any reference to Tegris ever being married, and that's not just in the Horde files, or having kids."

"Not everyone gets married, that doesn't mean crap."

"Just two minutes," Lonnie said, rolling her eyes. "Shut up for two minutes, can you do that? Is that within your power?"

Catra just sat there and stared at her and Lonnie stared back before she said, "Well? Can you?"

"Oh, sorry, thought you wanted me to be quiet."

"How am I still your friend?" Lonnie said.

"Trauma bonding," Catra replied with a grin.

"I see someone is seeing a Listener," Lonnie said.

"I'm not ashamed of it," Catra said.

"No, but you should learn some for other parts of your attitude, now let me finish," Lonnie said and Catra gave a little hand gesture of go ahead. "OK, so I never found anything about them being married, but like I was saying before you interrupted me, that's not necessarily anything. Between file corruption and some people not giving that kind of info, it could still be right, especially since like I said, they didn't belong directly to the Horde, they were more like a contractor and what they did was they recruited people. Now, again, everything you told me says this but what I don't have is that the Horde ever really recruited in Plumeria for any length of time, certainly not long enough to raise a whole freaking family there.

"Now, I have records from way back when the Horde started, right after the whole civil war in the Fright Zone that it was born out of, that shows that they did recruit there but it was really short lived, about a couple of months before they stopped. So this current Tegris is there saying they lived in Plumeria and they're younger than we are and their parent did recruiting there long enough for them to consider that's where they lived? It doesn't add up. They're either full of it or they're up to something."

Catra had gone from casually listening to sitting up to leaning forward with her ears fully forward and her tail twitching as Lonnie went on and she waited a moment before speaking.

"Does it say where they were recruiting?" Catra said.

"It's got a few spots, but the one that seems the most reliable shows they were in Wheatland," Lonnie said, referring to what had been a small town just outside of Plumeria that'd been under Horde control for years. Now, after the war, it was exploding in population and becoming a powerhouse in grains.

"OK, so that's not too far from Plumeria," Catra said, sitting back a little. "And Tegris did say the family moved around some."

"It's horseshit," Lonnie said. "The Horde had a recruiting office there but they didn't have contractors running it or even working it. I've found hints that some of the older Force Commanders used it to run their own private little ops and scams out of though. It also was a supply depot and grew a lot of the grain that got turned into ration bars back at the Fright Zone. So you're looking at a place were you could move money, troops, and equipment around and not have it noticed easily."

Catra was sitting back up again as she said, "So, do you know where the elder Tegris was running around?"

Lonnie grimaced a little and shook her head as she said, "No, but it wouldn't have been Plumeria or anywhere near it. The contractors were usually working independently in out of the way places, like way out of the way places. If I had to guess, the elder Tegris was getting paid through that depot there in Wheatland and was off doing something else that wasn't obvious to the rest of the Horde command."

"Which brings up just how was Shadow Weaver involved with this," Catra said.

"Except, I don't think Shadow Weaver was involved," Lonnie said. "It just doesn't seem to fit. She had her own thing going that was all around the Black Garnet. She wasn't running some partly off-the-books recruiting campaign."

"But you don't know," Catra said.

"No, I don't know but you read enough of these records and you get a feel for stuff. I'm not saying it's entirely ruled out but this doesn't have her oily presence all over it," Lonnie said.

"Fair enough," Catra said. "Do you think you could find out where though?"

"Maybe, but I'd much rather sit down with the younger Tegris," Lonnie said. "Then I can tell if they're full of crap and making stuff up or if they just have a bad memory or something. Then if something passes the sniff test, then I can go digging through all those records. They still here in Bright Moon?"

"I didn't check to see if they made it in last night or not after we met them at the cafe but I assume so," Catra said. "Let me check with the chamberlain real quick."

Catra walked over to the little intercom system and had a brief conversation before coming back to Lonnie.

"They're still here. Got put up in the Royal Suite."

Lonnie gave a little whistle as she thought about the super fancy suite that was usually reserved for visiting off-planet dignitaries.

"Bow going all out there," Lonnie said.

"I don't think that had anything to do with it," Catra said. "Probably just empty and the chamberlain figured why not since it's not going to be used anytime soon. That being said, how about I get dressed and we go have a talk with Tegris before they get the idea to flee?"

Lonnie agreed and as Catra was getting ready, said, "You really think they're up to something shady?"

"No, but you've kind of got the idea in my head now," Catra said as she went into a walk-in closet. "I don't know why they would be though, it just doesn't play out. I mean, are they trying to make friends or something for a scam?"

"No kidding, who'd want to befriend you if it wasn't a scam?" Lonnie said and then dodged the shoe that came flying out of the walk-in closet. "I see your aim hasn't improved since training!"

Another shoe came out. Lonnie caught it and threw it back into the closet.

"Missed again."

"I'm trying to get dressed here!" Catra said, having to shout as her voice was muffled by the plush carpet that lined the closet and, to Catra's eyes at least, the absolutely ludicrous amount of clothes that her and Adora had amassed living in Bright Moon. It didn't help that Bow loved to go clothes shopping and that Glimmer was only slightly less enthusiastic about it as well.

"Then get dressed, Cadet!" Lonnie shouted back. "We don't have all day!"

Catra came walking out of the closet smoothing down a plain brown t-shirt as she said, "I know you did not just call me cadet."

"Got you moving didn't it?" Lonnie said as she fell in step with Catra as she headed for the door.

"No respect for rank," Catra said.

"I have personally seen you chew someone out who kept calling you by your actual former rank," Lonnie said.

"I'm sorry, I should have said class," Catra said as they started down the hall.

Lonnie took in the plain shirt, baggy shorts, and complete lack of shoes that Catra was currently wearing, especially beside Lonnie's fashionable slacks and button up shirt with mirror polished shoes, and said, "Yeah, class, sure. You look like you're heading out to go garden."

"And you look like you're going to an accountant's festival after this," Catra responded. "You get a free Born to Be Mild button with registration?"

Lonnie snorted a little laugh as they passed through a large hall full of castle staff going along a buffet line grabbing breakfast. Lonnie detoured over to a table off to the side and grabbed two oranges and underhanded one to Catra without breaking stride. Catra caught it and extended a claw on her thumb to begin peeling hers.

"I will never, ever get tired of fresh fruit," Lonnie said as she dug a thumbnail into her peel.

"I know what you mean," Catra said, taking a deep whiff of the smell of the orange as she got the peel off in one piece. "I remember the first banquet Adora and I attended here. I was sick for three days after but it was so worth it."

"I remember that!" Lonnie said. "Rogelio and I were both groaning but Kyle was fine. He was sitting there eating greasy fried eggs while Rogelio and I were trying not to murder him for the smell."

"Sure that wasn't the booze being served that night?" Catra said with a grin before popping an orange slice in her mouth.

"Don't make me bring up that time you tried to climb the spire of Dryl after you got into Entrapta's wine cellar," Lonnie said.

"Oh, that was a good day," Catra said as they rounded the corner towards the suite that Tegris was lodged in. They both stopped, leaned against a wall next to a trash receptacle, and finished their oranges. "How do you want to do this?"

Lonnie shrugged and said, "Introduce me as what I am and that we wanted to get this out of the way so they could enjoy their time in Bright Moon."

Catra nodded and went up to the door and rapped her knuckles against it.

"There's a doorbell right there," Lonnie said. Catra said nothing except a shrug.

A couple minutes went past and Catra knocked again. Lonnie sighed and reached over and hit the doorbell as well.

"Well now we just look annoying," Catra said.

"Did it occur to you the door might be too thick? Much like your skull?" Lonnie said. Catra stuck her tongue out just as the door cracked open.

"Uh, hello?" Tegris said and Catra quickly adjusted herself.

"Hey, Tegris, I know it's early but my friend Lonnie here is the head of the effort to get everything wound down with the Horde and she's come out to get a statement from you," Catra said, a little too fast.

Lonnie did her best not to roll her eyes as she said, "It's not a big deal, just want to get some more detail and you're the first reliable person to come forward since we put out the notice on Saz. You mind if we come in for a little bit, ask a few questions?"

Tegris nodded and slowly opened the door.

"Sure, uh, come in, happy to help but I don't think, you know, that it's going to be very helpful."

"Anything added to the file is helpful," Lonnie said with a smile as she walked into the suite with Catra right on her heels.

"I guess sit wherever," Tegris replied as they gestured around the lavishly appointed front room.

"There's a little conference room off to the side here," Catra said as she went to a section of wall and opened a discrete door to a

room that was still nice but more businesslike. "Let's sit in there. I'm still not used to the furniture in this place."

Tegris gave a kind of uncomfortable smile as they said, "I know what you mean. Too soft."

"You get used to it," Catra said as she sat down at an office chair that shifted a little to fit her form. "Well, you try to get used to it."

Tegris sat down across from Catra and Lonnie took the head of the table as she sat down a writing pad. Catra noticed that Tegris kept looking back and forth between her and Lonnie and couldn't seem to hold still in their seat.

"Hey, it's not an interrogation, really. Don't worry," Catra said.

Tegris gave a grin and ran a hand over their scales on their head, a clear imitation of someone smoothing back their hair they must have picked up from someone.

"I know, I just, you know, I've heard of Lonnie here and of course you," Tegris said, nodding at Catra. "Then this suite and I already feel kind of stupid being here and the whole thing is kind of overwhelming."

"Don't sweat it," Lonnie replied.

"I'm lizardfolk, I don't sweat," Tegris said, kind of giving a half-hearted chuckle at their attempt at humor.

"I'm dating one, trust me, I know," Lonnie said with a laugh. "I should have said to just take it easy. Want to get started?"

Tegris nodded and Lonnie was off asking questions. She went from smiling to business in the blink of an eye and after five minutes, Catra kind of wanted to retract her statement about it not being an interrogation or at least remind Lonnie it wasn't supposed to be one. However, she noticed under the direct questions, Tegris seemed to calm down a little. The questions went on for about fifteen minutes, about Tegris' zizi and what

Tegris remembered about what they did for the Horde, about where they'd been located and where they'd moved around to, and about anyone that Tegris remembered them being in contact with, especially in regards to Saz. Catra noticed a few of the questions seemed to be the same question, just rephrased, and just leaned back and listened as Tegris answered.

What everything seemed to say was that the elder Tegris had worked around Plumeria, moving around to avoid Rebellion attention, and that as far as the younger Tegris had known, they'd been paid by the Horde. Lonnie finally zeroed in on the part that she had known was going to be uncomfortable and brought up what had happened to Tegris' parents.

"I really hate to ask," she said after asking. "I know it's probably still fresh but I do need to at least get it logged."

Tegris looked away from the two, towards the center of the table and the little crystal that sat there that'd throw up a hologram when turned on. They didn't answer for a moment before they finally said, "It was right after Prime landed his troops. Zizi and mom had been moving around, trying to stay out of the way because they thought the Horde was about to roll everyone up and then of course it…"

Tegris stopped, thinking of the massive betrayal that had happened that'd caused the Princess Alliance to turn the table, not to mention the planet getting yanked back out of Despondos, and how Catra had been involved in some of that.

"I know what happened, go on," Catra said, her voice flat.

Tegris cleared their throat, scratched at their hand for a moment, and then went on.

"I was huddled down, scared out of my mind, and Zizi said that they and mom would be right back, that they had to check something," Tegris said, looking at the table, their eyes hidden from view but their voice tight. "That was the last time I saw

either of them. I waited in hiding for three days, waiting, before I finally had to move because the clones swept through the area. Managed to avoid getting chipped… but that doesn't really apply to the rest."

The room went quiet as Catra looked away and Lonnie had her head bowed as Tegris traced a little pattern on the table in front of them. Finally, they took a deep breath and looked up.

"Is that… I guess that's what I know," Tegris said. "I don't think it's going to help you find your mom, sorry."

Catra just nodded in acknowledgment but Lonnie said, "I think we can wrap up but just one last question. Where were you hiding when, well, when Prime landed?"

Tegris frowned as they thought for a split second before saying, "I don't really remember exactly where. I was picked up a couple of days after I left by some Horde soldiers and ended up out in Dryl for a little while and then just around."

Lonnie made a quick note and the stood up as she said, "I'm really sorry that I had to drag up these old memories. Thanks for talking with me. I might have a few follow up questions once I get this in the database and do a little churning. Are you going to stay in Bright Moon for awhile?"

Catra was watching Tegris and saw a bit of surprise in their face as they stuttered out, "Sure, I can be here awhile, if you think it's alright I stay?"

The last part was asked to Catra who shrugged as she said, "Probably. I wouldn't worry about it, but I'll ask for you to be sure. Bright Moon is accommodating though, I think you could probably move in and no one would blink an eye."

Tegris nodded and the conversation went to banalities as they all headed towards the door where Catra and Lonnie took their leave. Nothing was said for a few minutes as they walked down the hall,

both in thought. As they turned the corner to head towards Catra and Adora's room, Lonnie cleared her throat and looked at Catra.

"They're lying."

Chapter End Notes

For those who've read my other stuff, yes, I'm blatantly using my own headcanon for the thing like how the Horde came into being and using some of the towns I've made up as well (an OC is an original character so would an OT be an original town?). This still isn't in those canons though, I'm just used to thinking of Etheria in a certain way and I'm not above cribbing from it so I don't have to come up with a whole different way. Although it's interesting, the Magicat stuff I'm using here (living way off grid in the Waste, their culture, etc) is something I've had in a WIP for awhile now but I could never quite make that WIP work. So I get to drag it into this one. It just works that way sometimes.

Also, I can't believe it took me eleven chapters to bring Lonnie back into the picture.

Chapter 12: Chapter Twelve - Saz

Chapter Summary

Aleph Squad is given a unique opportunity that scares Saz.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra woke Saz up screaming. Catra threw her little toy mouse at the wall as the ruff around her neck flared out. Saz instinctively pulled her close and backed up to the wall, her eyes moving all over, trying to figure out where the threat was coming from. Because of this, she didn't see the toy as it stopped writhing and hissing as it hit the wall. The rest of the squadron room was fully awake though and several people were already hollering asking what was going on.

Snick was out of bed and holding up their hands saying, "It's alright, it's alright, just some night terrors I think, nothing to be alarmed about."

"It's the third fucking time this week!" someone shouted from the front of the room.

"So go back to fucking sleep then," Basco said, sitting on the edge of her bunk, her feet swinging down. "No one is keeping you up now, crybaby."

A few more voices started to shout back as Kit knelt down next to Saz and Catra, asking if they were alright, when Kedgeree gave a sharp whistle. Everyone in the room went quiet as they turned to the sergeant.

"It's the middle of the night, we have to be up before daybreak, so why the fuck are you all sitting here arguing? Get back to

sleep!"

The last sentence was barked out as only a Horde sergeant could manage and everyone got back into bed. As people rolled over grumbling, pulling covers over themselves, Kedgeree stalked to the back of the room. Aleph Squad saw her coming and formed up around Saz's bed.

"I'm not coming back here to chew anyone out," Kedgeree said quietly, "but they're not wrong. This is the third time in five days. What's going on?"

"I don't know," Kit said. "I was just talking to Saz here and she thinks it's just the change of scenery as it where."

"It's been almost two months since they've been here," Kedgeree said, addressing Kit but looking at Saz for a moment before turning her eyes back to Kit. "I thought we had an arrangement. The kid is in the creche during operating hours, in the bunks otherwise, as long as…"

Kedgeree trailed off and looked at Aleph Squad. Saz was the one to finish the sentence.

"As long as she doesn't cause trouble."

She said each word sharp and clear and Kedgeree nodded at her as she said, "That's right. As long as she doesn't cause trouble and what do you think screaming in the middle of the night counts as in this regard?"

"She's just having trouble sleeping," Saz replied, not noticing that Catra had her eyes fixed on the toy mouse with her fist shoved in her mouth as she shook a little. "It won't last."

"It won't matter. This keeps happening, she stays in the creche at night as well, just like the other cadets," Kedgeree said and then saw the looks on all of Aleph Squad's faces. "No. I'm already bending the rules as it is and you all agreed to this when we

talked about it. You can visit her on your free time. Just to be clear, this is an order. Reign it in, *now,* or that's it."

Kedgeree turned her back and headed back towards her bunk while Basco made several quick rude hand gestures at her back. Snick walked over and picked up the toy mouse and turned to hand it to Catra, who recoiled and hissed at the toy. The whole squad looked at her in surprise. She was attached to the toy, very defensive of it, and it was considered a high honor if Catra let someone handle it normally. Snick looked at the others before trying one more time and Catra buried her face in her mother's shoulder, one eye barely peaking out as her ears flattened back entirely and a low growl escaped her throat.

"Well, that's weird," Kit said as Snick backed up and put the mouse in their pocket.

"I know, she normally can't be parted with it," Basco said. "Maybe she had a bad dream about it or something."

"I'll hang onto it for now," Snick said as they got back into their bunk. "That alright?"

Saz, who was holding Catra tight and speaking quietly to her in soothing tones, nodded her head and the rest of the squad settled down while, unseen, a little flick of shadow raced along the top of the room and out the door and down the hall.

The next few days went well, Catra didn't wake up screaming, and routine returned for Aleph Squad. Catra was doing well, though the few times Snick tried to return the toy to her caused at the minimum a growl and often hissing and claws, but the squad loved her and the rest of the squadron went to at least acceptance of her presence and Catra was treated almost like a junior member of the squadron for the most part.

Then, one day, Force Captain Octavia walked into the morning briefing. The squadron came to attention and Octavia gave a brief nod as she sat down at the desk at the front of the room and the

squadron settled back into their seats. Octavia looked out at the group for a moment and then glanced down at the papers in front of her before looking back up again.

"This squadron has an interesting make-up," Octavia said. "You have a broad mix of skills and you have a tendency to make sure that everyone in the squadron learns them to some degree. As such, it seems any recruits that is assigned to the squadron has a tendency to get rapid promotion. Trooper Saz is an excellent example of what I'm referring to. She's only been in the Horde for a short time but she's already received promotion, she's learned a significant amount and taught the squadron a few tricks of her own in regards to field-craft and physical combat."

The squadron was doing its best not to look around too much but this was odd. It wasn't normal that a Force Captain came down to heap praise on them.

"I can see you wondering why I'm bringing this up," Octavia said and a few of the braver heads were nodding. "I have brought an idea before Lord Hordak and in his wisdom, he has granted me the chance to try it out with this squadron. What say you?"

The squadron knew there really wasn't any choice in the matter so the affirmative response that came from them was more a matter of form then any real acceptance, especially without details. Then Octavia did something that was considered in very poor form. She acknowledged it.

"I knew you were going to agree because it is not like you're really given a choice normally," Octavia said. "That would be normal though and what I'm doing is something out of the ordinary. In the war against the princesses, we suffer from lack of intelligence." The squadron fought not to roll their eyes as they thought the age old soldier's thought that military intelligence was a contradiction in terms. Then they sat up a little straighter as Octavia went on. "I understand the feeling you may be having when I say intelligence. I was a soldier like yourselves once as

well and I know how that feels so I'm giving you the chance to be sure your fellow soldiers don't fall victim to lack of intelligence.

"You will be scouts but not part of our normal scout corp, well trained though they may be. You will be long range scouts, going deep into princess held territory, staying under cover, and gathering information to better plan our assaults. You may have to live off the land and move long distances on foot and you always run the risk of capture but I know this squadron, now renamed 1st HLRS Squadron, will be up to it. I don't want anyone who can't cut it though. I'll have no one who's scared to do their duty for the Horde and their fellow soldier. So if you want out, we will reassign you but if you stay in, you will be the elite with all that entails. So I'll put it to you again, what say you?"

This time the response was much more robust and not one person was willing to back out. The rest of the morning was taken up by outlining just what the squadron would be doing and Saz felt a sinking feeling as she realized she'd be gone for long stretches of time. As the rest of the squadron broke for lunch, Saz remained in her seat, thinking. Basco was the first one to notice as she headed for the door with the rest of Aleph squad and sent them on the way before turning back into the empty room to go sit down beside Saz.

"What's on your mind?"

"I'll catch up, go ahead," Saz said, shaking her head.

"Naw, come on, I know somethings up, you've got that look," Basco said with a grin.

"What look?" Saz replied.

Basco said, "The look like you just bit into something sour but you're trying to hide it, like you always do. It's about Catra, isn't it?"

Saz just shrugged but said nothing.

"Listen, it almost always is," Basco said. "It's because if you stick with this, then you're going to be gone for long stretches, right?" Saz's tail gave her away as it started flicking and Basco nodded. "I thought so. Listen, doesn't wherever you're from have traveling salespeople? Or people who have to travel for work at all?"

Saz shook her head and then finally said, "No."

"No one? At all? Come on, you're kidding me."

"No, no one."

Basco fought with herself to ask and finally just sighed as she said, "Well, it's not that uncommon everywhere else. People have kids, even single parents, and when they have to leave for that time, they put the kid with someone they trust and the kid, well, they turn out fine. You're not neglecting her, alright?"

Saz sighed as her ears flattened back as she said, "I took her from where we were because I did not want her to go away from me, to be raised by people who don't know her."

Basco gently reached out and touched Saz's hand and Saz froze up for a second before relaxing a little.

"You're still here," Basco said. "This is your job, at least for a little while, and this is part of that job. She'll understand."

"She is barely not a baby," Saz said. "She doesn't even speak yet so how do you think she's going to understand her own mother not being there?"

"The same way she did when we had to be gone for a couple of days? Remember that? She was happy to see you but the creche worker said she'd done pretty well while you were gone. It's just, well, more of that."

Saz looked down at the table for long enough that Basco was beginning to think she was ignoring her in hopes that she'd go away when Saz finally spoke up.

"My village… they tried to talk the same way to me. That I should send Catra to fulfill an obligation we had, to seal a treaty. She was going to be," Saz said and then paused as she tried to think of the word in Bright Moon before going on, "a hostage. We'd have a hostage of our own as well for the deal. It was just how these things went but the hostage didn't grow up with their people. They weren't treated horribly but they weren't treated with love." Saz looked up at Basco then and her eyes were sharp. "I want her treated with love. She does not have people anymore but she will have my love."

Basco squeezed Saz's hand.

"She has your love and more."

Saz's ears twitched a little and Basco went on.

"You don't think we don't love her too? Snick is still carrying that mouse around with them in case Catra decides she wants it again. Kit argues with Kedgeree all the time to make sure Catra sleeps with us and plays with her as well. I think she's the greatest too. She's a little fireball and I can't wait to see how she grows up. Maybe that's what we do when your stretch is up. We all head out and find our own little place. I've heard of a few places, whispered about, where a Horde soldier can get comfortable and not worry about princesses."

"That's years though," Saz replied.

"Ok, so? She'll be, what, about five? Perfect time," Basco said. "You just got to get through this time frame."

"Where we would we even go?" Saz said.

Basco looked around before leaning in and quietly saying, "I've heard the Crimson Waste isn't as empty as people say."

Saz's ears went completely flat and she sat back in her chair, pulling away from Basco.

"No."

Her voice wasn't loud but her tone screamed that no argument was allowed. Basco sat up, blinking in surprise as she thought for a moment before she said, "You're from the Waste aren't you?" Saz didn't answer and Basco leaned back in. "I'm not going to say anything to anyone but you really are, aren't you?" Saz's tail flicked back and forth as she refused to look at Basco. "That, wow, that really explains a lot. Why you couldn't really speak Bright Moon, the weird way you came in, the fact you look absolutely nothing like someone from Plumeria, and I've heard someone say your Magicat doesn't sound like any they'd heard before, because it's not any that anyone really knows outside of, well, the Waste. I'm right aren't I?"

Saz wouldn't speak, she just dug her claws into the chair she was sitting in as she thought fast. She had come to respect Basco, to respect all of Aleph Squad in fact, but she felt her heart beating hard because she didn't realize just how much Basco had figured out.

"You're wrong," Saz finally said as she turned to look at Basco.

Basco waited a moment before saying quietly, "Am I really?"

Saz just nodded but said nothing.

"Saz, come on," Basco said. "Do you still not trust me?"

Saz looked at Basco. She looked like someone from Bright Moon, which to Saz meant soft, but she knew Basco was nothing of the kind. She'd seen her spar, she'd seen her actually fight, and for a moment, she thought of what it would be like to move to the Waste with Basco. She could see Basco sitting on the doorstep of a stone house in the canyon land that Saz came from. It was such an intense image of Basco with a cup of tea in her hand, watching the sky lighten and the sandstone of the canyons warming up in the coming day and for a moment Saz could almost taste the dust in the air. Then she remembered that anyone she became

attached to would be tied into the debt she owed from the insult she'd given and she shook her head to snap herself out of it.

"It's not that…," Saz said and then found she couldn't even deny it.

"What is it?" Basco asked.

Saz didn't want to look at her. She felt her heart pounding and the feeling in her gut reminded her of the feeling when she ran with Catra. It was fear but this time it wasn't quite the same. It was mixed with something else this time. She remembered the night she met Catra's father, how she'd felt, and how she'd loved him. This was the feeling she had now. She could feel it mixed in with the fear and she couldn't help but remember how she'd grieved when he'd been killed and then grieved again when she realized she was going to have a child he'd never meet and for a moment tears were pooling in her eyes.

Basco saw the tears and slowly reached out to put a hand on Saz's shoulder.

"What? Come on, it's alright," Basco said.

Saz put a hand over Basco's and looked up as she quickly wiped the tears away.

"Tell no one about this or what I'm going to say," Saz said. "Not even the rest of the squad."

Basco nodded as she said, "Of course."

"Swear it," Saz said, her hand tightening on Basco's hand.

"I swear it," Basco replied.

Saz took a deep breath and then began to speak.

"I ran from my village in the Waste. If they ever find Catra and I, they'll… well, they can't ever find us. Ever. And it's not just them.

Their descendants will take up the cause as well. I've made enemies of two villages but Catra is safe and she'll grow up with my love."

"So you think people will hunt you down? And her?" Basco said and Saz nodded. "Doesn't matter. If they ever find you two, they'll find us too. They'll find *me,"* Basco said, thumping her chest. "I know Kit and Snick would feel the same. In case you haven't figured it out, it means you have a new village. Your enemies are my enemies."

Saz felt her heart skip a beat and felt herself looking hard at Basco. Her brown hair, her dark brown eyes, the little freckle that sat just to the right of her nose, and without even thinking she felt her hand drift up and run along Basco's jaw. Basco's eyes went wide as she moved her hand from Saz's shoulder and put it on Saz's hand that ran along her jaw. Everything was still as they looked at each other and then Saz hooked her hand behind Basco's head and pulled them together, their lips meeting as she put her other arm around Basco and pulled her in tight. Basco kissed her back and for a little bit, Saz was happy. She'd found love. She'd found a village. It was good.

Chapter End Notes

> Sometimes a family is a mushroom person, a satyr, a magicat and her daughter, and a person serving in the Horde together as a squad.
>
> I knew Shadow Weaver was going to screw with the toy, I just couldn't quite figure out how and still be able to show it. Then I remembered her shadow creatures and that was it. Yes, she's tormenting a one year old. Probably things of it as research or something.
>
> Also, I realized using squad and squadron might be a little confusing. Squads are a couple of people and multiple squads make up a squadron.

I, um, I did not intend the Saz/Basco thing. It was supposed to be a friendship but was writing that part where Basco figures out where Saz is from and it took a turn.

Chapter 13: Chapter Thirteen - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra, Adora, and Lonnie all go back to talk with Tegris, only to discover something has happened in the short time since they last spoke together.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"What do you mean they're lying?" Catra said as she came to a halt in the hallway.

Lonnie gave a quick look around herself, something Catra had realized she did as well before saying something too out of the ordinary. Her Listener had pointed it out during one of their sessions and ever since Catra noticed ex-Horde cadets did it constantly, even Adora. It was an instinct ground into all of them from a young age of making sure that there were only trusted ears around.

"First, some of their stuff doesn't quite add up but that could just be discrepancy," Lonnie said. "There's other things, mannerisms and stuff, but what really nailed it for me was they said they were barely eighteen, right?"

Catra nodded and Lonnie looked around again before going on.

"They look that age, kind of, but their eyes don't look that young," Lonnie said.

"Their eyes," Catra said, her voice deadpan.

"OK, cut it out, not some window into the soul crap. You lived with Rogelio for years so you remember the molting?"

Catra laughed a bit in spite of herself. She remembered the first time Rogelio had done so, when they were still kids, and Rogelio had thought he was dying and hadn't been quiet about it until someone had figured it out and explained it.

Lonnie grinned as she remembered the same thing as she said, "Yeah, well, they get those nice fresh scales. I'm guessing you probably haven't been around enough older lizardfolk to notice but right around their eyes it's not quite as fresh, it wrinkles a little more and stuff and as they get older, it starts to be more obvious. Tegris has older eyes."

Catra leaned against the wall as she thought for a moment before saying, "So what are you trying to say?"

"I don't know. Just that it's not what it seems," Lonnie said. "Maybe I'm too used to dealing with some of those old die hard Horde types who miss the Horde and I'm getting cynical."

"You're getting cynical you said? Getting?" Catra said.

"You know what I mean," Lonnie replied. "Don't be an ass or more of one I should say. I just think they're hiding something."

Catra got quiet as they both walked into Catra and Adora's rooms. She was thinking of what Lonnie had said and so didn't notice Adora at first.

"Where have you been up and about to?" Adora said as she stood up and walked over to Catra. "Hey, Lonnie."

Catra fought back the urge to get defensive at Adora asking where she'd been as she folded Adora into her arms and kissed her. Lonnie just stood there shaking her head, trying not to grin at the greeting from Adora that had basically been an afterthought. She knew how the two were around each other and had made peace with it. Mostly.

"We went and interviewed Tegris just now," Catra said as everyone got settled at the table. Catra noticed that Adora had

some kind of royal paperwork from Glimmer on the table and briefly saw something about a rebuilding campaign near Salienas. It was at that point that Catra looked away, not wanting to see if it was a town she'd personally sacked or if it was just one she'd ordered to be sacked. Adora was already shuffling it back into a pile and turning it face down anyway so the awkwardness was mostly avoided.

"What they'd have to say?" Adora asked.

Lonnie and Catra spent a few minutes filling her in on what had been said and then Lonnie's conclusion that Tegris was lying about something but they couldn't figure out what. Adora sat in thought for a moment before she said, "Why though? What's the point?"

"Revenge?" Lonnie said, glancing at Catra for a second before fixing back on Adora. "Not to bring up old, bad things but I'm surprised you haven't had to deal with more than that."

"I mean, I guess," Catra said. "It's a weird way to go about it though."

"If this is revenge, at least they didn't jump you like that one guy did," Adora said, frowning as she remembered someone going for Catra with a stun baton at a festival in Plumeria. Catra had parried with no problem and was getting ready to fight when a She-Ra enhanced Adora had intervened. The guy managed to suffer only minor bumps and bruises and people lauded Adora on her restraint, though Adora would later say it had been a close call between just subduing him or putting him in a synchronous orbit with the Velvet Glove.

"I'm not worried about that," Catra said. "I think most people are past that for now."

"You sure?" Lonnie said. "I know I want to take a swing at you occasionally."

"Because you know her," Adora said as she planted a kiss on Catra.

"Feeling the love," Catra said with a grunt. "Back to this Tegris character though, serious talk, what do they want? What would they gain?"

"I don't know," Lonnie replied. "Nothing other than what they're saying makes sense, that they're just reporting on something. Any thing else doesn't make sense. I mean, what convoluted bullshit would they be up to?"

"Steal the crown?" Catra said.

"That's just what you want to do," Lonnie said.

"Only on the occasional holiday, as a treat to Glimmer," Catra said.

"Besides how would that work with you?" Adora said.

"I wasn't serious," Catra said as she nudged Adora.

"You never know," Adora said.

The conversation lapsed as each settled into their head for a moment. Suddenly Adora sat up as she said, "I want to go talk to Tegris. Come on."

She was already heading for the door with Catra right on her heels as Lonnie said, "Why?"

"Because!" Adora said as she went out the door. Lonnie let out a long sigh but got to her feet and followed.

They were halfway to where Tegris was staying when Bow came across them in the hall and fell in with them.

"Where we going?" he asked as they trooped along.

"I want to go have a talk with Tegris," Adora said. "These two already have and I figured it wouldn't hurt if I had a little chat."

Bow looked at Adora for a moment, taking in her pace and body posture, and said, "Should I put the guard on alert?"

Adora looked at him a bit strangely before she realized how she was proceeding and slowed down with a little awkward smile as she said, "No, they just… I guess they were answering questions a bit oddly and I wanted my chance at them."

"I didn't say strangely," Lonnie said.

"You said they were lying," Adora said.

Bow held up a hand to get their attention as he said, "Um, if that's what's going on I should probably say they left the castle already. Thanked the chamberlain, said they were going home, and went on their way."

"Where?" Catra, Adora, and Lonnie all said at once.

"I don't know," Bow said.

"OK, we gotta find them, right now," Lonnie said. "Adora, can you talk with the guards, figure out if they had some kind of transport? Catra, you and I will hit the public skiff stop. How fast you think we can get there?"

"Assuming you can keep up, pretty fast," Catra said.

"I'll go with Adora," Bow said.

"Go with Catra," Adora said. "I'll get Glimmer and you know she'll have no problem finding you."

There was a short agreement and then the four split up, Catra, Lonnie, and Bow running towards the town of Bright Moon with Catra repressing a grin as she ran. It felt good to be running towards a confrontation and she felt a little bit of the old fizz in her blood she remembered from the war. As they got close to the little park where the public skiff operated from, they saw it coming in for a landing. It was a huge old Horde skiff that'd been retrofitted for hauling people around. It was comfortable, at least compared to the old Horde configuration and the service gave people easy access to other kingdoms. It was still only about a

year old but had already become a firmly entrenched part of the life of Etheria as people moved around the planet more freely.

"OK, lets take it slow," Lonnie said as she came to a stop at the broad gravel packed path that led back into the trees and towards the landing area. "This thing isn't going anywhere before we can get up there."

"I'll go first," Bow said. "I don't think they'll think to watch for me."

"OK, I'll cover your back," Lonnie said before nodding at Catra. "You want to hang back a little? I think they'll notice you quickest."

"Or how about we just have Bow ground the skiff?" Catra said.

"Uh, because I don't have that power?" Bow said. "Glimmer could get away with it but they'd just laugh at me."

"Bow, you're *you,"* Catra said. "Just do your goodie-goodie act and they'll eat it up."

"What are you talking about?" Bow said.

"He really doesn't see it does he?" Lonnie said to Catra who just shook her head.

"Just go and try," Catra said. "Lonnie, get on the skiff. I'll bring up the rear."

"OK," Bow said, not sure but headed up the path, Lonnie right behind him. Catra waited a minute before heading up the path herself. A stream of people were coming down the path, a good portion of them obviously from Plumeria but a little knot of people from the Kingdom of Snows standing out in their heavy clothes and flushed faces as they realized just how much hotter Bright Moon was than where they came from. Several Bright Moon citizens were busy with little carts along the path doing a brisk business of late breakfast, selling little items that the travelers

might have forgotten, and even a souvenir cart that Catra stayed away from because it was still weird to see Glimmer's face on a t-shirt and she didn't even want to think about seeing one with Adora's face as She-Ra.

As Catra went slowly up the path she scanned the faces looking for Tegris, but most of the crowd was moving away from the landing area and the few who were going towards it, like Catra, where generally in small groups looking for arriving friends or relatives.

Catra was almost to the clearing where the skiffs landed when she spotted the Magicat coming out of the clearing and onto the path. His fur was tawny like her fur but he easily had a foot of height on her and his shoulders were broad. His clothes were heavy fabric with leather sewed on at strategic points, such as elbows and knees, and a vest sat over the heavy shirt with a couple of pockets and a few carved beads on a necklace. A little bag was thrown over his shoulder on a single strap but the thing that caught Catra's eye was the long knife at his hip, something she'd could tell would be useful for both clearing brush and fighting.

She was staring a little because he definitely didn't look like someone from Half Moon, who tended towards loose flowing clothes in thin fabrics and riots of color, and while they weren't the only Magicats on the planet, they were the ones most likely to be seen in Bright Moon now. She was trying to place where the guy was from when he locked eyes with her.

"You!" he screamed, dropping his bag on the ground, and pointing.

Catra actually looked over her shoulder for a moment, sure he was yelling at someone else but that only lasted a second because she instantly focused up as he stripped the knife out of its sheath and started towards her.

"In the name of Staed I claim your blood!" he screamed. The crowd was already screaming itself and people were scattering in

all directions to get away from teh guy.

Catra wasn't sure who or what Staed was but she had no plans to give up any blood for it as she backed up, her hands coming up in a fighting stance she'd learned from the Bright Moon guard. The stance was all about subduing and restraint and she'd been determined to learn it, so she could do better.

"Hey, I think you got the wrong person!" Catra shouted back as she bounced a little on her feet, moving sideways to try and get a little better position and distance between them.

The Magicat spit on the ground and then thrust the machete forward and it was then that Catra figured out that the guy had a longer reach than she expected as she barely dodged the edge of the blade that flashed past her chest. It wasn't like she wasn't used to fighting someone with longer reach though, a little guilty flash of Adora's reach as She-Ra coming into her head before going right back out as Catra stiffened her arm and struck with the heel of her palm into the guy's side as she positioned herself to lock his arm up to try and bring him to the ground just like she'd learned.

It didn't work.

For a split second, she was sure she'd broken her wrist as she thudded into what she thought was some kind of armor but then realized when it gave just a little that it was actually just the guy's side. The arm lock never even got started as the guy responded by slamming his elbow into Catra, sending her sprawling backwards. She barely managed to turn the fall into a backwards somersault and came up on her feet. He spun to meet her, faster then she was used to, as fast as she was she realized and grunted as she shook her head.

"Screw this," she hissed as all thought of subduing left her head and ten sharp claws came out. The guy's eyes went wide as he saw the claws and Catra swore he looked ashamed for a moment before he shook his head, sheathed his machete and started to

run away. He grabbed his bag as he went and Catra swore she heard him say something that sounded like, "Later" before he disappeared into the trees.

Chapter End Notes

> Yes, one of my fantasies is free long-range mass transit. I also have this headcanon that during the war, few people traveled. It was difficult and potentially dangerous after all. Then, after the war, people started moving about more and someone came up with the idea of converting the old Horde heavy skiffs into public transport and making it a free service that travels between various spots on a routine schedule. This also folds into my headcanon that it's not unusual to see a party of four to six Etherian teenagers out and about traveling around by themselves far from home. The hostel system on Etheria is legendary. One of these days I need to put together all these post-war headcanons I have of how Etherian society functions because while I'm not a big worldbuilding person, I do throw it out there when the story requires it and I've done a LOT of writing in the post-war era so I have a lot of headcanon for the society.

Chapter 14: Chapter Fourteen - Saz

Chapter Summary

Saz and Aleph Team go on a little mission in which Saz gets to thinking.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Point, report."

Saz didn't so much as twitch at the voice that came over the headset she was wearing. She was splayed out on a roof of a rooming house in a little village while a group of five people hung around below her talking and laughing. It was at least after dark and the uniform that Saz wore was a dark blue, all the better to disappear into shadows, so they hadn't spotted her. That didn't mean someone wouldn't see her move if she did so and she wasn't quite sure what would happen at that point. The briefing for the mission had described this village on the far southern border of the Kingdom of Snows as a rebel hotbed but all she'd seen so far was people just going about their day in the high days of summer which was still pretty cold after dark she was finding out.

"Point, report."

Saz felt her heart beat a little faster at Basco's voice coming through on the headset but she didn't move, even to press the transmit key long enough to make a clicking noise. She just had to wait the people out below and for a moment she had a flashback to when she was just barely a teenager and got stuck up a rock by a pack of feral saddle lizards who'd been hunting her through the canyons by her village. The non-sentient creatures had been extremely persistent but had been confused by her scent

disappearing and had snuffled around the rock for hours trying to figure it out. They'd only left after the sun had gone down and the air had cooled enough for them to be uncomfortable. She was hoping the same would happen to these people but so far nothing of the sort seemed to be forthcoming.

Two of the people walked around the side of the building and for a moment Saz hoped the rest would follow but the two were back in less than a minute carrying chairs. One of the others was starting a little charcoal brazier and the rest got busy setting up the chairs and getting settled in, chattering and laughing the whole time.

"Point, you better report or I'm coming in to find you. I won't be quiet either."

Saz knew Basco wasn't kidding, she could hear it in her voice over the channel, and so she very slowly moved her hand up to the mic and squeezed it twice, breaking the transmission and causing two clicks to broadcast.

"Was that so hard, Point?" Basco's voice said in her ear.

She is not getting cuddles tonight, Saz said to herself though she knew it was an empty threat. The only chance of that not happening was if she got stuck on the roof all night.

"Aleph One to Point, are you in danger?"

Kit's voice sounded a bit strained and Saz gave one click over the radio to say no.

"Aleph Two to net, I have Point in view. She's stuck on a roof above five hostiles," Snick's voice said. Saz fought down a little laugh as the people below were anything but hostile as she heard one of them break open something carbonated but that was just how the Horde had trained them to refer to anyone not a part of the Horde or at least an ally of them.

"Where?" Basco said.

"Aleph Three, hold your position," Kit said. "Point, do you think you're in immediate danger?"

Saz gave a single click for no again.

"You hear her, she's good for now," Kit said. "Aleph Two, avoid detection and keep Point under observation and warn her if needed. Aleph Three, move to Rally Two and I'll meet you there."

A flurry of agreement came and then it was just Saz in silence on the steeply sloping roof. She'd known it was probably a mistake when she'd gone up there but it had just seemed like a good idea to get up high where she could see better and she knew people were less likely to look up. It still was a good idea she figured because after all, even though the people below her were only about twenty-five feet away or so, admittedly straight down, they hadn't seen her up in the shadows.

Saz took a long, deep breath and slowly let it out as she waited for whatever was to come next. She wasn't scared, even if it was her first deployment since they'd been given their new assignment some months back, but she was worried about how Catra was doing. She'd spent all of the previous day with her knowing she wouldn't be back to the Fright Zone for at least three days and probably longer. It didn't hurt quite as bad as it had before. Catra seemed to have settled in a little, the creche worker telling Saz that Catra was doing alright, getting along with a few different people. Saz had even seen her playing with the little blonde girl, Adora, and a little lizardfolk person she thought was named Rogelio.

"Aleph Two to net, four more people are coming up the alley from the east towards Point."

Saz let her eyes flick up the alley and saw the four people, holding hands and carrying baskets, as they came out onto the little patio the other five were on. Saz tried to flatten herself out more as everyone stood up and shouted greetings at each other and the

baskets were passed around as food got brought out and someone started grilling on the brazier.

"Aleph Three to Point, you still alright?"

Saz gave two breaks on the mic to show Basco she was fine.

"You let us know if you're not," Basco replied back.

"Aleph One to net, keep the channel clear," Kit said and Saz could just hear Basco's little irritated noise she was probably making.

The smell of freshly roasting veggies drifted up to Saz's nose and made her think of a raid she'd gone on, the last raid she'd gone on in fact, with her village. She remembered the smell of cooking drifting up the canyon on a stray breeze as they'd approached the village of Crailfish and how she'd been struck on how similar it was to her own village of Staed. The canyon where Crailfish sat was deeper, the approaches more narrow, but the sound of the wind through the breakwood trees that grew around the village's water source were the same as the ones around Staed's water source and the light was almost the same off the canyon walls and the smell of food was remarkably close to the smell of the food they'd eaten before they'd left and Saz had wondered for a brief moment just why they were doing what they were doing.

"Aleph Two to net, this is turning into quite the gathering. I see five more coming from the same direction as the last group," Snick said.

The memory burned away as Saz saw the group coming and the group below her calling out to them in joy. Another brazier was brought out and lit, more chairs were setup, and a few lamps were lit around the edges of the growing crowd as more food and drink was shuffled around and for a moment Saz looked at the food and thought of the food they ate at the Fright Zone and wondered if she could sneak down and grab a bite without being noticed. She knew it was silly and then she realized the lamp light below was bright enough to just reach her perch.

The crowd was getting loud enough that she took a calculated risk and very quietly spoke into her mic.

"Point to Aleph Two, give me a description of the area around me."

Snick responded back with a description of the patio, the little alley running behind the buildings, and a little side yard off to the side of the house she was currently perched on top of. Saz thought for a moment before she said, "Point to Aleph Two, describe the side yard."

Snick talked for a moment about it and the little fence that separated it from the patio and then sensing what she was thinking, pointed out that the fence was only about waist high with gaps between the pickets.

"Aleph One to net, rendezvous made with Aleph Three. Hold positions, we have a plan."

"Want to fill us in, High Aleph?" Snick said and Saz felt a little smile twitch at her mouth at the name they teased Kit with occasionally.

"Aleph One to Point, just get ready to move when the opportunity presents," Kit said.

"Acknowledge," Saz said as someone below pulled out a mandolin, another person pulled out a hand drum, and they started tuning up.

It was almost an hour longer, and another twenty people showing up, that Saz stayed up on the roof feeling the cold soak into her with only occasional reports from Snick and Kit. Saz wondered why Basco wasn't talking when she noticed another group of people walking down the alley. This was a group of seven and they were a little intoxicated, laughing and shouting at the crowd on the patio who stood and shouted out to them. Then she saw one of the people at the back of the group carrying a big bag. The person was also wearing a long coat with a hood pulled up and a

facemask on. The pants were baggy snow pants but even through the thick layers, Saz was almost one hundred percent sure she was looking at Basco.

"I see Aleph Three," Kit said, confirming Saz's belief. "Point, be ready."

"For what?" Saz said, keeping her voice low though it didn't really matter too much with the loud party going on below her. Then she saw Basco's eyes looking right at her and felt her heart start beating harder as she saw Basco wink at her. It wasn't just because of the little flirtation, it was also because Saz could see into the bag and it was full to the brim with what looked like fireworks.

"We brought fireworks!" one of the members of the new crowd shouted out as they joined the group.

Basco tossed them on a table and people gathered around to look in the bag as Basco backed up to try and maintain some kind of distance so no one could see her very well and think to ask just who she was and who she knew there. Saz thought this might be the distraction, since almost everyone was hanging around the bag as it got unpacked, and got ready to move. Then she realized what the distraction actually was when she saw the huge firework mortar round in Basco's hand.

"Don't," Saz said at the same time Basco underhanded it into one of the charcoal braziers.

"Shit! I dropped it!" Basco screamed as she pointed at the shell. Everyone on the patio froze for a second and then started screaming as well. The crowd became a frenzy of activity as everyone went diving for cover.

"Point, move!" Kit's voice came screaming over the radio but Saz didn't need to be told twice or even once as she was already rolling over towards the side yard and dropping off the roof. She hit the ground right as the shell went off, the explosion of the

lifting charge buried in the deafening sound of the main firework showering sparks all over the patio. Saz's ears were folded down completely, doing their best to keep the horrific noise from damaging her ears and she say Basco gesturing at her as she ran past towards the alley. Saz was right at her back, taking a brief moment to take tally of the damage. No one seemed to be hurt and she noticed someone had the good sense to have thrown a coat over the other fireworks so they didn't go off. When she turned around, she noticed that Basco wasn't wearing her huge coat anymore and put the two together.

"I didn't want to kill anyone, just distract them," Basco said as she stopped just long enough to shuck the snow pants she was wearing, struggling for just a second as the stun baton on her hip caught the waistband.

"Success," Saz said as stopped to make sure no one was following them but everyone seemed to be absorbed with checking everyone else out and they hadn't noticed the missing person yet.

Basco grabbed Saz's face and gave her a quick kiss as she said, "Told you I'd watch out for you."

Saz grinned as they both ran off into the night.

An hour later they met with Kit and Snick and spent the next few hours quietly making their way back to their hidden skiff in the woods. Snick had them in the air and flying at treetop level, the faint light of the aurora and moons peaking around clouds the only light out. Once they were far away from the town, Snick set them down and they went about getting the skiff covered again before crawling under the tarp with a sigh.

"OK, that went… um, not quite to plan," Kit said as Saz heated up their rations and started passing them around.

"No one caught us," Basco said.

"No one was supposed to see us though," Snick said with a little chuckle.

"And they didn't," Basco said. "I was wearing heavy clothes and had my face covered."

"I don't think that's what Octavia had in mind," Kit said.

"Listen, the information we got is still just as good now as it was before the, um, diversion," Basco said.

Saz nodded as she said, "For a rebel stronghold, that place seemed pretty undefended."

"Probably hidden," Kit said with a shrug. "Still, I'll mention in my report not much to see."

"Just that statue of a princess in the town square was the only real thing I noticed," Saz said. "Some of the vehicles are definitely heavy cargo and were tracked though and I saw a few indications of what might be air traffic control."

Snick looked up as they said, "They have radar but I know we didn't get picked up. Too small."

"Well write it up," Kit said. "I'll compile it for the report. Write up what could have been done differently as well and we'll discuss it when we get back to the Fright Zone."

The other nodded and after a little more discussion and clean up, everyone but Saz settled down into their sleeping bags as she moved a little ways into the trees and stood quietly on guard. She got to thinking of that raid she'd remembered sitting on the roof. She thought about just how close those people she'd raided back at her old village were so close to her own. Then she thought about what she'd just seen.

The intelligence Aleph Squad had been given said that this was a princess stronghold, a military strong point, but nothing she'd seen confirmed any of that. Sure, she'd seen heavy tracked vehicles but she also knew the area was under snow for a good portion of the year and that just made sense, just like the air traffic control. Something nagged at her as she stood in the dark,

a feeling that things weren't what they seemed, and she sighed. Then her ears perked up as she heard stealthy footsteps in the dark and her hand dropped towards her stun baton.

"OK, I should have known better than to try and sneak up on you," Basco said from the shadows and Saz relaxed a little as she waved her over.

"You know Kit said we can't hang out on watch or we don't get enough sleep," Saz said as she wrapped an arm around her.

Basco gave her a kiss before reaching up and gently rubbing an ear that set Saz to purring for just a moment.

"I know, I won't be here but for a few minutes," Basco said.

"That's a lie and you know it," Saz said as she pulled Basco's hand away from her ear and gave it a kiss.

"Naw, really," Basco said. "I just wanted to say, that, um, today… I was scared for you. I'm glad you're alright."

"I would have been alright," Saz said. "No one there seemed to even be armed."

"I know," Basco said.

Saz looked at her for a moment, Basco's voice sounding weird, but even with her eyes, she couldn't really make out her features in the darkness under the trees.

"What's wrong?" Saz said.

"Nothing," Basco said and gave Saz another kiss. "I'm just feeling a bit odd, having you in harm's way like that."

"It came out alright," Saz said with a shrug.

"Even though I almost burned a house down?" Basco said, giving a little dig at Saz's side with her elbow.

"Yes, even though you almost did," Saz said with a grin.

Basco gave her a kiss again before stepping back, pulling Saz's hand out with her, keeping contact as long as she could.

"I love you, you know that right?" Basco said.

Saz blinked in surprise. It wasn't something they'd ever said to each other but she found herself stuttering a little in surprise as she replied.

"I do. I, um, I…," Saz said and Basco held up a hand.

"Don't say it just to say it," Basco said. "I'm alright if you're not there yet."

Saz tightened her grip and pulled Basco back to her, kissing her deeply before saying, "I love you."

"Seriously?" Basco said, her voice sounding goofy.

"Yes," Saz said and then took a deep breath before saying something that felt silly to admit and scared her just a little in how Basco would react. "I dream about when we can leave; when we can live together on our own terms. Would you… would you want to do that?"

"Live with you? Raise Catra with you?" Basco said.

Saz nodded. That was a part that she hadn't even been able to say but she thought of Basco being Catra's mother with her and felt her heart beat faster.

"Yes, if you want," Saz said.

"You know I want that. I've said it before but yes, I'll say it again. I want that," Basco said. "We'll raise her, find a quiet place to do it in, see her out into the world, and then we'll grow old together. You and I, is that what you're thinking?"

Saz nodded, feeling a little lump in her throat as she allowed herself to think that far. She hugged Basco tight to her.

"I am," Saz said. "Our own little village, like you said."

"Our own little village," Basco said, giving her a kiss again. They stood that way for a little bit, arms around each other, swaying a little bit and kissing, before Basco finally stepped back. "OK, I swore I wouldn't be out here all night. I really need to go back to bed."

Saz pulled her in for a kiss again before letting her go.

"Sleep well," she said. "Because I'm waking you for next watch in just a few hours."

Basco gave a little chuckle as she said, "The sign of love."

"You're all the sign I need," Saz said and then felt her face flush hot.

"Me too," Basco said as she stepped backwards. "OK, I better get out of here or we're going to do this all night."

"I love you."

"I love you too."

Chapter End Notes

> CandianBear once said of my writing that it was an angst coaster. Well, this one is definitely rolling up that first hill now with this chapter. :)

Chapter 15: Chapter Fifteen - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra is trying to recover from the attack as people show up to try and find Tegris.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was trying to process that someone had just tried to carve her up and then ran off as Lonnie and Bow came running up to her. Bow had an arrow nocked and Catra felt herself grin as she recognized a net arrow, an easy task since she'd certainly seen the business end of it before.

"We heard shouting! Are you alright!?" Bow shouted himself, his voice a touch away from panic.

"I'm fine, I'm fine," Catra found herself repeating as Lonnie put a hand on her shoulder.

"You sure?" Lonnie said as she looked down.

Catra followed her eyes and realized that she'd missed the blade by less than she expected. The shirt she was wearing had a clean cut across her stomach and Catra reached through the hole as she tried to keep her hand from shaking but after she felt for a moment she let out a sigh that the shirt was the only thing that got cut.

"Yeah, it's just the shirt," she said and took a deep swallow before she went on. "Adora picked this shirt out, she's going to be so pissed."

This set her off giggling as she stumbled over and sat down on a bench on the side of the path. As she did, she saw Melog come running down the path. They stopped for a moment, took her in, and made a little chirp noise at her. She nodded, hooked a thumb over her shoulder to indicate which way the Magicat had gone, and Melog was off into the trees without another word.

"Should I follow them?" Bow said.

"They survived the almost total obliteration of their planet," Catra said, still giggling a little. "They'll be fine."

"Then what happened to you!?" Bow said.

"Some Magicat shouted at me and tried to attack me," Catra said as she felt herself start to shake. "It's nothing. I'm cool, just gotta take a minute."

Bow sat down next to her and pulled her into a hug. Catra stiffened up a little but didn't say anything else as he said, "You're freaking out."

"I am not freaking out," Catra said.

Lonnie kept looking around as she said, "No, you're freaking out a little. Just means you're normal, you know, shockingly enough."

Catra took a deep breath as she kept shaking, thinking of all the fights she'd had in the past. She couldn't remember shaking like this before but she'd seen it before in others and knew that Bow and Lonnie weren't wrong, she just didn't want to admit it. Then she heard Glimmer teleporting in and knew the whole thing was about to get way more involved.

She heard Bow shout for Glimmer and then suddenly her and Adora were standing right there as Bow and Lonnie gave them a quick rundown. Catra wanted to shove everyone away but then Adora was looming over her as She-Ra and picking Catra up to hold her close and Catra found herself burying her face into

Adora's shoulder and ignoring the face that Adora had her held a good foot and a half off the ground.

"I'm going for the skiff," Glimmer said and then vanished.

"I'll back her," Lonnie said and started running as Bow stood up and picked up his bow once again.

"I'll just, um, stand here," Bow said as Adora whispered to Catra that she was alright. After a few minutes, Catra calmed down enough to ask Adora to set her down. Adora did and then immediately began to look angry.

"I'm going to find that piece of…," Adora started to say and Catra put a hand on her arm and shook her head.

"Hey, no, don't," Catra said. "Let it go for now."

"Seriously!? You're standing there in a chopped up shirt and telling me…, damn it!" Adora shouted before suddenly turning back to her regular self with a huff.

Catra understood. She wanted to follow Melog with Adora hot on her heels and track down this guy but she felt something in her head pulling at her, telling her to stay calm, to take it easy, not to be Force Captain Catra but just Catra. In other words, she realized, she was trying to be the person that her friends loved and not the person they had once feared.

"I get it, alright?" Catra said. "Just… Melog's on his tail and I'm having whatever this is," she said nodding at her shaking hand, "and I just need to sit, OK?"

"OK, alright, I'm sorry," Adora said.

"Yeah, you are kind of sorry," Catra said with a little laugh as she hugged herself.

"You're going to be alright," Bow said and it took a moment for Catra to realize he was rolling his eyes.

"Yeah, I'm going to be fine as soon as I can stop shaking, damn it," Catra replied giving Bow a little smile.

Adora started to say something when they heard someone shouting down the path from the direction of the skiff. Other people were coming up the path from the town of Bright Moon, including a few members of the Bright Moon Guard that worked in the town, and they all stopped at the string of absolutely vile profanity that was coming from the direction of the skiff pad.

"I'd say that was Glimmer but I'm not sure she knows some of that," Adora said.

"Sure she does but she's so much more creative at cursing than that," Bow said.

Catra stood up as they saw Lonnie walking down the path. In front of her, partially stumbling, was Tegris held in an arm lock by Lonnie with Glimmer walking just to the side of them both with her staff held at a low guard. The guards, upon seeing the queen, went running towards her.

"They've got some luggage on the skiff," Glimmer said as the first guard got up to her. "Their name is Tegris. Go and get it off the skiff and let the pilot know they're clear to leave, please."

The guard gave Glimmer a salute and went off at a run. Lonnie got up to the bench where Catra was sitting and put Tegris down on the other end of it from Catra.

"Sit down and for Mara's sake, shut the fuck up," Lonnie said. "You're lucky Glimmer didn't take your head off when you took a swing at both of us."

Tegris opened their mouth to say something when Bow was suddenly looming over them.

"You tried to hit Glimmer?"

It wasn't really in the way he was standing. It wasn't even in the way he spoke, but something about the statement Bow made had Tegris shrinking back a little and shutting up.

"I'm fine," Glimmer said as she stood on tiptoes and gave Bow a kiss on the cheek.

"Good," Bow said, not taking his eyes off of Tegris.

"Any sign of the person who attacked Catra?" Adora said.

"Um, I was going after them," Glimmer said, nodding her head at Tegris.

"I was following her," Lonnie said, nodding at Glimmer.

Adora eyes flashed bluish-white for a moment before Catra said, "Melog is on his tail, remember? Not the time."

Adora calmed down and gave a little nod before turning to Tegris and said, "So, I understand you're a liar and apparently trying to get my girlfriend killed. Start talking. *Now."*

"Hey, it's not like that!" Tegris said, shrinking back into the bench as Lonnie walked around behind them.

Glimmer spun up a spell, the pink colors of the spell tinged here and there with purple and even a little black flickering in and out, as she said, "Oh, don't worry, I know you're not going to lie to me here in a moment."

"Glimmer!" Bow snapped at her and Glimmer gave him a look before frowning and letting the spell go.

"They had someone attack Catra, Bow," she said. "It's just a truth spell."

"No. It's not right," Bow said.

"I'll just tell you! Can I just tell you!?" Tegris said.

"Go ahead," Catra said before giving the others a look to be quiet.

"OK, I… I may not have been really truthful," Tegris began.

"Really? You weren't? Shocking," Lonnie said.

"Let them finish," Bow said and nodded at Tegris to go on like they were all just hanging out and someone had been interrupted.

Tegris nodded back as they said, "So, um, I don't have parents. I mean, I have parents and yeah, they're gone but I'm not a kid." Lonnie gave everyone a knowing look as Tegris went on. "I'm… I'm the one who recruited your mom."

Catra looked at Tegris for a long moment, fighting to keep her rage in check, and didn't realize she was suddenly standing right in front of them.

"Where? Where am I from?"

"I don't know!" Tegris said, shrinking back.

"You knew Saz's name," Catra said, "but you don't remember where you met her? Glimmer can get you talking you know."

"Catra!" Bow said even as Adora was nodding agreement.

"That's not what I meant!" Tegris replied. "I don't know where you're from but I recruited her in Plumeria, just like I said!"

"Then explain why you look like you're from the Waste," Catra said, plucking at their jacket for a moment.

"That's where I live now," Tegris said and Catra's eyes narrowed.

"Listen, nothing I've found says the Horde did a bunch of recruiting in Plumeria," Lonnie said.

"Not a bunch but they did a little and I was the one who did it," Tegris said.

"Where's your files? I want to see them," Lonnie said.

Tegris looked at Lonnie, the irritation on their face breaking through the fear as they said, "You think I kept files that are twenty years old or that I'd still have them after fleeing to the Waste during the occupation? Are you an idiot or just playing one?"

Catra could hear Lonnie's teeth starting to grind as her hands closed to fists.

"We're getting nowhere. Forget all of this, let's get recent. Who attacked me?" Catra said.

Tegris shook their head as they said, "I don't know. Truth spell me, I don't care. I'm done talking."

Adora took a step forward and Catra held a hand backwards as she said, "I just want to know more about her. I need to know if Saz might still be alive somewhere."

Tegris just shrugged and looked at the ground.

"Don't you understand? My earliest memory is the Horde. You said you had parents. I had *no one* I called that. Do you get that? I want to know where I come from," Catra said. She gripped her hands tight, trying to keep the waver out of her voice, hating herself for basically begging. "You know. You know something and you're not telling me. Come on, you have to tell me."

Catra realized she'd gone from wringing her hands to grabbing the front of Tegris' coat when their head snapped up. She let go and turned her back to walk away to the middle of the path where she stared off into the woods. One of the guards showed up with the luggage that Tegris had brought on board the public skiff and Catra was vaguely aware of Glimmer sending Tegris to the Bright Moon dungeon and she was still standing there when Melog came loping out of the trees up to Catra's side.

Adora was standing behind Catra now, not saying anything as Catra knelt down to hug Melog tight. There was a little back and forth between Catra and Melog where she learned that Melog hadn't been able to catch up to the Magicat who'd attacked her. After a little time, Catra looked up to see people walking along the path, curiously looking to see what was going on with the queen and her friends and Catra felt her hackles rising a little as she turned to Glimmer.

"Get me out of her, even if you have to teleport me."

Glimmer nodded and with a sparkle, they were gone.

Chapter End Notes

> OK, I enjoyed this chapter but I just remembered which chapter is after this and I am absolutely stoked to get to writing so I can release the next chapter quickly.

Chapter 16: Chapter Sixteen - Saz

Chapter Summary

> Saz gets called to come meet with an officer. She's not sure why but very quickly finds out it's not to meet with the officer. It's to meet with Shadow Weaver.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?
>
> I should also note, I re-tagged this story because of this chapter. Nothing awful but it's an interrogation by Shadow Weaver, it's not meant to be pleasant.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Saz stood at rigid attention in the small office, not sure what was going on but she tried not to look around. Kedgeree had seemed agitated when she'd ordered Saz to the office, Basco had been missing all day, Kit had been nervous as well, and only Snick had been their usual self and Saz was desperately trying to figure out what was happening. Aleph Squad was supposed to be planning for a joint scouting mission with another one of the squads in the 1st HLRS squadron and Saz didn't want to be late to see Catra since she knew she'd be gone for almost two weeks on the next operation.

The officer, named Konstain, was sitting behind the desk leaned back in her chair, flipping through some paperwork, and not speaking. Every once in a while she'd look up to see Saz still standing at attention, give a little head nod or shrug to show she was still aware of Saz's presence before going back to reading. Saz had changed a lot over the months she'd been in the Horde, she'd learned patience and how to put up with idiocy better for one, but that was wearing thin. Saz was about to put some very pointed words to Konstain when she felt something like a cold

wind had blow over her from behind and she heard a voice she'd learned to fear.

"Thank you, Cohort Major Konstain. You may leave us now."

Saz found herself stiffening up even more as Konstain quickly stacked the paperwork back on the desk and fled as Shadow Weaver flowed around Saz to stand in front of her. Saz barely remembered to snap off a salute as she did her best not to stare at the rippling black shadow of hair that seemed to reach out towards her.

"Trooper Saz of the 1st Horde Long Range Scout squadron," Shadow Weaver said.

Saz waited to see what would come next but when nothing was forthcoming, she figured responding like it was a roll call couldn't hurt.

"Yes, Force Captain, present."

Shadow Weaver sighed as she said, "I'm not a Force Captain, Trooper, though it is a common misconception. I am the will of Lord Hordak, his second in command, and as such, I am above mere rank. I suppose you haven't been told why you have been summoned?"

"No," Saz replied, feeling a bit off balance that she didn't have a rank to address Shadow Weaver by but she knew she was in deep with whatever this was and was desperately trying to figure out what was going on.

Shadow Weaver didn't seem to notice the lack of rank or other title as she folded her hands in front of her and said, "You and I have met before, do you remember?"

Saz thought of those first days in the Horde and running into Shadow Weaver when Catra had gone roaming the halls and repressed a shudder, wondering if this was something to do with Catra.

"Yes, I do."

"Did you know your child has spoken her first word?"

Saz felt her heart break. She didn't know but she fought to hide it away.

"I… no, I had not heard."

"That is why I'm here," Shadow Weaver said and Saz couldn't help but feel like the woman was starting to loom over her. Saz racked her brain, trying to think what Catra might have said that would be the cause of this. She knew kids could be little mimics and she was desperately trying to think what had been said around Catra recently that might have been repeated.

"Don't stand there trying to figure it out," Shadow Weaver said. "Sit down so that I may speak with you when you're not trying to break your spine by standing too straight."

Saz wasn't sure what to say but finally after a moment went and sat in the hard metal chair in front of the desk. Shadow Weaver moved behind the desk but didn't sit as she picked up a folder that Konstain had been reading and flipped through it.

"So as I understand it, you joined the Horde through a recruiter named Tegris in the Waste and had your daughter along with you. Then Tegris routed you around so the little secret about the Waste wasn't revealed and as far as I know, you have kept that little bit quiet as well. You seem to have done quiet well here, working hard, and your daughter seems to be coming along as well. Now, this is not standard procedure what I'm about to ask. As you may have noticed, the Horde does not care where you are from, only that you serve us faithfully, but in this case, I'd like to know why you left the Waste and why you brought what was almost an infant with you."

"I'd… I'd rather not answer that," Saz said.

Shadow Weaver sighed as she glided a little closer.

"I wasn't asking if you wanted to answer it. I expect you to answer it."

Saz tried to stay calm as she said, "I still don't want to answer and would like my squad commander here with me."

Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed as she said, "I see. You will not answer me?"

"I will not and I wish to have my squad commander here with me," Saz repeated, feeling herself shake a little at the look in Shadow Weaver's eyes.

"That is your right under the rules of the Horde," Shadow Weaver replied and Saz felt herself relax a little. "This isn't about the Horde."

Saz started to say something when Shadow Weaver lifted a hand and Saz felt bands of electricity seize her and hold her in place. She tried to grit her teeth to keep from screaming in pain but she still let loose a shriek as Shadow Weaver began to weave a complex spell in front of her. Saz managed to keep herself from screaming again but it was a close thing as she tried not to move.

"Good, don't struggle, it will just hurt so much more and I have questions I will get answers for. Don't worry, if you don't do anything stupid, you'll walk away from this with no memory of the pain."

"I'll kill you for this," Saz spit out and then screamed as the bands shocked her harder, causing her vision to narrow to a tunnel before letting up.

"That's an example of what happens when you're stupid," Shadow Weaver said.

Saz wouldn't remember what happened next. She didn't remember the spell washing over her or the scream that slipped out of her again or the sudden slackening of muscles as she

slumped over and her eyes went unfocused as Shadow Weaver stood over her and assessed her for a moment before speaking.

"Excellent. Trooper Saz, can you understand me?"

"Yes," Saz said, with only a slight hesitation and a bit of a slur, like she'd been drinking just a bit too much.

"What is your HID, squad, and rank?"

Saz paused a second before she rambled them off.

"Very well done, Saz. Sometimes this spell has undesirable side effects but your mind seems to be completely intact. Now for some questions. Why did you leave the Waste?" Saz shook her head, like she didn't want to answer. Shadow Weaver sighed as she said, "No, don't do that. Just answer me. Why did you leave the Waste?"

Saz shook her head again and then jumped a little from a mild shock.

"You don't want that again do you? You'd rather answer the question, I know you do," Shadow Weaver crooned.

"Blood feud," Saz replied finally. "My village… they were trying settle a blood feud and I wouldn't allow them to let Catra be a part of it."

"How interesting. Does she have other family?"

Saz's head bobbed up, lolling to the side for a moment before straightening out.

"Father's dead, related to most of the village one way or other but they'll all kill her if they find her."

"Now why is that?"

Saz shuddered. She didn't answer at first as her eyes drifted around the room for a moment before settling on Shadow Weaver before starting to talk again, only this time in Magicat.

"She was supposed to be hostage, stop fifty years fighting, but she deserved better. Would have been killed if anything breached peace… but… the.. peace always breached."

Shadow Weaver frowned as she said, "No, don't speak whatever gibberish that is. Tell me normally."

Saz's ears flicked as if they were trying to pick up a noise as she looked around before shaking her head and said in Magicat again, "I don't… What?"

"Damn this spell," Shadow Weaver muttered before dragging a finger along Saz's forehead. Saz recoiled and snapped her teeth at Shadow Weaver's hand but she was too slow and Shadow Weaver went on. "Now, tell me again."

"Told you, she would have been hostage, killed."

Shadow Weaver nodded as Saz responded in Bright Moon this time.

"So she would have been a hostage for what exactly?"

"Told you, settle blood feud, killed if peace breached. Probably being looked for now," Saz said and laughed a little, her voice seeming to echo for a second. "Started my own blood feud. My own people, Staed, the other village too probably."

"Is Staed your leader?"

"It's Staed. It's us," Saz said and then shook her head as tears slipped out of her eyes. "No, not us. Not me, not her, not anymore… broke that… but for Catra… always for Catra."

Shadow Weaver stood there watching Saz's head roll back to stare at the ceiling as tears tracked out of her eyes. They were both

silent for a little bit before Shadow Weaver spoke again.

"You love your daughter, don't you?"

Saz's head rolled forward again and she started into Shadow Weaver's eyes.

"To kill for, to die for, to live my life for… we're a village, we're us, five of us, a new us, small but still…"

Saz's sentence faded off, not really ending but Shadow Weaver's eyebrow went up a little as she said, "A village you say? Five of you?"

Saz nodded as she said, "Five."

"They care for her as well? These others?"

"Yes, Basco said so, said she loved me, loved her… I love…"

"Basco? She's a member of your squad so I assume this is your squad, the others you haven't named, that make up this new us as you put it?"

Saz seemed to realize something was off as her eyes narrowed and she didn't say anything. Shadow Weaver placed her hand on the top of Saz's head like a clamp and Saz's eyes rolled back as Shadow Weaver said, "Answer the question."

"Yes," Saz slurred out and Shadow Weaver released her head.

"So, to repeat, you left the Crimson Waste and anyone who'd call you family to save little Catra from the consequences of a blood feud, thereby starting another one, and now you have found new people to help you? Is that correct?"

Saz nodded. Shadow Weaver stood in thought for a moment and Saz surprised her when she spoke.

"Why? Why are you doing this?"

Shadow Weaver frowned. The spell she'd used should have prevented such questions and it was a permanent thing unless removed. She reached out and touched the top of Saz's head and Saz sagged forward, collapsing onto the floor as the bands holding her disappeared. Shadow Weaver thought about her next step, thinking of Catra and how she was bonding with Adora, no matter how much Shadow Weaver tried to intervene. However, with the story she'd got from Saz, she realized a plan she'd been forming was now much more feasible.

When Saz came to, she felt drowsy, and found she was laid out in her bunk. She remembered going to the Cohorot Major's office but she couldn't quite remember what had happened. When she tried to think about it, she just remembered some weird interview about loyalties but the memory felt weirdly off.

"Someone's up finally," Basco said as she scooted onto the bed and gave Saz a kiss.

"What happened?" Saz asked. "Where have you been?"

"I don't even want to get into it," Basco said, rolling her eyes. "I got called out to some furnace to check some upgrade to the armor they're building for our scout skiffs and when I got there I got the run around for fucking hours. As to you, they said when you turned around to leave from the meeting, I guess you got woozy or something, fell, and hit your head. I didn't think you were supposed to be left asleep but the medics looked you over, couldn't find anything, said it was alright if you had someone watching you so, here I am."

"Where's Catra?" Saz said, sitting up and felt like someone had kicked her in the head suddenly.

"Whoa, easy there," Basco said as she steadied Saz. "She's off with Kit and Snick. We brought her in to sit with you but she got really scared and upset at seeing you just, you know, laid out and not moving, so they took her out."

Saz leaned against the wall behind her bunk, something nagging at her mind, because while that seemed like what she remembered, it still kind of felt like something that had happened to someone else.

"Did they say what they thought caused it?" Saz said.

Basco shrugged and said, "They think maybe low blood sugar or low blood pressure or something like that. Who knows? They said they scanned you and it didn't seem to be something that will keep you out of the field and you're fit for duty. Well, once you stop laying around."

"I'm not laying around," Saz said as she moved to get off the bed. She stopped for a second as she felt like she thought she was about to black out as she saw a few shadows shifting in the room like they were trying to hide from her but after a moment she knew she was imagining things and got up off the bed as she ignored the throbbing in her skull.

"There you go," Basco said as she stood up as well and gave her a kiss. "Let's go find Catra and show her you're alright."

Saz nodded and the two left the room as one little flick of shadow followed along after them.

Chapter End Notes

> Was I screaming "Damien!" like a bad imitation of the chorus from the Omen when Shadow Weaver came in? Yes, yes, I was. Also, writing tip for Shadow Weaver: think of the most arrogant, self-righteous person you know and dial that up to eleven. Works every time.
>
> I was a bit worried about this one just because of the content but then I told myself that I'm worrying too much. I try to stick to at least Teen for most of my fics and my ruler to decide if it needs to go up is asking, would this be out of place in the Hunger Games? In this case, no, not in the least. I do try and tag though. That being said, I'm also really

excited for this chapter as well because I love writing Shadow Weaver and I think this is the most villainous I've ever written her (and that includes when she was actively trying to kidnap Finn in one of my series).

What's Catra's first word and will I tell? No spoilers!

Thank you as always for reading and I hope you're enjoying it!

Chapter 17: Chapter Seventeen - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra confronts Tegris about her mother and tries to find out something new. Catra is about to be reminded though that she should be careful about asking because sometimes the answer will change everything.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Everyone around Catra was shouting ideas and trying to come up with solutions but Catra was just sitting in the corner, hugging Melog. Adora was beside her with an arm around her as she talked with Lonnie, Bow, and Glimmer about what to do. Catra hated how she was acting right now, she felt like her mind had come to a screeching halt and she knew she should do something, say something but she wasn't sure what any of that may be. Melog kept telling her that it was alright, that she'd been frightened and this was a normal reaction to it, that it was a good way to know she was healing, but she couldn't help but think she was falling apart when she'd gone through so much worse situations with less reaction.

"I can't believe you wouldn't let me spell them," Glimmer said to Bow.

"Because that's not the way to handle it. It's not right and you know it," Bow said.

"But they were probably involved in an attack on Catra!" Glimmer said.

"Let me talk with them, I'll get an answer," Adora said. "Won't need magic either."

"OK, calm down there, slugger," Lonnie said, shaking her head. Catra heard the little silver beads braided into Lonnie's hair tinkling and found it oddly soothing for some reason. "We're not beating up some random person."

"They're not some random person, they know about Catra's mom, and they probably got someone to try and attack Catra," Adora said. "I'm not going to lay a finger on them but I bet I can put the fear of She-Ra into them."

"I can't believe I'm the voice of reason on this," Lonnie said with a sigh. "You all were involved with the Horde amnesty project and I know you all spoke up about treating everyone well. So was that just bullshit because you won?"

Everyone went silent. Catra felt herself relax a little bit as the silence seemed to soak in and soothe her more than the attempts at planning had while Glimmer was taking an intense interest in her fingernails all of a sudden, Adora was looking at her feet, and Bow was looking at the tops of his shoes. After a minute or so, Lonnie spoke up again.

"I'm just saying, I get it, you're all pissed, but this isn't the way, alright?"

"We just got mad. We would have calmed down," Bow said.

Glimmer gave him a look as she said, "Yeah, we. You know damn well you were arguing against it."

"Well we're together on this," Bow said. "So we."

"Well don't lump me into that we but I get what you're saying. Now what do we do?" Lonnie replied.

Catra suddenly stood up and everyone in the room turned to look at her.

"You alright?" Adora said as she started to get to her feet.

"No, stay sitting," Catra said. "I'm going to the kitchens, get something to eat. Any of you want something?"

"I can just have someone bring us a snack tray," Glimmer said, although what Bright Moon called a snack tray was more of a small mobile buffet.

"No, no, I just need to walk, get some tension out," Catra said as she started backing towards the door.

"I'll come with you," Adora said and Catra shook her head.

"I just need a moment, alright!?" Catra said and then took a deep breath as she realized she'd shouted before going on in a more normal tone. "I just need a moment, OK? I'm alright, I just need some quiet to myself."

Adora just nodded and Catra was out the door before anyone else could say anything. Melog was right on her heels asking a question and Catra frowned.

"I really do need to walk some tension off. I'm just not walking to the kitchen to do it."

Catra swore she heard Melog sigh but chose not to address it.

It didn't take long to get to the Bright Moon dungeon. Catra had heard it described as a horrible prison, with only a few choices of hand soap and only several sizes of throw pillows along along with only three options for each meal but, having seen two actually real horrible prisons, she had to keep from laughing when she heard people whisper about the Bright Moon one. At any rate, when she got to it and saw the Bright Moon guard at the desk, looking for all the world like a heavily armed concierge at a middle budget hotel, she still felt awkward.

"Hey, I'm here to see someone who was brought in today," Catra said and then tacked on, "if that's OK."

The guard nodded as she replied, "Sure, we don't restrict visitors. Is it Tegris?"

Catra took a breath and then said, "Yes, that's them."

"I'll see if they want to talk to you," the guard said as she tapped at a data pad on the desk. "They might not want to and we're not going to make them."

"I understand," Catra said. "I'll wait here."

"I should have an answer in a moment," the guard said.

It turned out to be almost ten minutes before there was a response and Catra was getting more and more nervous the longer it took. She was sure someone was going to come looking for her and she couldn't figure out why but she was terrified of getting found out. She kept rubbing the scar tissue at the back of her neck and then stopping herself as she waited and was about to tell the guard to forget it when she heard the data pad chime.

The guard looked at it for a moment before saying, "OK, you may go back but no one else."

The guard was looking at Melog and Catra said, "This is Melog. I'm not going without them."

The guard didn't respond but typed for a moment, waited, and the response shot back almost immediately.

"OK, you both can go."

Catra felt a sigh of relief slip out as the guard guided her back to the room where Tegris was staying. After a brief discussion of proper etiquette, the guard went on her way and Catra entered the room to find Tegris leaned back in an easy chair and reading a book.

"Comfy?"

Tegris looked up at her in a nonchalant manner that she was pretty sure they weren't actually feeling since the hardback book's cover was actually bending a little from the grip they had on it.

"Very, thank you for asking."

Catra stood there trying to think of what to say while Tegris tried to act like they were reading but were really stealing glances at Catra, waiting to see what she was going to do. After a moment, Catra went over to the small wet bar concealed in the wall and opened it up. She went through the limited drink selection, only five different flavors of fizzy drink, a few assorted mixers and snacks, and only one wine, beer, and hard alcohol selection each, as she tried to think what to say. Tegris for their part was sitting up as they looked at what Catra was doing.

"I, um, didn't know that was there," Tegris said as Catra filled a tall glass with ice and poured a fizzy drink into it that promised a grape explosion of flavor on the side of the bottle. Catra took a sip of the neon green liquid before she finally responded.

"I know. It's part of the punishment that they expect you to find it yourself."

"Wait, they really think this is punishment?" Tegris said.

Catra shrugged as she said, "Bright Moon style, yes. They'd call it rehabilitation though."

Tegris shook their head as they said, "I will never get these people."

Catra snorted as she said, "Join the club."

A brief tension hung in the air before Tegris quietly said, "So, um, could I get a drink?"

"No."

Catra shut the cabinet as Melog looked at her and she tried not to look back at them.

Tegris got to their feet, the book held tight to their chest, as they said, "I can't help but notice no one else is with you."

"Melog is, they're not no one but otherwise, yeah, just like you asked."

"But the guard said no one else was with you."

Catra looked at Tegris and silence dropped between them as Tegris tried to ask their next question. Finally, it came out.

"Am I about to find out what Force Captain Catra considers punishment?"

Catra couldn't help but notice they tried to say it calm and cool but their voice shook. She hadn't come down to do that but she'd still planned on her reputation to help her out. It turned out it was helping and she was ashamed. She sat the glass down on a side table by the couch and sighed as she turned back to the wet bar to open it.

"No, you're not. What do you want?"

"Nothing, I'm fine, really."

Catra turned her head to glare at them and Tegris cleared his throat as they said, "Just hand me one of the cherry fizzies. No glass."

Catra nodded and handed the drink to them and as they took it, she suddenly realized she'd just handed someone who could very well want her dead, enough to hire an assassin maybe, a heavy club or sharp weapon depending on how they used it. Tegris didn't seem to be thinking along those lines though as they fiddled with the pop top before using the edge of the coffee table to pop it off.

"Thanks," Tegris said.

"Sure," Catra said as she picked her glass up and took a sip. "Why are you doing this? Why did you lie?"

"Why should I tell you anything?" Tegris said, suddenly on the defensive again.

"Because you had to have some reason for this," Catra said. "I want to know. I'll even try and get you out of this if you help me."

Tegris shrugged as they said, "I didn't do anything illegal. I lied to you and then tried to leave Bright Moon. No rehabilitation tribunal is going to hold me over that."

"Maybe you tried to hire someone to kill me," Catra said.

"I didn't hire someone to kill you so best of luck proving that," Tegris said as they fiddled with the bottle before taking a sip.

Catra just stood in silence and stared, feeling the cold of the glass seeping into her fingertips.

"OK, fine, I did lie but still, I didn't hire someone to kill you, I'm not freaking Shadow Weaver," Tegris said. "I came here to give you a nudge in the right direction, that's it, so you'd know more. The thing about my parents, that was just so I didn't have to admit to Horde ties, people are still weird about that."

"They are," Catra said, thinking of the looks she got sometimes, even when she was with her friends. Though she had to admit that she wasn't the typical Horde solider or clone. Then she processed the first part of Tegris' statement. "Wait, you knew Shadow Weaver?"

Tegris shrugged as they said, "I knew of her and her reputation."

"You know she…," Catra said as she sat down and then trailed off as she realized raised was the wrong word.

"Listen, I don't know much about her other than she scared the shit out of a lot of people," Tegris said. "I heard she defected to Bright Moon finally."

Catra felt the old anger stir in her at the memory of being betrayed but shook it off as she said, "She didn't defect. She only had one side and it was her own."

Tegris just shrugged as they said, "You'd know better than I would. I was never a sworn member of the Horde so I wasn't around her."

Another memory came up, of the Horde swearing in when they had all turned eight, when they were thought of as old enough to fully understand what it meant and how proud Catra had stood as she'd said the words of the oath. It was a rare moment when Shadow Weaver had seemed to think Catra had done something right, even though most of her praise had been for Adora.

"Then why would you even work for them?" Catra said trying to not think about it.

Tegris just shrugged as they said, "I needed work. I wasn't Horde, I wasn't Alliance, and you can get awful lonely out there flapping around like a loose end."

Catra frowned as she thought of her life, how she'd felt like a loose end herself so many times, even at what she had thought of her highest point at the time, when she'd finally shown the world by overrunning Salineas. Of course she knew now that wasn't a high, it'd been a low, almost the lowest she'd ever been and she knew what she'd done at that time. Melog pushed up against her and she shook her head at them before turning back to Tegris.

"How do I know I can believe you on any of this? Lonnie says your Plumeria connection is pretty damn thin."

Tegris walked over towards a large kinetic sculpture that sat next to the bed. The sculpture gave a quiet tinkling noise as Tegris gave it a little push and points of light flicked around the room as

well from tiny motion activated lights inside of it. Tegris waited a second and then looked at the ceiling before speaking.

"Listen, I'm just trying to keep it close to the chest because… well, just because, alright? I know, I know, I gave you a bunch of bullshit but have I ever actually changed my story on the core of it?"

"So because you're more consistent in your bullshit, then I should believe you? Come on, I wasn't born yesterday."

"I know when you were born," Tegris said as they turned around and Catra's temper flared a little at the casual way they said it.

"Fuck you, no you don't," Catra said.

Tegris sighed as they said, "OK, maybe not exactly but I knew you before just about anyone else knew you. Well, not knew you, you were barely a toddler being carried around by your mom at that point and you didn't talk but before Etheria knew the name Catra, I knew it."

"So what, you want a cookie or something?" Catra said.

Tegris nodded towards a little basket sitting by the door as they said, "I could use one. These conditions are intolerable. They only have biscotti in that."

Catra chuckled in spite of herself as she looked towards the basket and then took a drink to hide the chuckle. They both sat quietly for a minute as Tegris looked at the ground and seemed to come to a conclusion in their head.

"Do you really want to know where you're from?"

Catra fought down a surge of hot anger before she said, "Yes, or I wouldn't be here."

Tegris sat down across from her as they said, "Will you keep it secret?"

"Why would I do that?" Catra said.

Tegris frowned as they said, "I mean where you learned it from. I can't have it traced back to me, alright?"

"This is getting deep," Catra said. "Well, Bright Moon needs more fertilizer for the gardens, so load on the bullshit."

Tegris shook their head as they said, "No, I'm serious. I'll tell you where you're from and where your mother was from in more detail but you can't ever let it be known it was me. Promise me."

Catra took a long drink before she sat the glass down on the table.

"I won't promise you, you don't get that from me, but I'm not going to go around blabbing. That's the best deal you're going to get."

Tegris cursed under their breath and looked away before finally shaking their head in disgust and turning back. They laced their fingers together and stared at them for a moment before starting to talk.

"So, normally I didn't really get to know the recruits I dealt with but your mom, she was different, it was weird that she showed up with you and it's not like you saw a lot of Magicats back then so I got to talking with her while I waited the few days for transportation to the Fright Zone," Tegris said. "And… shit I shouldn't be saying this… your mom was on the run."

"Yeah, you've said all that," Catra said, leaning forward in spite of herself.

"I know, it's this next part… shit, really, don't tell anyone you heard this from me… but your mom…," Tegris said and went silent for a second before taking a deep breath and going on. "She was a high priestess of Half Moon and running from several bad situations. You came with her because she was scared to leave you behind."

Catra blinked once, twice, and then laughed.

"Are you fucking kidding me!? You don't think we checked with Half Moon when they revealed themselves to see if that's where I was from!?"

"You don't believe me?"

"No, I don't fucking believe you. Try again."

Tegris slowly shook their head as they frowned.

"Listen, I'm telling you the truth. Get your little friend down here if you want, hit me with a truth spell, hit me with a stun baton, do whatever, but I'm telling the truth."

Catra rolled her eyes as she took a drink before saying, "Even if it's true, why would they try and kill me? What's the point? They've known about me for a while now."

Tegris shook their head as they said, "But no one knew about your mother until recently. It's fine if you're just some random Magicat but if you're the daughter of their escaped high priestess, the daughter who should have been trained in the mysteries of that position, well, that's different. Don't believe me, fine, but ask yourself, have they ever been super friendly with you?" Catra sat up a little, her ears folded back, as Tegris went on. "They act like they're the only Magicats that matter on the planet and hold the rest in contempt. They're just good at putting up a front even while they try to act all high and mighty but they'd do anything to keep their reputation intact. A priestess of their goddess, a high priestess at that, running away with her kid would have been a huge problem, especially back then."

"You can't really expect me to believe this," Catra said, although she did admit that the Half Moon people were a bit aloof, though she knew that they weren't that bad once you got past that. Even while she thought that, doubt waggled its tail in her head.

"Do or don't believe it but because of your mom I knew about them before almost anyone else did, back when they were doing anything to keep their secret kingdom hidden in that cave in Plumeria, and that's why I bounced on the recruiting gig. I didn't want to end up dead in some Plumerian grove because I knew they existed and they'd come looking for your mom. It's why I'm trying to do this quietly now, because I still don't know what kind of grudges they might hold and a Magicat trying to carve you up sure seems like a grudge doesn't it?"

Catra was shaking her head and Melog was trying to ask her questions. She held her hand out to Melog to let them know to hang on for just a moment. She was about to speak when Tegris went on.

"Listen, I get it, it's hard to believe but try this. Ask them the third name of their goddess, the one their high priestess takes as a sacred name when she assumes the position, and see what they say, see how they react."

"What is it?" Catra said.

"No, you don't believe me. Ask them. See what they say," Tegris said. "I've told you the truth and I'm done. You ask them, see if they'll even answer you."

"I will," Catra said and stalked out the door with Melog hot on her heels. When she got to the front desk, she ran almost headlong into Adora.

"What are you doing here!?"

"Where's Glimmer?" Catra said, as Melog paced behind her.

"She's trying to find you with Bow," Adora said and saw Catra's swishing tail and laid back ears. "Hey, what's going on? Did you talk to Tegris? What did they do to you!?"

"Nothing, forget about them. I need to find Glimmer because I need to talk to the Half Moon ambassador. Today."

The rest of the day was a mess of politics as Glimmer arranged the meeting. Catra just paced in a room, Melog right on her heels, as she waited and refused to answer almost any questions. Finally, the Half Moon ambassador to Bright Moon, a short jet black Magicat named Speleo, came walking into the room with Glimmer and Bow. Lonnie was already in the room with Adora and Catra stopped pacing when Speleo came in and gave the ambassador the shortest of bows to try and keep this friendly.

"I understand this is extremely important?" Speleo said, her voice smooth and quiet.

"Yes. Remember when we approached you about my mother a little while ago?" Catra said.

Speleo smiled as she said, "Of course. The princess rumor you had learned about. Is that what this is about?"

"Partly," Catra said, leaning forward onto the back of the couch as she tried to keep her voice even. She was cursing herself in her head but she'd had Tegris' words eating away at her for hours now and she had to know. "I've become privy to some new information and I have a single question for you."

Catra's friends were looking at her but she didn't pay them mind, keeping her eyes fixed on Speleo.

"Of course, what is that?"

"What is the third name of your goddess?"

Speleo's eyes widened as she said, "I'm sorry… what… why are you asking that?"

"It's a simple question. What is the third name of your goddess, the one that your high priestess takes as a sacred name when she assumes the position?"

Speleo was fighting to maintain her diplomatic composure as she said, "That's… that's not normally talked about."

"With outsiders you mean," Catra said.

"Well, that's a negative spin on it but no, it's not," Speleo said.

"I'm asking you to do it though," Catra said. "It's important."

Speleo was shaking her head as she said, "It's not… who told you to ask this?"

"Catra, what are you trying to do?" Bow said as he stepped up to her, his voice quiet.

"Just tell me," Catra said, ignoring Bow.

Bow turned to Speleo as he said, "Is it something sacred?"

"Yes," Speleo said. "It's not that… well, it's not that it's something completely hidden but it's only supposed to be spoken during rituals. Clarion is her known name, the one we speak normally, and her second name is spoken as an invocation to her. The third name is only spoken in rituals, it's the name of strength."

"Could you write it out?" Bow said. "Would that be alright?"

Catra's eyes were fixed on Speleo and her tail was slowly lashing back and forth while her ears were pointed straight ahead. She remembered how Half Moon had denied her and she had an idea what the name was as she leaned forward a little.

"I mean, I guess, but I'm… Your Majesty, I am not comfortable with this at all," Speleo said, turning to Glimmer. "I wish you'd warned me about this."

"It's Saz isn't it?" Catra said before Glimmer could respond and Speleo snapped back to look at her. The look on her face reminded Catra of when she's first asked if Saz had been a princess but the laughter had come almost immediately on the heels and Catra hadn't given it any thought at the time. Now Catra remembered the look and saw it for what it was, profound discomfort and Catra realized that Speleo had never actually said

Saz's name during that first meeting. She'd only referred to her as Catra's mom or just her mother.

Speleo opened her mouth a few times and then finally slowly nodded her head.

"Yes, it is."

Chapter End Notes

I meant to have this posted several days ago but I kept re-writing and revising it. It was originally about 2200 words. It's about four thousand now. It got changed a BUNCH but I'm happy with it now. Well, happy enough to post it because if I don't, I think I could revise this one for awhile.

I will never get tired of describing the Bright Moon prison like it's some hellhole while describing its various amenities.

And as to Saz's name… dun dun DUNNNNNNNN!

So fun trivia fact, that I may have said previously but can't remember, Saz's name is not something I just came up with. It's a reference to the original She-Ra and He-Man from the 1980's. I was doing a little side search on Magicats to see if I could find anything interesting to round this out with and I happened to come across a reference to Magicat's using the phrase "Saz's whiskers!" and I thought, "I like that name. I'm absolutely naming Catra's mother that."

Chapter 18: Chapter Eighteen - Saz

Chapter Summary

> Saz and squad get back from a patrol to relax, spend time with toddler Catra, and find out they're going to have to go out very soon on their longest mission yet to the Kingdom of Snow in winter.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next few months went by quickly. Saz thought she might be having mental problems from her collapse as she kept thinking she saw shadows out the corner of her eye but when she went to look, she never spotted anything out of the ordinary. She thought about saying something but the thought of mentioning it filled her with dread that she'd be taken out of her squadron and reassigned away from Aleph Squad. And Basco. She had to admit that scared her the most. If she got assigned to some administrative squadron, she'd have a hard time seeing Basco and she knew it but it also conflicted her because if she was in an administrative squadron, she'd not have to leave Catra behind so much. It was only seeing her happy each time she came to the creche, no matter how long it'd been, that kept her on edge wondering if she was doing the right thing by not mentioning it.

When she went out into the field a few days after she had her fainting spell, she didn't have any problems though. Everything went well, they scouted the castle of Dryl, almost got overrun with bots from out of nowhere, and then came back to report that whatever was going on there, it wasn't the best idea to get too close without more force.

Saz finally began to realize she only had the issues with the shadows when she was in the Fright Zone and because it was

already a dark and shadowy place, she just figured that's how it was and didn't think much more of it. Several more missions slipped past, most with nothing to note, and Saz began to wonder just where in the world the Princess Alliance were hiding their forces. Information seemed to indicate that Queen Angella and King Micah were building up forces inside of Bright Moon but the Whispering Woods was a formidable barrier and no one wanted to risk crossing it to scout and for once the high command of the Horde seemed to agree with its soldiers and no order to try was given. Most of their scouting ended up being in the prairies and forests around Wheatland, a town that the Horde had occupied and used for grain shipments into the Fright Zone, and Saz did have to admit, some of those missions did end up being fruitful.

After one of those missions, the whole squad got back to their squadron bay as Snick collapsed back onto their bunk as their arms flopped out around them. Catra, who Basco had just got from the creche since Saz was with Kit giving a report to Kedgeree, ran up to them and jumped up onto Snick's stomach. Snick could barely tell, since they were still wearing their armor, but they smiled all the same and reached up to tickle under their chin, something even Saz couldn't normally get away with.

Catra giggled as Snick said, "Hey there, little fuzzy. Miss us?"

Catra gave a quick nod as she said, "Yes!"

Basco sat down at Snick's feet as she said, "She almost didn't want to leave. She's making friends fast in there."

Snick grinned at the news as they made a little scuttling motion with their hand as they said to Catra, "Here comes Mx. Spider! What are you going to do!?" Catra swatted at Snick's hand trying to catch it as Snick turned to Basco. "Saz will be happy to hear that. Bet you are too."

"You know you are too," Basco said, grinning and looking away.

"Yep," Snick said, before tickling Catra's stomach and then jerking their hand away when Catra tried to catch their hand with her teeth. "OK, sorry hon! No tummy tickles."

"No," Catra said, shaking her head before smiling again. "Spider!"

"Here they are!" Snick said, running their hand along the mattress of the bed.

The three played for a few more minutes before Saz and Kit came back. Basco and Snick both had advanced warning because Catra stopped being interested in the clapping game they were trying to teach her and sat up with her ears straight in the air and pointed towards the door. A few seconds later, she took off scampering down the middle of the squadron bay on all fours, dodging around people and then leaping into the air to be caught by Saz.

"Mommy!" Catra said, burying her face into Saz's neck and hugging her tight.

"Hello, little fuzzy," Saz said in Magicat to Catra as she hugged her tight. "I missed you."

The mission had lasted for a week and Saz was exhausted. They'd found a base that was being supplied by the Salineas pirate princess and had been chased by him along with his hand picked force of pirates and brigands and all accompanied by King Micah himself for days. They'd hardly slept, keeping up almost constant movement as they worked to evade and circle back to get to their skiff. They'd finally succeeded only to almost lose anyway when Micah had used magic to stop the skiff dead in the air. It'd turned into a fight, stun batons and fists against pirate sabers and magic, and only Snick distracting Micah long enough to get the spell to drop had allowed them to get on the skiff and fly away, plowing through the upper limbs of tree branches in the process to try and stay low and out of the line of any followup spells.

All of that was gone for a moment though as Catra nudged her head up under Saz's chin and purred away in contentment. Saz

leaned down and took a deep breath, the scent of Catra filling her nostrils and she felt her whole body relax knowing her child was safe.

"If you don't mind, I'm going to wash this stink off me," Snick said as they stood up. A few other soldiers in the room heard them and made comments to the effect that they'd appreciate that greatly, though, since they were soldiers, it was said much more profane and louder.

"Thanks for watching her," Saz said, not looking up at Snick as Basco scooted closer to Saz.

"Hey, she's one of us," Snick said as they patted Saz's shoulder. Saz looked up with a tired smile on her face but said nothing as Basco leaned in to wiggle her fingers at Catra.

Snick went on and Basco and Saz played with Catra a little before Kit came back with a frown on her face and the little gills under her mushroom cap head flickering. They all recognized it as agitation as Kit sat on a footlocker.

"What's up?" Basco asked.

"They want us to go back up into the Kingdom of Snow," Kit said. "Soon."

"Wait, what?" Basco said as Catra pounced up on a ball of rolled up socks that Saz had rolled to the head of the bed. "Most of it is a frigid nightmare up there right now and the border towns will be that way any time now!"

"I know, I've had that argument but command thinks that the Rebellion will be moving tons of supplies and equipment under cover of the storms," Kit said.

"That's ridiculous," Saz said as she watched Catra bat around the ball of socks. "The skiffs are barely rated for that cold. We'll have no end of mechanical problems and that's no even touching on us and how cold we'll be. Never mind that the Rebellion doesn't even

have that kind of heavy hauling capacity. Are they going to load a bunch of mules with supplies and haul them over the mountains?"

"I mentioned that," Kit said. "Frequently and stridently until Kedgeree told me to lay off or I'd possibly face charges."

Everyone except Catra, who was busy shredding a pair of socks, thought of the detention block and shuddered a little.

"We did do that round of cold weather training," Basco said.

Saz looked at her with her ears twitching as she said, "Camping out in a field near Wheatland when it got a little chilly is not cold weather training and the other stuff we did up there doesn't count either."

"Well, it's stamped on all of our records that we did it," Kit said. "So we're expected to know how and I think Snick knows some stuff as well. I'll check with them when they get back."

"And their serious about this?" Basco said.

"Very," Kit said.

"It's stupid," Saz said as she helped Catra get her claws unstuck from the fabric.

"I think we can do it," Kit said. "Doesn't mean I think it's going to be easy but I think we can."

"Yeah but you're in charge, you're supposed to think that," Basco said.

Kit snorted as she said, "I'm in charge of you three and you three argue with me constantly."

"Because we care," Basco said.

Saz said, "Speak for yourself, I'm not getting us killed."

"It was joking, sweetheart," Basco said.

Saz frowned as she said, "I don't see the humor."

"I know you have a sense of humor," Kit said. "Maybe just not after this last mission. We can talk about this later, how about we get the routine stuff done."

Saz nodded as she scooped Catra up on to her hip and gave her a kiss on her forehead.

"Fine, we're going to get cleaned up," Saz said.

"No," Catra said with a little hiss.

"Yes," Saz said as she kissed her on the forehead again.

"No," Catra said again and Basco laughed. Catra smiled at her as Saz rolled her eyes.

"Don't encourage her," Saz said.

"You know you like it when she pushes back."

"Yes but it's not cute right now," Saz said as she started towards the door as Catra started to chant no over and over at her.

Basco got up to follow when Kit shook her head and held a hand out.

"Nope, I need to go over the engagement details on this next one with you," Kit said.

Saz waved at Basco real quick and said, "See you in a bit."

Catra waved at Basco and Basco waved back as they left the room before she turned to Kit.

"Listen, I'm ready to spend time with her that isn't hiding or running or screaming so what is it that's so important.

Kit waited a moment longer to be sure Saz was well out of hearing range before she started to say, "Listen, on the last op…"

"Don't. I would have done that for anyone," Basco said, turning back to Kit.

"But it always seems to be for her," Kit said.

"Because she's on point so she's usually the one in trouble," Basco said.

"Well, you almost left Snick hanging to get into that fight by her side," Kit said.

"Because we're too short handed," Basco hissed, her voice low as she looked around to make sure no one was close enough to overhear them. "We need at least two more people on this squad, ideally four. This four person shit is fine when we're doing full squadron maneuvers and our squads can support each other but we're going to get ourselves killed trying to do this without any kind of support."

"I've mentioned it to the higher ups, multiple times, but they just keep pointing out we're still succeeding," Kit said.

"We're getting lucky and you damn well know it," Basco said. "If they'd been just a minute or two early on this one, we'd have been screwed so of course I'm going to fight hard, it's my damn job."

"Listen, I wasn't calling you out on it and I haven't reported it or anything, I just need… damn it, I don't know what I need anymore," Kit said as she sagged against one of the top bunk supports. "I know you're right but…"

Kit trailed off and just shook her head. Basco patted Kit on the back as she leaned into her.

"I know. I know you're trying; I'm just being a pain in the ass and you're not really wrong. Who thought I'd find love here of all places? I know I've told Saz to wait, it's not really that long, but shit like this week or having to go out to the Kingdom of Snow in

fucking winter… it just makes you want to just let it all go, doesn't it?" Basco said.

Kit didn't respond at first, she just looked at Basco before looking around the room again to be sure no one had heard what Basco had said. Then Kit leaned in close.

"Yeah, yeah it does. I'm right there with you about just saying fuck it and bail."

Basco patted Kit on the shoulder again and neither noticed the little shadow flicking its way out from under the bunk and towards the exit.

Chapter End Notes

> Mmmm, that's some good exposition. I don't have much to say on this one, just that I'm enjoying writing the squad and toddler Catra. I've got another very short chapter that I'll probably post up in a day or so that comes right after this one. I'm breaking my pattern of alternating between Saz and Catra on viewpoint and doing someone else. Who may it be? :)

Chapter 19: Chapter Nineteen - Shadow Weaver

Chapter Summary

Shadow Weaver plans.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shadow Weaver held the little shadow in her hand and let it twine itself around her fingers as she thought, absorbing what she'd just learned from it as she stared at the Black Garnet. The creche worker standing before her was visibly shaking after answering some questions about Catra and how she was settling in quite nicely, making little friends and everything. Including Adora.

"I… I can keep an eye on her," the creche worker said.

Shadow Weaver didn't answer, just looked at the file that the worker had placed on her desk. She flipped through it, the records of Catra's progress and other little details. As the silence stretched further and further on the creche worker started to lean back towards the door, like her head had decided to leave but her feet hadn't quite made up their minds yet.

"Is there… is there anything else?" the creche worker said.

"Yes," Shadow Weaver said as she finished thinking. She flowed around the desk towards the worker. "No need to keep a special eye on her. I can handle that."

"OK. And of course, I won't say anything, like you told me at the beginning," the creche worker said.

"I know you won't," Shadow Weaver said as she gently touched the creche worker on her forehead.

The creche worker stiffened up and her eyes went glassy. Shadow Weaver held her hand there for some time and then released the creche worker.

"Go on now and don't forget, you've kept that paperwork updated, it's not missing," Shadow Weaver said.

The creche worker gave a slow nod, as if she was sleepwalking, and left the room.

Shadow Weaver turned to the Black Garnet and began to plan. Adora showed so much promise but was also starting to show a willful side. A lever was needed that could help keep Adora in line with her potential, something that Adora cared about. Or someone.

Chapter End Notes

> Not much to say here except that I love writing villains and Shadow Weaver has shoved her way to the top of the list here.

Chapter 20: Chapter Twenty - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra confronts the ambassador of Half Moon about whether or not they tried to have her killed.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You lied to me!" Catra screamed. "You said I wasn't from Half Moon!"

"You asked if your mother was a princess of Half Moon! She wasn't… we don't have one… and she wouldn't be from Half Moon, especially with that name!" Speleo said, her voice shaking. "It's… *blasphemous*!"

"Did you send that person to try and fucking kill me today!?" Catra said as she picked up a pillow in a stranglehold. "Did you!? Are you trying to hide some secret!?"

"What!? Someone tried to kill you!?" Speleo said, her eyes going wide in shock as her ears plastered back onto her head in horror.

"Let's try and calm down. I'm sure we can figure this out," Bow said as he went to stand between the two.

"Don't you tell me to calm down!" Catra said as she gripped the pillow tighter and felt fluff starting to seep between her fingers as her claws sank into the pillow without her even noticing. She tried to throw the pillow aside but it was stuck to her hand and fluff spilled out as she shook to try and free it.

"Don't you yell at him!" Glimmer said as she stood up from where she'd sat down. Catra cursed and pulled the pillow apart to free it

from her hands. She was turning to yell at Glimmer when Adora stepped right in front of her.

"Catra, hey, look at me. It's alright, look at me."

Catra was half-growling and for a moment her eyes met Adora's and Adora felt the old fear shoot down her spine at the look she saw in them. Catra saw the flash of fear across Adora's face and her anger blew out like a match in a gale to be replaced by a flood of shame.

Another Magicat stepped into the room as Adora whispered to Catra. Everything about her seemed to be normal, from their plain grey fur and Bright Moon-style clothes in a reserved cut, and the only thing that stood out were her eyes, calculating as they flicked around the room taking everything in, and the well used curved dagger in one hand. Speleo shook her head at them as she said, "Tinz, it's alright. Just tempers flaring, a little misunderstanding."

Tinz's voice sounded grave as she said, "That didn't sound like a misunderstanding."

"It's alright, really," Speleo said. "Go on back outside, please."

Tinz looked between Speleo and the rest of the room before she said, "No, I think I'll be staying."

"Tinz…," Speleo started to say when Bow interrupted.

"I'm sorry, ambassador, but it's alright with the Crown if she stays," Bow said and Tinz looked at him and Bow could tell she was trying to see some trick. "I wouldn't want to leave Glimmer if I felt she wasn't 100% safe."

Tinz gave a brief nod and moved beside Speleo while Adora continued to talk to Catra.

"What's going on? You know you can tell me," Adora whispered after she'd worked Catra through a few exercises to calm her down.

"I… I talked to Tegris and they said some things that made sense," Catra whispered back.

"Oh, honey, no," Adora said.

"I know, I'm stupid," Catra said.

"You're… ok, yeah, that's kind of stupid," Adora said.

Lonnie cleared her throat and said, "Do we need to come back? Maybe when Catra isn't feeling so homicidal?"

"Lonnie!" Bow replied.

Catra actually snorted when she heard that and pulled back from Adora's shoulder as she said, "You always were so tactful."

Bow threw his arms up in the air and went to go sit on a chair off to the side.

Adora was nudging Catra who swatted at her hand as she said, "I know, I know." She took a deep breath and looked at Speleo as she wrung her hands. "Listen, that was… it was uncalled for but…"

Speleo held a hand up to stop Catra as she said, "Something is obviously going on that centers on you; I'm not going to hold the Crown accountable."

The last bit was said to Glimmer who gave a little head bow and said, "Thank you for understanding. Just for clarification, she does not represent the Crown."

"But she is a part of your alliance and holds a seat in your councils so again, I will not hold this against the Crown," Speleo said.

Catra was silently cursing herself for losing her temper over what was probably some bullshit that Tegris had fed her, especially since Speleo was right, she was a part of the Princess Alliance, even if she wasn't a princess, no matter how much Adora teased

her about it when they were laying around in bed. She took another deep breath and tried to be diplomatic as she said, "Someone tried to kill me today, another Magicat, and some information I've come across has led me to believe you may not have been honest about some things the last time we met. Add in what we've just discovered about my mother, Saz," Catra said just to see Speleo twitch a little at the name and Tinz's eyes narrow at the word because Catra wasn't quite ready to play too nice, "and some things seemed quite plausible."

"Who told you this?" Speleo said. "Perhaps that will help us figure out what is going on."

"I'm not going to tell you," Catra said. "Let's start with who tried to kill me today."

"Surely you don't think we'd send someone after you," Speleo said. "Never mind that it'd be a possible declaration of war against the Alliance to kill one of their own, why would we bother?"

"Because I may have found something out that I'm not supposed to know," Catra said.

"The third name of the Goddess?" Speleo said. "I know we're considered to be secretive but that's not a kill someone secret. It's not even a secret really, it's just private."

"So you do have kill someone secrets," Catra said.

Speleo rolled her eyes as she said, "I'm not going to dignify that with a response. Do you want to tease this apart? It's going to take some trust."

"Come on, Catra, you know trust. Or have at least heard of it," Lonnie said.

Catra glared at Lonnie as she said, "You're not helping."

"Well you're being an idiot. I'm guessing you went and saw Tegris and they gave you some line of bullshit and now you're here

acting like a damn fool. We're not the Horde and this isn't the war, talk with the woman and give her some trust," Lonnie said.

"Wait, who is Tegris?" Speleo said.

"They're someone we have in the dungeon right now," Glimmer said as she ran her hand down her face with a sigh.

"You took the word of a criminal about whatever this is!?" Tinz said.

"Hey, they're not a criminal!" Bow said. "Never mind they haven't faced a rehabilitation panel yet, we don't talk about people like that!"

Tinz looked at Speleo, who was glaring back at her, and shrugged.

"But they are sitting in your dungeon as you put it," Speleo said.

Bow nodded as he said, "Well, OK, yeah, but they're not being mistreated."

"You sure? I've heard the stories of the horrors of the Bright Moon dungeon," Tinz said with enough sarcasm to stun a rhino.

"OK, we're getting off track," Speleo said. "Can we get them up here and we can all talk together?"

"Excellent idea," Adora said. "I'll see to it."

"Adora…," Glimmer said.

"Oh, sorry," Adora said.

"No, just… never mind," Glimmer said, shaking her head. "I'll give the order. I don't want to find out if the guard will follow you or not the hard way. How about you get the kitchen to send something up?"

At that Speleo lost her quiet composure and gave an honest smile as she said, "Could you have them send up some of that fish you

had at the last conference?"

"Can do," Adora said.

The room became a little calmer as Glimmer picked up a wall phone and Bow began to talk with Tinz and Speleo, doing a little last smoothing over as Catra began picking up the bits of pillow she'd shredded. She was frowning at how silly she'd been when Lonnie came over and handed her a tassel off the floor.

"I don't want to hear it," Catra said.

"I've already said it," Lonnie said. "You scared her, you know that, right?" The last bit was said quietly and Catra looked over to Speleo but Lonnie was shaking her head. "Not her."

Catra immediately though of Adora and the shame squeezed tighter on her.

"Yeah, I… I saw it."

"Make it up with her."

"You're not my damn Listener," Catra snapped and then took a deep breath. "Shit, sorry."

"You can't keep fucking up and saying sorry either," Lonnie said and then added, "but yeah, I accept it. This time."

"You know you have your own faults too," Catra said.

"But mine aren't as charming," Lonnie said.

"It's not charming," Catra said.

"You're right, they're not, but Adora seems to think so. It's the only reason I get why Adora puts up with you," Lonnie said with a little teasing tone to her voice.

"You really are just pushing it aren't you?" Catra said, a little smile on her face for a moment.

"Please. I can still take you at least one fall out of two and Rogelio would obliterate you if you tried anything anyway," Lonnie said.

"And Kyle?" Catra asked.

"Oh, fighting isn't where his skills lay. He's much better at other things," Lonnie said, her grin turning positively lascivious.

Catra mimed throwing up as she said, "Forget I asked."

Lonnie just chuckled as the phone on the wall rung and Glimmer picked it up.

"Hello? Yes, it's Glimmer… what do you mean? Are you fucking kidding me!? HOW!? No, no, yes, sorry, get moving, keep it quiet, and let me know. Who's involved? Well who am I to say no, just get moving, please, and keep me up to date."

"What's happening?" Speleo said.

"Tegris isn't in their room and no one knows where they went," Glimmer said.

Chapter End Notes

All I have to say is new headcanon for Kyle with this chapter. :)

Chapter 21: Chapter Twenty-One - Tegris

Chapter Summary

> Tegris is on the run from Bright Moon and they're sure it's going to go well. After all, they got away clean, there's no alarm, and it's not much longer before the public skiff comes for them to make their escape. A little law called Murphy has something to say about that though.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Tegris slipped into one of the parks near the Bright Moon public skiff pad and crouched down in a tiny clearing inside a group of bushes near a fountain. They chuckled a little at themself in relief as they opened the pilfered Bright Moon guard data pad they'd grabbed on the way out of the castle, wondering exactly who in Bright Moon had designed such simple locks on the doors or left data pads just sitting out on a desk. They knew the night skiff would be landing soon, they'd grabbed some clothes off a line outside a house on the way to the park, and ideally by dawn, they'd be long gone from Bright Moon.

Checking the data pad they saw the only activity on the main channel so far was routine patrols checking in and some conversation on a side channel about a dinner party that some of the guards were planning for that evening for some guest of honor. They wondered just how incompetent the guard was to have not noticed a prisoner had escaped and not to give an alert but Tegris wasn't worried about that. The skiff didn't have much longer before it arrived and beside, Tegris figured that the worse case scenario was they'd have to hike out to Plumeria, though the thought had them shuddering a little at the thought of having to

cross the Whispering Woods on foot but it was better than waiting around.

They looked around again before shutting off the data pad and shoving it into the laundry bag they'd taken with them from the clothesline and then quickly began to change. They'd were just finishing up, pulling a new shirt over their head, when they sensed someone behind them. Close behind them.

"Where are you going?" a voice growled as a hand closed over their mouth. Tegris had a stray thought that growled was an appropriate way to put it when a Magicat, especially one as big as the one behind them, threatened. Tegris was trying to think how they should respond when a knee crashed into the back of their leg causing it to spasm and drop them to the ground.

"I know you're not trying to run," the Magicat said as they used a foot to roll over Tegris with almost no effort. "I know you're not breaking your word."

Tegris looked up at the Magicat they knew as Chuut and remembered the first time they'd seen him in the village of Staed from roughly the same perspective they were in now, flat on their back.

"I'm not running. I was trying to find you," Tegris said as they started to reach down to rub their spasming leg. Tegris stopped though when Chuut gave a curt growl.

"And why would you be doing that?" Chuut said as he pulled the machete from his hip.

"To warn you they're on to you!" Tegris said quickly. "They used a truth spell on me! They know about Staed, they know about you, they know about everything!"

"You broke your word then," Chuut said as he laid the back of the slightly curved blade into his other hand.

"I told you, they used a truth spell!" Tegris said as their breath started getting faster. "You can't resist one of those! Come on! You gotta run! I can get out on the evening skiff but there's no way you won't get noticed! I'm trying to help you!"

"Help," Chuut said with a broad grin that showed entirely too many teeth for Tegris' comfort. "You said the same when we caught you, that you could help. That you weren't helping Crailfish, that you weren't trafficking in old Horde weapons to them, oh no, not you, you said that you were just trying to help us. Remember that? Remember when my siblings wanted to hang you from several canyon walls?"

"And remember when I swore to help you in settling your feud?" Tegris said. "I risked my life by coming here to verify that it was the same Catra, the daughter of Saz? I swore myself to the tribe! Remember the ritual!? Chuut, I'm one of you!"

Chuut's grin became a rattling chuckle as he said, "Did you really think you were one of us? Did you think by just dancing around a fire, drinking Dream Cactus juice, and going through a few stupid games that you'd be one of us?"

Tegris remembered one of the so called stupid games, trying to dodge down a gauntlet line while Magicats swung at them with inch thick sticks, and shuddered.

"So you tricked me!" Tegris said. "Where is your honor!?"

"It's not owed to you," Chuut said. "We can be tricksters as well, why do you think we knew you for what you are?"

Tegris tried to speak and found they couldn't find words.

"Nothing to say?" Chuut said, his voice full of innocence as he cocked his machete back.

Tegris managed to squeak out, "Wait!"

Chuut just shook his head and then snapped his head up as a bright light flooded the area.

"Bright Moon Guard!"

Tegris saw Chuut take his attention off of them and they went scuttling back into the bushes screaming, "He's trying to kill me! Help! Help!"

Tegris heard a curse in Magicat followed by the sound of a machete passing through the bushes just over their head. Tegris froze as vegetation rained down on them and then curled into a ball, not sure what else to do. They heard a commotion as several Bright Moon guards rushed toward them followed by Chuut screaming out a challenge in Magicat that Tegris vaguely understood. They were pretty sure it meant something like, "Death to you and tears to your loved ones" or something along those lines and the noise that followed had Tegris shaking so hard the bushes around them rattled.

After a moment of silence, Tegris opened their eyes slowly, sure they were about to see Chuut bearing down on them ready to kill them but to their surprise, they saw Chuut crouched in a fighting position facing off against two Bright Moon guards. A third guard stood a little back from the other two, speaking quickly into a radio.

"Lay down your weapons, you'll be well treated," one of the guards, a corporal according to her rank badge, said. "We don't want to have to fight you but we will."

Chuut seemed confused that they weren't pressing the attack and his ears twitched back and forth as they tried to make sense of the whole thing. The third guard said, "Backup is here, Corporal."

The corporal stood up straight and planted the butt of her poleaxe at the side of her foot. Now Chuut was legitimately thrown off at the nonchalance as she said, "Listen, you can't take the whole Bright Moon Guard corp and that's what's forming up around

here. Whatever is going on, there's a better way then this. You've had your little fight now so how about taking a breather?"

The third guard listened on the radio as Chuut tried to think of a response.

"Corporal, Half Moon is asking if we have an ID and said you'd tell them as soon as possible," the third guard said.

"Tell them they can wait," the corporal said and then shouted a warning at the other guard as Chuut suddenly rushed the two of them.

Tegris screamed as well as they were sure that Chuut was going to gut the other guard but the corporal's poleaxe seemed to drift almost effortlessly up off the ground, the butt of it slamming into Chuut's wrist. The machete dropped as Chuut's hand involuntarily opened from the impact and then he came to a screeching stop as the second guard followed up with the butt of her poleaxe to his chest, driving all the air out of him. Tegris couldn't believe their eyes, they'd seen Magicats fight in the Waste before and they were a force to be feared, even in a three-to-one ratio, and it didn't look like these women were even breathing particularly hard as Chuut dropped to his knees, gasping for breath.

"Just stop," the corporal said and then shouted a curse as Chuut bounded out of sight into the underbrush.

"Damn it!" the third guard said and then was on the radio sending out the warning.

The corporal turned to check on the second guard who nodded at her to show she was fine. The corporal took off her helmet and Tegris saw the chip scar at the base of her neck before she turned towards Tegris. The next thing Tegris noticed was the silvery plate on the right side of her head and the long black hair becoming streaked with silver on the other side as well as the scar that ran across her nose.

"Corporal…," the third guard said and then stopped with a flick of the eyes from the corporal.

"We can let that charade go for now, Kelie," Juliet said as she knelt down in front of Tegris.

"Of course, General," Kelie said.

"Now, Tegris, I heard some interesting things hiding in the bushes. Things about Staed and weapons smuggling and something about a feud. So, what do you think about telling me, in detail if you don't mind, just what is going on. While you're doing that, why not try telling the truth this time."

"Or what?" Tegris said, scraping up a last bit of bravado from somewhere.

"We'll let you go and leave you alone," Juliet said as she gently removed a twig covered in leaves from Tegris' shoulder and then glanced at the machete still laying on the ground.

Tegris followed her eyes and then looked back at her and began to talk.

Chapter End Notes

First, shout-out to the old sci-fi series that gave Chuut his name. It's called the Man-Kzin Wars and it's a whole series about giant cat aliens attacking humans. Can I recommend it? No, not really. Did I read a ton of it when I was a teenager? Yes. Do I still read one of the stories that's basically an AU of Treasure of the Sierra Madre IN SPACE about once a year still? Also yes. At any rate, Chuut is part of a character name in the series and I thought I'd grab it since, well, giant cat character.

Also, I find it funny that Tegris is taking such a big role here. They were never supposed to be that big of a character but

then again I didn't think this would be novel length and since I broke 50K on this the other day, here we are. Thank you for reading!

Chapter 22: Chapter Twenty-Two - Saz

Chapter Summary

> Saz finds out that her patrol squad will be out for up to a month. A month away from little Catra and Saz finds she can't take the Horde much more and begins to make concrete plans.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"It's how long?" Saz said, not quite believing her ears.

"Two weeks with a potential for resupply and then another two weeks for further observation if we turn anything up," Kit said.

"It was bad enough when it was supposed to be just a week but now, fuck, why so long!? Last weather report showed almost back to back blizzards! Nobody is moving anything in that!" Saz said.

Basco and Snick, sitting at the small round table in the little meeting room, both nodded their heads in agreement. Basco put her arm around Saz and hugged her close as Snick said,

"Listen, I know part of it is Catra, and I think we all feel the same way," she said to general head nods, "but even looking at it from a strict military standpoint how are we going to operate that long!? If we have to leave the skiff that limits how much rations we can carry and we won't get far in snow."

Snick was looking down at the table as they said, "Well, it's not just that. Our gear is going to be heavier. We can maybe get away with a tarp and build snow shelters but that takes away from what we're supposed to be out there doing. Sure, we can make compromises in the gear and make up for it with local stuff but

then we end up spending all our time trying to survive instead of doing what we're supposed to be up there for."

Kit help up a hand as the other two started to speak and she said, "What do you mean, compromises?"

"Well, we can build that snow shelter like I said. We're going to be on the southern end of the Kingdom of Snows so we'll have access to wood so we don't have to carry a bunch of stove fuel. Things like that but all those things take time and they make it more obvious we're in the area," Snick said. "Honestly, after a while, we'll be doing all of that instead of trying to observe whatever we're up there to observe."

"Maybe we do that then," Basco said. "Here me out, we do all of that, say we didn't see anything, and we're out in two weeks. We look innovative for trying the new thing and we don't get stuck in an outdoor freezer for a month."

Kit was shaking her head as she said, "That's an idea but it's not going to work. There's more."

"Damn it, what now?" Saz replied.

"We're not going out as a single squadron," Kit said with a grimace. "I mentioned our problem about needing more support in combat ops and, well, Force Captain Octavia agreed. She's sending another squad out with us."

"Which one?" Saz said, her eyes narrowing in suspicion.

"It's not a 1st HLRS squadron," Kit said. "It's 1st Squad of 1st Infantry Alpha Squadron."

The room went silent for a second before Basco shouted out, "Those clowns!? They're only useful as base guards and even then they'd probably be suckered by someone trying to sneak in!"

"Octavia wants to expand the HLRS concept and says that they score the best out of 1st Infantry Troop for what we're looking

for," Kit said.

"They're going to get us killed," Saz said, her voice flat and her ears laid back flat.

"Come on, it can't be that bad," Snick said.

"They've been through some extra training but yeah, they're green as can be," Kit said. "We're supposed to give them field experience and to be fair, they have had some actual battles."

Basco rolled her eyes as she said, "So they ran around screaming and yelling while a princess dangled some of them by vines?"

Kit ignored the comment as she said, "Listen, we asked for help, this is help. There's resupply setup as well if we need it. If it's any consolation, I think it'll be incredibly unlikely we see anything and we'll be back in two weeks. I'm not sure who came up with the supposed intel that shows this but it's not from the regular place as far as I can tell."

"Then why are we following it?" Saz snapped.

"Because I think Octavia is looking to expand and is using it as an excuse for field ops to train," Kit said.

The room went silent. Saz was brooding, Basco had her arm around her, Snick seemed lost in thought and Kit looked just miserable having to be the bearer of the news. After a little bit, Kit spoke up again.

"There's… there's promotions as well in this," Kit replied. The other three looked up in confusion as she went on. "We're going to be a training squad it seems so I'm getting bumped up to squadron corporal, which I should have been already and the rest of you are all going to corporal so you can give orders to the other squad and be able to make it stick."

"With the increase in pay?" Snick said and Kit nodded. "Well, that's good. We've been talking about setting money aside for the

future."

Saz nodded as she thought about how the four of them had been very quietly talking about what the world would look like after they left the Horde and of course money had come up along with where they could live. It didn't help that the Horde paid in scrip that had to be converted to any other currency but Basco said she knew how to get it done outside the Horde. Of course, where they would go was still an open question, with the four of them having at least eight different ideas. Saz herself wondered if it was too much to find another Magicat community to live in or near. She knew that the Waste was pretty much off limits, even if the suspected blood feud wasn't a thing, because her people would never have allowed Basco or the others to live there but she wondered if that would hold for others, if they even existed.

"Pays no good if we freeze to death," Basco replied.

Snick grinned as they said, "We're not going to freeze to death. Listen, this sucks but what else can we do?"

"Run," Basco muttered but still loud enough the others heard.

Kit shook her head as she said, "Cut that shit out. So, are we in agreement? Can we make a plan now?"

There were various levels of agreement and they sat to getting something down on paper for the patrol. They contacted 1st Squad and got their input on what the squad could and could not do and then worked it into their plan. After a full day, they finally broke to go get something to eat as Basco and Saz took off for a little private time before getting Catra.

"You're distracted," Basco said as she pulled away from Saz in the little closet they had got into. It was full of bathroom supplies and the hand soap containers gave a weird chemically flower smell to the air.

Saz sighed as she sat back on a box of paper towels.

"I shouldn't be, two weeks is long… but…"

Basco leaned her head against Saz's shoulder and took her hand.

"But a month is the longest you've been apart from her. She's not going to forget you, you know. How could she ever forget you?"

Saz gave a little smile as she kissed Basco before sitting back again.

"But what if she gets scared? What if she thinks I'm never coming back?"

"Has she yet?"

"Well… you know, I don't know. It's not like the creche people tell me about that stuff. It's just development stuff, no emotional stuff."

"She seems happy," Basco said. "She's got friends, like that Adora girl and those other couple of kids, and remember how fast she started speaking? Like she was silent one day and then babbling the next. She's doing good. I know it's not great but it's… it's OK."

Saz shook her head as she said, "I should have taken her to have her hands printed on the wall by now."

Basco thought of what Saz had said about it before, how when a child finally talked they took them to a protected alcove in Staed and had their hands dipped in colored paint and then putting them on the wall next to all the others placed there over the generations.

"Do you want to do something like that here?"

"No! I don't want this place to ever remember I fucking existed!" Saz said. "When we get to where we make our village, where we settle, then we'll mark the walls there. But not fucking here. I hope she never remembers here."

"No, not here, you're right, it wouldn't be right for your daughter to be stuck in this place. She deserves more."

"Our daughter," Saz said as she ran her hands into Basco's hair. "It's our daugher."

Basco blinked in surprise as she said, "Our daughter?"

"Our daughter, yes. You're as much a part of her life as I am now. I…," Saz started to say and trailed off.

Basco grinned as she said, "No, you gotta finish that sentence; you can't say all that and then not finish."

"I thought after her father died, that was it for me, I'd never love again. Then I ran and I knew there was no way I'd find anything here… but I did. It's like finding water in a rock, it's impossible but it's here and… I just… shit, I just want to spend my life with you," Saz said. "I know I've said it before but I can't wait, I know I've got years to go but I don't want to wait. We need to leave."

"When?" Basco said.

Saz started to open her mouth but found she couldn't find the words. She sat back with grunt, rattling the shelf behind her a little. Basco kissed Saz and felt her relax a little. When she pulled away, she heard Saz give a contented purr and smiled.

"That help?"

"It did," Saz said with a little smile. "Do you have an idea of when?"

"You tell me, I'll follow," Basco replied. "I know Snick and Kit will be on board as well."

"You sure?"

"Well, Kit would be the one I'm a bit unsure about but just because she's the most Horde of us all."

"That's not saying much."

"True. Snick though, I think they'd have already left if we weren't around but they're a thousand percent in on helping us. You know they still have Catra's mouse on them?"

Saz looked surprised as she said, "I wondered what happened to that. Can't believe they cared that much."

"They cared that much about her, said they'll wait until she's a bit older, let her have it then when she's able to understand better and explain why it might scare her."

Saz pulled Basco in closer to her as she said, "We need to go and I think it needs to be soon. Maybe we could sneak back in when we're supposed to be on this mission, get Catra and go."

Basco nodded as she said, "Sneaking in is what we do."

Saz didn't answer for a moment before she said, "Let's talk to Snick, then we'll gauge Kit. Let's do this before we lose our nerve."

Basco sat up with a grin as she said, "Are we really doing this?"

"We're really doing this," Saz said. "We're absolutely doing this."

The two looked at each other and Saz felt the blood pumping hard in her veins.

"If you can give up Private Time, let's go find Snick right now," Basco said.

"We'll have all the time in the world for that in just a few weeks, lets go," Saz said with a smile.

As the two stood up, they only had eyes for each other so they didn't see the shadow slide out from under a shelf and scoot past them down the hall.

Chapter End Notes

I'm sure she'll be fine.

Thank you for reading!

Chapter 23: Chapter Twenty-Three - Catra

Chapter Summary

Catra deals with the fallout from the meeting with the ambassador from Half-Moon while they wait to hear back from Juliet on the chase.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bow had Speleo laughing and Tinz at least smiling as he talked with them while they waited to see what came of the hunt for Tegris. Catra looked at the ambassador and body guard on the other side of the room before quickly looking away. She still wasn't sure she believed them, the revelation of her mother's name in regards to their goddess had hit her like a brick, but she had to admit, between the two, Tegris was still the least reliable. She thought. Maybe.

"Hey, you don't have to be ashamed," Adora said as she hugged Catra, an easy thing for her to accomplish since Catra was sitting in her lap.

"Shut up, I'm not ashamed," Catra muttered back to her.

"You didn't scare me," Adora said. "You just caught me off guard."

"I know what you look like when you're scared, Adora," Catra said.

"Just startled, really," Adora said. "See, everyone is calm."

Catra looked at Bow laughing at something Speleo had said with Tinz standing beside her. Glimmer was in the corner with a Bright Moon guard lieutenant following the chase for Tegris and a couple of the kitchen staff were manning the mobile buffet while Lonnie stood across from it talking high end cooking with them.

"Because..," Catra started to say.

"If you say because of anything other than they're calm, I'm throwing you out of my lap," Adora said.

"Liar," Catra said.

"Maybe, maybe not. Want to test it?" Adora replied.

Catra leaned back into Adora with a brief purr as she said, "No, it's fine."

Lonnie went over and began to talk with Glimmer when a data pad rang. Everyone in the room went silent and turned towards the lieutenant.

"Go ahead…. yes… excellent… excellent, I'll let the Queen know. Out."

"What happened?" Glimmer said.

"General Juliet says they apprehended Tegris and they had some interesting things to say," Tri replied. "The Magicat's name is Chuut and they haven't caught up with him yet but they're not trying hard. They're trying to see where he's hiding first."

"I'm sorry, but did you say Chuut?" Tinz replied.

"Yes, I did," Tri said.

"Is it important?" Bow said.

Tinz made a little waving gesture with her fingers as she said, "Maybe. Go ahead, I didn't mean to interrupt."

Tri nodded as she said, "They're bringing Tegris back here at their request. The General believes she got the truth out of them this time."

Catra snorted as she said, "I thought Juliet was smarter than that."

Tri's eyes narrowed a little as she said, "The General is and she said she'd explain when she got here."

"Even if she did get tricked, I mean, it's not like others haven't fallen for a stupid story from this pain in the ass," Lonnie said, making hard eye contact with Catra who looked away while flicking a hand at her as if dismissing her.

Tri said, "Either way, the General said she'd be here in thirty minutes to give a full report."

Glimmer nodded as she said, "Thank you, Tri. I appreciate everything you and the Guard have done tonight."

"Our job, Your Majesty," Tri said. "If you'll excuse me."

Glimmer nodded as she said, "You know you don't have to ask."

Tri just gave a smile and left the room as Speleo remarked, "Well it sounds like we are in for a bit more of a wait."

"There's no reason you need to stay for this," Bow said. "I know it's getting late."

Speleo shook her head as she said, "That's true but the company is good and besides I'm, what's the term, ah, yes, invested in the outcome now."

"And I go where she goes," Tinz said with a rare smile.

Speleo smiled back at Tinz as she said, "Yes, you certainly do."

In the next thirty minutes, the mood in the room mellowed even more. Speleo settled onto a couch with Tinz sitting beside her and Bow sitting in a chair next to them. Lonnie was talking with Adora and Catra while Glimmer flitted between the two groups, trying to give equal time to each. Speleo was tucking into some mixed drink, with Tinz ears flicking in concern, and Bow was considering one himself when all three sets of Magicat ears in the room flicked towards the door a moment before Juliet walked into the room.

Glimmer went over to give her a hug, marring Juliet's parade ground perfect posture, and Juliet smiled as she hugged her back.

"Aunt Juliet, you know you didn't have to go out with them," Glimmer said.

Juliet kept an arm around Glimmer's shoulder as she said, "I didn't have to but it helps with morale if you get out in the bushes with the rest."

"I imagine it's fun as well," Tinz said.

Juliet replied, "I'd say satisfying."

"So what happened?" Adora said.

Juliet gave a curt nod to Adora as she said, "To the point then. When the decoy data pad we had laying out started moving after the sensor on Tegris' door tripped, we knew that something was up. We had a squad on them right after they left the main castle grounds and followed them through the town. I formed up with another squad, mobilized several other squads, and then handed over command authority to Adjutant Lissa as I would be in the field and we didn't need second guessing. Lissa made some quick assumptions based on Tegris' actions, such as getting clothes and heading towards the public skiff pad, and had us infiltrate the park in the area.

"At that point, it became easy. We settled down close to Tegris and that's when the Magicat, who's name is Chuut, showed up. We listened in and learned that Tegris seems to have been running weapons in the Crimson Waste to a place called Crailfish that seems to have some kind of conflict with another place called Staed." Catra scooted to the edge of Adora's lap and listened, her tail flicking a little. "Chuut and others caught Tegris and tricked them into thinking they had been accepted into their community and Tegris agreed to come here on their behalf to check on Catra."

"Hang on," Adora said. "They know Catra?"

"Yes," Juliet said. "We're not quite sure why just yet, we're still talking with them. This is all preliminary."

"How do we know they're not lying again?" Glimmer said.

Juliet said, "This was all said before we revealed ourselves. Tegris was stating it to Chuut as if it was already a known thing to Chuut and stated that Chuut had induced Tegris to come here for that purpose. I should mention that Chuut was threatening Tegris from the beginning of their conversation and Tegris was trying to talk themself out of a hard place. I believe that what was stated was true enough. The situation began to deteriorate so we revealed ourselves. Tegris hid, there was a brief struggle with Chuut who escaped, and then I had a short conversation with Tegris in which he confirmed most of what we had already heard and we're having them fill in details."

"What details?" Catra said.

"Things like why Chuut was here and what Staed has to do with anything," Juliet said.

"So this Tegris is the one who brought the killer," Speleo said.

"I could argue the way you put that but yes, essentially," Juliet said. "When we have Chuut, we'll know more."

"You seem awfully confident that you will have him," Tinz replied.

"We're following them, I doubt my people will lose track of him," Juliet said.

Speleo turned to Catra and said, "Does this settle it between us?"

Catra frowned as she said, "I still think that Tegris is lying somehow. They know I'm interested in my mother. For all I know they made this up, brought that Chuut guy along, and something got of hand."

"But we can check it out," Lonnie said. "In fact, I think it's time to go over the files again. I've got an idea as well."

"Yep, we probably should," Catra replied. "I should also, you know… probably… you know…"

Speleo gave a kind smile as she said, "I accept your apology."

"That's not what I'm trying to say!" Catra said before Adora poked her in the side. "OK, it was, I'm sorry that I thought the worst of you."

Speleo said, "I understand. We're still mysterious to the rest of Etheria, aloof some would say, and you're trying to get to the bottom of things. I can see where it might be reasonable."

"I can't," Tinz said as she tried not to glare, mostly succeeding, and scooted a little closer to Speleo who was giving her a look. Tinz cleared her throat and went on. "Though maybe I can see how one might be put on that idea."

"Now what?" Adora said.

"Lonnie, you said you had another idea. What was it?" Catra said.

"Something we probably should have done sooner. Let's ask Hordak," Lonnie replied.

"Where is he?" Catra was saying at the same time that Tinz was saying, "You haven't asked him yet!?"

Lonnie answered Catra by saying, "Last I heard, he's still at Beast Island."

"Has his service to the Crown not ended?" Speleo said as she sat a hand on Tinz's shoulder.

"That was never his service and it's not to the Crown, it's to the people of Etheria," Glimmer said. "He's still serving that. Beast Island is a hobby of his."

"It's his *hobby!?"* Speleo said in shock.

"It's more his girlfriend's hobby," Bow said. "He goes along to be supportive."

"Like he doesn't genuinely enjoy it," Catra said with a snort.

"Why haven't you asked him before now?" Tinz said, doing her best to ask politely.

"Because if we're going to believe they're ex-Horde, we don't go around constantly quizzing them about their past," Bow said.

"He's a grump too," Lonnie said with a little grin as she typed at her data pad.

"There's that as well," Bow said. "He's really not that bad once you get to know him though."

Catra snorted as she said, "Sure, keep telling yourself that."

"I like him! And Wrong Hordak is with him," Bow said.

"Wrong Hordak?" Speleo said.

"It's a weird story," Glimmer said. "He's one of Hordak's brothers."

"That doesn't exactly narrow it down," Tinz said.

"He's… distinctive," Adora said.

"I've got a message off to Hordak," Lonnie said as she stowed away her data pad. "Sent one to Entrapta and Kadroh as well so hopefully one of them will see it and respond."

"Who's Kadroh?" Tinz asked.

"That's Wrong Hordak's maybe new name," Lonnie said. "He said he's trying it on for size to see if it fits him."

"How long you think it'll take to hear back?" Glimmer said.

Lonnie shrugged.

"Couldn't tell you."

There was a knock at the door and Juliet went to answer. There was a brief conversation before Juliet turned back around.

"Well, this just got more interesting. Chuut actually evaded my people. He was last seen disappearing into the Whispering Woods."

"So now what?" Adora said.

"Now I think we all go and have more of a little talk with Tegris," Catra said.

"No," Juliet said. "I'll have some of my people do it. They won't get emotional about it and they're better trained at this then you are."

Catra started to object when Adora put a hand on her shoulder.

"How about we call it an evening then? We'll wait to see what Hordak has to say and we'll pick up fresh."

There was a general agreement around the room and Bow began talking with Tinz and Speleo about getting them settled for the evening. Catra and Adora made their good-byes and headed towards their room. Lonnie and Glimmer got to talking about some little detail on the day-to-day of winding down the Horde as Juliet left the room. She headed down to the place where Tegris was being held and walked in as they were talking to two different guards who were dressed down in casual clothes. Tegris still look shook up over the evening as Juliet sat down across from them.

"Did you catch that maniac?" Tegris said.

"No," Juliet said. "He's seem to have eluded us."

Tegris shifted, their scales seeming to shift color just a little, as they said, "I've been talking with these two, telling them everything they want to know."

"That's good," Juliet said. "I appreciate your help."

Tegris rolled their eyes as they said, "Please, I know an interrogation when I see one." They looked at the two guards. "You're both very polite and friendly but don't think I didn't notice you re-wording questions to test my answers before."

"Never would have thought to pretend otherwise," one of them said.

"Just being thorough," the other said.

Juliet was looking at the data pad of one of the guards, flipping quickly through it, before handing it back and saying, "You do look like you've been much more forthcoming this time around. I'd like to wrap this up and get back to my lovely wife so may I ask you one question and we'll consider this done for the evening?" Tegris nodded. "Where is Staed?"

"What?" Tegris said.

Juliet steepled her fingers together and leaned forward into them as she fixed Tegris with a look.

"You've said some things about what happened out in the Crimson Waste and about Staed but you've not said one thing I'd like to hear right now. Where is it? That's what I want to know. Where is Staed?"

Tegris hesitated for a moment and then began to talk.

Chapter End Notes

> OK, I did not intend to wait almost three weeks between updates but you know, life. Not even the fun, "What the hell do AO3 authors go through!?" kind of funny update thing, just some family time and an actual vacation. So it was nice, just kept me from the keyboard. Then I went to update this and realized that something in it wildly conflicted with something I wrote further on in the story and it took a day or two to re-write it so I didn't have to re-write like two whole

chapters. Anyway, thank you for sticking with this, I appreciate each and every one of you.

Chapter 24: Chapter Twenty-Four - Saz

Chapter Summary

Saz and crew have made up their mind. It's time to execute their plan and leave the Fright Zone as soon as possible so Catra can grow up free of the place.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The four had been worried that stowing away enough stuff to actually strike out on their own would be difficult but everyone knew who they were by this point. They were the elite HLRS and so their were questions like: "You sure you need that?"

And they'd answer.

"It's going to be really cold, we need the extra energy," Snick would say in reply to stocking up on the special dense ration bars for field maneuvers as they showed off the calorie burn from cold weather they'd calculated (while tossing in a few extra points here and there).

"We'll be at the extreme range of resupply," Kit would say when asked why they needed a few extra spare parts for the skiff while showing off maps and distances she'd juggled.

"We'll need every bit of power we can get for charging," Basco would say while showing energy usage that'd been fudged so much it was a dessert.

"It's cold and the rest of them don't have fur," Saz would say as she got extra clothes, thinking of how to modify the clothes so they'd fit Catra.

All of that and more, until the squad began to fear the skiff wouldn't even leave the ground while Snick assured them that they'd figured out a way to get the necessary lift they needed.

"It won't be fast, but it'll work," they'd say and the rest would nod and hope.

When the day came to leave, the four of them went over the skiff one last time before reviewing the skiff of 1st Squad of 1st Infantry Alpha Squadron that was to come with them. Saz knew their names but she'd done her best to not get attached to any of them and keep them at arm's length. She knew if what the

planned worked, these four people standing before her could be blamed, extensively, for it.

Kit made a last look over 1st Squad's skiff, it also having been stuffed with some extra stuff just to keep it looking normal, and snapped off a smart salute to the trooper in charge.

"Ready for your first field assignment as a long range squad?" Kit said.

"Yes, ma'am!" the trooper replied and Saz felt tired. The trooper, barely 18, had just been promoted to that rank, jumping right over recruit. She was fresh out of the cadet squadrons, and Saz found the energy and enthusiasm depressing. She had a brief vision of Catra standing at perky attention with the same enthusiasm and the idea made her sick and only strengthened her resolve to leave.

"Then form up," Kit said. "Corporal Basco wishes to have a few words with you and I think you'd do well to pay attention."

The two recruits and two troopers formed up in a line, their backs straight and their faces proud. Basco stepped up beside Kit and looked them over before she began, just like Aleph squad had planned.

"Alright, you're getting dropped right into it. You've had training and you're all bright young things that command assures me are competent and ready." Then Basco pitched her voice to show her disdain. "As far as I'm concerned though you don't know shit until you've been on the sharp end a few times and this is going to be as sharp as it comes. This isn't some easy shake down mission, not some milk run out of Wheatland to Plumeria, this is the Kingdom of Snows in the winter. One of our first ops there ended with explosions and running and screaming."

Saz actually had to fight a little from grinning as she remembered it was Basco who'd started that explosion with the bag of fireworks.

"Some of the hardest fighters the Rebellion has come from this region. They fight like a nightmare made flesh. They hide so well you never see them until they're screaming at you out of nowhere, blades bright and cold. I got these scars there and I'm lucky it was so mild," Basco said as she pulled her left arm out of her sleeve a little to show some gnarly looking scars there. Saz knew every scar on Basco and none of them had come from combat. If she remembered correctly, Basco had said those had come from accidentally falling through a glass table when she'd been younger. "That's not the worse. Those are just people and while you should be worried about them, it's the weather that should terrify you." Basco was now pacing up and down the line just as the four of them had planned. "It's going to be cold. It's going to be cold like nothing you've ever encountered. *Everything* is going to freeze without constant attention and that includes you. Blizzards there can last for days and days until all you know is the constant howling wind that makes you want to scream but you'll wish for that howling when the silence of a clear night comes through and the temperature drops like a stone until the very trees explode in the silence."

Basco stood in front of the other squad now, looking each of them slowly in the eye. The pride was gone from the other squad now and the trooper who'd responded so confidently just a few moments before looked like she was trying not to shake a little.

"Are you scared?" Basco said softly as she looked them over before pausing a moment. "I hope so. I hope I've scared the shit out of you. I hope you don't stop being scared until you're back here in your bunks because then you'll pay attention and so when we tell you to do something, you do it, no matter how weird it might sound. We're not just some Horde squadron," Basco said, gesturing back at the rest of her squad. "We're Aleph Squad of the 1st Horde Long Range Scouts and we're harder than armor and more clever then any little princess that might come against us. You're not, not yet, but listen to us and you will be."

Basco stepped up to the first recruit and looked her in the eye from barely a foot away.

"Are you ready?"

The recruit swallowed before saying, "Yes, Corporal."

Basco gave her shoulder a pat as she nodded before she stepped to the next recruit.

"How about you? You ready?"

The recruit's voice shook a bit but he said, "Yes, Corporal."

Basco looked him up and down for a moment before nodding and then stepping back a little so she could see the two troopers.

"You're ranking in this squad," Basco said. "Those brand new shiny rank badges didn't just get you a little bit of extra pay, they mean you're responsible for these two. Their success is a reflection on you just like their failures are your failures, no matter if you knew about them or not but you know what? I think you two might just be able to handle it. Am I right?"

The two troopers said, "Yes, Corporal," in unison and Basco looked along the line before turning back to Kit. Basco ripped off a parade ground perfect salute as she faced her.

"Squadron Corporal, I've had my say and while I think they've got a long way to go, I think they may just make us proud," Basco said.

Saz felt bad as she saw 1st Squad stand up straight and tall at the little compliment. The whole point of the speech had been to get them primed to do what they were told so Aleph squad could make their move without inconvenient questions. Now she saw the four young people ready to charge into battle and felt a little sick. Then she remembered the day before when she'd been watching the final shakedown of the skiffs by the techs.

Saz had stood in the bay watching as the techs finished their assessment of the skiff. There been some bantering back and

forth along with some arguing but finally the head tech for the crew was disconnecting the testing leads with a smile.

"We estimate it'll operate well below the temp estimates you gave us," the head tech, a short, squat woman named Clara, said. "It's not going to like it, so don't try anything overly fancy, but it'll fly."

Saz frowned. Snick really should have been the one there but they were busy going over the cold weather kits and so this had fallen to Saz while Basco and Kit were busy making sure the other squad going with them was prepared.

"Is there anything else you could do to prepare it?" Saz said.

"Maybe, if we had another few weeks, but you said you to have it ready to go," Clara said. "Listen, I can guess where you're taking this with the temp estimate you gave so I'll just say this, don't try to fly too high or too fast and definitely don't go into the Northern Reach. I can't guarantee it for that, I'd down-check it if I knew you were going there and make you wait that few weeks. You follow me?"

Saz didn't for a moment but then she did and almost lied and said that's where they were going but finally she sighed, remembering what they would be doing with this skiff very soon, and shook here head.

"No, we're not going there."

Clara nodded, her eyes going over Saz's shoulder accompanied by her lips tightening up, as she said, "OK. Well, I think you have someone looking for you. I'm checking this off as ready and I'm taking my crew elsewhere."

Saz turned to see Shadow Weaver floating towards her and stiffened up a little into attention at her approach.

"Corporal Saz, you have done well for yourself," Shadow Weaver said. "I understand Catra is doing well herself too."

"Thank you," Saz said, not sure what to say.

"I understand that you and your squad are going out on a long mission," Shadow Weaver said.

"We are," Saz replied.

"Very good," Shadow Weaver said. "I'm going to make sure before you leave that you and your squad has the evening with her tonight. I know how important Catra is to the four of you."

Saz tried to think of what the angle was but Shadow Weaver seemed to be genuinely caring in her offer.

"Thank you, I appreciate that. The rest of the squad will as well," Saz replied.

"Your Catra has bonded well with Adora and I see no reason we can not be friendly to each other, at least inside the bounds of our respective stations," Shadow Weaver said.

"Of course," Saz said. Catra had mentioned the kids in her creche occasionally and Saz knew she was making friends but she didn't know how she felt about Shadow Weaver being close. She found herself thinking how having someone who was the second in command of the Horde as at least a friendly acquaintance would be useful. Then she remembered what the squad had planned and it actually brought a smile to her face. It didn't matter how much Catra liked this Adora girl, she'd probably never see her again after they left so whatever Saz said, it wouldn't matter. "I look forward to it."

Shadow Weaver nodded as she said, "I look forward to it as well. I think you'll be an important person in the Horde and to me. I look forward to what we can do together."

Thinking on it now, made Saz shudder remembering it and she knew she had to get herself, Catra, Basco, and the rest out of this place as soon as possible.

"Let's get on these skiffs and get going," Saz said and Kit nodded.

"Agreed. All aboard," Kit said and 1st Squad ran to their skiff as Aleph squad looked at each other, ready to do what needed to be done.

Chapter End Notes

> Oh, I am so pumped about this chapter. It's finally going down! They have a shot at being free! 😁

Chapter 25: Chapter Twenty-Five - Catra

Chapter Summary

Catra gets up, goes to breakfast, and to a sudden realization.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra stretched as she got out of bed. It was still so early that the day hadn't even started yet. She kissed Adora on the forehead, grinned as she listened to Adora grumble for a moment before going back to sleep, and then quietly got ready. She left a note for Adora and headed down to the kitchen.

She found the usual busy bustle that marked most mornings in the kitchen. The bakers had already been up for hours and were pulling out the fruits of their labors that filled the kitchen with a smell that still entranced Catra. The cook were busy prepping to cook for the entire castle staff along with the residents. The fact they had a visiting dignitary in the form of Speleo didn't phase them at all, it was just one more day in Bright Moon Castle. There was a table out of the way in the far corner of the kitchen way where Glimmer had said she'd had most of her breakfasts growing up and that's where Catra was heading now.

She paused for a moment as she did, seeing Micah sitting with Castaspella and Juliet at the table, a light breakfast already laid out on the table in front of them. Micah saw Catra and smiled as he gestured at her to come on over. Even a year ago, Catra would have tried to make an excuse and leave. Every person at the table had good reason to hate her after all and Micah and Castaspella had extra reason in Catra's mind but that had been put behind them. It hadn't been easy though and Catra felt herself straightening up a little as she approached the table.

"You've got the Shadow Weaver Posture going on," Micah said as Catra pulled a chair out.

"What?" Catra said, even as she realized exactly what Micah meant. After all, he was the one who'd pointed it out to her and how he and Castaspella had suffered from the same thing for a long time when they became nervous about something.

"Come on, you know you are," Micah said with a smile as he slid a tray of fruits and assorted breads over to Catra.

"At least you're not doing it as often as you used to," Castaspella said.

"Habits are hard to break," Juliet said and Catra swore it felt accusing for a moment but honestly, Juliet and her bluntness usually did to Catra's ears.

Catra forced herself to relax and sat down at the table and began to pick through the fruit on the tray.

"It's not a habit, it's an instinct at this point," she said as she speared a grape with a claw. She made sure to ignore Castaspella's little raised eyebrow at the habit but did find some comfort in Micah's grin at his sister's response.

"Those are even worse to break," Micah said. "I know some things are just instinct, especially with family."

"That was not an instinct, you were being an ass," Castaspella replied.

"It's just how the universe works," Micah said with a little smile.

"I am literally the head of Mystacor, I know how the universe works," Castaspella shot back.

"I feel like I'm missing something," Catra said.

"They were arguing about something Micah did when they were both young when you came in," Juliet said. "He was claiming it's because he's the older sibling and so was obligated to it."

"That's a thing?" Catra said and then felt stupid at the looks she got. Then she felt guilty when everyone realized how they were looking at her, and why Catra wouldn't understand sibling interactions, and then the looks became looks of awkwardness. Catra took immense interest in the cream cheese selection in the middle of the table as she tried not to look around.

Juliet got over the awkwardness quickest as she said, "Older siblings certainly seem to think so."

Micah took the opening and laughed as he said, "Listen, it's all laid out in a book I received when Casta was born. It's very important to follow the book."

Castaspella rolled her eyes as she said, "There's no book, Catra, don't let him fool you."

"I figured that part out at least," Catra said with a smile as began to lather up a bagel.

"So what brings you out this early?" Micah said. "Not that we don't love to have you but normally it's your other half out before the break of dawn."

Catra just shrugged as she said, "Don't know. Couldn't sleep and figured I'd come get something to eat. Didn't realize it was old people's hour or I'd have slept in."

Micah laughed and slapped the table as he said, "There you go, that's what I'm looking for."

"I am not old," Castaspella said, sitting up straighter.

"Speak for yourself," Micah said. "I feel it every day when I have to spend five minutes straightening up to get out of bed. It'll happen to you soon enough."

"I'm not that much younger than you," Castaspella said. "I think I'd already be having that."

"Sweetheart, you know how I get up and stretch every morning?" Juliet said. Castaspella nodded with a grin as Juliet went on. "That's so I don't sound like I'm a sheet of bubble wrap moving around."

"Is this what I have to look forward to as I get old?" Catra said. "Comparing aches and pains?"

"Of course not!" Castaspella said. "There's so much more!"

"You can talk about your bowel movements as well and people don't look at you as weird," Micah said.

Catra made a face while Micah chuckled at his joke and Juliet shook her head as she said, "If that hasn't completely put you off breakfast, this might. Tegris was talking until late into the evening."

"Not at the table, dear, please," Castaspella said.

"What did they say?" Catra said, ignoring Castaspella and putting her bagel down. "And how do you know they're not full of shit again?"

"Oh, they're definitely full of it but something we did was actual cross-reference what they were telling us along with some other checking. We caught them in a few little weasel wordings and called them on it. We used some of what they'd already told you to trip them up. As to what they said, well…," Juliet trailed off and Catra sat up a little, having never seen the general thrown off before.

"You already opened your mouth, might as well finish it," Micah said.

"They told us where Staed is in the Crimson Waste," Juliet said.

"Staed?" Catra said. "You mentioned that last night. I think you even said it was in the Waste."

"It's where the Magicat who attacked you came from," Juliet said.

"So what's the big deal?" Catra said. Again, Juliet looked down at her plate and Catra leaned forward. "Hey, what is it? This isn't anything new."

"Maybe we should wait until you've had breakfast, dear," Castaspella said.

Catra shifted in her seat a little as she shook her head.

"No, come on, what did you find out?"

Micah said, "Just tell her. She deserves to know."

Juliet frowned before letting loose a little grunt and speaking.

"Staed is where we think your mother was from."

"Well is she still there or something?" Catra said, her pulse spiking as she tried to take even breaths.

"No, we don't think that," Juliet said. "I've reviewed that old file, but…"

"But what?"

Micah took a deep breath as he said, "Catra, she talked with us about this and we all agree. If you have any family left, Staed is probably where you'd find them."

For Catra, it felt like the whole room went silent and all she could hear was the pounding of her heart.

thump, thump

Family.

thump, thump, thump

She might have family left.

Family who'd know her mother.

Family who'd know who she was and what she came from.

Family.

thump, thump, thump, thump

What did that even mean?

thump, thump, thump, thump, thump

"Catra?"

What was going on?

"Catra!?"

What was out there in the Waste waiting for her?

thumpthumpthumpbreathbreathbreaththumpthumpthumpthumpthumpIcantbreathwhycantIbreaththumpthumpthumpthump

"General!?"

"Healer! NOW! And get Adora!"

Chapter End Notes

I had to rewrite part of this because I forgot that I'd already partly revealed Staed to Catra! Other than that, I really like this one and I hope you do as well.

Chapter 26: Chapter Twenty-Six - Catra

Chapter Summary

Catra deals with her panic attack while Adora tries to figure out just what is going on.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next few minutes of Catra's life seemed to stretch on and on as a Bright Moon Guard healer knelt beside her and quietly talked, trying to get her to take deep breaths through the panic attack. The healer had tried to put a comforting hand on Catra's shoulder and had removed it when Catra hissed at her, fangs on full display. Micah and Castaspella had backed up to the wall out of the way as Catra slowly made her way to the floor and curled up as she tried to fight the sensations running through her.

"You're going to be alright," the healer said.

Catra tried to tune her out as she clutched at her chest, telling herself she just had to power through it, she knew, she just had to power through it. She vaguely heard Adora slamming through the doors behind her but when she slid onto the floor beside Catra and put a hand on her shoulder, Catra turned and curled into her embrace.

"Hey, I'm here, we got this, we got this, come on," Adora said. "Been here before, you know it'll be alright."

Catra buried her face into Adora's shoulder, shaking the whole time as she tried to catch her breath. Adora slowly stroked the top of Catra's head, whispering the whole time she did and Catra slowly calmed down. As she took one deep shuddering breath and pulled away from Adora, she saw the healer, Micah, Juliet, and Castaspella all standing to the side and put her face right back into Adora's shoulder.

"What did you all do?" Adora snapped out.

"Stop, it's not their fault," Catra muttered.

"Don't talk, deep breaths," Adora said to her and Catra sat up, shaking her head.

"Stop, it's nothing, I'm alright."

"You were curled up on the floor with that far off stare breathing like…"

Adora wanted to say breathing like she remembered from when Catra was almost dead in her arms and had to take a deep breath herself.

"It's nothing, really," Catra said, hugging herself.

"It's nothing?" the guard healer said with a raised eyebrow. "Pretty sure that was a full panic attack, those aren't nothing. Are these common with you?"

"Hey, I didn't ask for your opinion," Catra snapped and the guard healer shrugged.

"Fine. See a healer as soon as you can though," the guard healer said and headed for the door.

"We will," Adora said with a forced smile and a glare from Catra. Then Adora turned to Micah, Castaspella, and Juliet. "What happened?"

Castaspella looked a bit shocked at Adora's sudden shift to a flat, hard tone and Micah didn't seem to have much of a response but Juliet gave a curt head nod as she said, "We were talking about things we learned from Tegris last night. One of the things was upsetting."

Catra shook her head as she said, "No, it just caught me by surprise is all. It's no big deal."

"Of course not," Castaspella responded with a smile. "It's a bit of a shock, I understand."

"Bullshit," Micah said. "Don't you underplay this, it's a big deal. You learned…"

"Micah!" Castaspella snapped. "Don't set her off again!"

"Hey! You're going to set me off if you don't tell me what's going on!" Adora shouted.

"They think they found where the rest of my family might be," Catra muttered.

Adora looked down at Catra as she said, "What!? Where!? This is the no big deal!? This is huge!"

"That's what I was trying to say," Micah said. "Finding out something like this about your family…"

Micah trailed off before suddenly sitting down hard on a chair next to him.

"I get it," was all he said before looking away.

Catra knew what he was thinking of and felt the shame etch a little deeper into her. Micah may have forgiven her but that was a far cry from Catra forgiving herself as she felt herself start to tremble a little again.

"Hey, it's alright," Adora said as she focused back on Catra. "Just like always, focus on me, deep breath, alright?"

Catra nodded as she carefully gripped Adora's arm, doing her best not to bring out the claws. After a couple of minutes, she felt better and sat up from Adora's arms.

"OK, let go, it's alright," Catra said.

Adora gave her a quick kiss before letting her up.

"We need to talk about this," Adora said as she stood up and faced Juliet.

"Of course, but maybe not right now," Juliet replied. "I need to report to Glimmer. If you can be there, I can do it all at once."

Adora had her arm around Catra's waist and nodded as she said, "I can be there."

"We can be there," Catra said, frowning at her. "I'm not sitting this out."

"Are you…," Adora started to say before getting cut off.

"Yes, I'm sure. This was nothing, alright? Just a bad moment."

Catra ignored the four sets of eyes on her as she went to the table and grabbed her bagel before muttering a good bye as she went out the door. Adora was about to follow her when Micah stepped in front of her.

"Did I hear you say this has happened before with her?"

"Just… I mean, sometimes, but not usually," Adora said.

"She needs help you know," Juliet said.

"I know," Adora said before shaking her head. "I mean, I'm helping her, she's doing alright."

"Honey, no," Castaspella said softly as she put a hand on Adora's shoulder. "She needs…"

Adora shook her head again as carefully took Castaspella's hand off her shoulder as she said, "No, she's fine. We're fine."

Micah and Castaspella started to speak when Juliet spoke over them as she said, "Alright, that's your call and we'll let it be. I'll let you know when today's meeting with Glimmer will be." Adora nodded and was heading for the door when Juliet spoke up again in her command voice, the voice cutting straight to Adora's years of Horde training. "If you need help, I trust you to reach out. I know you wouldn't let Catra continue to hurt just because you thought you needed to handle it yourself. I know you know better."

Adora froze with her hand on the door handle, not seeing Micah and Castaspella both looking at Juliet with wide eyes.

"I…," Adora started to say without turning around and then found she couldn't find the words.

"I'm listening," Juliet said.

Adora turned around almost like her feet were working on their own and the other three couldn't help but notice that it was a parade ground perfect turn.

"Ma'am…," Adora started to say before shaking her head like she was shaking a fly away and then clamped her mouth shut.

"You were saying something?" Juliet said as she stepped forward and Adora straightened up ramrod straight, and for a moment everyone in the room saw what Force Captain Adora would have looked like reporting in if she'd stayed with the Horde. Then something broke loose in Adora and they saw something different.

"No, you don't do that to me," Adora snapped. "Don't you dare turn that part of me against me."

"That's not what I was doing," Juliet said. "But…"

"No! No but! I am not your tool!"

"Adora, she's just trying to help," Micah said softly. "We don't think you're a tool."

"You think I don't know she needs help!? And then you try and imply I'm ignoring it!? Damn it, I know! I know better than all of you!"

Juliet had stepped back as Castaspella said, "Sweetie, really, take a breath, it was a mistake."

"No! That was intentional!" Adora said as she pointed at Juliet and then looked up to see the kitchen staff standing and staring. She

was about to shout and ask if they were enjoying the show when Micah cast a quick illusion that put up a wall between them and the rest of the room.

"You're right, it was," Juliet said. "Good intentions but you're right, I should have picked a better way. I apologize."

Juliet held her hand out to Adora, who looked at it like she wanted to slap it before she turned her eyes up to bore straight into Juliet's eyes.

"Yes, you should have."

Then she turned on her heels and left the room, slamming the door out of her way on her way out.

Chapter End Notes

> OK, something I did a lot in my early fics was making confrontation a lot less, well, confrontational. Big things were settled quicker and while I don't mind it in those early fics, I have decided that I wanted these kind of things to have more weight. So here we are.

Chapter 27: Chapter Twenty-Seven - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra goes in search of refuge, a place she can take a moment and calm down.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra didn't go to her and Adora's room. That was her sanctuary but it wasn't close and she knew she'd run into people. It didn't matter though. Within a week of being in Bright Moon Castle, she'd sought out multiple refuges and had every one of the locations memorized so she could go there with hardly any thought. She didn't even realize she was doing it at first, she just thought she was exploring, but she figured it out when she kept going to out of the way places that had little nooks and crannies. The refuge she headed for now was close to the kitchen but still a little off the beaten path. It wasn't a hollow under a staircase, a stack of old storage crates with a little cranny behind them, or a forgotten corner somewhere but it was a place she found comforting and quiet.

When she went in, she didn't expect the occupant to be there just yet, it being so early, but he was anyway with a smile on his face like he had every morning. The smile turned to concern as he saw Catra's face.

"Catra, what's wrong?" Bow said, standing up from the little table he used as a desk in his office with his arms open.

"Don't, no hugs, don't touch me," Catra said as she flopped down onto the little loveseat that served as a visitor's chairs. She looked at the bagel in her hand and tossed it onto the cushion next to her.

"OK," Bow said as he dragged his chair around to the front of the table and sat down. Catra scooted back a little, he was so close to her in the small office, and just sat staring at the little holograph of Glimmer floating over the corner of the table desk. After a few moments passed, Bow spoke up.

"What's wrong?"

Catra started to talk and then snapped her mouth shut just as fast. She started to talk again, stuttered on a few words, and then stopped again.

"Hey, it's alright, you just need to sit somewhere, I get it. Just emotional stuff?" Bow said.

Catra nodded and Bow gave a solemn nod back.

"We'll just sit then."

Bow sat back in his chair as Catra suddenly said, "I pissed everyone off."

"Everyone?" Bow said with a smile.

"Cut the shit, you know what I mean," Catra snapped and Bow's smile faded as he sighed.

"I do," Bow said. "Is this about last night?"

"Fuck," Catra said as she fell back into the loveseat and ground the heel of her hands into her eyes. "I wasn't even thinking of that part. No, I freaked out on Micah, Juliet, and Casta at breakfast because they said they might have found my family."

"They found your family!?"

"No! They think they might have and then I acted like a fucking asshole about it!"

"This is a big deal and no way you were an ass about it. You couldn't have," Bow said.

"I sure as shit could and I did," Catra said as she snatched up the bagel and ripped a piece off with her teeth before continuing to talk, speaking around the chunk. "I got all weird and I know I pissed them off."

"What did you do?"

"I just got all weird about it," Catra said, looking away. Bow scooted a little closer and Catra shot him a warning look. "I'm serious, don't fucking touch me. No. Hugs."

"I'm not, I promise," Bow said. "I just… what do you mean weird?"

"I just freaked out, alright? They had to get Adora to talk me down and she made a big deal out of it too. You know what, so am I, I don't want to talk about anymore."

Bow tried to think of what to say and ended up just kind of nodding along.

"Stop looking at me with those stupid eyes," Catra muttered as she crossed her arms and looked away, her ears folded back and the tip of her tail swishing back and forth.

Bow looked away, fighting off the urge to smile a little. He picked up his data pad off the desk, read something on it for a moment before typing out a reply and sat it back down.

"I think I had a panic attack," Catra said, quietly as she looked down at the floor.

"About your family?" Bow said.

"Suspected family," Catra shot back before calming down a little. "But yeah and it's not just then. Just… it's so much sometimes."

Bow sighed along with her as he said, "You know Glimmer gets them too?"

Catra looked up in surprise as she said, "Sparkles? You're kidding me."

"No. It's not often, just sometimes but yeah, she gets them, usually at night."

"Same," Catra said as she began to pick at the loveseat arm with a claw.

Bow shifted a little in his chair as he frowned suddenly

"Uh, I probably shouldn't have told you that without asking but, just, you know, you're not alone you know."

"She's not going to be mad at you," Catra snorted. "She's stupid in love with you, anyone can see it."

"I know," Bow said with a smile. "But you got the part about how you've got help, right?"

"I don't need help," Catra said as she rolled her eyes. "I just need to…"

"Hey, don't say that," Bow said.

"Don't tell me…!" Catra started to snap before she looked quickly looked away. "Sorry. I'm such a pain in the ass, I know."

"No, you're not," Bow said. "You're my friend, I love you, you're not a pain."

"Glimmer says I am," Catra said.

"She's teasing," Bow said. "You know that. You and Adora do the same thing."

"Whatever."

"I don't think that you're a pain."

"You're just being nice."

"Catra, come on, that hurts. You really think I'd be like that to you?"

Catra looked at Bow and he genuinely looked hurt.

"Well just more proof that I'm shit."

Bow leaned forward with a groan as he said, "Damn it, that wasn't what I was trying to say."

"Listen, I didn't come here to talk about my feelings. Just… I don't know, sit there and work and leave me alone."

Bow started to say something but finally just shook his head and rolled up behind his desk again. Catra looked down at the arm of the loveseat where she'd plucked up a few threads. She plucked at it with a claw a little more, starting a little hole in it. She suddenly realized what she was doing and snapped her head up to look at Bow who was bent over his desk again, looking at some paperwork in a folder labeled, *Dinner Rankings - Suggested Changes.* She put her hand over the hole and tried to think what to do, feeling the anxiety starting to creep back up. Then she jumped when Bow spoke up.

"I don't care, Catra," he said without looking up, a little smile on his face. "That thing is in here because it's too junky to keep in the guard lounge anymore. Tear it apart if you want."

Catra started to speak, found she couldn't as she felt a little lump in her throat, and then finally just nodded and went back to picking at the arm of the couch. After a few minutes, she laid her head on the arm of the loveseat as she kept picking at it, the hole widening as the stuffing of the arm started to poke out. Bow looked up about ten minutes later when he heard a noise and saw Catra curled up on the cushion next to the arm slowly breathing in and out, a little purr escaping her lips as she slept.

Chapter End Notes

The folder Bow is reading actually has a name because of something I saw a while back on Tumblr. Someone was talking about when people are doing desk work in fics, most of the time, the writers will have them doing generic paperwork without saying what that paperwork actually consists of. Part of it, OP suggested, was because some fic writers haven't worked in offices so they don't know what to put there and others don't want to figure out what it actually is so saying "They're doing paperwork" is a shorthand to say, "They're working at an office/administrative type job."

Now, I don't think there's any big deal with saying that but ever since I read that, I've always tried to make the paperwork actually be something. In this case, it's the Bright Moon service staff revising the different rankings of dinner settings, appropriate menus, decorations, and entertainment to go with various functions from intimate dinner for the Queen and her friends/family all the way up to full state dinners for visiting ambassadors and such. I like to think that Glimmer has Bow handle most of this kind of thing and Bow is 100% on board with it.

Chapter 28: Chapter Twenty-Eight - Catra

Chapter Summary

> It's time for the briefing to find out just what Juliet and the Guard found out from Tegris with Catra and the rest all in attendance. Just what will be revealed?

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra woke up to Adora gently touching her shoulder. She jerked up on the couch, wondering what was under her arm until she saw Melog curled up, who gave her an annoyed look for a moment before stretching and jumping off the couch.

"You doing better?" Adora said as Catra looked around the small office, wondering where Bow had gone off to. "He's getting ready for the meeting with Juliet and Glimmer."

"Stop doing that," Catra said, giving Adora a playful push.

"I'm not doing anything, it's obvious what you were looking for," Adora said. "Are you doing better though?"

"Yeah, I guess," Catra said as she sat up on the loveseat as Adora shuffled in next to her. Melog jumped up behind her and curled up behind her head. "So how pissed is everyone?"

"No one is mad at you," Adora said as she shifted a little. "Though, um, they might be mad at me."

"What did you do?"

"I may have got a little ugly with them."

"You're the golden She-Ra," Catra said with a snort. "They're not going to stay mad at you."

"Well, I mean, they weren't mad, Juliet was trying to apologize for something and I may have kind of told her to fuck off."

"You did not!" Catra said with a laugh.

"OK, well, maybe not in those words but I did reject her apology."

"What did she do that she thought she needed to apologize for?"

Adora paused for a moment before giving a quick rundown.

"SHE DID WHAT!?" Catra said and felt Melog bristling behind her. She took a few deep breaths before going on. "OK, I'm sure… fuck her… no, she probably didn't… damn it!"

"I may have not said it right," Adora said.

"She really tried to use your training against you!?" Catra said.

"Well…"

"Well what? Did she or didn't she?"

Adora thought about it, a frown getting deeper on her face, before she sighed.

"I don't know. It's what it felt like. She had her whole command thing going on."

"Adora, she always has that going on. It's *General* Juliet, remember?"

"OK, but I've known her for years and this just… it felt different alright?"

"Alright. Let's get it done then."

Adora pulled back a little to look Catra in the eye as she said, "We're not going to war with her."

Catra rolled her eyes as she said, "I meant let's go to the meeting. I'm not declaring war on her." She paused as she debated saying the next words but she took a breath and said it anyway. "I will though. For you, I'll do anything."

Adora felt her heart stop for a second before she felt heat wash over her as she thought of that.

"Ummmm… you, uh, don't have to do that."

Catra grinned as she said, "I've seen you look like that before."

Adora shoved her as she said, "Shut up!"

"Hey! I'm not the one getting turned on by that!" Catra said laughing as she pushed back.

A few minutes later Bow walked in on them wrestling on the floor and Melog hopping around the room making chirping noises of laughter.

"OK, at least you're both dressed this time," he said as they both looked up at him.

"Ha, ha, Arrow Boy," Catra said as she reached over and straightened the table from where it'd been knocked out of the way.

"Is it time?" Adora said, the joy fleeing from her face.

"It is," Bow said. "Everyone is…"

"I don't care," Adora lied quickly.

"Well, come on or you're never going to get up," Bow said.

"That's not true. We stand up all the time," Catra said as she stood up and stretched, winking at Adora who went from looking

uncomfortable to blushing furiously.

"You two, I swear," Bow said with a laugh.

"Hey, I might be a mess but I'm at least a quickly recovering mess," Catra said.

"Maybe don't joke about that right now," Bow said.

"If I don't joke about it, I'm just going to spiral again and I have shit I got to find out and get done," Catra said. "So let's go find out what Juliet has to say about this lying fuck Tegris."

"Going in with an open mind I see," Adora said as she stood up, straightening her shirt a little before putting her jacket back on.

"Well, come on, let's go," Bow said, backing up and making little hand gestures at them to move it along.

"We're not kids!" Catra said as she followed him out of the little office before responding to Adora. "Open mind? Really? On this?"

"Hey, I'm just saying," Adora said to Catra's rolled eyes.

After a short walk, they were all settling down into a Bright Moon Guard briefing room. Catra was surprised to see Speleo and Tinz sitting on the front row of the small theater shaped room next to Glimmer and Lonnie. Juliet stood beside the holographic projector with a data pad in her hand speaking with one of the guard. A few other guards were sitting off to the side and they both turned to look at Bow, Adora, and Catra as they came in with Melog padding along at their feet. Adora couldn't help but feel like they were looking at her a little harder than normal and she fought the urge to shrink back a little.

After a quick back and forth hello with everyone, the three got settled down in the front row. As soon as they seated, Juliet started speaking, her voice overriding the last little bit of chatter from the room.

"Your Majesty," Juliet said, addressing Glimmer, "this is a report on a guest of yours named Tegris. They have been the cause of some mischief in your kingdom. Are you ready to receive this information?"

Glimmer stood, Bow smiling up at her as she said in a clear voice, "Thank you, General. I am ready to receive your report and I give my gratitude to the Guard Corp for their diligence."

The voice was so much different and was definitely something Catra thought of as The Queen Voice and she had to refrain from teasing Glimmer as she sat back down but then her eyes snapped to the front as Juliet began to speak.

"Tegris came to Bright Moon claiming to be in possession of information on Saz, a Horde Soldier currently listed on the Missing and Unaccounted for Horde Personnel List," Juliet said. Catra bristled at the way Juliet referred to her mother but kept her mouth shut. Juliet seemed to sense it, briefly looking at Catra but going on without stopping. "Tegris reported several things to Lonnie, the current Administrator of the Horde Demobilization Effort, as well as others of what they knew, giving false statements that are detailed in the full written report."

Juliet went on for a few more minutes, giving details of Tegris' actions over their time in Bright Moon before finally saying, "After being brought back to Bright Moon, Tegris began to speak to various members of the Bright Moon Guard. With independent checking of the details of Tegris' story, we have determined some basics that can be regarded as fact. One, Tegris is in fact from the Crimson Waste, not Plumeria. Two, they worked as an independent recruiter for the Horde in the Crimson Waste and recruited people from that area into the Horde, including Saz. Three, Chuut was using them to try and find Saz and her descendants as part of a blood feud on behalf of the citizens of Staed, where he is from."

Juliet paused for a moment, looking at Catra before turning towards the holographic projector as several orthoimages popped

up. They all had the look of images taken from orbit and showed a series of narrow canyons and badlands. Juliet worked the data pad and one image came forward, overlaid with topographic lines and some technical details. Green lines formed a box over a vast swath over the image.

"Fourth, we believe this is the approximate location of Staed."

Chapter End Notes

> I couldn't work it into the briefing but something I wanted to say is that this is kind of where the Horde tradition of disappearing into the Waste comes from. Tegris recruited people who knew the Crimson Waste wasn't empty and they whispered it around. When someone wanted to leave the Horde, at the end of their term or not, then they knew they could go to the Waste.

Chapter 29: Chapter Twenty-Nine - Etherian Encyclopedia

Chapter Summary

A short entry from the modern Etherian Encyclopedia on Snowtop Pass above the town of Snowtop.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Snowtop Pass

Overview: Snowtop Pass is a mountain pass that connects the town of Snowtop with the southern edge of the Northern Reach of the Kingdom of Snows. The top of the pass is 12,346 feet (3,763 meters) with flanking peaks on either side that reach over 14,000 feet (4267 meters). The tallest peak, Snowtop, 14,976 feet (4,565 meters), gives the town and the pass their names and is known as an extremely challenging peak for both its altitude as well as its ruggedness and its weather extremes. The pass itself was was not a main travel corridor until after the Fall of Prime and the creation of a series of tunnels, all weather roads, and emergency shelters for travelers.

History: The pass was originally used for expeditions into the Northern Reach for both exploration and settlement. Due to difficulties with Snowtop Pass, other passes at lower altitudes were more popular for year round access into the Northern Reach. Snowtop Pass was mainly used during the short summer season as, owing to its latitude, it does offer access into higher latitudes of the Northern Reach with less travel time and closer resupply from the town of Snowtop.

Several stories surround the pass of snow monsters and evil voices heard on the wind. The archives of the town of Snowtop record many such stories that have been published by Princess Frosta's personal press. While current locals discount the stories, pointing out that the pass is dangerous enough without being scared of imaginary creatures or spirits, it is part of the history of the area. There is a shrine at the start of the pass that many leave small offerings at to placate the alleged entities.

Climate: The top of the pass is an alpine climate with the north side of the pass passing into subarctic climate. The base of the pass, and the town of Snowtop, are temperate though still high altitude. The yearly average temperature at the top of the pass is 19.4°F (-7°C) with a summer average high of 45.1°F (7.2°C) and a winter average low of -6.3°F (-21.3°C). Records for high and low temperature are contested due to measurement inconsistency but at the completion of the current all weather road, a high temperature of 51.7°F (10.9°C) was recorded by construction workers while a search and rescue team (SAR) recorded a low of -63.2°F (-52.9°C) the year after Prime's Fall.

Average precipitation is 38.52 inches (97.84 centimeters), most of which falls as snow at elevation, giving the mountain of Snowtop both its distinct look as well at its name. Summer rains can also be accompanied by strong lightning storms. Winter storms are renowned for their high winds and extreme blizzards blowing down off the Northern Reach with winds in such storms averaging 43.6 MPH (70.2 KPH) with recorded sustained winds of 62.1 MPH (99.9 KPH) with gusts of 87.4 MPH (140.7 KPH) being possible. White out conditions are known to happen almost instantly in all parts of the pass.

Recreation: The local town of Snowtop holds a marathon up the pass every year at the height of summer with two categories, one for regular runners and one for local search and rescue (SAR) crews in full gear. This coincides with the local week-long Summer Slam festival put on by the local bocce ball clubs. With the availability of surplus Horde skiffs, the area is also becoming a

hub of competitive skiff mountain racing with the peak of the pass serving as both a starting and ending point for the races.

There is an annual winter celebration held in the town's community hall on three nights with the last night culminating on the longest nights of the year. Simply referred to as the Winter Festival, it includes, songs, plays, readings of various kinds, dances, and community dinners. Known for the colorful lights and elaborate costumes of the participants it ends with a everyone greeting the return of light at daybreak of the third night with shouts and revelry.

Chapter End Notes

> There was an absolute Wikipedia lookup frenzy for this one and I had a ball. There may or may not have been an Excel sheet involved (there was). I tried to make this place seem, rightfully, pretty harsh and now I just want to visit it. This also makes me wonder, what is the Etherian equivalent of the Seven Summits and the fourteen 8,000 meter peaks we have?
>
> I also had to keep telling myself that 40 MPH winds are pretty damn fast for wind because I live in Oklahoma and we get regular spring and summer storms that hit those wind speeds.

Chapter 30: Chapter Thirty - Catra

Chapter Summary

> The plans begin to take shape for finding what may be Catra's original home and possible family.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra looked at the screen and the images on it. It was the Crimson Waste but it looked even worse than she remembered. When she'd been in the Waste, it'd mostly been open terrain with a few canyons. This looked like a nightmare of slot canyons full of twists and turns. She spotted what looked like a river that ran through the heart. The room was silent and Catra realized that everyone was looking at her as she was engrossed in looking at the images.

"OK, yes, I know," Catra said, as she remembered her early freak out and shifted a little in her chair as Melog jumped up in Adora's lap and curled up with their face barely peaking out. "Just let it go, alright? I'm not going to start frothing at the mouth. Go on."

Juliet looked at her for a moment before she went on.

"We've reached out to Huntara to see if she can tell us anything about this area but she's not responding. This is a part of the Waste that few have been to and we have basically no information on it beyond what Tegris has given us so it's the least reliable of what they've given us as we're not able to properly verify it. The orthoimages are courtesy of the clones aboard the Velvet Glove who took them after a request from us and are only a few hours old. Your Majesty?"

Juliet nodded at Glimmer who'd half put her hand up.

"Uh, yeah, how do we know this is where…," Glimmer paused for a moment to look at Catra who narrowed her eyes a little and gave a little go on hand wave. "Sorry, how do we know that's where Staed is located? How do we know that Tegris didn't just make it up to get us running around inside of there?"

"Excellent question, Your Majesty," Juliet said and adjusted the data pad. "We know something is there because of these other images." Another overlay popped up, with a scale on the side showing heat ranges. Most of the overlay was fairly uniform, mostly shades of orange. A few spots stood out as slightly warmer though and Juliet pointed them out. "These spots show traces of heat we'd expect to see from some kind of settlement. The Velvet Glove is going to take some images after dark today to see if we can spot any lights. From Tegris' description, the villages are deep in the canyons but unless they practice some kind of light discipline, I'd expect to see something."

"What's the next step then?" Glimmer asked.

"That's up to you," Juliet said. "I have simply advised you of what we have learned."

Glimmer looked at Catra again for a moment before saying, "Thank you, General. If you could the send the compiled report to me and copy Lonnie and Bow, I'd appreciate it. They'll distribute as necessary. Please keep me up to date on any new developments."

"As you wish," Juliet said with a short bow before leaving with the rest of the guards.

When Juliet had left Glimmer shifted a little uncomfortably in her seat.

"I, uh, didn't mean to send her away."

"I think I might have made her angry this morning," Adora said sheepishly.

"Dad told me about that," Glimmer said before being cut off by Catra.

"Well I don't want to talk about it because this has been absolutely bizarre. Lonnie, want to throw something helpful in here?"

"How about uncomfortable instead? I think we need to go out there and poke around," Lonnie said. "It's part of my groups job to follow up on out of the ordinary entries on the List and this fits. I can muster up some help and have my own resources to tap."

"Of course the Crown will help as well," Bow said.

"Half Moon is more than willing to let us come along as neutral observers," Speleo said, causing people to suddenly turn around. "Forgot we were here didn't you?"

"Of course not," Bow said. "Just surprised you're interested in this."

"She's invested now," Tinz said with a look at Speleo.

"And you?" Bow said.

"I'm her guard, I go where she goes," Tinz replied.

"Besides, a possible group of Magicats who've been isolated from the majority of Etherian society? Half Moon has an interest in that," Speleo replied.

"Well, you're welcome along," Glimmer said.

"Hey, this is my family reunion," Catra said. "Someone want to ask me what I think?"

"Really, you're joking about this already?" Lonnie said.

"I'm just saying, this is probably a wild bot chase," Catra replied. "I don't think we need to be making a big deal out of it."

Adora looked at Catra, trying to read her but failed. Melog peaked out from Adora's lap before burying their face again.

"What makes you think this means nothing?" Tinz said.

Catra frowned as she looked Tinz before saying, "Because Tegris hasn't exactly been upstanding and straightforward. I get the General and her people are good at getting information but I've got my doubts and the General did say this is the least reliable of the information. Besides, someone tried to kill me and now we all want to go hiking into, well, that?"

Catra pointed at the canyons on the screen as everyone's eyes followed back to the screen. The silence fell for a moment before Lonnie cleared her throat.

"OK, fair point but we're not going to go in blind. I know some people in the Waste. I'm asking them what's going on."

Catra was about to scoff and ask who she knew in the Waste until she remembered that not only did Lonnie know people from her, Rogelio, and Kyle living there for a while but for that matter, Catra knew people as well.

"You know, I think I know some people myself," Catra replied.

"Who do you know there?" Adora said.

Catra remembered the gang she'd briefly been the leader of, who'd help imprison Adora, and cleared her throat. Adora felt Melog shift in her lap and jump down. That's when she made the connection.

"Oh, yeah, them."

"Who?" Speleo asked.

"Just some people Catra met when she was still in the Horde," Bow said, catching on.

"Who are you talking about?" Glimmer said before Bow shot her a look. "Oh, yeah, them."

"Someone want to fill us in? Is this that gang you brought back to the Fright Zone? The one who…," Lonnie said before suddenly looking at Adora. "Oh, shit, that's right."

Tinz snorted as she said, "This is part of your two's insane relationship drama isn't it?"

"Hey, it's not that bad!" Glimmer said.

"As someone who was basically on the outside of it all," Tinz said, "sure, I wouldn't say bad but I did say insane. Do I really need to go over why?"

"Diplomacy, please," Speleo quietly said to Tinz.

"That was the diplomatic response," Tinz replied.

"I mean, she's not wrong," Lonnie said.

"OK, can we not talk about our drama?" Adora said, snapping a little when she did before turning to Catra. "Go ahead and call them. Whatever we can learn would be helpful."

Tinz was looking at the images and went over to the screen to look closer.

"I think I know where a few may be," Catra said. "I'll start when we're done here."

"I'll hit mine as well. Since this is technically going to be part of the List duties, any objections that I coordinate?" Lonnie said, looking around. When no one objected she went on. "Glimmer, could we get a list of what Bright Moon can offer?" Lonnie said.

"Of course," Glimmer said. "Should be a fair amount, I'll be going along after all."

Bow sighed as he said, "The Guard is going to flip you know."

"I'm not sitting another adventure out," Glimmer said as Tinz turned around and said something in Magicat to Speleo who looked at Glimmer and the rest before answering back. Glimmer looked between them before speaking. "What? What did you just say?"

"Tell her, please," Speleo said.

"I'm trying to convince her not to go and she is not agreeing," Tinz said with another look at Speleo before pointing back at the image. "This is a killing zone."

The room went quiet as Catra nodded her head in agreement.

"We're not heavily versed in war but we do know staying hidden," Speleo said. "In a cave, it's easier. Just disappear. There… I think I know why no one knows what's going on in there very well."

Adora had stood up and moved to stand beside Tinz. Catra watched as Adora tilted her head just a little as she thought.

"There's a road."

Now it was Tinz and Speleo's turn to look at Adora.

"Where?" Lonnie said.

"I can't point it out, it's an assumption actually, but see the river?" Adora said and pointed at a bend. "It slows down here and you can see what appears to be a beach. There's indications of settlements here, here, and here, all within easy distance of that spot. Probably not a lot of shipping going in and out or this would be more well known but Tegris said they were smuggling when they were caught by Chuut. I bet whatever gets shipped in lands there and gets disbursed in on something like a road. The spot looks wide, the river current is probably slow at that point, and the beach that is built up is probably pretty solid. I'd want more

overhead but I bet that's where the main traffic in the region goes in and out and that's where we'll start.

"We establish a base camp here," Adora said, pointing at the beach, and then started making quick hand gestures as she went on. "Then we send scouts here, here, and here for reconnaissance. If we can get some skiffs from the old Horde supplies then we can do aerial scouting as well. Once we get some reports back, we strike out up one of these canyons with outriding scouts on either side forward of our direction of travel to probe as we move, and we leave a contingent back at the main camp to hold our rear area open in case we have to withdraw. Once we make contact, we pull one of the scout groups back into the main column and have the other one spread out as forward observers. We can negotiate and talk from there."

Adora stopped with a thoughtful look on her face for a moment before wrapping up.

"Issues I see are supply lines, comms due to the canyons blocking reception, limited movement options, and unfamiliar ground as well as an unfamiliar local situation but I'd say we could use this as an outline of a basic plan and refine to limit those issues especially as more intelligence comes in but either way this is a solid start."

Adora looked for a moment longer before giving a decisive head nod and then turned to see a completely silent room.

"What?"

Catra was grinning as she said, "I think they got used to the distracted Adora and forgot this side of you."

"I didn't forget, I just hadn't seen this Adora in awhile," Glimmer said.

"I have. She can be very goal driven if you get my drift," Catra said with a wink.

Lonnie threw a pen at Catra as she said, "I do and I'd appreciate it if you drifted it away from me."

"Hey, I had to hear about Kyle's talents the other day, it's only fair," Catra said.

Tinz in the meantime was ignoring the banter and looking at the image before she said, "It's a good idea. I have a few reservations but as you said, it's only a basic outline for now."

Bow was already typing away on his data pad as he said, "We'll have the Velvet Glove stuff soon I think and I've got a secure site set up for our planning as well."

"OK, we're just ignoring Catra, I can do that," Glimmer said and then grinned as Catra stuck her tongue out at her.

Speleo had a delighted smile on her face as she said, "It truly is a joy to watch how different people work."

Tinz turned and smiled back at her as Lonnie said, "This is actually fairly organized for this lot."

"Well, we do learn eventually," Bow said as put an arm around Glimmer.

"Eventually being the main word here," Catra said.

"Maybe we should wait and see what Hordak has to say as well," Adora said as she turned back to the images. When no one responded, she turned around again. "What? Remember? We reached out to him for input."

"I mean, do we really need to wait?" Catra said.

"He might have something worthwhile," Adora said.

"True," Lonnie said. "I mean, he was around back then after all."

"OK, yeah, that's true," Catra muttered as she sat back.

"This is a personal issue again, isn't it?" Speleo said. "Is it because he was the Horde leader?"

Catra remembered the sound of a laser canon blowing a hole through a wall right next to her and gave a humorless laugh as she said, "Sort of."

"I thought you two were good," Bow said.

"Adora is," Catra said. "I'm… yeah, not so much."

"He makes Entrapta happy," Adora said.

Catra just shrugged as she said, "There is that."

"Come on," Lonnie said. "How about we not fall down the feelings hole and actually start planning some of this."

"The feelings hole?" Glimmer said.

"You know exactly what I mean," Lonnie said. "And I'm sure Speleo and Tinz don't want to hear our little group's drama."

"I love drama," Speloe said. "We put on excellent ones in Half Moon."

"Yeah, well, they're not so fun when you're a bit actor in one," Lonnie snorted.

"Not going to let that go are you?" Catra said.

"Listen, I'll say the same thing I said when we first reconnected after the war. How could you two not tell!?" Lonnie said as she pointed back and forth between Catra and Adora.

"Hey, we didn't really get it ourselves until we really saw them together," Bow said.

"I've heard about you two," Lonnie said. "Don't make me say the same thing about you."

Glimmer laughed as she said, "We weren't that oblivious."

"I understand," Tinz said. "Some people just don't see what is right in front of them."

Speleo nodded as she said, "That's very true. Some people just don't get it."

"OK, OK, enough," Catra said waving her arms around as Tinz looked at Speleo before looking away. "Let's take a break, clear our minds, and come back."

"Can do," Bow said.

The group broke up and went off for a quick break but Adora continued to look at the images, flicking overlays on and off them, as Catra came up behind her and wrapped her in her arms.

"Sorry it took so long," Catra whispered to her.

Adora took her hand and kissed the palm as she said, "Doesn't matter. Got our whole lives ahead of us."

Catra looked at the canyons in the image before saying, "Which might not be long in that maze instead of just staying home."

"We can call it off."

Catra shook her head and kissed the back of Adora's head before speaking.

"I have to know."

Adora simply clutched Catra's hand tighter.

Chapter End Notes

> If you want to know what I'm thinking of when I think of this part of the Crimson Waste that Staed is in, think of the canyon lands of Utah or the canyons around the Grand Canyon (which is pretty much the same thing). We're still

discovering new Ancestral Pueblo dwellings in those canyons that are over a thousand years old.

Completely side note but I originally said Anasazi above in reference to the people who lived in those dwellings and I went to double check something on it and that's how I found out that since I learned that word about thirty years or so back that it has become controversial. Basically, it's a Navajo word that was applied by a white rancher to Mesa Verde in the late 1800's and it got picked up. The word has some negative associations in Navajo (there's a whole linguistics lesson in there, I won't go into why) and the Pueblo people have said they prefer using Ancestral Pueblo people so that's what I went with. There's some great reading out there on this.

Chapter 31: Chapter Thirty-One - Shadow Weaver

Chapter Summary

> Shadow Weaver tries to force a search for the missing Saz and crew but Octavia digs her feet in against it.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Screams echoed down the hallways of the Fright Zone, sending people scattering to find something to do, preferably somewhere far away from the screams.

"What do you mean they're missing!?" Shadow Weaver shouted at Octavia.

"Don't yell at me!" Octavia shouted back. "Both squads seemed to have gone down somewhere in the mountains just outside Snowtop. We're trying to get SAR on site but the weather is absolutely atrocious, the worst we've ever seen in the area. It doesn't help that one of the last transmissions we have from them was that they may have seen a massive buildup of Princess led forces in the area."

"Then get in there and get them out!" Shadow Weaver replied.

"No!" Octavia said. "I'm not risking SAR just to go in and get obliterated by a Princess strike team! That's even before taking the weather into account!"

"Do you have no concern for them!?" Shadow Weaver said.

"Fuck you! The HLRS was my idea but I'm not risking more troops," Octavia snapped back. "My SAR commanders have said

that it is not safe and I trust their word. They'll go in as soon as they deem it safe and not a moment sooner and I will not order them to do so before then."

"Corporal Saz has a child in case you forgot," Shadow Weaver said.

"So do some members of the SAR teams," Octavia said. "I've reviewed their records, they were well supplied. If they wrecked or simply had equipment trouble, they have plenty of supplies to hold out a storm."

"I can order you to go in and rescue them," Shadow Weaver said, standing taller as the shadows around her darkened and lengthened.

Octavia fought the urge to step back as she said, "You can and I'll refuse. I've also told my subordinates to do the same before I came here. Don't think I didn't notice that people suddenly change their minds after private meetings with you. I've also instructed them to protest the assignment to Lord Hordak if anyone attempts to convince them to undertake this mission before conditions are right."

"You dare to try and undermine me?" Shadow Weaver said, her voice low.

"Dare? Already did," Octavia said. "I started the Horde with Lord Hordak after overthrowing the Last King. I'm not letting someone who came over after fucking up at Mystacor screw me around."

Shadow Weaver stood for a moment before saying, "Get. Out."

Octavia nodded and left, never turning her back on Shadow Weaver as she did.

Shadow Weaver stood staring at the door before screaming again, lashes of shadow flashing around the room.

"Damn them! They still had to come back for her!"

Shadow Weaver paused for a moment, wondering if perhaps they'd decided to abandon Catra and strike out on their own before shaking her head with a hiss. Something else had happened and she needed answers. The shadow spies weren't bringing her any so over the next couple of days, she interrogated anyone and everyone she could think of who might have had something to do with them leaving and the information she got seemed to tell the story she already knew. Nothing had changed. It was blatantly obvious once you put it together they had grossly oversupplied the mission but she knew they had planned to come back for Catra and it had been then she would have sprung her trap and got Saz, and by extension the rest, under her thumb for her own uses.

A week after the first report of squads going missing came in, a SAR team was finally able to go out to the pass above Snowtop to begin what they hoped was search and rescue but they knew in their gut was probably search and recovery after the brutal weather. Shadow Weaver waited in a staff briefing room, wondering what was going to happen, what was going to be found, along with Octavia and several other Force Commanders. The Force Commanders tried to make conversation but it kept dying off before it'd really get started, both from the tension and from Shadow Weaver sitting slowly drinking wine with her eyes fixed to the screen. The conversation eventually lapsed to silence and everyone just watched the screen. A map with marks representing the five skiffs of the SAR crew moving up the pass was the only thing on it at the moment and they all could see the SAR crew making careful parallel sweeps. All they could do was wait.

They waited for a long time.

Finally, as Shadow Weaver started into the second bottle of wine, a text message came across the bottom of the screen.

Position of 1st HLRS and 1st Squad of 1st Infantry found.

Shadow Weaver let out a long breath she hadn't been aware she had been holding. It wasn't that bad. They'd found them. Then the next transmission came through.

Moving from rescue to recovery.

Chapter End Notes

OK, I realized as I was editing this that the last line might not have the punch if you don't know much about search and rescue, though I think you can figure it out from context. The term rescue means that you're actively trying to find someone and you expect them to be alive. Recovery is a kind of euphemistic way of saying you don't expect them to be alive and you're simply recovering a body. You'll most often see this in news reports about disasters that the mission has shifted from rescue to recovery and it's usually about three days after the disaster has happened and they know no one left is probably still alive (for lack of water, oxygen, whatever).

Personal story, I used to belong to a search and rescue group when I was in high school but we lived in the middle of Oklahoma so we didn't ever really do anything (though we did get to help the police locate murder evidence once). We mostly just read stuff and practiced on camp outs. I remember in one of our little training documents, there was one particularly poignant photo of a search that the crew thought was going to be the recovery of a missing kid. It was shot in early morning looking through a field towards a treeline. The sun was still low so it was lighting the grass just right so you could see a clear line through the dew in the grass going straight to a tree. Under the tree was the kid, looking back at the rescue team, clearly alive. Gives me shivers still thirty years later thinking about it. I can only imagine what that SAR crew felt.

Chapter 32: Chapter Thirty-Two - Catra

Chapter Summary

A simple meeting getting ready to head to the Crimson Waste with a bit of a surprise at the end from Lonnie.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A week had passed. The Velvet Glove had taken nighttime images in several spectral ranges of the canyon lands. At night the areas they'd suspected of being inhabited showed a little bit of visible light but in the infrared spectrum the inhabited areas almost glowed against the cold stone and sand of nighttime. As predicted, the Bright Moon Guard hadn't been the least bit happy their queen wanted to go into a remote, and probably dangerous, area but hadn't done more than argue it a little because in the end, she was the queen. What had ended up being more uncomfortable was what came about next.

"I'm going with you," Juliet had said.

It'd been in a full meeting of what was thought of as the expedition leaders and Juliet had done her best to not look at Adora when it was said. Adora for her part was doing the same.

"You really don't have to do that," Glimmer had replied.

"My queen is taking the field, I'll be at her side," Juliet said. "I promise I can be impartial."

This time Juliet had looked at Adora, if only for a fleeting moment, and Adora was a bit surprised to see that she looked a bit embarrassed for a second. Adora for her part looked away, shuffling her feet a little as she went back over the loadout for

one of the Horde surplus skiffs Lonnie was setting up in the Fright Zone at the moment.

Catra pretended she didn't notice as she looked over a roster of the people coming along and said, "You sure we're going to have enough here?"

Tinz pulled up the roster herself as she said, "Looks like a pretty large group. What do you think we're missing?"

"She's kidding," Speleo said gently.

"Ah, yes," Tinz said.

"We could probably actually leave the chefs at home," Lonnie said over a holographic connection. "I don't think they're that necessary."

Bow shook his head as he said, "I know it sounds pretentious but Chef Brassicales insists on going and it's not like they didn't run the field kitchen when we were living out of tents. She knows what they're doing."

"True, and it's not like we're going to suddenly not need food and stars knows we don't want Glimmer cooking for us," Catra said.

Glimmer did her best not to show Catra a few obscene hand gestures since Speleo was present and it was technically a formal meeting but she did manage to kick Catra under the table.

"If we can get back on track," Adora said, picking up the agenda she'd written, "Huntara did finally respond and tell us about the area. She said there's definitely people back there but they're incredibly insular. She did confirm they are probably Magicats though."

"Probably?" Speleo asked, her ears twitching up.

"She hasn't been there herself and said she wasn't going to commit," Adora said. "She's being careful honestly."

"That's not like her," Catra said.

"It's not and I pushed her a little on it but she just shrugged and said she hadn't been in that area herself and didn't have anything to say," Adora said.

"Isn't she the princess of that kingdom?" Tinz said.

"It's not a kingdom and she isn't," Glimmer replied. "Up until recently most of the planet thought it was an empty waste full of deadly creatures and plants."

"And it is," Bow said, drawing a look from Glimmer before she went on.

"However, as I was saying," Glimmer said, "the Valley of the Lost is the only place you'd call under any kind of rule of law right now and that's new."

"That's an understatement," Lonnie said with a laugh. "I lived around there through the occupation. The rule of law didn't start until after we'd left so we're talking barely a year or two. It's still very much a new thing."

"On the upside, because of that, we can stage out of the Valley of the Lost without too much worry," Bow said.

"I still caution against that," Juliet said.

"We have to trust them sometime," Bow said.

"And if we don't, we have to haul way more stuff and bring more people and it stops looking like an exploratory group and more like an invasion," Catra said with a snort. "And from what I've heard from the people I know out there, that wouldn't go well."

"Speaking from what I saw them do to an actual invading army, I agree," Lonnie said.

Adora looked back up from the list as she said, "I'm looking over these skiff loadouts and I think we're pretty ready. Lonnie, what do you think?"

Lonnie nodded as she said, "Got some old supply sergeants getting them loaded up and some mechanics fixing them up. They're going to fly them out to the Valley of the Lost tomorrow and set up our first stage if we don't have any issues."

"I'm just glad I'm not going to be mass transit for everyone," Glimmer said.

"Some of us know how to get something done without magic," Lonnie said with a grin. "Besides, you're still hauling the core group, Your Majesty."

Tinz looked at Speloe and chuckled as Speleo gave her a look back but no one was paying attention as Glimmer was getting ready to argue with Lonnie before Bow laughed and said, "OK, let's not get into it. So it sounds like we're ready to go. Am I right?"

Silence fell over the room as everyone looked around at each other. It was Catra who broke the silence.

"I think I am."

The others chimed in and Lonnie nodded as she said, "Alright, I'm sending the notice for my skiffs to head out there."

"Your skiffs?" Adora said.

"My skiffs," Lonnie replied. "Scorpia might be princess of the Fright Zone but I'm the head of the what's left of the Horde and so they're my skiffs. Administrator of the Horde Demobilization Effort, remember? Just try not to chip the paint or dent them."

Speleo and Tinz looked concerned and Juliet was frowning but the rest were laughing.

"Chip or dent them? You mean more than they already are? And you need a better title, something less bureaucratic," Catra said.

"Hey, there's nothing wrong with that," Bow said.

"Sounds like something made up in Bright Moon," Tinz said while Speleo just sighed, having given up on getting her to be tactful when she realized the group didn't mind though it still offended her diplomat soul.

"It was," Lonnie said. "They led the committees that set it up."

"Tell you what, I got a title for you," Catra said.

"I swear if you say…," Lonnie started to say before Catra waved her arm.

"I'm not going to call you after him," Catra said, referring to Prime. "And Lord doesn't fit you, so how about Force Captain?"

The room went silent at the look on Lonnie's face as she spoke.

"You're kidding, right?"

"Um, no," Catra said, her ears flattening back a little as Melog curled under her chair, their paws over their face. "Didn't, um, really think that one through."

"No, you did not," Lonnie said before forcing a bit of a smile. "It's alright, Fuzzy. Administrator doesn't sound so bad after those options."

"Fair enough," Catra said.

"OK, before we get any more awkward before we're stuck together for a couple of weeks, how about we call this to an end for now?" Bow said.

"I think that would be best," Speleo said.

"Oh, um, one thing," Lonnie said. "It's my turn to make this awkward. Hordak finally got back with me. He's heading to Bright Moon to talk with you and will probably be there this evening."

Catra leaned back in her chair with a groan as she said, "The hits just keep on coming don't they?"

Chapter End Notes

I think this may be the first thing I've ever written with a nonbinary character who uses she/they (Chef Brassicales). My first nonbinary character was Finn (they/them) and I remember writing them was what made me begin to realize that I was nonbinary as I wrote their pronouns and thought, "Hey, this isn't that hard to do. Kind of like it in fact." I know several people who had their lesbian awakening from the show but for me it was my gender awakening (a bit after the fact with a non-canon character but here we are).

Chapter 33: Chapter Thirty-Three - Saz

Chapter Summary

Saz has reached the pass above Snowtop. So what happens next?

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There's many different kinds of cold. There's the cold of winter when frost sparkles in the late afternoon sun on a windowpane as seen from inside a house by a warm fire with friends gathered around. There's the blah, damp cold of early morning after a rain in late winter where everything is a smear of gray and you have to head to work. There's the sharp cold of a cloudless evening right after a heavy snow when everything is muted and the stars stand out sharp as glass. That's just normal cold, cold most people know.

There's a cold though that few experience. It's not bitter. It's not biting or brisk or blustering because those are concepts people can grasp and name. There's a cold that's elemental, beyond normal grasp, like the full force of a god, the kind of cold that drives a person mad. It can't be defeated, only survived if possible.

That was the cold Saz was huddled in now. The flight in had taken them into the pass near Snowtop. Snick had flown low enough that there were green streaks on the paint on the bottom of their skiff from clipping the tops of the trees. The other squad had been just behind them, though not quite as low, and they'd settled in a position far enough up the pass that the skiffs hadn't been seen from the town. The hike down to view the town was when they'd all realized just how cold it was as they'd settled down into a depression made by the root ball of a fallen tree.

They'd set up tarps, checked that no light showed from under them, setup lookouts and began the task of getting ready to patrol. That'd right before the first evening had started.

That's when the blizzard hit.

Saz was first on lookout as the wind had picked up and the snow had begun to fall. She hadn't left an inch of herself exposed to the weather, everything had been under some form of clothing, and even then she felt like she was standing naked before the wind. She had been able to see the location of the camp about thirty yards behind her in the trees when she'd set up but in seconds she could barely see the trees only a few steps away as the wind began to scream. For a moment she thought about walking back to the tarp as there was no way anyone would be out in this weather and sneaking up on them. Then she remembered Snick's warning about whiteouts and realized she was stuck for the moment. She took a moment to tie herself to the thin fir tree with a length of rope to keep herself from wandering before she huddled in the lee of the trunk as the light began to fall.

She remembered the first time she'd thought she was going to die. It'd been on a raid in the canyons around her village of Staed. She was still young and she'd gotten separated from her chaperone that was supposed to act as instructor and guide. She'd been moving through a canyon, not paying close attention to her surroundings as she berated herself for getting separated when she'd come face to face with another Magicat. They'd both stood there in shock for a moment, neither of them expecting a person to be in what each had thought of as a remote canyon. Saz could still remember that Magicat's face. Swirling blonde colored fur that blended with the stone around her, her pupils dilating wide in shock, her ears flattening back, and then the fight had started.

Saz had gone for her knife but the other Magicat had slammed into her and the fight became a nasty brawl that rolled along the ground. At first neither had used claws, something drilled into them as kittens as both a cultural norm to only use them in honor

duels but also to avoid little kittens tearing everything up, but as it became obvious that neither was going to gain the upper hand, the claws came out as did the fangs. The canyon had echoed with growls and hisses as they fought.

Saz though she had the upper hand when the other Magicat slammed her head into a stone. Everything went weird and Saz slumped trying to fight down the urge to vomit as the other Magicat locked Saz's arms up so she could go for the throat. Saz shuddered in the cold now remembering it, she'd been sure she was going to die that day but at the last second her chaperone had shown up and knocked the other Magicat off of Saz with a thrown rock. The other Magicat had gone limp and fallen on top of Saz as her chaperone came flowing across the rocks.

He'd been only a few years older than Saz but had been infinitely more experienced, at least to Saz's mind. He'd taught her to hunt, he'd taught her to fight and track, and he was considered one of the finest warriors in the village. She lived in a state of half terror, half hero worship of him and when she shoved the other Magicat off of herself and stood up, she couldn't look him in the face as he came trotting over to her.

"I should have stayed close," she muttered when he stopped in front of her.

"You should have," he said as he looked down at the other Magicat who had twitched a little and made a little mewling noise. "You used claws."

Saz nodded, her ears folding back even further in shame as she knew the next question.

"Was she worthy of those claws?"

"No, but just…," Saz said.

"An excuse?"

"Chuut, it's not like that!" Saz said, looking up at him.

"It's exactly like that," Chuut said, looming over her.

"She'd have killed me!" Saz said.

"I'd rather you be dead then to dishonor yourself like that," Chuut replied.

Saz didn't agree with him but she just looked down and stayed quiet.

Chuut put an hand on her shoulder as he said, "You're not the only one who thinks that way but if you want to be a warrior, a real warrior, then you have to hold to these beliefs. It's what makes us different. It's what makes those of us from Staed special. You have nothing if you have no honor."

Saz just nodded as she looked at the woman on the ground next to them. She was moving slowly, trying to crawl away and retching as she did. Saz realized the woman wasn't really any older then she was at the time, and Saz now took in the satchel spilled across the rocks. The woman had been out collecting spellmallow, a plant with little use beyond ornamental. Saz saw some of the thick stalks had been weaved together already, the tiny purple blossoms bright against the red sand and rock. Saz realize then she had almost killed a girl who'd been out making flower crowns.

Saz finally saw, hunched down in the screaming blizzard, that had been when she'd started to pull away from her people. It wasn't even a thought then, just a little seed planted, a seed that blossomed with her finding herself running across the Crimson Waste with Catra. She thought of how she was raised and now thought of how Basco and her were raising Catra and she hoped Catra would be able to make those hard decisions as well. That'd she'd stand up for herself and fight and go at the world tooth and claw to secure what was hers.

Most importantly, she wanted Catra to know love like she now knew. Even in the short time with Basco, Saz realized just how

much love she'd really had. Even with Catra's father, who Saz had loved, it hadn't been the same. She'd have killed and died for Catra's father because honor would have demanded it but for Basco she'd kill and die for her because to do otherwise would be unthinkable.

Now, sitting in the snow a thought crossed her mind that she wasn't entirely sure she could still feel parts of her extremities. For a moment, it was an abstract thought, no big deal, and that was when the fear sank its teeth deep into her throat as she realized what was probably going on and that she could very well die. She was so close to being free of the Horde, being free to be with Basco and the rest of her little created village, and she felt the fear of death gnaw deeper into her throat at the thought of what might happen to Catra.

She kept telling herself to get up, do something, break radio silence but she just sat there as the noise of the wind sunk into her and she began to realize she was hearing voices but not any she knew. She sat up straighter, trying to look into the swirling nightmare before her, but saw nothing. Then she realized the voices were speaking to her and she felt herself leaning forward as she strained to here them.

Failure.

Useless.

Lost.

Unloved.

Unknown.

Give up.

Sleep.

Lay down.

Sleep.

It won't be long.

Give in.

Sleep.

"Hey! What the fuck are you doing!?"

Saz came around to strong hands shaking her. For a moment she wondered why it was so dark and what the bright light was in her eyes before she focused a little to see Basco knelt down next to her in a climbing harness, a rope leading back into the swirling void of snow as the headlamp she wore shone in Saz's face. Saz tried to say something but she couldn't seem to say anything through the shivering that felt like it was going to pull her apart. She mumbled something and tried to roll away, just wanting to go back to sleep where it didn't hurt.

"No, fuck that, get up! Get up! You are not fucking dying!" Basco said as she undid the rope holding Saz to the tree, tied Saz off to her with the same rope, and dragged Saz to her feet. "Come on! Get moving! Now!"

Basco pulled one of Saz's arms over her shoulder and half dragged her forward.

"Fuck! Get your feet moving! I can't drag you! Come on!"

Saz felt a little chuckle in her throat. It all seemed so silly and she just wanted to sleep, just like the voices on the wind were telling her to do.

"Damn it, Saz! It's barely thirty yards! Fucking walk! I'm not leaving you so you move or we both die!"

Saz felt the frown on her face at the thought of Basco dying as she muttered out, "No… go on… just… just need some… rest."

Suddenly Basco was in front of her, holding her by the front of her parka as she shouted, "Rest at the shelter or die here with me!"

Saz shook her head but managed to put a foot down and Basco was right under beside her as the next foot came forward as if trying to see where its friend had gone and Saz and Basco finally started moving forward. It was an eternity. Once away from the tree, it was nothing but swirls of white caught in the headlamp. And the voices.

Curl up with her.

Sleep together.

Lay down with her.

Sleep side by side.

Together.

Always together.

Sleep.

Saz nodded as she started to slump towards the ground dragging Basco down with her as she did.

"OK," Saz muttered to the voices. "OK. Sleep."

Basco was shaking from the cold and her teeth chattered as she fell down beside Saz.

"No! Don't sleep! Come on! We have to go! Saz! No! Come on! Up! *Get up!*"

Saz reached up to touch the side of Basco's hood with a smile as she closed her eyes.

Chapter End Notes

Is this the saddest chapter in this fic? No, no it is not, you just haven't seen it yet.

Chapter 34: Chapter Thirty-Four - Catra

Chapter Summary

A young Catra wonders just what happened to her mother.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra didn't like sleeping in the creche at night. She cried a little every once in a while as she missed being curled up close to her mother and hearing the soft purr that slipped out of her every once in a while as she fiddled with Catra's ears. She missed waking up to see Basco leaning over from the top bunk dangling down an edge of a blanket so Catra could bat at it. She loved Snick coming up with little games to play and how Kit would join in along with them. Catra couldn't have articulated what a family was but if someone had explained it to her, she'd called them her family. All she knew was the feeling she had for all four of them and the dull ache that she had when she didn't get to see them.

Catra got a reputation as difficult with the creche workers as she began to fuss throw fits when it became obvious she'd be in the creche for another night. She didn't know how long it had been now since she had last seen her mom and she kept looking towards the door every time it opened when she was nearby, hoping to see her mom or her other family coming in and when it didn't happen, she'd express her dismay. Loudly.

She had a friend though. When it came time to nap or to sleep for the night, they always ended up by each other. Adora would always hide a toy and they'd try and play with it when they were supposed to be sleeping. Sometimes another little girl named Lonnie would be with them and she'd play a little as well. The play never lasted long as the creche workers had long ago caught on to what was going on but it never stopped Adora from trying. The

creche workers also learned what happened when they tried to separate her from Adora and it was easier to keep an eye on the two instead of trying to deal with a Magicat kitten full of anger and claws.

There was one woman though who would come occasionally to check up on Adora and Catra, a tall woman in a long gown that floated across the floor and who's face Catra had never really seen since it was always behind a mask. Catra had been afraid of her but the woman was kind to her and would occasionally take Catra and Adora out together to go and spend a little time with her. She was stern but she'd give the girls little toys and even occasionally hugs and Catra found that she warmed to her. Catra knew her name was something long, something that made her think of the darkness in the corners that scared Catra sometimes because it'd move a little when Catra wasn't quite looking at it, but that got mixed up in the little affections the woman would give Catra and soon Catra found herself not really being scared anymore.

Time passed. Catra began to cause less of a fuss as she fell into the routine of the creche. She asked the woman once about her mother but she'd simply said, "I don't know. Do not ask again."

Of course, Catra did ask again and got in trouble. She didn't like to remember that part. That didn't stop her asking but the next time did when the woman, Catra had learned to call her Shadow Weaver, had punished her more severely. Then she told Catra she didn't like to punish her but she needed to behave and if she couldn't behave, she'd have to punish Adora as well because it was obvious that Catra had to be learning it from somewhere. Catra learned then not to ask about her mother and the few times she thought to ask again, she shoved it down. It became easy after a while. Then she just didn't think of it.

She no longer looked towards the door when it opened.

Chapter End Notes

Oh, hello, chapter that made me cry.

Chapter 35: Chapter Thirty-Five - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra wakes up in a canyon in the Crimson Waste, ready to find out more about herself. Of course, she doesn't realize what is going to be presented to her just yet.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra woke up and for a moment wondered where she was as she stared at the soft pastel of a Bright Moon tent ceiling. Then she remembered and rolled over to see something with entirely too many legs peak up out of Adora's boot before sliding a little deeper into it out of sight. Catra sighed as she pushed the blanket out of the way and stretched. Adora stirred next to her in the early morning darkness and muttered something Catra couldn't quite make out. Catra rolled over to see her looking back towards her.

"You alright?" Catra whispered. She wasn't sure why but the stillness of the canyon seemed to demand it. All she could hear outside were the liquid sounds of wind and river.

"I could ask you the same," Adora whispered back. "How early is it?"

"I don't know but I think I'm going to go out."

"Get me some coffee?"

Catra kissed her as she whispered, "Alright. You have a guest in your boots, just so you know."

Adora groaned a little as she muttered something but nodded and burrowed back into her blanket. Catra got up, shook out her clothes, and threw them on. She grabbed her leather jacket on the way out the tent flap and shrugged it on because she knew just how chilly the Waste got at night and while it wasn't as bad down in the canyons, it was still present since day hadn't started. The jacket still felt good, even with the bad memories that went with it, and she grinned a little at the new paint it had on the back. Huntara had pointed out that wearing the colors of a Crimson Waste gang wasn't going to go over well, especially one she wasn't actually affiliated with anymore, and so Catra had spent a little time redecorating the jacket. Now it sported a painted on sword in gold and white.

Catra sighed as she felt the sand under her bare feet, chill from the night but comforting, and once again noticed how easily she moved over the sand when others floundered a little in the looser sections. As she headed along the two lines of tents facing each other, she watched the shadows around the canyon slowly shift as Etheria's never ending light show in the sky filtered down into the deep canyon. Catra nodded at one of the Bright Moon guards standing at the end of the double row of tents as she made her way towards the main command tent.

On her way, she passed multiple low two person tents set up by the row of skiffs they'd brought in. They held the ex-Horde personnel that had volunteered to come out and work as ground crew with the skiffs. They'd been offered, multiple times in fact, more spacious tents but they'd just shook their head and insisted on using the old Horde tents. Catra had to admit they seemed pretty content with them, though personally she preferred her double cot with Adora and a bit more elbow room. One of the ex-Horde members, a grizzled looking lizardfolk who was probably old when Catra was still in diapers, was sitting outside his tent yawning as he gave a little half-salute as Catra went past. Catra returned it with a wave, hating to salute even when she was still in the Horde, but he seemed to take in stride.

As she passed the last of the tents, she saw the lighter colored fabric where the Horde emblem had been removed and it made her think of Hordak and the meeting they'd had the day before he'd left. He'd flown in on a skiff type that no one recognized at first until one of the guards commented that it looked like an overhauled light cargo skiff. It was then that people started recognizing the changes made to it with pieces retrofitted from various craft of various kingdoms and a few no one recognized but found out later was from detritus dumped on Beast Island over the years.

This they found out from Entrapta who came hurtling down the ramp to them, hair flying every which way as she waved at people and began to talk a mile a minute about what they had been doing.

"You would not believe how the pookas behave now that we finally got the signal turned off!" Entrapta said as she settled in front of Bow, her hair holding her like a chair off the ground so she was eye level with him.

"Are they less vicious now?" Bow said, shuddering a little at the memory of the little beasts.

"No! More! The signal actually caused them to be calmer! We saw them strip a whole deer to nothing but bone in moments! They've become smarter as well, according to several different metrics! It's fascinating!"

Bow shuddered harder at the thought of smarter, more vicious pookas but that thought was sidetracked by Hordak emerging from the skiff. By most accounts, ex-Horde members were becoming fully integrated into society and faced little day-to-day issues. Of course, as Catra could have told them, that didn't necessarily extend to the high command and the silence that fell over the landing area was proof of that. It wasn't a complete silence, Entrapta kept talking about some little bit of First Ones tech they'd found, but for the most part, everyone had turned to look at Hordak.

Hordak didn't seem to really notice, or care, and he carefully walked down the ramp to the ground, a thin network of rods forming an exoskeleton to keep him upright. The long black dress he wore, what he would have called a tabard still, seemed to point up how thin he was and made him look more severe than less. Adora didn't mind though, she went up the ramp to meet him with a smile.

"Thank you for coming."

"Of course. I don't believe I'll be of much help though."

Catra, who was standing back trying to push down her feelings, had to admit he seemed not to be the same Hordak who'd tried to shoot her, admittedly while she was trying to beat the stuffing out of him. Of course, she did have a little thought in the back of her head saying, "You could definitely take him now," but she shoved it down and stepped forward while Melog lurked behind her, trying not to bare their teeth.

"Force Captain," Hordak said, lowering his head a fraction of an inch in recognition of her.

"Lord Hordak," Catra shot back, doing her best not to lose her temper at being called Force Captain for Adora's sake. She did notice his eyes narrowing at being called by his former rank though so it was at least even in her mind. She then saw Adora giving her a look and forced a smile. "Thanks for coming to help."

Hordak started to respond before noticing the look Adora was giving him as well and he forced a thin smile as he said, "Of course."

Entrapta came up the ramp to hook a length of hair around Hordak's arm as she said, "Bow said they've got a tiny food buffet set up for us!"

Hordak turned to look at her and his smile went from thin to warm as he said, "Shall we investigate it?"

"We shall!" Entrapta said with a cackle as she began walking forward with him.

Adora put a hand on Catra's arm and quietly said, "Listen…"

"I know, I know," Catra said as she watched Bow started walking beside Hordak and Entrapta. "He just really…"

"I know but he's been through so much and really, he did take me in after what Light Hope did and could you, I don't know, not antagonize him?"

"Seriously?"

"OK, yeah, I know, and I'll try and say something to him but you're right here," Adora said with a sigh. "And he is here to help. That's got to mean something."

"It's his duty and he shall not shirk it," Catra said, trying to imitate Hordak's voice while Melog perked up.

Adora gave half of a laugh as she said, "OK, that was terrible. Be nice. I know you can."

"I'll do my duty as well," Catra said as she started following the rest.

"You're impossible sometimes, you know that, right?" Adora said as she gave her a little push.

"But you still love me so what's that say about you?"

They both laughed a little as they hurried to catch up, pushing each other as they did while Melog ran in and out of their legs.

Later, as they were gathered in a small sitting room with Entrapta hovering over the buffet with a caliper, ruler, protractor, and data pad, Adora handed Hordak a printed copy of the file Lonnie had found. After a brief description of what was going on, Adora said, "That's when we decided to reach out to you. It was a long time

ago and I know you weren't fully aware of everything that happened in the Horde but this seemed to be like something you might remember and anything could help."

Hordak gave a brief nod as he said, "I remember Force Captain Octavia's long range scout plan but I never knew the participants, I'm sorry."

"Do you remember shutting it down?" Adora said.

"I do not."

There was an uncomfortable silence while Catra hugged Melog a little closer to her. Then she blurted out, "Do you remember anything?"

Hordak frowned as he straightened up even more but didn't respond. Adora sighed and Catra sighed right back as she said, "OK, shit, that didn't come out right."

"I accept your apology," Hordak said.

"That wasn't an…," Catra said before stopping herself. "Yeah, sure, thank you. Let me put it this way, do you remember something more?"

"No. As I said, it wasn't much. I remember when it was shut down, there was some talk about an accident but that is all I remember," Hordak said.

"You didn't shut it down?" Catra said with a frown.

"I told Force Captain Octavia that she should be diligent with Horde resources and to review whether or not this was useful," Hordak said.

Catra bristled a little as she thought of her mother being referred to as resources as Adora laid a hand on her thigh. Catra's eyes darted over to Adora and she calmed down a little as she ran her hand down Melog's back.

"Maybe you can review the file?" Adora said.

Hordak nodded as he said, "Of course."

He began to read and after a few minutes, it was obvious he wasn't skimming but soaking in the details. Adora gave a little nod towards the buffet and Catra just shook her head before giving a little hand wave to indicate Adora should go ahead. Adora gave her a quick kiss before going over and grabbing a plate to start filling. After another minute or so, Hordak began to frown. He flipped back, read again, and his frowned deepened.

"This isn't correct," Hordak said and Catra sat forward.

"What do you mean?"

"This says they were lost in a pass above a town called Moraine," Hordak replied. "I do remember the location as a pass above Snowtop."

"Are they near each other?" Bow said.

"I do not know," Hordak said.

"They're not," Adora said from the buffet. "Moraine is further south and its main pass is called Overhang."

"How sure are you?" Catra said, not noticing Entrapta suddenly go still and look towards Hordak as he frowned.

"I am not. Few things are sure after the Pool," Hordak said.

Catra felt Melog shrink beside her as they buried their nose under her arm. For her part she was remembering the horrible clinical smell of that bright green pool as the chanting of "All beings must suffer to become pure" echoed in her head. Adora had her arm around Catra in a second as she took a long, deep breath as she screwed her eyes closed.

"I did not mean to cause distress," Hordak said as Entrapta came up behind him.

"I didn't either," Catra said through gritted teeth. "It's fine, really, it's fine."

The meeting ended quickly after that.

Dinner that night was a more formal affair than normal, mostly because Bow wanted an excuse to break out the really good china, and they avoided uncomfortable topics. This resulted in most of the dinner conversation being between Bow and Entrapta as they talked about science and engineering for which Catra would have normally hated but was profoundly glad for this time.

The next morning, after a brief meeting that yield little information, they all walked back to the skiff, Hordak eager to leave Bright Moon and Entrapta eager to get back to their research, and it was there that Catra got blindsided. They tried to keep simple small talk going as they walked, though Entrapta had already bailed out of it and had scurried ahead to get the engines running when Hordak addressed Catra.

"I am sorry I was not able to be of more help."

"It's alright," Catra said with a little shrug.

"I do not have parents but I understand they are important to those that do," Hordak said, clearing his throat a little before going on. "It is partly my reason why you do not have your parent so I say again, I am sorry that I can not be of more help to resolve this in some way."

Catra looked at him, her mouth hanging open a little, as she looked at the man she used to be terrified of as a child, then fought hard to impress, and then hated before finally being sorry for him after she met Prime. All those feelings had been rolled together into a spiky ball in her mind and what he'd just said seemed to go against everything she thought of him. Then she

saw the soft expression that was on his face for a moment and felt like her mind had come to a screaming halt.

"Did you just…," Catra started to say as Hordak's default face snapped back.

"I will review the document again, in case anything is recalled on further examination, and send you any details that may be of use to you. Also, I am willing to help again if you reach out but we must leave now," Hordak said before turning to Bow and Glimmer. "Thank you for the hospitality of Bright Moon."

Everyone had heard the exchange and Bow was too busy trying to get his mouth shut but Glimmer managed to get out, "Oh, of course. It was a pleasure to host you."

Hordak gave a curt nod and then turned to walk up the ramp, his back ramrod straight, and when he got to the top, he turned as the ramp began to rise and looked at Catra for a brief moment before giving a little wave to them all that was cut short by the ramp closing and the skiff lifting off.

As the skiff cleared the nearest trees and picked up speed, silence reined on the field before Catra finally spoke.

"I've lost my mind. I've lost my mind because there is no way I just saw Lord Hordak give a cutesy little wave."

"Told you he changed," Adora said.

"Now is not the time," Catra replied.

"It is always the time for I told you so," Adora said with a grin.

Catra had that thought in her mind as she stepped into the command tent. The soft light of a lantern didn't do much to dispel the darkness inside but to Catra's eyes, it was fine. Speleo was actually smiling from where she sat at a table, reading some papers. A few Bright Moon guards sat around at small portable

desks, monitoring senors they had around the camp, but mostly it was quiet.

"Where's your shadow today?" Catra said, sitting down beside Speleo. "I figured she wouldn't be away from you."

"She has actually stepped out to answer nature's call," Speleo replied. "And where is your shadow if I may ask?"

"She's not my shadow," Catra said with a snort. "She's my better half."

"I like that term, 'better half.' We have something similar in our language," Speleo said before saying a few words in the Half Moon Magicat dialect.

"You know, still don't speak that," Catra said with a grunt as she glanced over to see Tinz entering the tent.

"It means something like my foundation," Speleo said.

"It means the base of the stalagmite," Tinz said. "It also implies a long build up of feeling."

"Well you are the poet, not I," Speleo said with a smile as Tinz sat down beside her. "Either is a good translation."

"I suppose," Tinz said, looking at Speleo for a moment before looking down at the documents. "Dispatches from home?"

Catra looked between the two, sure she was imagining what she was seeing, as Speleo responded.

"They are, came in on the courier flight at nightfall. Figured now would be a good time to review them. Mostly just tedious council questions."

"Must be nice to be mostly out of contact," Catra said as she filled a mug from a huge pot of coffee. The smell off of it gave her a little grin as she thought of how disappointed Adora would be.

She preferred some awful instant coffee she'd discovered at some point and always complained how actually decent coffee just didn't have the same kick. Catra found though that living in Bright Moon had its perks, one of which was actually decent food that never came in a pressed loaf shape or was only called coffee because it was brown, hot, and steaming.

Speleo brought her out of her thoughts as she said, "I actually miss home right now if I'm being honest."

Catra sat down at the table across from the two as she tried to think of something to say when Tinz said, "I miss the quiet of home." Catra, who'd been to Half Moon a couple of times, thought of the caverns and how everyone seemed to be on top of everyone else as Tinz went on. "I can see you're thinking of the main caverns but I live in a side cavern that few others visit. The silence that descends at night… it's all encompassing. It's a dead cavern as well, so you don't even have the water drip except in rare moments of exceptionally heavy rain upside."

"I miss the closeness," Speleo said as she sighed. "Everything upside is so big and far away."

"It is," Tinz said with a nod. "Here's not too bad, though I could do with a good solid rock ceiling overhead."

"Everything you're saying, no offense, sounds like a nightmare. Complete silence? Everything close in? And then of course the complete darkness," Catra said with a slight shudder as she remembered darkness that had soaked into her, "is just… oof."

Tinz was frowning a little but Speleo was smiling as she said, "That's one of the reasons we say that just because someone is a Magicat does not mean they are part of Half Moon. I know it's seen as a snobby thing, an insular society, but it's because of that I believe. The first time I went to the surface as a child, I was terrified."

"Your rocks were missing is why," Tinz said and Speleo shot her a look before continuing.

"Yes, my rocks. My home, my stones, my life," Speleo said.

"Why did you become a diplomat then?" Catra said.

"I did not chose, the council chose when the war finished. We knew we needed to contact the outside world, that we couldn't stay hidden and I was one of the people chosen," Speleo replied.

"You didn't get a choice?" Catra said, sitting forward.

"It's not like that," Speleo said. "I serve Half Moon and I serve its people. Because of this, I was one of several chosen to form our new diplomatic corp."

Tinz said something to Speleo in Magicat and Speleo responded back.

"You know, one of these days I may learn to speak that," Catra said.

"I'd be honored if you did," Speleo replied.

"Wait, what? Why?" Catra said.

"You may not be of Half Moon but you are a Magicat and this language is part of your culture. You should learn it."

"I… I don't even know…," Catra said and hated herself for the sudden yearning she had when Tinz spoke up.

"The Horde stole this from you," Tinz said. "I know some apologists say that they only saved children who would have had a short, miserable life but whether your life would have been better or not, we can not say, because you were robbed of the chance to know. People speak of our lives as if they were less because of our isolation but I know both sides now and perhaps there's truth to that but we have a choice. Even before, we were

still aware of upside life, we still saw what was going on, and you didn't even have that given to you. Your culture is the Horde, your people are the Horde, and you were denied not only the choice but even the knowledge a choice was available." Tinz slammed her fist into the table and cursed in Magicat. Catra jumped and Speleo looked on in surprise as Tinz continued. "If you want to know, I'll teach you Magicat, I will show you what you have missed, I will teach you what should have been your mother tongue for as long as you want. I swear it by the Tears and may the Squeeze take me if I fail."

Catra opened her mouth but nothing came out. Tinz had been fairly reserved and to see the white hot fury that had flashed across her when she'd cursed had set Catra back. She didn't know what the Tears were but she knew enough of Half Moon to know the Squeeze was some mythical entity that hid in the blackness of the caves to trap unwary people. In the end though, she knew after such a phrasing, she had only one response.

"When do we start?"

Chapter End Notes

> That's a long one! Not much to say here except thank you for reading!

Chapter 36: Chapter Thirty-Six - Excerpt from Horde Report SAR-25-103 - Final Report on Snowtop Pass Operation (Aleph Squad of the 1st Horde Long Range Scouts and 1st Squad of 1st Infantry Alpha Squadron SAR Ops)

Chapter Summary

> An excerpt of a report written by the 27th SAR Cohort of the Horde discussing the results of search and rescue mission for the two missing scout squads in Snowtop Pass.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It is the conclusion of SAR Units Two, Three, and Four, a conclusion endorsed by 27th SAR Cohort Command, that while not all Horde members were recovered, that all Horde members on the scouting operation in Snowtop Pass should still be considered as lost. While only one out of four of Aleph Squad was recovered (Squadron Corporal Kit, HID #78-57987-HLRS), it is the opinion of SAR Command that based on weather conditions (Appendix W-2, Appendix W-3), condition of the camp (Appendix A-1, Appendix A-2, Appendix A-3), condition of the skiffs at the initial insertion point of the scout squads (Appendix A-4, Appendix A-5), and the condition of the initial insertion point itself (Appendix A-6), that the missing three have not survived. It is recommend that none of the eight be included on the Role of the Lost as no indication of enemy action was present and that their service records indicate death was a result of misadventure.

The final findings of the 27th SAR Cohort show that inadequate equipment and training combined with extreme weather

conditions were the contributing factors to the loss of the eight troopers. The highlight of corrective actions to avoid future loss are improved training for extreme environments, improved operating ranges for equipment, and better logistic support. Full recommendations for corrective actions are in Appendix C.

For the Glory of the Horde,

Cohort Captain Trate-Trin of Horde 27th SAR Cohort Command

CC: Shadow Weaver, Force Captain Octavia, 549th Horde Filing Legion (99th Cohort)

Chapter End Notes

> Yes, I have worked in an office for years and I do write formal reports. I still had to double check how CC works because something in my head kept telling me I was wrong (I was not). I'd also like to say that one of the little fun bits of this fic has been coming up with bits and pieces of Horde bureaucracy and such. That may also be the longest chapter title (or title period) that I have ever used. Definitely longest in relation to the actual length of the chapter.

Chapter 37: Chapter Thirty-Seven - Adora

Chapter Summary

Adora has to work with Juliet but so far it's awkward and no one quiet seems to know how to handle it.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora walked across the sand as morning woke up and lit the canyon. Further down the beach she could see the little driftwood homes of the small group of people who lived on the beach and she watched as the lizardfolk who lived in them came out and looked their way before moving on. Adora remembered stepping off the first skiff to land on the beach and one of them had come over to them to talk. The fact he was lizardfolk was obvious but where Rogelio was smooth skinned, this one was shorter and built like a brick wall with pebbly skin in a mottled black and light orange pattern with sandals, heavy pants that clung to his frame, and a broad brimmed hat. He'd spoke in a language Adora didn't know, though it sounded a bit like what Rogelio spoke, and when he realized they didn't speak it, he'd rolled his eyes a little and said in Bright Moon, "Traders?"

"No, we're surveying the area," Adora had said, the cover story they'd come up with. "My name is Adora."

He'd looked her up and down cautiously before saying, "I'm Gila. Who commissioned you?"

Catra was right behind her and she swore she could hear her grinning. Catra hadn't been on board with the survey story and had said they should have just packed some trade stuff and claimed to be traders but had been overruled.

"No one," Adora said. "We're from Bright Moon and we're trying to get good maps."

Gila slowly scratched at the side of his neck as he said, "Why?"

She could hear Catra fighting the told you so as she faltered a little but managed to say, "For knowledge."

Gila had harrumphed as he said, "So you're going to setup here?"

"Yes, if it's alright with you," Adora said, not sure what they'd do if he said no. The rest of the skiffs were already on the way and three of the four skiffs that were with them were already starting to unload so they could head back to ferry more supplies in.

"I don't own this," Gila said. "Do as you wish."

"Are those your people?" Adora said, nodding down the beach at the group of driftwood homes. "We'll be sure to stay on this end."

Gila had froze for a moment and Catra groaned inwardly because Adora didn't understand the Waste at all but Gila had loosened up and replied again, "Do as you wish."

With that, he'd turned around and started back across the sand, shouting something in his language at the group of people who'd formed up to watch from a distance. They all seemed to collectively shrug and go back to whatever it was they'd been doing before they'd arrived.

"You handled that well," Catra had said.

"Really?" Adora replied, perking up.

"No! I can't believe you asked about the other people! Also, I believe I said that story was bullshit and that pretty much proved it," Catra said.

"Come on, I was just being polite and he seemed to think it was a fine story."

"He thought you were full of shit, he basically said you were full of shit, and then when he walked away, I bet he told everyone down there that you were full of shit," Catra said. "And it's the Waste, don't be so polite, be cautious but aggressive."

"You act like you've spent a ton of time here," Adora said with a roll of her eyes. "You've barely spent more time here than I have."

"And I believe I ended up with my own gang and you ended up getting suckered by Huntara," Catra said.

"Let's just get the camp set up, alright?" Adora said with another roll of her eyes.

As Adora approached the command tent now, she thought of how they'd landed the rest of the equipment and supplies while Gila and the others had watched them off and on from the far end of the beach. Glimmer had landed with the last of the equipment, grumbling the whole time but the Bright Moon Guard contingent had refused to let their queen come in first. When she'd jumped off the skiff she looked windblown and irritated while Bow looked around in awe at the deep canyon in it's multitude of colors. Adora and Catra were waiting as they climbed down.

"We saved some heavy lifting for you, Your Majesty," Catra snarked as Glimmer kicked at the sand a little.

"I wanted to be here before you, Fuzzball," Catra said.

"It's for your safety," Bow said as he gave her a hug.

"I defeated a room full of clones all on my own," Glimmer said. "I won't break."

The Bright Moon Guard had fanned out and a few were taking in Gila's group hanging out on the beach further down in the last of the late afternoon light.

"We'd like to get you under cover, Your Majesty," one of the guards said to Glimmer.

Adora noticed the look and said, "They're alright. It's their home after all. They've been really mellow about us being here."

"Because they think you're full of it," Catra said. "That and there's no way you're dangerous because of it."

The rest of the conversation hadn't been much beyond the four laughing and teasing each other as they'd got back to work and now, as Adora entered the command tent, she felt like that had been a good time. It felt weird to think of that as a good time but today was the day they launched the first aerial scout teams and she felt nervous because while she was in command, her advisor was waiting for her in the tent.

"Princess," Juliet said with a curt nod as Adora approached a newly setup holographic table in the middle of the tent.

"General," Adora said, hating the awkward moment between them but she refused to say something. She wished Catra was there and wondered where she was but went forward anyway. "Where do we stand with the scouts?"

Juliet flicked on the table and a holographic topographic map titled towards them. After a moment, it expanded to show the actual terrain. Adora couldn't help but notice little readouts showing uncertainty to some of the underlying data but she didn't have anything she could say about it at the moment. Part of the job of the scouts would be actual surveying after all.

"They'll be leaving any moment now," Juliet said and began working the controls of the table. Little lines sprung up and moved up along and to the side of the main side canyon that ran into the river they were camped beside. "Two squads of two skiffs, as planned. I've taken the liberty of putting two more squads, same composition, in reserve for rapid response." Two little circles with a plus sign in them appeared on the rim of the canyon above them. "They'll stage here. They'll leave shortly as well."

Adora could see Juliet wanted to say something more but she wasn't sure what and she didn't want to really find out.

"Thank you, the reserves were a nice touch that I should have considered," Adora said as a few Bright Moon guards filtered into the tent with yawns and settled down at small tables with bits of

equipment on them. She couldn't help but notice they were giving discrete looks their way.

"It's alright, it's not something you commonly think of for scouting," Juliet said before frowning a little. "I should say that most people don't think of for scouting."

"I understood your meaning," Adora replied and then looked up as she heard skiffs pass overhead and heard one of the seated guards talking to them.

"We receive you, five by five. Safe flight, Hordie, over."

"Always, Moon, over and out."

Adora's eyebrows climbed her face as she turned to look at the guard who happened to catch Adora's look. She straightened up a little as she blushed and said, "Sorry, I know it's not strictly professional."

"No, that's not it, just… hadn't heard that before. Sounded really friendly."

"We've been hanging out with them, swapping stories," another guard said. "We've kind of bonded."

"After all, we broke a lot of the stuff they had to repair during the war," yet another guard said to a little nervous chuckle through the room.

Adora joined in and was happy to see Juliet at least smiled.

"We are one crew now after all," Juliet said and then nodded back at the first guard. "Call incoming, guard."

The guard blushed harder and answered the call as the next set of skiffs went by overhead and Adora sighed as the moment passed. Juliet turned back to the board where the various skiffs in the air were now showing up on the hologram. Adora watched them but it was like any other visualization she'd seen during the

war, though a bit updated, and while she was ready to find out the results, she found she couldn't focus on the minute details.

"I believe you have this well in hand, General. I'll excuse myself and go find breakfast and Catra," Adora said as she stepped back from the table.

"I'll follow you," Juliet said as she called a lieutenant over to watch the board with instructions to find her if anything happened. Adora wanted to tell her not to follow her but she just nodded with pursed lips.

They were both silent as they left the tent and headed towards a spot towards the canyon walls not too far away. It reminded Adora a bit of a picnic with the large pavilion covering tables and chairs sitting around near some breakwood trees. However, even a Bright Moon picnic didn't usually have a full cook tent large enough to house multiple skiffs beside it where the Bright Moon kitchen staff were working away. Breakfast was in full swing, with people heading towards the line that snaked into the cook tent and out into what people had started calling the mess hall before they'd even got it set up, when Juliet stopped for a moment and turned to Adora.

"I'd like to talk now, while no one else is around," Juliet said.

Adora stopped, feeling her gut drop. It could have been about anything they had going on but she knew better. She knew what it was about.

"I don't want to talk about it. It's fine."

"It's not," Juliet said. "I've made a mistake and…"

"Listen, I just… I don't want to talk about this, not out in the open, not when we've got so much more to deal with. We're working together, that's what matters, we can put our disagreement aside for now," Adora said as she started back towards the mess hall.

Juliet was right by her side as she said, "It's not good to let this fester. We need to settle it somehow."

"It's not festering, it's you tried to use my past against me," Adora snapped as she stopped and turned to Juliet. "I do not want to talk about this. End of story."

Juliet sighed as Adora sped up and walked away from her. Adora for her part felt stupid but she still remembered that moment, how she had felt, and how the shame had etched into her that she hadn't kicked that reflex, that urge to be perfect and to please. She was thinking about that as she walked into the mess hall and saw Catra sitting with Speleo and Tinz. Catra waved her over and Adora found a smile on her face, despite the things rolling round in her head. Then she came to a flat stop next to the table as Catra looked up at her and spoke in Magicat.

Catra's face was one of both being pleased with herself and love but it quickly switched to irritation when Tinz chuckled.

"What!? I said it just like you said!" Catra said as Adora sat down next to her.

"No, I'm sorry, you did," Tinz said. "You just… you have the wildest accent when you speak Magicat."

"She does not," Speleo said. "Stop teasing her."

Tinz shook her head but didn't say anything as Adora spoke as she took Catra's hand in her own without thinking.

"What did you say?"

"I love you, beautiful," Catra said and Adora thought of how shy she looked for a moment. Adora blushed a little but didn't stop her from leaning forward to kiss Catra.

"I love you too," Adora said before turning to the other two. "Is this a new thing or did you just want to learn that?"

"Tinz talked me into learning Magicat," Catra said with a nod towards Tinz. "Sorry, I forgot about your coffee."

"It's alright," Adors said with a smile. "Besides, I can't complain about learning new ways to say you love me."

Catra looked away with a little grin and then they all looked up as Bow walked in with Gila and a few other lizardfolk. They weren't the only ones looking but the conversation in the mess hall didn't flag any and after a moment everyone went back to what they had been doing. After a little bit more chatting, Adora got up to get something to eat and when she got back to the table, Glimmer had joined them. What Adora had planned to be a short breakfast turned into a long breakfast as they talked and laughed. Adora was just becoming relaxed when a Bright Moon guard came running under the pavilion and beelined towards Adora.

"General Juliet told me to come find you. We have contact, ma'am," the guard said, throwing off a quick salute. "We need you in command."

All thoughts of a relaxing morning fled Adora's mind and she took off at a sprint.

Chapter End Notes

> Yes, Gila is patterned after a Gila Monster. Yes, he's venomous. I'm almost 100% sure it's also not the first time I've had a Gila Monster lizardfolk in one of my stories but it may be the first time they've had a speaking part (I'm pretty sure Capella sees one in the Waste in her series). If you're not sure what they are, it's these guys.
>
> https://www.britannica.com/animal/Gila-monster
>
> They're venomous but also pretty mellow from what I've heard. I remember reading about a doctor from the turn of the 20th century who said something like how he'd never treated a Gila Monster bite and was pretty sure he would

refuse because any idiot that managed to get bit was probably doing something to deserve it.

Chapter 38: Chapter Thirty-Eight - Catra

Chapter Summary

> The search of the Crimson Waste canyon lands has already reported a contact and now Catra and crew try to decide just what the next step should be when a surprise changes all plans.

Chapter Notes

> Shall?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was on her feet and running after Adora overtaking her in moments as Adora was reminded once again that running in sand is not easy. Melog came bounding out from where they'd been exploring and was on her heels as well. When they reached the command tent, Adora was only feet behind as they came crashing through the door, almost running over Glimmer who'd just teleported.

"You know, we could just have…," Glimmer started to say.

"Nope, no, never, not happening," Catra said as she made her way to the table. In a moment, she'd taken in the little symbols and saw that one of the squads had grounded, the color and pattern of the little box beside them showing they'd made an unknown contact. She reached into the hologram and touched the little tag hanging over it and a window appeared before her face. She read for a moment before huffing a little. "They reported a contact for this!?"

"It's a contact," the Bright Moon guard on duty said. "Any sign of habitation, as per our orders."

Catra opened the images attached to the report and saw what had brought them in. A windmill, cleverly camouflaged in the

scrub a little back from the rim of the canyon, had caught one of the squad members attention when they'd seen the movement. When they landed they discovered that what looked like a natural water feature next to it was actually a constructed cistern.

"That's not that far away," Adora said as she looked at the scale and then the map.

"Well, we did see the features that said habitation close by," Catra replied.

"What's the point of it though?" Adora said. Catra looked at her and Adora could see her visible restrain herself from making a comment. "OK, yes, water in the desert but there's nothing there and the notes say the only tracks are animal tracks."

Catra responded by holding up her own foot as she said, "We sure about that? Are they trackers?"

"It does say only small animal tracks," Adora said as she flicked through the contact report.

"Adora makes a point though," Glimmer said. "It's kind of exposed. Maybe it's for emergencies? Some kind of herd animal that we haven't seent yet?"

"Maybe we ask them to do further reconnaissance," Juliet said as she stepped into the tent.

"Already doing so, General," one of the other guards named Rose said. "They've advised they're laying a few sensors as well so we'll be able to monitor the area."

Catra noticed Adora go from interested to stiff as Juliet walked in and sighed. Then everyone turned as the second team reported another contact.

"Another cistern?" Glimmer replied.

"No, movement," Rose said.

Everyone went quiet as a video feed came up the time stamp showed a few minutes earlier and for a split second, they clearly saw a Magicat form flicking through some scrub into some rocks and disappearing.

"Bring them in," Catra said as Tinz and Speleo entered the tent. Eyes turned to Catra who straigtened up. "Bring them in now."

"What? Why? We're getting results," Adora said, her awkwardness with Juliet forgotten for the moment.

Catra knew it was the right call.

"Did you see them? They're hiding from us. If we keep circling, it looks like bad intent. Bring them in."

"We're not circling," the guard said. "Rules of engagement say we keep going like our cover says, that we're a survey crew. That's why the first team grounded. Water would be a noteworthy feature. A lone person would not."

Catra frowned as she said, "I don't like it. We don't need to scare them."

"There's going to be some awkward at first," Glimmer said. "You agreed to this."

"I know," Catra snapped before taking a breath and taking it down a little. "I know. It's just…," she said before trailing off. She was thinking of the figure dashing into shelter and memories of doing the same in the Horde smashed up against her mind.

"We're going to have to go up that canyon eventually," Rose said carefully. Catra turned towards her, her mouth opening, before she shut it and pinched her nose with her eyes screwed shut.

"I know," Catra said. "I know we will and I know this huge group probably doesn't look good and damn it, I know I agreed to the plan but now it just looks stupid! What were we thinking!?"

"Micah's Law," Rose said with a nod.

"Wait, what?" Glimmer said and Rose suddenly was sitting very still and blushing.

Juliet said, "Your father, during the First Princess Council years, coined a phrase. The guard loved it and incorporated it into our doctrine and named it for him. I don't think most of them even make the connection."

"Well, someone want to tell me what it is?" Glimmer said.

"Gotta say, I'm curious myself," Catra said, a little grin at the weirdness on her face.

Juliet looked at Rose who stood up from where she was seated and said, "No plan survives."

"No plan survives?" Adora said. "Survives what?"

"That's all. Just that no plan survives," Rose replied.

"It's a reminder plans must be flexible," Juliet said.

"I know Dad. I have a feeling it's a joke that got taken too seriously," Glimmer said with a laugh. "It's not wrong though. Do we want to maybe pull back the scouts then?"

"No, leave them up for a bit more," Adora said. "Let's see if we can keep the cover story kind of intact. Have them keep making their sweeps, then come back in about two hours."

Adora was looking at Catra with a questioning look on her face as Catra just sighed and nodded assent.

"I'll let them know the change," Rose said as she sat back down and began to work.

"Interesting," Speleo said with a smile. "I've heard stories of the princesses and their adeptness at improvisation. It's nice to see it

in action."

"That's not improv," Adora said. "This is way more planned than anything we did during the war."

"Hey, we planned!" Glimmer said.

Adora smiled as she said, "Micah's Law."

"OK, no," Glimmer said. "Some of our plans went well."

"Sure, we'll go with that," Catra said.

"What should we do now?" Juliet said. "Catra, you have the misgivings, what do you think?"

Catra frowned as she thought. Tinz stepped up and started fiddling with the hologram controls, zooming in and out.

"Do you mind if I speak?" Tinz said and Catra made a go head gesture at her. "We know the side canyon has something resembling a path in. We were going to go up it eventually, what's the thought of a few people going up it?"

"Some people adapt at remaining unseen, I assume?" Speleo said.

"Yes, that is correct," Tinz said as Catra looked down at Melog, who'd got comfortable under a table and was staring back at her.

"I think we can do that pretty easily actually," Catra said. "At least just a few of us."

"I think you're right," Adora replied.

"I'm not sure I want just a few people going up a canyon we're not familiar with especially without some kind of clue how the locals will react if you're found," Speleo said, her eyes falling on Tinz as her tail lashed a little back and forth. Tinz didn't notice as she leaned into the hologram to look at a detail of the map.

"I think we'll do fine," Catra said with a grin as Melog came walking over as she knelt beside them right as they both disappeared.

Speleo swore in Magicat as her ears went straight up and her eyes went wide. Tinz snapped around as Adora laughed and Glimmer grinned but rolled her eyes. Catra and Melog appeared again as Catra said, "As I said, I think we can do this with no problem."

Speleo had taken a step back as she said, "I wasn't aware you knew magic."

"She doesn't," Glimmer said.

"Hey, she's pretty magic," Adora said with a smile.

Glimmer rolled her eyes again as Catra said, "Melog knows how to do it." Melog chirped at her and Catra shook her head. "OK, but you can do it so you know how." Melog chirped again and Catra grinned. "Now you're just being pedantic."

"Is it just you?" Tinz said, looking at Melog, who looked right back with a pleased expression.

"No, it can cover a good sized group," Catra said. "Noise can still be heard."

"That I'm not worried about," Tinz said. "I think maybe you, I, and Melog should go for a trip up that canyon then."

"Now hang on, she's not going alone," Adora said.

"Indeed," Speleo said, her tail flicking back and forth again. "I insist on more going along."

Tinz looked at Speleo, then her tail for a moment, and then back to Speleo's face as she said, "I understand I'm supposed to stay beside you as your guard but I think we can trust these to defend you."

"It's not that," Speleo said and then looked away with a frown as she went on. "I just, I um, don't want you to get in trouble when we get back to Half Moon."

Everyone in the tent was paying attention to the two now and Tinz frowned as she said, "I won't. I'll follow proper protocol."

The two looked at the audience and straightened up a little. Glimmer took the opportunity to say, "Juliet, will it be alright if one of the guard corp stands in for Tinz while she's gone?" Speleo started to speak and Glimmer went on. "It's the right and the duty of a reigning monarch, me in this case, to be sure that diplomats are protected."

"Look at you, all queenly," Catra said and Glimmer did her best to ignore her while Juliet answered Glimmer.

"It should be no problem to provide a detail for Ambassador Speleo," Juliet replied.

"I want to talk with them first," Tinz said, her ears twitching and Juliet nodded her assent.

"OK, so that's solved," Catra said. "When do we want to do this?"

"I think nighttime would be a good time," Tinz said. "Does Melog have issues with low light?"

"They're right there, ask them," Catra said, pointing.

"Sorry," Tinz said, turning to Melog. "Do you have issues with low light?"

Melog said something and Catra snorted.

"They said no," Catra said, fighting back a smile.

"I think they said more than just no," Tinz said, "but since it was my faux paus, I'll let it pass."

"Best for everyone," Catra said with a serious face betrayed by her flicking tail.

"I want to come along," Adora said.

"Me too," Glimmer replied.

"Absolutely not," Catra and Juliet both said at the same time.

"Alright, we can't all go along," Catra said and was about to speak more when Glimmer spoke up.

"You could use both Adora and I and you know it."

"Your Majesty, please, don't put me in this position," Juliet said.

"It's not putting you anywhere," Glimmer said. "I'll be fine. I'll went into battle after I became queen and you weren't this protective then."

"That was because of necessity," Juliet said. "This isn't the same."

Glimmer started to argue with Juliet while Catra started to try and talk Adora out of going and Speleo and Tinz began to speak in Magicat in tones that were definitely a tense disagreement. The other people in the tent were looking back and forth at each other when Lonnie walked in with Bow and Gila and a few other lizardfolk. After a moment of no one paying attention, Lonnie let loose with a shrill whistle that silenced the tent, causing all eyes to turn towards them.

"There you go," Lonnie said with a grin at Bow.

"Well, it worked I guess," Bow said as he took a step forward. "Everyone, I think you remember Gila, he greeted us when we landed. I took the opportunity to go down today and invite him and a few of his people down here for breakfast and we got to talking. They say they can tell us who's in the canyons around here."

Chapter End Notes

Thank you all for reading, I hope you're enjoying this!

Chapter 39: Chapter Thirty-Nine - Catra

Chapter Summary

Catra's past comes back to haunt her and possibly complicate her search for where she comes from.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

After the questions had been quelled by Bow's announcement, the group had moved back to the mess tent and settled down around some tables. Gila had introduced who was with him and then began to talk.

"The village up Orange Canyon is named Crailfish," he said as he pointed at a printout of one of the overhead photos. "We're here, and the village is about here. We do a lot of trading with them."

One of Gila's group, a person named Ferri, spoke up in the local language. Gila responded back before going on.

"Ferri isn't fully convinced we should be talking but Bow has assured us you're trying to help a friend."

Catra sat in awe once again of how Bow seemed to be able to walk up to people and just become friends with them and then to inspire them. The whole planet technically knew that, Bow's face looming large from the spires during the Fall of Prime was still a popular image, but even then it caught her off guard since she was around him almost constantly and to her, he was just a friendly, goofy guy. Which, if she was being honest, is probably why people took to him so well.

"Yeah, they're helping me," Catra said.

"You look like someone from Staed," Gila said. "Is that right?"

No one said a word for a moment before Catra cleared her throat a little and spoke up.

"I, uh, don't know. That's why we're here," Catra said. "Why do you think I'm from Staed?"

"The eyes," Gila said as he reached a finger up and tapped beside his own. "The fur is similar but the eyes are a huge giveaway."

"Everyone has it there?" Catra said and hated the longing she heard in her voice.

"No," Gila said. "But if you see it in a Magicat, it's a pretty good indication. You two, I don't know what village you're from."

Gila had turned towards Tinz and Speleo as he spoke.

"I'm an ambassador of Half Moon and she is my bodyguard," Speleo said.

Gila shrugged as he said, "Never heard of it. Is it further up the Red there?"

"Is that the river's name?" Speleo said.

"It's what we call it."

"Ah, thank you. No, it's further away, by the kingdom of Plumeria."

"Heard of Plumeria, don't know much about it," Gila said with a shrug.

"You're more than welcome to visit if you ever chose," Speleo said and Gila gave a little appreciative head nod before Catra spoke up.

"OK, thank you, great story, good to hear, but I'm going to be rude. *Where is Staed!?"* Catra had one hand on Melog and the other doing its best not to dig claws into the table where she sat.

Gila frowned a little as Catra went on. "Listen, it's important alright. I'm an asshole, I know, but I'm tired of waiting."

"We've know you, or of you," Gila said and Ferri and the couple of others with her nodded. "Some of our people went to your dig project during the war. They said you were not receptive to their offers and had no issue showing that."

Catra didn't understand what he was talking about before it came crashing hin that he was referring to when she'd been in the Waste with the Horde excavating Mara's ship. Her ears folded back as she began to wonder if her past was going to haunt her even all that way out here.

"I wasn't," Catra said. "It's… I don't have a good reason to tell you other than it was with the Horde and we did our own thing."

Gila shrugged as he said, "So we know you're an asshole." Catra couldn't help but notice he hesitated on the word and she saw one of the other lizardfolk translating to the rest and paused on what she assumed was the word before going on, making a gesture with her hand. The others chuckled as Gila went on. "Of course, that means, what are you going to do for us?"

"I thought you wanted to help?" Bow said.

"I said I knew what was up that canyon that you sent people up and that I'd tell you," Gila said with an offhand gesture. "I've done that. Now you want more, so, what will you do for us?"

Silence fell and Catra felt a mix of anger and shame climbing in her as Melog almost felt like they were bubbling under her hand. Adora slipped an arm around her and Catra reached up to touch Adora's hand as all she could think about was how close she was, how they didn't need this guy, how she could do it on her own, and fuck this guy for judging her off something that wasn't even really her fault to begin with, she'd just been following Horde protocol after all, and she spoke up finally.

"What can I do to fix this?"

"What?" Gila said.

"What can I do to fix this? I want to find Staed, I need help, and you obviously have an issue with me. Fine, that's nothing new but the new thing is what can I do to fix this?"

"Do you seriously think you can just say some words that'll fix this? Your soldiers attacked my people in some cases."

"It's not words. I want to know if there's something I can *do* to fix this," Catra said.

Gila looked at her for a moment before turning and talking to the others, confident that no one would understand them. Lonnie leaned forward as they did and after a moment leaned back with a frown.

"What?" Catra said quietly, as she leaned over to her.

"Nothing," Lonnie said, shaking her head. "It's just it sounds like Rogelio but…"

"Yeah, it's not the same language," Catra said. "We should have brought him and Kyle along though."

"I offered, they declined. They're both having a spa week in Plumeria right now."

"Rude," Catra said with a snort and a grin.

"Tell me about it," Lonnie said and then sat up as Gila turned around.

"Trade," Gila said.

"What?" Catra said.

"We want to trade," Gila said. "You'll make it happen."

"Uh… want do you want me to trade?"

Gila looked confused and asked someone next to him a question before turning back to Catra.

"You trade what you have," Gila said. "What do you have?"

The only thing Catra had, in her mind, was Adora. It was the only thing she valued but she knew that wasn't what Gila wanted.

"OK, I don't have anything so I'm kind of…," Catra said as she shrugged.

"You don't have anything?" Gila said with a snort and then swept his arm around to indicate the camp around him. "You have everything! And you're trying to hold back after you just said you wanted to atone? Are you that arrogant!?"

"Whoa, whoa, whoa!" Catra said, holding her hands out in front of her. "You mean you want to actually trade!? Like for our stuff!?"

"Yes!" Gila said, his tongue flickering out for a moment in irritation. "We're traders! You refused our trade before and now we want in! What part of that did you not understand!? And not some piddly cast off stuff, we want things like that."

Gila pointed at one of the skiffs and Catra sat back with a relieved laugh as she said, "OK, I did not read this right and yes, we can trade. I will refer you to my good friend Bow for the details."

Gila nodded at him as he said, "The King of Bright Moon has been very kind to us so I'll accept him as your representative."

"I'm not the king," Bow said as Catra reached over to pat him on the back as Glimmer snickered a little.

Gila looked a little confused and looked at Glimmer who said, "He's correct. His official title is Consort."

Bow started to object and Catra stealthily kicked him and gave a quick shake of her head.

"Either way, we accept him," Gila said. "We'll negotiate with part of the negotiation showing you the way to Staed."

"Deal," Catra replied as she extended her hand to Gila who took it and shook once, hard.

"Deal," Gila said. "Let's begin."

Hours later, as the day began to fade towards night, Gila was frowning as Bow clarified a point.

"The skiffs aren't a problem but as I've said already, I won't trade weapons. Not a chance. I'll offer better terms on anything else if that's what you want."

"Why are you squeamish about that? You're all armed," Gila said.

Bow just shook his head and crossed his arms as he said, "No. I won't do it. If that's the breaking point, so be it."

Most of the rest had long since left to do other things, leaving just Catra, Bow, and Speleo. Tinz was seated off the side, watching the crowd but out of the conversation. Lunch had happened while they talked, people staying away from the group, and dinner was already in progress but Bow was single minded, not looking away. Catra knew he had steel in him and it was interesting to see it on display over his usual friendly demeanor.

"Then how about shipments of RQ-321-E capacitors? We will accept those instead," Gila said after a quick consultation with one of the other members of his group.

"You mean one of the core components of the Horde handheld laser canon array? That capacitor?" Bow said with an innocent look.

Catra almost laughed when one of Gila's advisors threw her hands up and snapped out a word that Catra was pretty sure wasn't polite.

Gila for his part gave a humorless little smile as his unblinking eyes looked at Bow.

"Yes, that capacitor. It has other uses you know."

"Well, I just ask because you also asked for some yttrium aluminum garnet doped crystals which, among it's many uses, is the lasing medium for the same weapon. Surely you're not trying to get around my refusal to traffic in weapons by setting up your own factory are you?"

Gila closed his eyes, shook his head, and finally just laughed as he said, "Well, I'm not anymore."

"Glad to hear it," Bow said with a smile.

"You know, if you ever tire of Bright Moon we could use a savvy person such as yourself," Gila said.

Bow reached up to gently touch the pearl earring in his ear as he said, "I'm not likely to tire of the kingdom soon."

"Very well," Gila said. "I believe we can discuss more on this at a later time. I think we'll be long term partners. For now, can we agree to this list? As a sign of good will."

One of Gila's advisors handed over a hand written list that Bow took a moment to read. It was innocuous things, mostly small luxury items and some skiffs, and Bow nodded.

"Bright Moon agrees to this list," Bow said. "Do we have the beginning of a deal?"

Gila nodded as he said, "Ferri will draw up the language. I'm sure your people will go over it but I consider you honest. Shake my hand and I'll tell you about Staed."

Bow did so as Catra leaned in, ready to learn.

Chapter 40: Chapter Forty - Shadow Weaver

Chapter Summary

> Shadow Weaver makes sure there's no traces left that she can't control.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shadow Weaver stood and stared at the bulk of the Black Garnet as an ornate brazier stood about waist high in front of her, heat flowing out from the burning charcoal within. On a table nearby was a box with files carefully spread out in front of it while in her hand was a single file folder. She'd stopped being angry about the loss of Saz pretty soon after the incident and had gone into fixing the problem that loss had created for her. Now it was down to just figuring out the final touches.

Adora would be great someday. She knew talent and magic and Adora was overflowing with both, even as a toddler. She'd taken a shine to Saz's daughter though and that child was a distraction to Adora. But Shadow Weaver tried not to lie to herself. That child had talent as well. Maybe not magic, Shadow Weaver didn't seem to see any kind of special ability there, but the child showed promise. She was quick and clever and just needed some kind of restraint. With that, Shadow Weaver could use her. Both of those children would shine one day, she was sure of it, and it'd be her joy to see them do so as they helped her but first, she had to be sure she could make sure they obeyed. Adora was a willful child but it was obvious that she could keep Adora in line by using Catra's friendship against her.

Shadow Weaver opened the file in her hand. It held all of Aleph Squads personnel files and all of the records on their missions and she'd managed to destroy all other copies of the records. These

were the last. She pulled the records out, setting the personnel files in the folder aside, and flipped through them for a moment. She pulled out the first mission record and the last and set them with the personnel records before tossing the remaining mission files into the brazier. For a moment, nothing happened, then they starting smoking before bursting into flames. She moved her finger slowly, using magic to stir the paper a little to be sure that all was reduced to ash.

She opened another file and looked at all the pictures in their that she'd taken from Aleph Squads bunk area and personal effects. Catra was in a lot of them, playing with the four members of the squad. Shadow Weaver took out one of Catra laying across Saz's legs as Saz looked up into the camera and stuck it with the saved. The rest she committed to the brazier.

Finally, she picked up the files she was keeping and put them back in their box. There weren't many left now but she intended to keep culling them until it was down to only what she thought she might need to keep Catra under her thumb and useful. She had run over many scenarios of how that might be. It just mattered how it was presented after all. She thought of several scenarios as she began to draw a magic circle around the Black Garnet.

"Dear child, see what the Horde let happen to your mother? I managed to hide these documents so you could know when you were older."

Shadow Weaver liked that one. It kept Catra loyal to her and questioning the Horde.

"The Horde doesn't accept failure. See? This is your mother's failure and that's why no one speaks of her."

That one was alright she thought. It could keep Catra in line with the Horde but still let her see that Shadow Weaver was willing to keep her informed.

"Your mother? She left you. Never cared about you. Here's the record of her last mission. See how her body was never recovered? Her and her lover obviously faked their deaths to not have to deal with you. I didn't want to show this to you but it's time you knew."

That one she didn't like as much. It was cruel and hurtful and it was the one that held the highest chance, in Shadow Weavers opinion, of breaking the child and that wasn't helpful. A broken person wasn't of much use. Though use it she would if she had to and hope Catra was tougher than she looked. If she wasn't, well, even broken tools could usually be put back together. They were rarely as useful but any tool can find its place.

Shadow Weaver finished up the magic circle and she became to pour power into it. Her thoughts became focused on the task at hand and the last thought she spared for Catra for the moment was that maybe today was the day she gained control of the runestone and all her other plans wouldn't be needed after all.

Chapter End Notes

> Have I said before how much I love writing Shadow Weaver? Because I do. There's something about writing a villain that actually has some dimension to them and Shadow Weaver is full of that. Villains don't see themselves as villains. I say this constantly and it's something I believe is an incredibly important life lesson. A good villain believes what they're doing is right and proper and they've justified it to themselves so even when they might go a bit too far, they know it was something that had to be done. Or so they think. And that's something we're all capable of doing and so the best villains are incredibly human in the sense that even if they lose their humanity in the story, you can just maybe understand why.
>
> Anyway, this is a short one but I really wanted to get this up so I hope you enjoy and thank you for reading!

Chapter 41: Chapter Forty-One - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora have a little chat along the river while someone may be watching from the shadows.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra sat in the sand staring at the water of the river run past in the late evening light. Melog sat beside her, staring as well, as Adora walked up to them.

"You alright?"

Catra shrugged but didn't say anything else as Adora flopped down beside her. She held out a vacuum jar along with a bowl to Catra.

"Got you some soup, you missed dinner."

"I'm not hungry."

Adora sat it in the sand beside her as she ran her hand through the sand for a second.

"You… you're kind of worrying me."

Catra turned to look at her, Melog mimicking her as she did.

"What's that supposed to mean?"

"I mean, you heard all that stuff about Staed and then you've been out here ever since. You haven't talked to anyone, you're just staring at the rive, and it's kinda freaking me out."

Catra didn't respond for a moment as she turned back to the river. She hooked an arm around Melog without thinking as she said, "They attack everyone. I mean, I get the whole idea of a blood feud but it sounds like… I mean it sounds like they go out of their way to provoke it. Maybe Gila is full of shit but come on, that Chuut guy came all the way to Bright Moon to look me up. They 're…"

Catra shook her head as Adora said, "They're just like the Horde?"

"Yeah."

Adora nodded and they both sat and stared at the water for a while.

"You're still going to go and look aren't you?"

Catra snorted as she said, "Yes, and that's what's got me out here. Why would I want to know any of those people?"

"They're your family?"

"You're my family. They're… I don't know what they are but they're not family. They haven't earned that."

Adora scooted over a little and pulled Catra in close. The two stared at the shifting light on the river before Adora finally spoke up.

"You don't have to go."

"I want to know what happened to her."

"They might not know."

"I know."

"You know you might never know."

Catra was quiet for a moment before she sighed and nodded.

"I know."

"Still going?"

"Yeah, still going."

"I'll never understand."

Catra snorted as she said, "That's because you were born from like a mushroom in a field or something."

Adora laughed as she shoved her.

"Hey, you know damn well that's not what happened!"

"Maybe Hordak lied. Maybe he just found you as a mushroom baby and took you in."

Catra was smiling now as Adora shoved her again.

"So I'm not a First One?"

"Maybe they were mushrooms. You don't know. Ask Bow's dads, maybe they translated something new."

"Where's my gills and cap?" Adora said, making a motion around her head like she was searching for a mushroom cap.

"I don't know, maybe they fell off," Catra said but she was just kind of half smiling now as she leaned forward to rest against her knees.

Adora caught her mood and gave her a little hug.

"When do you want to go up there?"

"Gila said he was going to send a messenger. I guess we'll see what they have to say."

"At least we got away from the plan. You really changed on that one."

"Well, you know, Micah's Law," Catra said.

Adora just shrugged before sitting up as little and looking down river a little.

"Did you see that?"

"See what?" Catra said, looking the same way.

"I swear I saw someone down that way."

At first Catra thought maybe it was one of Gila's people but it was the wrong direction. The river formed a bit of a backwater in the direction they were looking before meandering away around a corner. Between them and that backwater was some low scrub of salt cedar and breakwood.

"What's down there? Rock fall?" Catra said, talking about one that formed a side of the backwater.

"Yeah, and that little slot canyon too but it doesn't go anywhere," Adora said.

Catra got to her feet as she felt a chill down her back.

"Somethings wrong," Catra said.

"Come on," Adora said. "It could have been nothing. There's plenty of moving shadows down here. Even if it was, probably just… I don't know… a lizard."

Catra was shaking her head as she began to slowly walk down the beach. They were just outside of the perimeter of the camp and she was looking for one of the squads of guards that walked the perimeter.

"Then why did you mention it?" Catra asked. "Go find one of the guard squads, Melog and I are going to go take a look."

"No! You go find them!"

"Damn it, I don't have time to argue! Go and find a squad!" Catra said as she disappeared along with Melog and took off down the beach.

Adora restrained the urge to yell at Catra before she took off for the perimeter.

Catra for her part felt the rush of adrenaline of going into something risky. She felt a little bad at the rush but the feeling bad part lasted all of a second as she got focused and moved into the brush and rocks. She moved slowly, just like she'd been taught when tracking, listening as much as she looked because listening was far more effective in the darkness. The problem she realized was that she didn't know what was normal and what was out of place when it came to sounds. It was just the nighttime sounds she'd heard since arriving only a couple of days before, water, wind, rustle of vegetation, and the occasional scurry of some creature. She sniffed but didn't smell anything out of the ordinary either. She could vaguely see Melog and wondered if she should send them out looking but suddenly felt like she wanted someone by her side when she heard a rock shift slightly.

She froze in place, trying to sniff, trying to hear, even trying to see but she suddenly realized the wind was at her back so it was taking any scent away from her, it was rushing past her sensitive ears and creating extra noise even as she moved them to cut it, and sight was worse then useless in the shifting shadows. She was an excellent fighter but she was also badly out of her element and she knew it.

Melog was looking up at her, feeling the anxiety as it shifted to fear flowing back to them from Catra and made a little head gesture. Catra knew what they were suggesting, having them move around some, but she just shook her head and hooked a thumb back the way they'd come. Melog nodded and jumped up on a rock by Catra to go around her.

The rock shifted.

Melog fell tumbling to the ground, not ready for the shift, and thumped hard against a couple more rocks before coming to rest. Catra suddenly realized she was visible as Melog shuddered a few times before making a noise at Catra.

"Shit, shit, shit, shit…," Catra muttered over and over as she scooped her friend up and started back to the camp as quick as she could in scrub and rocks.

Melog said something to her and Catra whispered, "No, you're hurt, stop asking."

Melog chirped quietly and Catra said, "I'm carrying you, shrink a little if you want but I don't like the way you were twitching."

As she left, Catra didn't realize just how close a Magicat had been to her. She'd smelled Catra and had started circling the spot where Catra had stood, figuring out where the unfamiliar Magicat scent was coming from and slowly getting closer. Then suddenly, closer than expected, Catra had appeared. All the Magicat, a young woman a little younger than Catra named Thorn, knew at first was that Catra wasn't someone she knew and didn't dress like any of the other Magicats in that area of the Waste.

Then Thorn realized that it was probably the Magicat with the Bright Moon group that had flown in which meant, according to Chuut, it was Catra, the daughter of Saz. Thorn held back the grin that wanted to split her face as she followed Catra. She was young, without any victories to boast about, and had only come out to see if she could put eyes on this camp because people at home were buzzing about. However, now the opportunity had come up to not only have a victory but a major one. If she could kill the daughter of Saz, she'd be lauded as a hero at home in Staed. The fact Catra was carrying some injured pet meant it would just be easier for her. Thorn slid a long, thin knife from its sheath as she moved along behind and to the side of Catra, looking for a time to strike.

Catra kept looking over her shoulder, even turning all the way around to check with Melog grumbling the whole time, but she never caught sight of Thorn, who froze low every time Catra looked. Thorn felt her heart race as she realized that Catra's reputation of being tough, strong, and fast were obviously over-hyped and almost laughed as she saw her muttering to the weird pet in her arms. It didn't matter. It was the reputation that mattered and Thorn knew she'd be the one to be remembered because of it.

Catra stopped for a moment, almost out of the rocks, to take a quick look around and because Melog would not stop pestering her that they were fine. Thorn waited until Catra was looking away as they slid out from behind a large rock. She was silent, her form was flawless, the blade in her hand was dull grey and didn't reflect light and her fur blended with the darkness. Thorn was already celebrating in her head as she stabbed forward at Catra's back.

Adora's fist slammed into Thorn's face, knocking her backwards off her feet to bounce off the boulder she'd come from behind and then to the ground, hitting several small stones as she landed. She rocked back onto her shoulders and leapt to her feet and as she did, Adora's boot met her rising chest, knocking her right back down again into the stones. Melog squirmed out of Catra's arms, changing to a tiny kitten-like shape as they dropped. Thorn rolled, grunting as she went over multiple hard rocks as she did so, only to be stopped with a hard kick from Catra to Thorn's side.

Thorn wasn't celebrating anymore. She was sore and thought she was maybe even bleeding from the rocks as she got ready to disappear back into the shadows. She was trying to get her feet under her when a large weight dropped onto her and she heard a growl unlike anything she'd ever heard before right by her throat.

Glancing out the corner of her eye, she saw the creature that Catra had been carrying, grown to a huge size with very sharp fangs. Chuut and her other mentors had taught her many things. They had taught her to fight and what her place in the world as a

warrior was and how a Magicat didn't surrender, that a true warrior of Staed didn't even know the meaning of the word, but Thorn was learning all kinds of things at the moment with sharp, slavering fangs very close to her throat.

"I yield," she said.

"What did she say?" Adora said.

"I don't know, I know like ten words of Magicat," Catra said, looking around. "Giving up seems to be the general vibe though." Catra leaned over so Thorn could see her. "You give up?"

Thorn had no idea what Catra was saying but she repeated, "I yield" again and really, really hoped that Catra would understand somehow and call off the monster that seemed to be her ally.

"Yeah, I think she's had enough for now," Catra said just based on roughly what she could see of Thorn's face.

"Well get her to her feet and let's go," Adora said.

"Melog, could you let her up?" Catra said.

Melog didn't move for a moment before reluctantly getting off of Thorn, who rolled over slowly as the aches and pains really crowded in on her. She felt like she'd been hit with a shovel in the face and gingerly probed at her nose before deciding it hadn't been broken again. She began to bring her knife up to give to Catra only to freeze as Melog snarled and Adora stepped forward with her fists up. What flooded her with shame though was seeing Catra's claws come out. Catra was ready to fight her with honor and she'd tried to stab her in the back.

Catra saw Thorn's ears flatten back and slowly lowered her hands as Thorn slowly turned the knife's handle towards Catra.

"Take it, I yield," Thorn said.

"I don't understand," Catra said but after a moment she slowly reached forward and took the knife. Thorn stood with her head down a little and Catra sighed. She wasn't sure what was going on but she could tell the woman was not going to be a threat, at least not immediately, and that's all that mattered for right then.

"Hey," Catra said and then repeated it a little louder. Thorn looked up and Catra pointed towards the camp. Thorn looked that way, her face scared for a split second before she managed to control it but Catra pointed again and tried to think of something she could say in Magicat. Then she remembered the one word that might help.

"Camp," Catra said while pointing again. Thorn looked a bit confused but finally nodded before she started walking.

"Melog, could you keep on her, please?" Adora said and Melog chirped back as they got right on Thorn's heels.

Chapter End Notes

No commentary other than I'm excited for people to see what's coming up. :)

Chapter 42: Chapter Forty-Two - Thorn

Chapter Summary

> The Best Friend Squad sit down to have a chat with the young Magicat that tried to stab Catra in the Crimson Waste.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Thorn sat in a chair listening to the people around her. She didn't know what they were saying and she was kicking herself for giving up so easily now but the shock of getting hit so hard and so fast, along with the creature that Catra had with her, had driven her decisions for a moment. She'd already started thinking of escape when they'd got to the border of the camp, and the waiting guards, but she'd delayed. She told herself it was because she was trying to get a look at the camp to tell the warriors back home when she did make her escape but the truth was she was curious. She'd heard about Catra all her life and she wanted to know more.

Though as she looked around the first word that came to mind was just how arrogant they were. They had good weapons, decent equipment, though not very well suited to the desert but she could see they were making do, and certainly Catra and the woman she was with seemed to be capable warriors but they were so blatant with their presence. They weren't even trying to blend in. They hadn't even bothered to restrain her.

Instead they'd sat her down in a chair in a tent with a whole bunch of tables and benches and chairs. One of their warriors who was carrying a large polearm, Thorn almost snickered at the thought of wielding that in a tight canyon, had even sat a bowl of food in front of her and a mug of something that seemed to be an orange colored liquid. There was no way she was accepting food

but overall, there were a lot of things she was trying to figure out as Catra, her creature, her companion, some short sparkling woman, and a man with a bow kept an eye on her and quietly talked.

"She sure is taking it all in, isn't she?" Glimmer said watching Thorn looking around as her ears twitched back and forth and her tail swished a little. "Does she speak Bright Moon?"

"I don't think so," Adora said. "We've tried to say a few things to her and she didn't seem to understand."

"Doesn't mean she doesn't," Bow said.

"Where would she even learn it?" Glimmer said.

"Gila speaks it just fine," Bow said.

"Good point," Glimmer said. "Probably shouldn't say anything important just yet."

"Like we have so much to hide," Catra said with a snort as Melog slowly walked several arm lengths back from Thorn as they looked her over as Thorn did the same while trying to pretend she wasn't.

"What if she gets away?" Glimmer said. "She's seen a lot here."

"Then we follow and see if she leads us to Staed," Catra said and watched as Thorn sat up a little more and then tried to act like she was just stretching.

Thorn figured she'd thrown them off her interest but she'd almost jumped when Catra had said Staed. She'd wondered if Catra had even known about her home but now it was obvious she had and Thorn knew she had to get away. Thorn knew about Catra, had heard the stories over the years, and it was obvious she was a warrior, just like her mother Saz had been, and it was obvious Catra had bided her time in the blood feud and had now brought an army to deal with it.

"Where in the world is Speleo and Tinz? It'd be nice if we could tell her," Adora said with a nod of her head at Thorn, "that we're not here to attack or anything."

Thorn saw the repressed irritation on the blonde one's face and the head nod and wondered if she was arguing for something awful to happen. Thorn had been hit before but the blonde had a strike like a hammer blow and so she had it down in her head that she was the most vicious of the group.

"Well, it's late, they're probably having to get out of bed," Bow said. "I'm sure they'll be here in just a few."

Catra turned to Thorn and remembered another of the few words that Tinz and Speleo had taught her earlier.

"Drink," Catra said, nodding at the cup.

Thorn had managed to control her breathing so when Catra spoke to her again in poorly pronounced Magicat, she didn't react but it was obvious she wanted her to drink and eat the food. Thorn didn't speak, just shook her head.

"She doesn't trust us," Catra said with a grunt.

"Well gee, from what you told us, Adora punched her in the face and you kicked the crap out of her before Melog threatened her with sharp teeth," Glimmer said with a grin. "Can't imagine why she's not your best friend."

"She tried to stab me," Catra said with an eye roll.

"With our track record, that means we're going to be best friends," Glimmer said and Bow managed to suppress a laugh.

"Too soon," Adora said with a sigh.

"OK, OK, but come on, it's not like we're set up to hold a prisoner, even if that's what we want to do," Glimmer said.

"And hopefully she really doesn't speak Bright Moon because you just announced we can't easily hold her," Catra said as she ran her hand down her face as her ears lay back a little.

Thorn saw the archer and sparkling one laugh a little and then the blonde seemed irritated again. Then Catra's ears leaned back a little and Thorn just became more confused because Catra didn't look happy and Thorn wondered if maybe she'd misinterpreted the food. She'd worried about poison but she also didn't want to accept hospitality. She was their enemy and she knew they knew this but were still acting weird about it. Again, she quickly looked around and thought maybe she should make a break for it. She knew the area better than any of them but then the creature looked at her, cocked their head to the side, before jumping up on the long table not too far from her to lie down, their eyes not straying. Thorn was wary of the creature but curious as well and that kept her from making a break. Then her curiosity went through the roof as more strange Magicats joined them.

"Who's this?" Speleo said as she stepped into the tent yawning, her fangs obvious as she stretched.

"We don't know," Glimmer said. "She attacked Catra, her and Adora subdued her and brought her back and she hasn't spoke the whole time. We think she only speaks Magicat."

"Didn't think that through?" Tinz said as she came to stand a little forward of Speleo. "Just figured everyone spoke Bright Moon, did you?"

Bow awkwardly shook his head as he said, "We figured we would find translators."

Tinz just shook her head as Speleo asked Glimmer, "What do you want me to ask?"

"Introductions first, let her know we don't want to hurt her," Catra said and Glimmer gestured at Catra to show Speleo she agreed. "Let's see if she responds."

Speleo nodded and then sat down on a bench in front of Thorn and began to speak in Magicat.

"I am Speleo, Ambassador of Half Moon. Queen Glimmer," Speleo said, gesturing at Glimmer, "is from Bright Moon and has asked that I speak with you. We do not wish to harm you as long as you do not try to harm us. The rest of the group here is Adora, She-Ra, Princess of Power, Royal Consort Bow of Bright Moon, Catra of Bright Moon and her friend Melog, and my associate, Tinz of Half Moon. Now, may I ask after your name and if you need any medical attention?"

Thorn was already surprised to see more Magicats and then became incredibly confused as Speleo began to speak. She wondered why in the world Speleo was using some ancient word for speaker to describe herself. Her whole dialect was like that to Thorn, the language weirdly peppered with old words and an odd accent. Thorn also wondered what kind of fool Speleo thought she was to think she'd believe that Speleo and Tinz were from some fairy tale place like Half Moon. She looked at Adora again as well, having heard of She-Ra, and figured Speleo was probably lying about that as well, trying to make them seem more impressive then they were. Adora definitely hit hard but Thorn had heard She-Ra was eight feet tall with glowing eyes and a massive sword and Adora definitely didn't fit that description. In fact, the fact she said the little sparkly one was the supposed Queen of Bright Moon, a woman rumored to be able to take on hordes of enemies at once, didn't seem right either which meant Bow was probably just some guy as well. She didn't know anything about the one they were calling Melog, which told Thorn they probably weren't some pet or beast like she thought though she still wasn't sure, so Thorn just crossed her arms.

Speleo said in Bright Moon, "She doesn't seem to trust you," as Juliet and Lonnie quietly joined them.

"Yes, we figured that out all on our own," Catra said.

Thorn saw an imposing looking woman join them, dressed in armor, and wondered what that meant. The other woman with her just crossed her muscled arms as she yawned and watched with what looked like idle curiosity. Thorn understood that because her own curiosity was warring with deep confusion. She had so many questions, like why Catra wouldn't just speak to her on her own. She'd already spoke to her in Magicat after all, even if only a couple of words, and then Thorn realized that's probably why Speleo had used the weird archaic word for speaker. Maybe Speaker was some position in Catra's command and that was what Speleo filled and spoke on her behalf.

Things started to click into place then as Thorn nodded a little. It explained why they said they were from Half Moon, why Speleo was using such an odd dialect, and why Catra wasn't speaking. Clearly, after the Horde in which she'd ruled had fallen, Catra had set herself up with these people, pulled together some surplus Horde equipment as well as technicians and fighters from the same, and now she was trying to claim the legacy of the lost kingdom of Half Moon. Thorn was sure now. Catra hadn't just come to settle a blood feud. She'd come to conquer.

It took everything to keep her tail still and her ears neutral, as the pieces snapped together in her head. Obviously Saz had raised Catra in the Horde, knowing that she'd kicked off a blood feud by her actions, and had done it because it gave Catra a chance to gain power and followers. The letter Thorn had heard of that had passed through many, many hands to reach them years ago of Saz's death had obviously been false, as the village council had determined, and now Thorn knew that it was a ruse.

Thorn also knew she had to get out as soon as possible to bring this information back. She'd slipped away to check out the camp they'd heard about and no one would be looking for her until at least the next morning. But she couldn't just run. She was sure she could outrun most of them but she was also pretty sure now that Melog could not only keep up with her even at a sprint but probably outrun her and all Catra had to do was keep up just

enough. She had to get them to let their guard down. She had to be clever. Thorn listened carefully as Speleo spoke to her again.

"We really don't mean you harm. If the food isn't to your liking, we can find you something else."

"I won't eat that."

Thorn saw everyone focus in on her and almost laughed at how serious they all suddenly seemed as Tinz translated for the crowd and Speleo spoke back to her.

"It's not dangerous. I'll eat some myself if you'd like."

Thorn shook her head as she said, "I'm fine. What do you want?"

"Well, you did attack one of us. We'd like to know why but first, can I know your name?"

Thorn almost lied but figured she could at least give her name. She tried to sound tough but faltered a little as Melog shifted a little to the side without breaking their watch.

"My name is Thorn."

"Thorn, thank you, it's a pleasure to meet you," Speleo responded. "Is there anyone we should contact so they know you're not harmed?"

Thorn nodded as she saw the trap. The concern might even be real but the very obvious ploy was to get her to reveal for sure she was from Staed. Thorn decided the truth was best here though.

"I'm not expected back until morning. If you really don't mean me harm, then you don't need to send a message."

Thorn liked that one. It was true while not revealing anything.

"OK, do you need any medical attention? I know our first meeting wasn't exactly friendly."

"I'm fine," Thorn said, doing her best to ignore the translation going on with Melog only a few feet from her, though not as big as she remembered at least.

"I'm glad to hear it," Speleo said with a nod. "I'd like to have a chat, ask some questions and I'm sure you have some of your own."

Thorn thought for a moment, trying to think of what she was going to say. She was young but she was clever, everyone said so, and she just had to get left alone for a few minutes and she'd be gone. Curiosity drove her next question though.

"What are you doing here?"

"Our main purpose is conducting a survey," Speleo said. Thorn was about to say something when she saw Catra roll her eyes at the translation and even if she hadn't known it was a likely lie, that would have tipped her off.

"Catra there doesn't seem to believe you," Thorn said.

Speleo stopped to speak to the group for a moment and Thorn wondered what they were saying but Catra nodded at something said and Speleo turned back to Thorn.

Speleo gave a bit of an embarrassed smile as she said, "Well, it's not just that. Catra is also here looking for possible family."

"Then why doesn't she tell me that herself?" Thorn said.

"She doesn't speak our language," Speleo replied.

Thorn almost snapped at her that there was no our between them but said instead, "You expect me to believe that? She's already spoke to me."

Thorn saw Catra cover her face with a hand as the translation went through and knew she'd scored a point.

"She doesn't," Speleo said gently. "Really. Tinz and I have started teaching her a little but she doesn't speak the language."

"How do you think we can talk if you keep lying to me?"

Speleo sighed as she said, "I'm not lying to you but I understand why you'd think so."

"Then speak the truth," Thorn said.

"Excellent. I think we should," Speleo said. "I'll start by asking why you attacked her tonight. You tried to stab her in the back I believe?"

Thorn opened her mouth for a moment before shutting it again. Finally she spoke as she said, "I was startled."

"Yes, I often get startled by people in front of me and then try to silently stab them," Speleo said and Thorn couldn't help but notice that Tinz actually gave a little snorting laugh as she translated. The rest gave little smiles as well except for Melog and Catra. They both were focused on her. Thorn found she couldn't stop looking at Catra and forcibly moved her eyes back to Speleo.

"Don't mock me."

Speleo held up both hands for a moment as she said, "I apologize. You do see why your statement seems a bit… silly though?"

Thorn said, "I was simply hunting in the rocks."

"At night? By yourself?"

"Yes."

Speleo didn't say anything for a moment before she turned to Tinz and said, "Could you get me something drink please?"

"Now?" Tinz replied.

"Well, I keep looking at Thorn's drink and I keep thinking I'm thirsty."

Thorn looked between the two, trying to figure out what ploy was going on but couldn't figure it out as Tinz shrugged and walked over to a table and drew a cup of something from an insulated container. Thorn watched, always trying to keep Melog in sight.

"Thank you," Speleo said as she took a sip. Thorn noticed that the drink was steaming a little in the cold night air and the scent had her tail flicking a little. "Would you like a cup? It's spiced tea. A bit strong to my palette but just the thing for these cold nights."

Thorn wavered for a moment because the scent really was making her nose twitch but she finally just shook her head as she said, "No, I'm fine."

"Let me know. Plenty for all," Speleo said as she took another sip. "So you said you were hunting?"

"Yes."

"What were you hunting?"

Thorn had already thought of this and just gave a little smile as she said, "Furballs."

"Those little fanged things that hide under the rocks?" Speleo said, referring to a creature that was nocturnal, hidden, and would latch on with vicious intensity if provoked or startled.

"The same," Thorn said.

"Wouldn't get me poking around after them but that's me," Speleo said with a shrug.

"They're tasty and the furs are useful," Thorn replied.

"You sell the fur?"

"Sometimes," Thorn said with a shrug. There wasn't really a market for the short pelts but she wasn't lying, she had sold them before and figured explaining wouldn't help.

"Industrious of you to be out here helping your people in Crailfish."

"I'm not from Crailfish," Thorn snapped.

"But isn't this part of their boundaries?" Speleo said, confusion across her face as she took another sip.

"No!" Thorn snapped again.

"I've heard differently," Speleo said as she calmly took another sip. Thorn seethed a little at the thought of Crailfish claiming the area that was supposed to be neutral and then Speleo sat her cup down and casually said, "I hope you at least got permission from them before coming over here."

"It's not part of their territory and even it was, Staed spits on their claim! We go were we want!" Thorn said, scooting to the edge of her seat as she felt her claws reflexively come out.

"Thank you," Speleo said. "I was hoping I could talk to someone from Staed."

Thorn didn't get it at first and then realized what she'd revealed. She'd tried to be clever and had been led by the nose. She felt herself sag a little as she looked at the rest of the group and they were all calm and collected, all except Catra who seemed upset.

Then Catra spoke. Everyone looked at her and Thorn was sure that was it. She wouldn't get out to warn the others but she wouldn't run like a coward.

"Tell her I'll meet her claw to claw and spit in her face no matter what," Thorn said, not feeling even a quarter of the bravery she was trying to show.

"You want me to tell her that?" Speleo said but Tinz was already translating and Catra was responding. It didn't matter. Thorn was terrified but ready.

Chapter End Notes

I really can't write a long fic without throwing some OCs in can I? :) Also, damn, this is a long chapter. I just kept going and going and going and I though, "Maybe I should break for a chapter" but Thorn needed some room to talk so she got it.

Thank you for reading!

Chapter 43: Chapter Forty-Three - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Thorn try to come to an understanding when Catra gets several surprises.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Are you fucking kidding me!?" Catra said as Tinz translated the invitation to a fight. "She's a child!"

"I don't know about child," Lonnie said. "She's definitely young though."

"I'm not fighting her!" Catra said as she got to her feet, gesturing at Thorn.

Thorn scrambled to her feet, breathing fast with her hands up, and Catra shook her head at her.

"No! Damn it! Tinz, tell her no! I'm not fighting!"

Tinz spoke to Thorn who looked confused and said something back.

"She doesn't get it," Tinz said and listened a moment while Thorn spoke. "She wants to know if she should fight your mother instead and then you."

Catra stood a bit shocked before saying, "What!?"

Speleo said, "Tinz translate exactly."

Tinz rolled her eyes as she said, "She said that the blood feud won't die until you and your mother are both dead or victorious

and she'll fight both of you."

"I think we're still having some communications barriers," Juliet said softly from the back. "Maybe rest and come back to this?"

"That's not a bad idea, it is late," Bow said.

"OK, hang on, hang on," Catra said, pinching her nose with her eyes squeezed shut. "Ask her this." Catra opened her eyes and looked right at Thorn. "Do you think Saz is still alive?"

Tinz asked, a bit uncomfortable at the name of her goddess, and then waited as Thorn nodded and gave a curt reply.

"She said yes," Tinz replied.

"She's dead," Catra said, looking at Thorn. "Or disappeared long enough as to not make a difference."

Thorn shook her head and gave a short little snorting laugh before responding. Tinz translated and said, "Whatever lies you give, I don't believe you."

"Why would I lie!?" Catra said.

"I mean, plenty of reason," Adora said. "Tactical or strategic advantage is a big one."

Glimmer snorted with laughter as Tinz translated as Catra said, "You're not helping!"

"Just like she said, you could be lying for any reason," Thorn said.

Catra snapped back to her and said, "I'm not though! Damn it! What would I… damn it, you can speak Bright Moon!?"

"What!? No, I can't! You're speaking Magicat!" Thorn shouted before pointing at Catra and shouting louder. "I knew you were lying!"

"No, stop fucking around! You're clearly speaking Bright Moon!"

"No, I am not! You're just trying to trick me! Just like you and your people always have!"

Catra felt her temper flaring and then she saw Melog sitting beside Thorn with a smug expression.

"Is this you!?"

"Obviously," Melog responded.

"How!? You know what, I don't care," Catra said as she sat down. Thorn looked at Melog and then at Catra and then back to Melog.

"Your pet is doing this!?"

"Have some manners, I'm not her pet, I'm her friend," Melog said. "And before we go on, you two are the only ones who can understand each other like this so someone should probably explain to the rest what is happening."

"Catra, she's not speaking in Bright Moon," Bow asked as everyone looked between Catra and Thorn.

"I know, Melog is getting us to understand each other, butt out," Catra snapped before taking a deep breath. "Sorry, just… let me talk with her."

"What did he say?" Thorn say and Catra realized that Tinz hadn't bothered to translate, nor had Melog.

"Couldn't just do everyone could you?" Catra said to Melog who just gave her a little smile. Catra turned back to Thorn as Bow asked Tinz to keep translating. "He's confused because we're talking without translation, or don't you believe me?"

Thorn's ruff bristled a little as she said, "Maybe I don't."

Catra was about to respond when she almost felt like laughing and then crying as she realized Thorn was acting very familiar. She was acting like Catra herself five years before.

"How old are you?"

"Old enough to kill you," Thorn replied and Catra heard Adora shifting forward as Tinz translated.

"That's… listen, I'm not here to fight you," Catra said as she put a hand on Adora's shoulder. "In fact, I won't fight you, especially not over some feud I have nothing to do with. Do you know anything about me?"

"I know enough," Thorn said, though she was beginning to wonder what she really did know. "I know you're a coward."

Catra just started laughing at what she knew was supposed to be a serious insult but she thought back to everything she'd gone through in her life and just couldn't take it seriously.

"Don't laugh at me! You're a coward who refuses to defend her honor!" Thorn replied.

Catra tried to calm down but just managed to laugh even harder as she said, "I'm not… I'm not laughing at you!"

She tried to say something else but a sputter of laughter cut her off as Thorn rose to her feet.

"Stop! Laughing!"

Catra nodded her head and managed to get the laughter under control a little.

"I swear, it's just… you called me a coward," Catra said and fought down the laughter that threatened to swamp her again. "It's just… did you think I was going to fight you because of that!?"

"If you had an ounce of honor, you would," Thorn said. "It's worth dying over."

"Yeah, no, not really," Catra said. Thorn just stared in shock at the casual dismissal and everyone waited to see what would be said.

After a moment, Catra continued. "It's not. Dying is just dying, there's no great statement to it."

Thorn sat back down as she shook her head, "But… you were…"

Thorn could see in her mind Catra's claws out, ready to fight, the sign of honor and respect to another, and just shook her head again.

"Hey, how about we just talk. Let's get rid of the rest and you and I can talk. OK?"

"Not a chance," Adora replied scooting a little closer.

"Not right now," Catra said, her temper flaring a little. "Everyone, out. Go on. I'll be fine."

Thorn looked at Catra before shaking her head again but not speaking. Bow spoke to Catra for a moment and she nodded and Glimmer whispered something before patting Catra's shoulder. Slowly, everyone filtered out until it was just Melog, Thorn, and Catra.

And Adora.

"Everyone," Catra said looking at her.

"No."

"Come on, don't argue with me."

"I said no. Deal with it."

Catra actually had to grin a little at the response.

"OK, but just sit there, don't say anything."

Adora nodded and finally Thorn spoke.

"Is she your guard?"

Catra shook her head as she said, "She's my girlfriend."

"And… them?" Thorn said, looking at Melog who'd stretched out on the table beside her and was nudging at the bowl of food Thorn had ignored.

"Melog. We've been introduced already. You should try and remember this time," Melog replied. "Are you going to eat this or not?"

Thorn opened her mouth, tried to think of a response, and then just shook her head.

"Then I'm going to," Melog said and started daintily eating.

"You know, you're the first beside me who can here them," Catra said.

"Wait!? She can understand Melog!?" Adora replied and then looked at Melog. "Buddy! Don't I always give you snacks and let you hog the bed!?"

"You let me 'hog the bed' because you use me as a pillow," Melog said.

Catra snorted as she said, "They said you let them hog the bed because you use them as a pillow."

"We had an understanding," Adora said with a fake sad face as Catra turned back to Thorn.

"OK, Thorn, listen, what is going on? I'm getting told I'm part of some blood feud with people I hadn't even heard of until really recent. You trying to stab me has made it pretty clear that you're on the other side of it so, since you're sitting here being, well, not stabby, I'm just going to say, I don't want to be involved."

"You can't just not be involved! And why would I believe you anyway, when you came with an army?"

Catra snorted as she said, "This isn't an army. This is the Bright Moon Guard on holiday along with some people who wanted to take a vacation and get paid for it. If I was going to raise an army, you'd damn well know it." Catra suddenly stopped and her ears shot back in shame as she realized what she'd just said and Adora gently put a hand on her shoulder. Catra patted it for a moment before saying, "OK, that wasn't well said. I came here because I'm trying to find out what happened to my mother."

Thorn rolled her eyes as she said, "Are you going to say she's dead too?"

"I have no idea because I never knew here. I don't know if she's… wait, what do you mean too? Has someone else come and told you she's dead?"

Catra leaned forward and Melog stopped eating as well to fix Thorn with a hard stare.

Thorn scooted a little over from Melog as she said, "Is she… is she really…?"

"I don't know. That's why I'm here. Someone named Chuut came to Bright Moon to try and kill me, some other person named Tegris told me that Chuut was from this village and maybe that's where Saz was from, so I came out here to try and figure it out. Is this where I'm from?"

Thorn's ears were standing straight up in surprise and any attempt to hide her emotions had fled at the mention of Chuut. Her tail flicked back and forth as she finally said, "Is Chuut… is he…?"

"He's fine last time I saw him," Catra snorted. "After he tried to kill me and ran off that is. Last I heard he had disappeared from Bright Moon."

Thorn's ears went down as she shook her head and said, "He wouldn't run."

"He did when I didn't back down and decided to stop screwing around and actually fight," Catra said as she held a hand out and let her claws extend for a moment.

"You were going to… you were going to use your claws?" Thorn said, her ears folding back.

"Well, yeah," Catra said.

"You were going to do the same for me…," Thorn said, trailing off again.

"If you'd kept fighting, yeah," Catra said. "Why wouldn't I?"

Thorn shook her head as she said, "I wouldn't."

"That's a you problem," Catra replied.

"But… you really… that's what you think?"

"Of course," Catra said shaking her head. "Do you really think I wouldn't? Come on!"

Thorn started to cry.

"Hey," Catra said as she started to stand up.

Thorn looked away, her face angry as the tears soaked it. Catra just kind of stood there, half out of her seat, when Adora pulled a napkin from a little jar on the table and held it out silently. Thorn didn't respond at first but then snatched it fast enough to make Adora jump.

Catra looked at Adora who just shrugged in silence. Melog shrunk back a little and looked at Catra who mimicked Adora with the shrug. After just a few seconds, Thorn looked back, her eyes bloodshot but her face set.

"Why do you consider this an honor matter?"

"What?" Catra said.

"You fight with claws even though it's a blood feud," Thorn said. "Saz taught you this?"

"OK, again, I did not know her. I didn't know about this feud until like, last week," Catra said. "Why would claws be any different than anything else?"

Thorn's ears went back in surprise and Adora almost laughed. She had only understood half the conversation and was working hard on context but she knew something had happened.

"You don't… you didn't…," Thorn said. "You don't know!?"

"No! That's what I'm trying to say! I don't know!"

"Claws are only used in serious matters of honor!" Thorn said.

"And a blood feud isn't that!?" Catra shot back.

"So you do admit…!" Thorn started to shout when Catra cut her off.

"No! I don't! But you said it's a blood feud and it's not over honor!?"

"Well of course it is but the other side doesn't have honor so why should you treat them that way!? Don't you know *anything!?"*

"Obviously not!"

Thorn frowned as her tail flicked and she finally said, "So earlier… you didn't… you just always use your claws?"

Catra threw a quick guilty glance at Adora before saying, "Yeah. It's… I mean, it's just a thing that's there you know?"

"You don't… it has nothing to do with honor?"

"Listen, I knew honor was bullshit before I was ten," Catra said.

Adora looked at her but Catra wasn't going to look at her. She still remembered Adora talking about the honor of the Horde when they were older cadets and she was already having one weird and difficult conversation without starting another right then.

"It's not," Thorn said.

"No, it is, at least this kind. Loving my friends, my girlfriend, doing what I can for them, telling them the truth because that's what they deserve and they'd do the same for you?" Catra said as she smacked her palm against her seat. "That's honorable."

"You'd die for them?" Thorn said. "Because I'd die for my people."

"Of course you say that because it's fucking easy," Catra said leaning forward. "I wanted to die most of my life and I didn't for one reason and I lost that reason and you know what? People suffered. I made people suffer and now I have to live with it every fucking day and that's hard but damn it, it's worth it to try and make amends. You think you're hard?"

"Hard as a rock," Thorn said, sitting up straight.

"Rocks shatter when they're hit. I'd rather be soft," Catra said, her voice dropping a little. "I'd rather survive and bend and learn."

"I'd rather have my honor," Thorn said.

"Because you're a kid and you don't understand," Catra said.

"I'm not a child! I know what I feel!" Thorn snapped.

There was a moment of silence before Catra let out a sigh.

"OK, yeah, you do know what you feel. This isn't going anywhere though. Just answer me this and you can do whatever you want. I know Saz is from here because you said so but what did you mean someone said she was dead?"

Thorn didn't say anything for a long moment and Catra began to wonder if Melog had stopped doing whatever was translating before she finally spoke up.

"I heard someone sent a letter years ago," Thorn said. "It said she was dead. No one believed it."

"Who from?" Catra said.

"You said I just had to answer that," Thorn shot back.

Catra slapped her hand to her face and dragged it down before she said, "OK, yes, I did. Forget it."

Catra started to stand up and Thorn suddenly said, "I don't know anyway."

"Thanks," Catra said as she finished standing. "You want a place to stay the night or you want me to walk you to the boundary?"

Thorn stood up as she said, "You were serious? I can do whatever I want?"

"Yeah, I keep my word," Catra said.

"Good."

Then Thorn threw a hard punch at Catra.

Chapter End Notes

> So on my Tumblr I did a poll asking if Melog could act as a universal translator between people. The choices were yes, no, and depends (like if it's funny). I think it's obvious which way I lean. :) Also, this may be the first time I have EVER written Melog actually speaking.

Chapter 44: Chapter Forty-Four - Saz

Chapter Summary

> Saz wakes up, surprised to still be alive, only to find out, her ordeal isn't over yet. It's time for soul searching and honesty. It's time to make decisions.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Saz woke up to warmth folding around her. It took her a moment to focus as every bit of her body hurt but after a moment she heard the wind and saw in the thin light of a lantern Snick crouched over a small field stove as only a satyr could manage. She felt Basco's arms around her and realized she was in two sleeping bags zipped together. Snick looked up at her and their eyes looked like they were looking straight through her.

"You're awake," they said. Saz tried to talk and found that she couldn't as her throat felt awful. "Yeah, no need for response, I was just saying. Go back to sleep."

Something nagged at Saz's mind and she couldn't quite place it at first but as she drifted off again, it came to her.

No one else had been in the shelter.

She fought awake again and tried to speak a few times with Snick just watching her. Finally, she managed to croak something out.

"Where's everyone else?"

Snick didn't say anything at first, just poured out some steaming beverage from the kettle off the stove before taking a drink, the steam fragrant and citrus sharp in the close confines of the

shelter, and shutting the stove off. After a moment they said, "It's just us now."

Saz tried to think of what to say before just saying, "How?"

"1st Squad fucked up," Snick said, taking another drink, their voice flat. "The two here went out to get their two sentries, didn't overcome the voices I assume, never came back in."

"Kit?" Saz said, already guessing and feeling the tears in her eyes.

"She was in charge," Snick said with a sigh. "Went out after them, never came back."

What Saz didn't know was the image in Snick's mind of Kit stepping out into the screaming blizzard, ice already forming on the gills under her mushroom cap, and ordering them not to leave. Snick had told her to stay, it was too late, but Kit just said, "It's my duty. Don't worry, I'll just be out for a few."

Snick knew better but had just hugged her tight and let her go. They wondered if they'd ever stop hating themselves for letting her go.

Basco shifted as she sleepily said, "You're awake?"

"She's awake," Snick said. "Storm's still going."

Saz didn't know why Snick had bothered to specify, the screaming wind was more than enough evidence of that. For a moment she thought she heard voices on the wind but Snick got a little closer to Saz and Basco and said, "Don't listen."

"You hear it too?" Saz said, her ears back as she remembered being a young child staring into the dark looking for a threat after hearing a scary story except this time, the story was real.

Snick nodded as they said, "Don't know what it is but… my people are from along the mountains rimming the southern edge of the

Kingdom of Snows. There's stories about voices on the wind in some places."

"Why didn't you fucking warn us?" Basco said.

"I didn't believe in them," Snick said. "There was more than enough danger than telling you about something I didn't think was real."

"It's real," Saz said as she heard a whisper and shuddered.

"I know," Snick said and Saz saw in their hunched shoulders they were trying to tune out whatever they were hearing. She wondered if it was the same as what she was hearing, though she doubted it.

Catra.

She's so alone.

Catra.

All alone.

No one.

All alone.

Savehersavehersavehersavehersavehersavehersavehersavehersavehersavehersavehersavehersavehersavehersaveher.

"SHUT THE FUCK UP!" Saz screamed at the wind before a hacking cough escaped her as her raw throat screamed right back at her.

Basco gently covered Saz's ears and Saz reached up to put her own hands over them.

The three sat like that for some time. It was hard to tell how long, though they tried to keep track. They tried to make radio contact with the skiffs, where the long range radios on board should have been able to relay a message, but they couldn't get anything to

work. Time seemed not to exist as all three felt like they were slowly going insane. Food wasn't a problem, they had more than enough because of their casualties. Water was a bit of an issue, melting snow used up stove fuel and they had to reach out of the shelter, but it would be a bit before it was a real problem. They just had to wait the storm out and not give in to the voices. It was a tightly defined existence. They slept, they played cards, they wrote letters, not sure if they'd ever be read, and they talked.

Saz thought she'd been close to the Basco and Snick before but it was nothing compared to the soul baring they did waiting for the weather to relent. Snick told of a fight with their family and leaving the mountains, roaming Etheria and feeling outcast before finally ending up in the Horde. Basco talked about her own fears, how she was terrified of ever being loved again after multiple failed relationships, how finding Saz had felt like salvation. Saz spilled everything about her upbringing under Chuut as a mentor, how her family loved her but she still felt driven, her fears of Catra being consumed by hate like she saw some in her village become, and how when they got back, they'd grab her and go.

"I don't care if they chase us," Saz said. "No more complex plans. No more waiting, we fly to Bright Moon and turn ourselves over."

"You sure about that?" Snick said.

"What if they take her away?" Basco said, her voice cracking a little.

Saz stared into the dregs of the drink mix in her mug a long time before she said, "Maybe it's for the best."

"What!?" Basco said.

"What good have I done for her? I've got her stuck in the Horde. If we die out here, she's stuck there, no one to give a shit about her. It's not any better than Staed. It might even be worse and I brought her there. It's my fault."

Saz thought she'd cry then but it never came. She just felt sick. The other two were silent for a long time before Snick suddenly looked up at the shelter ceiling. The other two noticed and then they heard the same thing.

Or didn't hear at it were.

"Did it stop?" Basco whispered into the silence left by the absence of wind.

Saz shook her head, her better hearing still hearing a little bit of wind, but it was no longer the storm roar.

"It's there but it's just… it's just normal wind. I don't hear the voices either," Saz whispered back.

"Pack," Snick said as they got up and started grabbing the stove and other stuff and shoving it into a pack.

"It's night time," Basco objected as Saz started shoving a sleeping bag into a stuff sack. "It's going to be freezing."

"Good. Less chance of an avalanche," Saz replied.

Basco thought for a second and then began packing.

"Think the skiffs are alright?" she said.

"We'll find out," Snick said. "If we can't get out, maybe we can at least get a distress call out. If we can't get the call out, then we'll come back here. Think we can handle it?"

"If we can't out and can't get a call out, we go down to Snowtop and surrender," Saz said.

The other two didn't stop packing but did look at her.

"You sure?" Snick said.

"Do we have a choice?" Saz said.

"What about Catra?" Snick said.

"They can imprison me or kill me or whatever the princesses want to do but I'll get her first. I'll even show them how to get into the Fright Zone as long as Catra comes back out with us," Saz said.

"That's the spirit, hon," Basco said with a tight smile that was met by Saz.

Shortly afterwards, they stepped out of the shelter with their packs. Snick looked around, the light of the aurora sneaking through gaps in the speeding clouds overhead.

"Is it really ended?" Saz asked as Basco clipped a carabiner with a line attached to a harness on Saz and Saz did the same to Snick.

"Long enough for us to take this chance, let's go," Snick said. The three started off uphill in the deep, new snow, not looking back.

Chapter End Notes

Thought you'd seen the last of Aleph Squad, didn't you? For the inevitable questions, this is a bit achronic in order, at least for the Saz timeline.

The drink that Snick is drinking is something called Russian Tea Mix. It's not Russian at all but it's a good hot drink. Recipe below. Drink and enjoy and be glad at least you're not lost in Snowtop Pass with more than half your group dead!
Ingredients

- 2 cups dry orange drink mix i.e. Tang
- 1 cup instant tea
- 2 cups sugar
- 1.25 ounces package unsweetened package lemonade mix **
- 2 teaspoons cinnamon, heaping
- 2 teaspoons ground cloves

Instructions

1. Mix all ingredients together. Store in an airtight container.
   To Serve: Stir 1 heaping tablespoon mix into 1 cup hot water.

Chapter 45: Chapter Forty-Five - Catra

Chapter Summary

Catra gets fed up with Thorn and moves to make some kind of headway.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra didn't think, she just reacted as Thorn's fist came at her. In slow motion it would have looked like Catra's right hand angling up and then back to the right to catch Thorn's wrist with the back of Catra's wrist which then turned so she was able to grip Thorn's wrist followed by a slight step forward while her body turned to bring up the left hand to push on the outside of Thorn's elbow, locking it in place and by doing so allowing the arm to work as a lever. Catra then kept her body turning to push Thorn forward and down, completely the throw.

At regular speed it was just half seen motions with a few grunts, thumps, and then a thud as Thorn went to the ground in a split second.

"What in the…," Catra started to say when Thorn twisted in the arm lock and a foot came striking at Catra's face with the claws out. Catra let go and jumped back as Thorn came leaping to her feet.

And then she was three feet off the ground being held at a long arm's length by Adora who now barely fit under the dining tent as She-Ra.

"You will not hurt her," Adora growled.

Catra didn't have time to dissect all the emotions that came with the shiver that went up her back at that voice as Thorn tried to kick Adora while shouting, "You're really She-Ra!?" over and over.

"Yes, she's She-Ra!" Catra shouted at her.

"Yes, I am! Now stop trying to kick me and behave and I'll set you down!" Adora said and then looked at Catra when she realized yelling wasn't going to help her magically understand her.

"Calm down and she'll put you down," Catra said.

After a moment, Thorn stopped before finally giving a nod and Adora carefully put her on the ground. Thorn's eyes snapped to Melog and then to Adora before finally settling on Catra.

"I couldn't help but notice the claws this time," Catra said.

"If you use them, I'll use them," Thorn said.

"Adaptable of you."

"No, I'll just stick to the proper way. It won't be said that I didn't return it even if you don't believe it."

"Whatever you say," Catra said and then waved away the guards that had come running at the noise.

Thorn was quiet for a moment before she looked at Adora again and then back to Catra.

"Was that really the queen of Bright Moon earlier?" Thorn said.

"Yep."

"And those two others, the Magicats with the weird dialect… are they really from the lost kingdom of Half Moon?"

"Well, it's not lost now but yeah, they are," Catra replied.

Thorn turned away and stared at the bushes behind them, deep in thought as Melog jumped off the table and padded over to Catra.

"What's on your mind?" Melog asked softly and for a moment Catra thought they were talking to her but then she say them looking at Thorn.

"I don't want to talk," Thorn said and Catra noticed that she was hugging herself tight.

"Realizing some things, aren't you?" Catra said.

"Shut up."

There was no real fire in it though and Catra just nodded before turning to Adora and quietly saying, "Head on to bed, OK?"

Adora looked at Thorn and then back to Catra and started to open her mouth but Catra just shook here head. Adora frowned before she finally kissed Catra and left. Catra sighed as she leaned back against the tabletop and thought of what it would be like to have a normal life. In theory she knew what it meant. Grow up with people who loved you, who taught you, who helped you, and yeah, she knew there were problems but they were regular problems, and when you got older you went out into the word confident that you knew how everything stood. Thorn probably had something like that, Catra told herself. And then then the thought continued.

What happens when the world isn't the world you knew? When it all changed, when you had to face it because your face was getting bashed against it, and how would she handle it?

"It's not all a lie," Catra said. Thorn didn't turn around but she saw Thorn's ears flick back to listen a little better. "Really. Fuck, I'm probably not the one who should be trying to help you with this, my fuckups are literally legendary, but… I get it, alright?"

"Shut up."

"No. Now what?"

Thorn turned, her eyes bloodshot and it was in that moment Catra realized they were colored yellow like her left eye and she wondered what that meant, if anything.

"Your girlfriend isn't here to protect you."

Catra actually snorted as she said, "Melog is and I've seen how you've been looking at them."

Thorn shot a look at Melog who stretched as they said, "Don't look at me. I'm not fighting."

"Thanks. I was trying to bluff," Catra said.

"Do better then," Melog replied to Catra as they padded over to Thorn, shrinking as they did, until they weren't much larger than a house cat. They jumped on the table beside Thorn and curled up into a little bun. "Would you like to place your hand on me? I'm told it's comforting."

Thorn looked at Melog before she said, "I'm not falling for your trap. You won't ensorcell me."

"My magic doesn't work that way," Melog said. "Offer stands."

Thorn kept looking at Melog before shaking her head as she said, "I don't know what this is, I can understand you because of this… because of them, and I know it's magic but…"

"Listen, I think we're getting nowhere," Catra said. "Let's get some rest. If you're here in the morning, we'll talk more. If not, well, I get it."

"As if I'd rest here with an enemy," Thorn replied.

"Listen, I get it, but damn, how many times do I have to say this!? I don't care about your blood feud! If anything, I'm the stupid one for offering you shelter because you do care about it! Did you think about that?"

Thorn frowned as her ears twitched as she said, "That's what I'd expect you to say."

"Was I this big a pain in the ass?" Catra muttered to herself.

"I am not being a pain!" Thorn snapped.

"I mean, you are but I guess I shouldn't be surprised," Catra replied. "I'd be afraid to stay here as well I guess."

Thorn's fur stood out a bit more as she said, "I'm not afraid!"

"OK, you're not," Catra said. "But I'm tired, I'm going to bed. You want to stay, let me find a place. You don't want to? Fine. Walk on out. No one cares. You want to fight, well, fuck off, I'm not fighting you. I'm tired of all that."

Thorn's lips went thin as she stared at Catra. Finally, she said, "I'll find my own way out."

"Tell the rest I'm just here to talk," Catra said. "If they don't want to, well, I don't care anymore."

Catra left and was halfway back to her tent when she realized Melog wasn't with her.

Chapter End Notes

Content warning: I talk about medical stuff in this.

OK, this one was short and it's been about a month since I updated. So what happened? I had a bit of a medical issue which is an understatement but I'm trying to make light of it because quite frankly, it's fucking terrifying. I had a cardiac arrest in a store, came very close to dying, spent over a week in the hospital, and now I have several medical devices implanted in me that will be with me for the rest of my life. Toss in a secondary infection that caused its own troubles as well as complete life style changes in diet and habits and a string of doctor's visits and I don't know what normal is anymore. As I said, fucking terrifying, and it is still fucking terrifying. In all of this my wife has been an absolute rock of a person who has been there for me, truly putting out the definition of the old wedding vows of "through thick and thin, in sickness and in health." I am incredibly lucky to have her.

As to fic, I gave thought to just putting up a couple of short paragraphs for each of my pending stories to let people know where it would have gone and being done with this. It was really hard to imagine making up my fun little stories

anymore. There's a lot I haven't been interested in and of course, a lot of that is mental trauma having its way with me. Within just the last few days though, I've really been on the mend though, starting to feel like maybe there is a normal out there, whatever it might be shaped like. And I realized that maybe fic is going to be part of that normal. Tonight, I sat down at my computer for the first time in weeks to figure out a problem with a video game I'd been working on before all this happened about a month ago. As I waited for an update to finish, I poked into my fic folder and I realize, I'm not done with it yet. I have no idea how quick I'm going to be coming back to this but I still got stories in me. I know they're going to look different because I'm not the same I was a month ago. That's life though and I feel that even deeper now. Thank you for your patience and thank you for reading and for God's sake, remember to treasure the ones you love. Tomorrow, hell, the next second, isn't promised. You never know.

Chapter 46: Chapter Forty-Six - Thorn

Chapter Summary

Thorn talks with Melog as she gets ready to leave.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Thorn watched Catra walk away and fought down the urge to attack her again. It helped that Melog was sitting right beside her in the sense she was pretty sure Melog could bat her twenty feet away without effort and assumed that's why they were still there.

"So she lied," Thorn said, standing and backing up a little from Melog.

"About?" Melog replied as they hopped off the table, shifting to their normal size.

"I'm not free to leave. You're going to do her dirty work."

"I'm not going to do anything. I'm her friend, not her servant."

"Then why are you here?"

Melog stretched a little before settling back on their haunches.

"I'm not ready to sleep."

"Well, I'm leaving," Thorn said. "I'll be back though. I won't be alone either."

"That is your choice," Melog said.

"You're right, it is," Thorn said as she backed up until she was up against the serving tables. She fumbled around until she found a

mug and filled it from the spiced tea dispenser, cursing as she spilled a little of the hot liquid across her hand from trying to fill it while turned sideways to it.

"Just turn around," Melog said. "I'm not going to attack you."

Thorn shook her head as she drank the tea and grabbed a muffin in the other hand.

"You could have had all that earlier," Melog said. "They really are kind folk, even to enemies much worse than you."

"Why should I believe you?"

"Other than your own eyes? You've seen how they acted."

"Yes, acted."

"I've seen them put on plays," Melog said with a sigh. "Trust me, acting is not what they're good at doing."

"Stop it."

"Stop what?"

"Stop acting like that!" Thorn said before taking a bite out of the muffin. Her eyes went a little wide as she broke eye contact with Melog and looked down at it as she chewed.

"Chocolate blueberry," Melog responded.

"Are you reading my mind?" Thorn said, her mouth half full.

"No. But I remember Catra had the same reaction when she ate one," Melog said.

"I've had chocolate before," Thorn said. "Berries too."

"But not like that have you?"

Thorn took another bite, chewed, and then shook her head.

"I'd say the Bright Moon kitchen staff are magic but I don't think they actually use magic," Melog said with a little smile. "They're just some of the best cooks on the planet and don't even realize it."

Thorn finished eating before grabbing another muffin, wrapped it up in one of the cloth napkins and shoved it into her satchel.

"Take the basket if you want," Melog said.

"I'm just grabbing one for my trip," Thorn said. She drank the rest of her tea and then shook her head. She grabbed yet another muffin and started walking.

"Of course," Melog said as they padded along beside her.

"You're going to follow me aren't you?" Thorn said.

"Just to get you to the perimeter," Melog replied.

They walked in silence for a moment before Melog spoke up again. "You know, breakfast is even better. The muffin? That's just a starter. They'll have fresh fruit, pancakes, crepes…"

"Stop."

"I'm just saying."

"I know and you're trying to get me to betray my people. She's my sworn enemy!"

"All of them? Even the cooks?"

"You don't understand," Thorn said.

"You know, you're not my first Magicat to be a pain in the ass," Melog said.

Thorn looked at Melog as she said, "I'm not being a…"

"Yeah, you kinda are," Melog said. "It's alright. I get it."

They were approaching a low plastic barrier that the former Horde soldiers had dragged out of storage somewhere. It was about knee high on most people and was supposed to be deployed with other barriers such as fences but for this outing, they'd figured it was enough as a way to mark a boundary. Thorn jumped over it and Melog sat down.

"If you're going to follow me, just follow me," Thorn snapped.

"I'm not following you. You heard Catra, she doesn't care anymore," Melog said.

"She didn't mean that though," Thorn said.

"First astute thing you've said since you've been here," Melog said. "You're right, she does care but I know her. She meant what she said. She's not going to fight, she…"

Melog trailed off and Thorn looked at them over the barrier.

"She what?" Thorn said.

Melog sighed and looked away as they said, "She's not going to chase approval again."

"We don't apprrove of her," Thorn said, the word approve coming out in thick sarcasm.

"I know," Melog said. "I think she realizes that as well."

"Well… I don't care," Thorn said. "Tell her to be ready."

Thorn turned her back and went trotting off into the darkness. Melog sighed and started back towards Catra, not noticing Thorn stopping at a pile of rocks and looking back over her shoulder. She jumped to the top of the pile of stones and balanced there, eating the last muffin she'd taken, looking at the camp. A few people stood along the perimeter but for the most part, nothing moved. She finished the muffin, looked one last time at the camp, and then turned her back again and started climbing up the cliff, being

sure to stay on stone so she couldn't be followed while thoughts rolled in her mind.

Chapter End Notes

> This one is pretty short and I must say, it's still weird to have Melog actually *speak*. Not much else to say! Thank you for reading!

Chapter 47: Chapter Forty-Seven - Catra

Chapter Summary

Catra makes a decision of whether to wait or whether to go.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I swear, I've never met someone so hardheaded before," Catra said as she stretched. Early morning light filtered into the tent and Catra caught the look on Glimmer's face. "What?"

"I was just going to say I have but we won't get into that," Glimmer said.

Adora gave a little snort from where she was sitting and giving her boots a quick polish.

"Oh, ha-ha," Catra said with a roll of her eyes. "I wasn't that… you know what? I'm not going to dignify it with a response."

"You just did," Melog said with a yawn.

"Hush," Catra said.

"You weren't like that," Adora said.

"Thank you," Catra said as she pulled on a shirt.

"You were so much worse," Adora said with a grin as she pulled her boots on.

"So we're at the teasing stage, huh?" Catra said as Adora stepped over and leaned down to kiss her.

"Yeah, but I love you," Adora said as Catra stretched up a little and kissed her.

"You're lucky I love you too," Catra said.

"More than I know," Adora said.

"Do I need to leave you two alone?" Glimmer asked.

"Nah," Catra said as she stood up and adjusted her belt a little. "Want to go see what's for breakfast?"

"Going to be the same as yesterday," Glimmer said with a sigh.

"They've been mixing it up," Adora said as they stepped out of the tent.

"I mean, I guess. It's still the same ingredients though," Glimmer said.

"You know, you say something like that and it just reminds me just how different we grew up," Catra said.

Glimmer gave a little grimace as she said, "OK, come on."

"Not teasing, just saying," Catra said, looking around. She had half expected to see Thorn sitting outside the tent waiting and found herself disappointed she wasn't.

"Well you don't have to make that face," Glimmer said.

"The last I saw of her, she was climbing a cliff wall," Melog said.

"It's not you," Catra said to Glimmer before turning to Melog. "I didn't ask."

"What? What did they say?" Glimmer said.

"It's private," Catra said while giving Melog a look.

"She was looking for Thorn so I guess Melog said something about her," Adora said and Catra snapped her head around. "What? You're not as subtle as you think you are, especially after you refused to talk about it last night when you got back, and then tossed and turned half the night."

"We're not talking about this," Catra said as she took off at a fast walk. The others caught up with her but didn't push it and they were soon standing in line waiting on breakfast. Bow waved at them from a table were he was talking with Gila and a few other locals.

"I swear, he could make friends with a wall," Catra said.

"One of his brothers told me that he used to talk to some of the vines that grow on his dads' library," Glimmer said. "He had a whole backstory for them."

"I believe it," Adora said with a laugh.

"So… what are we doing here then?" Glimmer said.

"An excellent question," Melog responded as they looked at Catra.

Catra noticed those in the line with them were looking at her as well and she said, "Can I at least eat first?"

"Hey, not that we don't mind the vacation but it's a good question," one of the ex-Horde members said.

"She said she has to eat first," Adora said and several people held their hands up in response to distance themselves from the ex-Horde member.

A few minutes later, as they were sitting down while Adora grumbled under her breath a little, Catra answered Glimmer.

"I think… damn, I don't know, I think maybe it's time to pack this up."

"Are you kidding me right now? After all of this?"

"Listen, just talking with Thorn makes me think. These people… they aren't ever going to accept me," Catra said. "Maybe they're related to me but that doesn't matter to them and unless Thorn was lying, my mother is dead."

Adora shifted a little bit on the bench, poking at a bowl of oatmeal covered in sugar and fruit, before she said, "Maybe it was wrong."

Catra shook her head as she said, "No. It's not."

"Gut feeling?" Glimmer said.

"Kind of, yeah," Catra replied. "I mean…"

Catra trailed off and Glimmer said, "What? Finish."

Catra just shook her head and began to eat, refusing to speak. After several tries, including from Adora, they gave up and turned to other conversations. After breakfast, they all headed towards the command tent, Catra still not talking. Juliet was waiting there as they came in and sat down, as were a few of what Catra was thinking of as the representatives the various little groups, like the ex-Horde members, that made up their little expedition. Adora looked at Juliet for a split second before sitting down. Bow came in with Gila and spoke to Glimmer for a moment before the two of them took a seat. Juliet looked at Gila and Bow gave a little nod and a smile and Juliet nodded back before beginning to speak.

"OK, I've made a review of our original plan versus the changed plans," Juliet said while a holographic chart appeared beside her. "Our original plan was to scout the region, locate Staed, and make contact. The revised plan cut back on the scouting as we have located Staed and made contact with a citizen of same. I'd say our objective is mostly met at this point and so we're here to discuss next steps."

Again, everyone turned to Catra who shrunk down in her seat a little while Melog shrunk down and crawled up under her chair. She did manage to speak up.

"OK, yeah, we know why we were all out here and it's probably gotten out that Thorn has left us. I'm going to say that at this point, I'm… uh… you know, OK with going back unless I can hear an argument otherwise," Catra said.

Lonnie spoke up and said, "I mean, other than the huge amount of effort we've all put in?"

Catra shrugged but wouldn't look at her as she said, "Yeah, that."

"It's OK," Bow replied. "We've met Gila and his people. We're talking about putting up an embassy for Bright Moon here. So

we'll have an easy way to make contact if they want to reach us after this group leaves."

Catra could see Glimmer making eye contact with Bow that said something along the lines of, "We're doing *what?"* but Glimmer didn't say anything so Catra held her tongue.

"Listen, I don't think of this as cutting anything short," Juliet said. "It was valuable training for my people."

"They did do well," Adora replied. Juliet looked at her a bit surprised but one of the ex-Horde members spoke up to say that if nothing else, they had a fun little time out. The group spoke up in general consensus before Catra spoke again.

"I hate that I dragged everyone out here but it's what it is."

"Hey, you've dragged us into worse, Fuzzy," Glimmer replied.

Lonnie snorted as she says, "I have the scars to prove it."

"Yeah, thanks for reminding me," Catra said with a roll of her eyes. "I don't think we're going to accomplish much else without starting an actual fight so let's talk winding this down."

The conversation went on for most of the morning, mostly figuring out how things would be packed up and lifted back out, with Gila offering help and it getting accepted, until they finally broke for lunch.

Adora and Catra were following Glimmer out while she quizzed Bow on what he had meant by embassy when Juliet asked Adora if she could speak with her. Adora didn't respond at first but finally nodded and told Catra she'd catch up with her.

"You sure about that?" Catra replied.

"Go on, I'll see you soon," Adora said with a quick kiss.

Catra glared at Juliet with Melog flashing a quick red before they both left. Now it was just Adora and Juliet and a few people sitting at various computers around the big tent, doing their best to show they weren't paying attention while almost falling out of their chairs leaning over to overhear. Juliet looked at the people before turning back to Adora to say, "Do you mind if we step outside."

Adora just nodded and turned around and left the tent. Juliet sighed a little and stepped out as well.

Outside, they could hear the buzz of the camp and Juliet carefully ran her hand over her head as she said, "I'm going to try this again. I know I upset you. I would like to mend things between us, if possible."

Adora had her arms crossed as she looked up at the soaring canyon walls.

"You can't," Adora said as she looked back down. "And you know, saying that, I can kind of feel better knowing that but I also know you were trying to help."

"I was," Juliet replied.

"I know, it wasn't a question," Adora snapped before taking a breath and looking down. She muttered the next part as she said, "Sorry."

"No, you're not," Juliet said with a little smile.

Adora looked up and gave a little smile back as she said, "No, I'm not but old habit." Her smile disappeared as she went on. "It's like I said that day, it felt like you were using my past against me and implying that I didn't care about Catra."

"I understand…," Juliet started to say before Adora cut her off.

"No, you don't. I was a tool most of my life. You might think you're a tool of the Bright Moon crown but you chose that, as an

adult, and you can leave it at any time," Adora said, angrily wiping at tears starting to pool in her eyes. "Not me. I wasn't even a regular Horde cadet, I was a tool, a means to an end for the greater power of another. I got used. The only time I was allowed to be myself without punishment was when it fit that agenda. Then I left the Horde, only to be a tool again for another person's power play. So yeah, you didn't do that to me but you fucking used that bit of me that still jumps to attention to try and do something. Do you understand that?"

Juliet's face was blank but she was slowly nodding.

"Yes, I do."

Adora glared at her for a moment before finally sighing and looking away.

"You meant good though and everyone deserves another chance," Adora said. She stood there awkwardly for a moment before holding her hand out. "I'm still going to be angry about this but I'll try and let it go."

Juliet took Adora's hand and gave it a solid shake as she said, "And I'll not do that again."

Adora gave a nod and walked away, feeling a bit better.

Chapter End Notes

> Nothing to say here really except I'm recouping well with my health. It's been a massive live change but it's starting to seem more normal. Thank you for all the well wishes!

Chapter 48: Chapter Forty-Eight - Catra

Chapter Summary

> The decision to leave the canyon behind has been made and Catra is surprised at the last minute by an announcement.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It had been two days since they'd decided to head back home. The camp was no long a buzzing hive of activity and was down to just the command tent and a few sleeping tents. The Bright Moon chefs had packed up the afternoon before and headed out and it was then that Catra had realized just how soft she'd become when they'd broke out field rations for dinner. The guards had grumbled a little about it and Catra had found herself agreeing until she'd realized that just a few years back, this would have been a feast for her. The stew wasn't that great, the crackers were a bit on the salty side, and the desert a bit bland but Catra found herself grinning all the same about it. The morning after the chef's left they'd been eating something one of the guards had said was nothing more than a ration bar for breakfast and Catra had actually laughed at her.

The guard, named Sera, immediately realized who she was saying it to as Catra said, "This is not a ration bar. This is so far from a ration bar, they're not even in the same universe."

"I mean, it just, you know, it's kind of blah," Sera said, taking a bite of the bar and trying to grin.

"Listen, I'm not saying they're fantastic, but come on," Catra said before suddenly getting a grin. "You know what? Hang on, I'll be right back."

Adora followed her as she left the command tent and slipped into the tent they'd been sleeping in. Two skiffs screamed overhead as Gila's people took them for a test run that looked suspiciously like a race. Catra didn't pay any attention though as she rooted to the bottom of her pack.

"What are you doing?" Adora said and then actually recoiled a little as Catra came up with a gray wrapped bar. "You actually have a ration bar!?"

"Yep," Catra said. "Probably been sitting in there since a little after I moved into Bright Moon." She looked at the label for a moment and nodded. "Yep, still within expiration."

"Only because they don't expire for like ten years," Adora said. "Are you really going to torment Sera?"

"Naw, we're just going to have a little cultural exchange," Catra said with a chuckle.

"I'm not responsible for this," Adora said with a shake of her head as Catra passed her to go back to the command tent with a quick kiss to Adora.

Catra came back in with a grin on her face as she said, "So, I've got a little surprise for everyone."

Bow looked up from where he was eating with one hand and fiddling with an arrowhead with the other, saw what was in Catra's hand, and said, "What? Are you going to do a controlled demolition of that? Only way to be sure it doesn't come back."

Sera looked at the ration bar as Catra sat down beside her, trying to figure out what it was, as Catra said, "Nope. I think we should all try this."

Sera had a dawning look of recognition on her face as she said, "Wait, is that actually…?"

"A genuine Hordak-era Horde ration bar," Catra said. "In gray flavor, the best kind."

Lonnie was making gagging noises as she said, "I never got why you two thought those were good. The green ones, those were the best."

"Ugh, those left a horrible aftertaste though," one of the few remaining ex-Horde techs said.

"They all did," Adora said as she sat down. "At least gray was kind of sweet, it balanced out the rest of the flavor some."

Lonnie shuddered as she said, "That's what was so awful about it! It was cloying!"

Catra was just grinning as she popped a claw and slit the heavy foil wrapping and pealed it back. Sera leaned back a little as Catra used a knife to slice a piece off and held it out to Sera.

"Really, I believe you," Sera said.

"It's not like you're thinking it is," Bow said.

"Yeah, it's so much worse," Glimmer said.

"You really don't have to," Catra said. "I'm just messing around."

She flipped the piece into her mouth and started chewing. Then she started to gag a little.

Lonnie started laughing as she said, "Haven't had it for a while have you?"

Catra was shaking her head as she tried to swallow, gagged again, and then finally got it down before taking a long swig of fruit juice. Her eyes were streaming tears as she gave a smile and said, "See? Not that bad."

"It can't be that bad," Adora said as she took the bar from Catra, took a slice off it and then popped it into her mouth, followed by coughing and a lot of forced chewing before she finally swallowed it. "How did we eat this all the time!?"

"Did it go bad?" Sera said, followed by the ex-Horde members laughing.

"It doesn't go bad, not really," one said.

"Honestly, it's best past its expiry date," another said. "It loses its flavor."

"I worked in the place that extruded it," yet another said. "I tried it fresh once before it even got wrapped. Calling it fresh is an insult to fresh. It was horrendous."

One of the Bright Moon guards said, "Come on, Sera. You got to try it."

Another one of the guards started to chant, "Do it, do it, do it" and the rest of the guards took it up.

Sera screwed her face up and took the bar from Adora and pulled her field knife to slice a chunk off. She sniffed it and recoiled a little as Glimmer shouted, "For the love of Mara, don't smell it! That's just going to make it worse!"

Sera finally shoved the chunk into her mouth and immediately gagged as she started to chew. For a moment, it looked like she wasn't going to be able to get it down but she finally did and threw her fist in the air as she continued to gag a bit as one of her fellow guards handed her a fruit punch to wash it down.

"You're next!" Sera shouted as she pointed at the first guard to tell her to try it.

"Nope! Not a chance!" the guard said with a laughter and then realized she was stuck as Sera started chanting "Do it!" along with the rest of the room.

Juliet walked in a little bit later to see her guard staff laughing and gagging in equal measures after they'd tried chunks of the ration bars, as well as some of the ex-Horde members doing the same in a show of solidarity. Someone was trying to get Bow to try it and he was laughing as he said, "Not a chance, I know what they taste like, I don't need a reminder."

Juliet cleared her throat a little with a small smile as the guards came to their feet and the conversation died as Juliet looked around.

"I wondered why no one was out getting us ready to leave today," she said before walking over to the guard holding the ration bar. She held her hand out to the guard. "May I?"

The guard handed it to her without a word and Juliet used her fingers to pinch off a glob before putting it in her mouth. She chewed calmly, a contemplative look on her face, before swallowing it with a nod.

"Interesting," Juliet said as her smile got a bit bigger. She broke another bit off and ate it before nodding. "The taste is memorable." Everyone was absolutely silent, even a bit awe struck at how calm she seemed to be. Juliet looked at her guards as she sat the ration bar down on a table. "I applaud you on your initiave to have a group bonding moment but now, perhaps, we should get to work."

The guards nodded and quickly left the tent, followed by the ex-Horde techs. The few remaining inside could hear them all start talking in astonishment as Lonnie leaned forward with a cup of fruit juice.

"Well played," she said with a grin.

"Thank you," Juliet replied fervently as she took the cup and took a drink before swallowing and then immediatly followed it up with another that she took the time to swirl around in her mouth. "That is foul."

Adora laughed as she said, "You had me fooled!"

"Not me," Glimmer said. "I've known her too long."

"Well, Your Majesty, do I need to hire a food taster in case someone tries to slip that into your food?" Juliet said with a smile.

Catra responded by saying, "No need. Ration bars will dye any food it comes in contact with."

"Wait, seriously?" Bow said.

Adora was nodding as she said, "I mean, not completely, but yeah, the coloring will stain whatever it's mixed with."

"Are we sure this isn't some senient being then?" Bow said as he gave the block a push and it wobbled a little.

"Hope not," Catra said. "We ate a lot of those over the years and I don't need someone else being pissed off at me for something." Everyone went quiet and Catra sighed. "Oh come on, it was a good joke."

"At least it wasn't something depressing about your childhood again," Glimmer said.

"I mean, it is," Lonnie said as she picked up the ration bar and threw it in a trash can. "That was definetly a part of our childhood."

"OK, before this gets any more cheerful, lets get packed up and headed home," Glimmer said as she stood up.

"Miss your fancy bathtub?" Catra said with a grin.

"Yes, and at this point, I'm not ashamed to admit," Glimmer said.

"It is absolutely beautiful here though," Bow replied.

"Fine, we'll come back for a campout," Glimmer said as she headed for the door.

"We'll have to come back to visit the embassy anyway," Bow said and held the door flap for her.

"Still can't believe you did that," Glimmer replied with a smile as the door flap closed behind them.

"I have to admit, a big bathtub and a long soak sounds amazing," Lonnie said before slapping the sides of her legs. "Whelp, going to go get my stuff stacked up by the skiffs. I'm out."

As she left, it was quiet for a moment before Juliet said, "Do you need anything from me?"

Adora shook her head as she said, "We're all packed up except for a few things."

"If you want to do that, I could use some help dropping the main command tent, if you don't mind," Juliet said.

Neither were really looking at each other as Catra gave a long sigh and said, "We'll help out. Come on you," she said as she grabbed Adora. "Let's go get packed and find Melog wherever they are so we can get out of here. I know you're probably missing a bath as well."

"I mean, a bit," Adora said. "Is that alright?"

"You kidding? I'm going to give myself a good brush and then curl into a stack of pillows while you wallow in the water," Catra said before looking at Juliet. "I'm glad you two talked but damn, you're still both awkward as fuck."

"We don't all have your social graces," Juliet replied with a straight face and Catra broke out laughing.

"OK, good one. See you in a few," Catra said.

A couple of hours later, everything was packed up and on the skiffs. Bow was saying goodbye to Gila and was being introduced

to one of Gila's people named Quartz who'd come with them to help get setup for shipping their trade goods.

Catra was leaning against a skiff waiting on Adora when Melog came trotting up to her.

"You certainly took your time. I was worried something had happened to you," Catra said as Melog sat down in front of her.

"I was exploring," Melog said with a long stretch.

Catra started to open her mouth about the dangerous conditions and then remembered who she was talking to and closed it again.

"Very good on thinking first," Melog said with a little flick of their tale and a half-grin.

"OK, that was uncalled for," Catra said as her own tail flicked in response. "Seriously, I was worried."

"I understand. I came back to tell you that I'll see you back in Bright Moon," Melog said.

"Wait, what!?" Catra said. "Why!?"

"I find this environment interesting and I find I need to spend more time in it," Melog said. "Will you be OK without me around for a little while?"

"I mean, I think so," Catra said, her ears flattening back a little. "How long?"

"I can't imagine more than a week or so," Melog said.

Catra knelt down and hugged Melog tight as she said, "I don't know about this."

"I understand," Melog said as they settled their head on her shoulder. "If you do not want me to leave, I'll stay."

"No, I can't do that," Catra said and found herself sniffling a little. She fought it down as she went on. "You've always been there for me but…"

She found she couldn't go on as Melog nuzzled in a little closer and said, "You are so much stronger now than you were then. If you need me, I'll be there faster than you realize, I promise."

Catra said back as she said, "You promise? You know…"

"I know what promise means to you," Melog said. "I will not let you down. I say again, I'll stay if you wish."

Catra shook her head as she said, "No, you said need, I get it. You sure you can get back OK?"

"I lived on a deserted planet by myself for longer than you can imagine," Melog said. "I know I'll be OK."

"You're right," Catra said as she sat back on her heels. "You leaving now?"

"I may, yes, if that's OK," Melog said. "Give my wishes to the others?"

"Of course," Catra said with a nod and then leaned forward to hug Melog again. "I love you. Be careful."

"I love you as well," Melog said. "It won't be long before I see you again."

"I hope so," Catra said as she hugged them tighter before finally letting go.

Melog nudged her with their head before turning away and turning invisible. Adora found Catra a few minutes later sniffling behind the skiff.

"You alright?" Adora said as she sat down and pulled her in close. After Catra explained what was going on, Adora said, "You think

they're going after Thorn?"

Catra sat up, her eyes wide as she said, "I hadn't thought of that."

"Maybe they think she needs help too," Adora said.

"I guess," Catra said, settling back into the sand with a sigh, feeling a little better. "I hope so."

"Hey, either way, you can ask them soon," Adora said.

Catra looked up at the canyon walls and sighed.

"I hope so."

About an hour later, Melog sat on a rock above the beach watching the last of the skiffs lift off. They could see the last one with Adora and Catra on it and watched it until it cleared the rim of the canyon and disappeared. Then they turned to Thorn.

"You could have gone with them."

Thorn shook her head and then winced. She reached up to touch her head and winced again as the movement pulled on the rough field dressing she had on the slash across her right arm.

"No."

"You know Catra would have…"

"I know what she would have done," Thorn snapped. "I don't want that. Chuut and the rest are still my family, even after…"

Thorn looked at the ground as Melog said, "I was going to say she would have helped you leave. She is not what you think she is like, she is not in fact what most people think she is like."

Thorn coughed a little, which caused her to clutch her side in pain, and then cough again and for a couple of minutes, she kept that up, clutching her side in pain while she coughed before it finally subsided.

"I still say you need medical attention," Melog said.

"I'm fine," Thorn said before she started walking down the rock towards the beach. Melog chose not to say anything at the slight limp and followed her.

Chapter End Notes

> Yep, this is still ongoing! It's been a different kind of month gone by. Still on the rebound from my medical issues, realizing I very likely have PTSD from same, but also having moments of absolutely transcendental beauty and appreciation of life. There's a line in the Fight Club movie that says, "Tomorrow will be the most beautiful day of Raymond K. Hessel's life. His breakfast will taste better than any meal you and I have ever tasted." Of course, in the movie it's some weird moment where the main characters dragged a guy out of his job and threatened to kill him but it's a line that's always stuck with me because after something awful, the world does glow through the horror. That's where I've been living since January 22nd, in the glow and the horror.
>
> Thank you for reading. :)

Chapter 49: Chapter Forty-Nine - Catra

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora are back home after their time in the Crimson Waste, relaxing. Or as much as Catra can as she worries about Melog and where they might have gone off to.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"It's been over a week, should I go back?" Catra said, pacing the floor of the bedroom.

"It's been eight days," Adora said. "I'm sure they're fine."

"I shouldn't have left them there," Catra said. "What if they did go back for Thorn and she did something or her village did something…"

"OK, you're just working yourself up for nothing," Adora said. "Melog is a survivor."

"So am I," Catra said, her hand carressing the scar on her neck for a moment before grunting. "Everyone gets out of their depth though."

"If you really think there's trouble, we can go back," Ador asaid, sitting up in the beanbag she'd sunk into. "We can teleport even."

Catra stopped and considered it, shocking Adora who'd only been joking with the last part, before shaking her head. "I'm being…"

She shook her head again and walked over to a window, looking out across the garden below.

"Going to finish that?" Adora said as she stood and walked up behind Catra, folding her into her arms.

"No."

"Was it bad?"

"Not really."

"Promise?"

Catra shook her head before she said, "OK, I was going to say stupid."

"You're just worried," Adora said, kissing the top of Catra's head. "About Melog and I bet Thorn too."

"Her?" Catra said her ears twitching a little. "No. That pain in the ass made her decision."

"You really think that?" Adora said.

Catra didn't answer and just stared out at the garden. After a minute, Adora said, "Do you want to go to town tonight? We can go to the cafe, eat something, relax, whatever you're up to."

"Is tonight open mic night?" Catra said after a moment.

"I don't think so," Adora said.

Catra turned around with a tired smile as she said, "OK. I'll go."

"Come on, it wasn't that bad last time," Adora said.

"We can agree to disagree, either way, I'm happy it's not tonight," Catra said.

"Want to go now?" Adora said as she went to the closet.

"Sure, why not," Catra said with a shrug.

An hour later found them walking into the Bright Moon Cafe. The large outdoor patio was starting to fill up as it came closer to evening, the overhead trellis full of flowering vines that butterflies and moths were flitting in and out from. The inside is where they wanted to be though, with its semi-private booths and soft lighting coming from huge pierced tin lanterns with colored glass. Catra slid into one of the booths in the corner, her favorite, and sighed as she sunk into the soft cushions.

"OK, this is good," Catra said as she watched a group across the room playing some elaborate board game.

Adora watched her for a moment before she said, "Good, because I've been worried about you."

"Phfft, I've been alright," Catra said. "You're just put off because Melog isn't here for you to cheat off of with my mood."

Adora gave a little grin as she said, "I mean, there's that as well, but no, you've been quiet." She took Catra's hand as she went on. "You haven't been quiet like this since… well, since right after the Fall."

Catra started to say something, her ears flattening back, before pursing her lips together and looking down.

"I'm not trying to…," Adora started to say before Catra cut her off.

"Look, I know, alright? Can we just have an evening out? I promise I'll have fun," Catra said, still not looking up.

"Hey, you don't have to promise," Adora said. "Really. And I'll let it drop, I just wanted to tell you."

Catra looked up before smiling as she said, "If this is the worst I have to deal with, I'm doing good, really. I just miss them."

"Me too," Adora said.

They both leaned their heads together for a moment before a long drawn out kiss that was interrupted by a startled, "Oops! I'll be back!"

They book looked up to see a server named Elm backing up from the table with their hands up and an embarrassed look on their face.

"It's fine, Elm, it's fine!" Adora said with a laugh.

"I can come back, really," Elm said, who'd at least stopped backing up.

"It's fine," Catra said with a smile. "Bring this one the usual snack tray and I'll take a fruit punch, make it punchy."

Elm gave a nod and returned the smile before heading out.

"Make it punchy?" Adora said.

"Hey, Bow was telling me they were putting rum in these things now, I have to try that," Catra said.

Adora groaned as she said, "Please don't make me carry you out of here tonight."

"Oh, stop, I'm just getting one," Catra said with a quick kiss on Adora's cheek.

"I hope so," Adora said, bumping her hip against Catra. "I'm not carrying you."

"But you love that so much," Catra said.

"Yeah, when it's to bed," Adora said.

Catra blushed a little as she said, "Aren't you suddenly saucy?"

"Saucy? You've been reading those novels Glimmer loves again, I see," Adora said as she gave a Catra a little shove.

Catra shoved her back as she said, "Maybe. It's given me a few ideas."

"Oh, I bet."

The conversation came to a halt as Elm came back with the drink and food. Adora smiled at the big tray laid out before her full of food that was savory, sweet, salty, spicy, and some combination of all of them laid out before her. It was meant to be a tray for at least four people. Adora had no problem taking care of it on her

own, though Catra would eat a bit off of it, dodging Adora's teeth as she'd jokingly put it.

"Got you your usual as well for a drink," Elm said as she sat a mug of spiced cider in front of Adora. "Hope you don't mind."

"No, I do not," Adora said with a grin as she took a drink before digging into the tray in front of her.

"Thanks, Elm," Catra said as Elm left with a wave.

The day melted away and the lights on the square in Bright Moon turned on like little twinkling fireflies, casting a gentle glow over the people sitting around and the children playing games. Adora and Catra moved out onto the porch and ran into Speleo and Tinz playing Go.

"I thought you two would have left by now," Catra said as she sat down at a table beside them.

"We had," Tinz said with a frown as she placed a white stone. She held her hand on it for a moment before removing it. Speleo quickly placed a black stone and began to pick up a few white stones with a grin as she placed them in a small bowl in the table.

"Don't give me that look, you knew it was a bad move or you wouldn't have hesitated," Speleo said to Tinz before turning to Catra. "I got an urgent note a day ago saying that a representative of Half Moon should be present in Bright Moon soon."

"Why?" Adora said as she looked over Tinz's shoulder at the board. Tinz gave her a look and Adora moved to the side.

"I don't know," Speleo said with a shrug. "It wasn't a request from the Queen and asking the other kingdoms turned up nothing either. However, I wasn't pressed for time on anything so here we are, ready to represent if needed."

"So you got a note from some random person saying you were required here… and you still came?" Catra said as she sat up straighter and looked around. "Tinz, I expected better."

"It wasn't my choice," Tinz said. "I spoke quiet heavily against it."

Speleo reached out and gave Tinz's hand a pat as she said, "You are always so vigilant for me."

"It's my job," Tinz said, not meeting her eyes.

Speleo held her hand on Tinz's for a moment longer before giving it a squeeze and pulling it back. Adora was looking back and forth between the two and Catra was leaning forward with a grin.

"You can stop that now," Tinz said, "we are not to be gawked at."

"This isn't gawking, this is surprise," Adora said. "I did not see this coming."

"Really?" Speleo replied. "When we told people back home, they all said some variety of, 'It's about time you admitted it.' I was under the impression that we were the last to know."

"Well, we don't have a good track record with recognizing these things," Catra said as her ears twitched a little.

"That's true, you don't," Tinz said.

"Well, congratulations are still in order!" Adora said. "I'm buying the next round of drinks!"

"I don't drink," Tinz said.

"Don't let her fool you," Speleo said. "She drinks quite well and is quite amusing when she does as well. Cuddly too."

"You know what I mean," Tinz said, looking away with a bit of a blush.

"Well, we're only drinking fruit punch so either way, it's fine," Catra said as she raised her hand at a passing server. About half an hour passed as the four talked and Catra marveled at how she finally seemed to be clicking with the two Magicats. She didn't know if it had been the time spent in the Waste with them or what the difference was but it was nice. She was leaned back in the crook of Adora's arm, her eyes half closed in relaxation when she saw Melog come running up to her.

"Oh good, you're all together, come with me," Melog said before turning and heading back out across the square.

Chapter End Notes

> OK, so I came up with the Bright Moon cafe years ago. I absolutely want to visit it. That said, I decided they had a special fruit punch (secret recipe!) that changed flavor over the course of a year, depending on what fruit juice they could get, but it was always amazing and the thing they were best known for throughout Etheria. I just had the idea that you could mix it with rum and make it an alcoholic drink as well. Then I realized that what I'm describing is basically a Hurricane. Which I'm fine with, I just find it amusing.

Chapter 50: Chapter Fifty - Thorn

Chapter Summary

> Thorn has arrived in Bright Moon, nervous and worried of how she'll be received.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Thorn sat on the bottom step of the huge skiff and looked out at the thriving tangle of trees and bushes that made up the edge of the public landing area of Bright Moon. Her mind reeled at the sheer amount of vegetation and everything she'd ever been taught about plants told her she was in grave danger from something that was growing in such abundance. She knew they couldn't all be dangerous but her gut was still tight looking around. The air felt weird too, full of water to the point that she almost felt like she was trying to breath through a wet cloth. She knew it couldn't be as hot as it was back in the Crimson Waste but the heat was miserable. It wasn't as if she'd never heard of high humidity before but experiencing it was a whole different story.

She heard a brief murmur from the people still sitting on the skiff and finally stood to her feet and stepped up the few steps into the skiff.

"It won't be much longer," Thorn said.

"We've trusted you," Bluestone, an older Magicat from Thorn's village said.

"It's not misplaced," Thorn said.

"She's got us this far," another of the Magicats said from the back.

Thorn flinched a little at motion above her in the luggage racks and then actually smiled a little as she saw that some of the younger kids had gotten up into the racks and were watching her from there.

"She has," Bluestone said as she didn't take her eyes from Thorn. "To what end? You said the old feud with Saz had been settled but the longer this takes…"

Thorn's ears twitched and she fought to keep her tail from lashing back and forth in irritation, not very successfully, as she said, "You trusted me enough to help me back in Staed when I returned. I tell you, Saz's daughter cares not for the feud. It's dead."

Bluestone shook her head as she said, "It could be…"

"It's not!" Thorn snapped as she saw a group of people forming up at the head of the path that led back into the trees from the landing area in the dark. They couldn't see into the skiff very well but those aboard the skiff, Magicats all, could see the crowd gathering quite clearly under the softly glowing lights that lined the path.

"I don't see weapons," someone said near the back.

"They could have them hidden," someone else said.

"Makes no sense," the original voice said. "They would want something ready for battle and something small enough to hide isn't helpful."

"There's enough…"

"I'm telling you, they're not violent," Thorn said.

"That's not what I've heard," Bluestone said. "The queen has a reputation of…"

"Well, she isn't and I've met her and you haven't and that's the end of it," Thorn said, almost growling as she wondered what in

the world was taking Melog so damn long.

"How much longer are we going to…?"

"I don't know, alright!? I don't know! Melog said they'd get help and to wait here, so we're waiting here!" Thorn snapped back over her shoulder. She hated this, she hated being the one they all looked to for answers. She didn't mean to be a leader of any kind.

When Thorn had returned to the village, she'd taken a beating from a group of warriors led by Chuut, recently arrived back, for being caught even when she'd tried to explain what seemed to be going on. She wanted to say she gave as good as she got but she'd be lying. She'd crawled back out of the village to recuperate by herself and tend to her wounds, mental and physical. A little further up the canyon, she'd found a small indention in the rock with a tiny spring trickling out of it that had enough water for her and the tracks in the sand around the tiny pool showed she had a chance of maybe ambushing something to eat. She wasn't sure how she'd cook it but she figured she wouldn't be moving much anyway any time soon so she'd figure it out when she got hungry.

She didn't have time to get hungry. Bluestone had found her pretty quickly and started tending to Thorn's injuries, setting down a small bundle of food beside Thorn as she worked.

"Chuut and the rest are telling us to leave you alone, that you need to suffer for what you've done," Bluestone had said.

"Then leave," Thorn had replied, wincing as she did from the pain in her side.

Bluestone had tutted at her and reached into her shoulder bag and handed her a couple of pills.

"Take this."

Thorn looked at them on Bluestones hand with suspicion before saying, "What are they?"

"Painkillers."

"I don't need to be…," Thorn started to say and Bluestone cut her off.

"You need to not be hurting. Stop arguing and take them."

Thorn finally took the pills and Bluestone settled on the ground next to her, humming as she watched the stars overhead in the narrow gap of the canyon. Thorn wanted to argue with her, tell her to leave, but she didn't, she just lay on the sand and soon felt the pain recede a little. She found herself listening to the humming and suddenly came awake, to realize she'd been dreaming it and Bluestone was gone. Another, named Dust was in her place.

"You're awake," they said as Thorn moved and then groaned a little.

"What are you doing here?"

"I'm the next watch," Dust said.

"You're going to get into…," Thorn started to say.

"I don't care. You said that the feud was over and it's just… this whole thing is crap," Dust said. "The whole world can't be just fighting and feuds and… you stood up to them."

"No, I didn't," Thorn said.

"Well, you're the leader of this I say."

"I'm not a leader!" Thorn hissed back.

Thorn remembered that as Dust came to stand behind her on the skiff. She didn't want to be some leader but Dust was young, like Thorn, and had been looking for a reason for change for a while. What Thorn hadn't known was that Dust had been talking quietly with people, very quietly and very carefully, for some time. Thorn

had been the catalyst, showing what Chuut and the rest aligned with him stood for and what they could have instead.

Having Melog show up while Dust was there had only helped Dust's argument. A day after Melog and Thorn had watched the Bright Moon contingent pack and leave, Chuut and most of his warriors had left on a raid. Twelve hours later everyone Dust had been talking with knew it was time. They'd packed everything they cared about and left in a line back to the beach. There they'd made a deal with Gila and his group to transport everyone to the Valley of the Lost with their newly acquired skiffs. Thorn had made a count when everyone had arrived in the Valley of the Lost and estimated that at least half the village had left.

Thorn also knew that Chuut would not be happy about it and that had amped up the need to move. Thorn and Dust had negotiated for large scale transportation. That had got them all out to Plumeria, where most of their group was still waiting, and Thorn had packed everyone she could into a public skiff, essentially hijacking it, and took them to Bright Moon. Now she waited to see what Bright Moon would have to say about a skiff full of refugees and even more waiting to come.

Thorn shifted to try and relieve some of the pain she still had, though it started a new growing pain in another place but that had been her lot since she'd taken the beating, and then stood up with a grunt of discomfort as she watched Melog come trotting out of the crowd, a big grin on their face. She stepped off the lower step of the skiff onto the ground as she said, "It took you long enough."

"It took me as long as I needed," Melog said. "I told you to go ahead and get everyone off."

"And if you were wrong, we'd have had a hard time getting everyone back on," Thorn said.

Melog shook their head as Thorn looked up to see Catra, Adora, Speleo, and Tinz making their way up.

"Can you still understand me?" Catra asked, doing her best to ignore everyone staring at her from the skiff.

"Were you truthful about rejecting the feud?" Thorn replied as Speleo began to translate to Adora.

"Ah, so yes, you can and yes, I am," Catra said with a shake of her head. "Why?"

"Then you're part of our people and I'm asking you to help us," Thorn said.

Catra opened her mouth to speak, closed it, opened it again, then shook her head before saying, "What?"

"We have a couple hundred people that need help," Thorn said. When everyone looked towards the skiff, she shook her head. "They're not all on there. This is just the first group. They're young or elderly for the most part."

Catra looked towards the trees and Thorn shook her head again as she said, "They're in Plumeria waiting for us to bring them here."

Speleo stepped forward and said, "Why did you pick here?"

"You mean why here and not Half Moon," Thorn stated.

"Well… yes," Speleo said with a shrug.

"OK, still don't speak Magicat, what is she saying?" Catra said to Thorn.

"She's looking to take us to Half Moon," Thorn said her eyes narrowed.

"OK, I think I've been misunderstood," Speleo said in Bright Moon. "I just was wondering…"

"We will not be your pawns," Thorn said and Speleo sighed.

"What? I'm missing something," Catra said.

"We will not be your pawns either," Thorn said, turning to Catra.

"OK, now I'm really missing something," Catra said, eyeing Dust standing behind Thorn, watching them all. "You came to us."

"And I'm asking that as one of us, you help us, selflessly," Thorn said.

"You wanted to kill me not too long ago," Catra said and then flicked a look over her shoulder as she heard Glimmer and Bow show up.

"Is that a skiff full of Magicats?" Bow asked behind them.

"I'd be more interested in why Thorn seems to be arguing with Catra and Speleo," Glimmer said as she made her way up to stand next to them.

"Are you going to help us or not?" Thorn said to Catra.

"You've hardly given me a chance!" Catra snapped at her as her ears folded back a little before she took a breath and closed her eyes for a moment.

Thorn moved back a little onto her trailing foot and Adora sighed as she heard Tinz translate what was being said. "Tinz, translate for me." Then she looked at Thorn and said, "As She-Ra, I offer my protection to you and your people. I will help you however I can."

Thorn looked at Adora as Catra settled back down a little and said, "Same."

Glimmer was nodding her head as she said, "There's plenty of places in Bright Moon we can settle you in, your pick. The Crown offers it's full support."

"And Half Moon offers any assistance you may need as well," Speleo said as Tinz did her best to translate everything being said.

"We won't be your pawns," Thorn said again, though she seemed to be calming down.

"We have a very robust civil code for helping refugees. I'll do my best to make sure no one takes advantage of you," Bow said with a smile. "I'm sure we can get the whole Princess Alliance to help as well if you don't want to settle in Bright Moon. We'll help you get wherever you decide to go."

"And if you're willing to accept me, well, we'll talk about that but yeah, I'll help you," Catra said.

Dust leaned forward and whispered to Thorn. Catra watched them to see what they were saying to her but it was very quiet and she couldn't catch any of it. Thorn seemed to accept whatever was said and gave a little nod.

"Then deal for us," Thorn said to Catra. "In our best interests."

At first Catra thought it was a mistranslation and that Thorn meant deal with them. Then realized the link through Melog wouldn't have done that.

"You mean deal with them?" Catra said, hooking a thumb over her shoulder at Glimmer and Speleo.

"Yes." Thorn said and Dust nodded as well. "As one of us."

The small group went quiet as Tinz translated and all eyes settled on Catra. She didn't answer for a moment. Adora set a hand on her shoulder but Catra didn't look at her, only reached up to touch Adora's hand for a moment before she stepped forward to Thorn.

"As one of you then," Catra said and took Thorn's hand in her own.

Chapter End Notes

OK, didn't expect this to take a month but I'm still moving along. Slowly, but still moving. Nothing to say other than thank you for reading!

Chapter 51: Chapter Fifty-One - Catra

Chapter Summary

> Catra helps the people of Staed settle in at Bright Moon and gets told something that surprises her.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The night of the first arrival of the Magicats from Staed was unbelievably busy and it just didn't let up in the days to follow. Catra suddenly found herself surrounded by people like her, a thing she had only experienced for brief moments in Half Moon. But where Half Moon had been friendly, though a bit standoffish as she was an outsider, the former residents of Staed folded her in to their ranks for the most part. Glimmer set aside part of a sprawling bit of Crown land just on the outskirts of Bright Moon itself for Staed to settle down into. It was craggy canyon land but full of trees and bushes. The Staed people began building into the stone faces almost immediately while staying in comfortable tents in the meantime as the rest came in from Plumeria. The princesses kicked in and helped out as well as the people of Bright Moon and over time, other people came in to help building, especially ex-Horde members looking for a way to give back.

For the first few days, people were calling it Staed and then someone, noticing Speleo and Tinz mingling and helping, made a crack about how they were from Half Moon and this town was being built around Bright Moon so that the new town must be Quarter Moon. People repeated the joke until it suddenly wasn't a joke and the town of Quarter Moon was born.

About a week in, Catra found herself sitting in a comfortable pile of pillows late in the evening inside one of the first finished cliff houses, listening to several older women talk about her mother.

Thorn was there with Dust and Melog was there so Thorn could translate for Catra.

"You look a lot like her," one old woman named Tritra said.

"Acts a bit like her too," another older woman named Vitchtrol replied.

"What do you mean?" Catra said.

Vitchtrol shrugged as she said, "She was very willful."

"And strong," Praet, another old woman, said.

Tritra grinned as she said, "Absolutely but she wasn't a bully, like some I won't mention."

The three woman made a quick movement from side to side in front of themselves with their left hand fingers crossed over themselves, something Catra had seen some others do when Chuut had been mentioned. It'd take a moment for her to realize it was a gesture to ward off evil and she copied them in this moment. They grinned at her and nodded before Vitchtrol said, "When she first disappeared, we thought it was another village. We were always raiding and so we were always negotiating and taking her captive as well as you would be useful. You were already being considered as a hostage after all, why not both?"

"A hostage?" Catra said softly.

Tritra nodded as she said, "You weren't a good hostage honestly but both leaders were pushing for infants. See, it was pretty often that the peace would be breached and that usually meant the hostages were killed. It was thought that infants would make the peace last longer, that no one would want to kill a baby."

Praet snorted as she said, "Or at least make them think a little harder about it before they did what they were going to do anyway."

"So she took me… ran away with me…," Catra said as she felt things snapping into place.

"To save you," Tritra said. "At least that was her thinking I believe."

"It's not like any of us know," Vitchtrol said. "She didn't consult with us. One day, she's agreeing with the idea, all 'Honor of Staed, do what must be done, my sacrifice is nothing,' and then suddenly, gone."

Praet grinned as she said, "Disappeared pretty good too. Once they realized Crailfish didn't have her, they tried to track her. Never found hair nor claw of her." Then her grin went away. "Of course, we thought she'd come back with you eventually or reach out somehow but…"

Praet shook her head as Tritra said, "When we first heard of you, no one was sure that it was you. Well, you know, YOU. We all thought maybe it was but where was Saz? It's not like we knew a lot back in Staed but when you came to the Valley of the Lost to dig out that ship, we learned a bit more."

"Why didn't anyone reach out?" Catra said, trying to keep the anger out of her voice.

Vitchtrol shrugged as she said, "Well, by that point we'd received a letter saying Saz was dead but most people thought it was a lie because the Council said it was a lie and pushed that. There was the feud as well and then of course, you were a Force Captain in the Horde."

"We might attack everything but we do try and think it through first," Tritra said and Thorn, translating, laughed a little at that. "Oh, Thorn thinks we're funny."

Thorn gave a little head bow as she said, "I apologize, Elder."

"It's alright," Tritra said as she reached over and mussed up Thorn's mane. "You're a good kid."

Thorn didn't translate that but Catra got the gist and tried to hide her grin at Thorn's poorly hidden irritation. Thorn shot her a dirty look but didn't say anything as Catra took a deep breath as a thought occurred to her.

"So, you were pretty sure it was me but you didn't reach out or do anything," Catra said.

Praet and Tritra both looked away as Thorn translated but Vitchtrol just nodded as she said, "That's right. We left you there." Catra started to speak and Vitchtrol went on. "You were powerful. You had the Horde at your command. If you were us, sure you were our enemy, would you have brought yourself to our attention?"

Catra wanted to argue with her, say she would have gone out of her way to find out, but she thought of the times she'd hidden as a small child to avoid having attention brought to her. It brought back another rush of anger, that she'd had to do that at all, but she worked to let it pass. Melog curled up at her side, their mane flickering blue, red, and mixing to purple in places before finally calming down to blue again.

Vitchtrol nodded as she said, "You at least thought it through there. I'd heard you were brilliant but volatile. It's good to see that might not be true."

"It's something I'm working on," Catra said.

Vitchtrol nodded at Thorn and said something and Thorn shot back, "I'm fine."

"What?" Catra said.

"Nothing," Thorn snapped.

"Tell her," Melog responded gently.

Thorn finally huffed and said, "Vitchtrol said that she should take note and follow her cousin's trail."

Vitchtrol nodded as Thorn repeated it and Catra nodded for a moment before she said, "Wait!? Cousin!?"

"You're part of the group now, we're not close blood related or anything but yes, I'm your cousin," Thorn said.

Catra finally asked the question she'd wanted to know.

"Do I have close blood relations left?"

Thorn shook her head as she said, "Your father died before you were born and you didn't have any siblings. Your mother's parents died when she was young and your father was a foundling."

Catra sat back against the pillows and looked out the little window at the shadows being cast by a willow tree on it.

So I'm really alone.

She took a deep breath. She was getting closer to these people but there was no way she was going to cry in front of them. Adora was the only person she could do that in front of and even then it wasn't easy. She knew she needed to work on that but it sure wasn't going to be now.

Melog nudged her and looked at Thorn. The three older women didn't seem to mind waiting for her response but Thorn was staring at her hard.

"You asked," Thorn finally said.

"I know," Catra said and hated herself a little for the catch in her throat. She cleared it as quietly as she could. "I just…"

"You were expecting a big family," Praet said.

Catra looked at her, not hiding the surprise as her ears perked up and she nodded.

"You have one," Tritra said.

"I know," Catra said, feeling a little guilty now. "You all are my family."

Tritra nodded as she said, "No. Well, yes, we are, but I meant your Adora and the queen and her consort as well as the other princesses."

"You're surprised," Vitchtrol said. "If anything, your family has just gotten bigger or did you think you would be rid of us once we were settled?"

Catra hadn't been sure what she'd thought would happen but she realized now she figured they'd want hardly anything to do with her. Sure, maybe she'd still talk to Thorn but she didn't think the rest would. Now, she realized that she had a family.

No, she thought. *Like they said, I already have one. Now it's bigger.*

She had a small idea of how big, though she wasn't sure how to navigate it. She made a mental note to ask Bow. With his many brothers, and their families, Bow definitely had a sharp grasp on large families.

"I dreamed of a family, before I even really knew what it was you know," Catra said.

Praet nodded as she said, "You have it now."

Vitchtrol chuckled as she said, "Goddess help you, you do."

"What does that mean?" Catra said as Thorn chuckled with her.

"I hope you're not a private person," Tritra said.

Praet gave a short little hiss that Catra had found was the equivalent of clucking at someone with their tongue for her people before she said, "Stop trying to scare her!"

Tritra laughed as she said, "You think I can scare *her?"*

"I'm not scared," Catra said as she found herself smiling. She wasn't. She might not know what having these people in her life meant but she was eager to find out she suddenly realized. She reached forward and ruffled Thorn's mane, with Thorn batting her hand away with a growl and a hiss before Catra could do much. "My cousin here has me covered I'm sure."

Chapter End Notes

> What's this!? It didn't take me a month to post again!? I know! Shocking, I know. :) I don't think there's going to be very many chapters left honestly.

Chapter 52: Chapter Fifty-Two - Catra

Chapter Summary

Here we are, at the end.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Chuut finally showed up several weeks after Thorn and company had set up, it was almost a let down. Catra was sitting around with Thorn and some others, conversing in her slowly improving Magicat, when she heard the shouting. She stood up, throwing on her leather jacket she'd started wearing around Quarter Moon because people seemed to relate a little better to Catra, Crimson Waste Gang Leader, for some reason. She figured it was just a transition thing, feeling a little closer to their old home as they settled into the new but she didn't think about that as the whip on her hip thumped against her as she went out the door, just ahead of Melog and Thorn.

Standing in the newly cleared square for the new town, right where the plumbing for the fountain was laid out, ready to be installed, was Chuut with a few people who were obviously fighters. Some of the older women were busy yelling at him to leave while younger people were gathering around with a mixture of scared and defiant looks on their faces.

"You!" Chuut shouted as Catra walked forward. She could feel Thorn fall back a little, her breathing faster and all Catra could remember was the story Thorn had told her of the beating she'd received.

"Was it them?" Catra said, not breaking eye contact with Chuut.

"It was," Thorn said as Chuut shouted out some challenge that Catra didn't really hear as she felt everything go quiet and loose. Melog said something that Catra didn't catch and then she moved, the whip coming off her hip almost of its own accord.

Chuut and his group of five others moved as well, long knives sliding out of sheaths as light caught along their edges.

Then the first balloon hit. Catra stopped in shock when she saw the blue paint spread across Chuut's face followed by multiple other colors as balloon's filled with thick paint splattered across Chuut's group. They all came to a stop as they fought to clear their eyes, mewling sounds escaping their mouths in the sudden confusion of being able to see.

"Reload!" Catra heard and turned to see Dust and some of the other younger Magicat's reaching into bulging bags and pull out the paint balloons. Thorn was looking at Dust with a huge grin on her face and the rest of the crowd had shifted suddenly from fear and anger to laughter as Chuut got his eyes clear, started to shout something and got plastered in his open mouth with a balloon that Dust threw with precision.

Catra coiled her whip back up and hung it off her belt as she sat down on a pile of stones that were waiting to become a wall. Chuut finally finished spitting paint out of his mouth and his eyes cleared but the fight had gone out of his crew, though Catra could still see murderous intent in Chuut's eyes.

"I don't think they're interested in your little vendetta anymore," Catra said as Thorn translated for her.

"You think this will stop me? I have not abandoned my honor," Chuut said before looking at the assembled crowd. "Unlike others!"

Dust started to draw back with another paint balloon when Thorn shook her head as she came forward.

"You fight for the honor of Staed," Thorn said. "We are not Staed any longer."

"You are the people of…," Chuut started to say and Thorn snapped out her claws as she shouted, "No! We are not Staed!"

The other five were started to slink backwards, but Chuut moved forward towards Thorn, growling with this knife out.

"Thorn…," Catra started to say and Thorn shook her head and moved, claws out. Chuut's eyes widened at the claws and stepped back to get out of the way and tripped, causing everyone, including his own people, to laugh.

Thorn stood over him, claws out, ears back, and hissed, "Shall I show you honor?"

The crowd went quiet as Chuut looked around and realized he was all alone. He got up, spit paint on the ground, started to say something, and then just turned and walked off. The last anyone saw of him he was climbing onto one of the public skiffs and flying away.

A year passed. Catra and Adora moved into a small home carved for them just off the town square of Quarter Moon and both were fully involved in the life of the town. A patois of Magicat and Bright Moon had formed with the residents of Quarter Moon and Half Moon, though Adora and Catra both spoke Magicat fluently, and people on both sides were learning the full languages quickly as well.

It was one afternoon that Catra was leaned back in Adora's lap watching the light of the Etherian sky flickering through the leaves overhead as she listened to Thorn and Dust playfully arguing with each other when Lonnie walk into the small courtyard of their home. Catra sat up a little with a smile and then sat the rest of the way up with a frown when she saw Lonnie's face.

"What is it?"

Lonnie sighed as she sat down on the edge of a small pool full of small fish darting back and forth as she pulled out a folder full of paper and held it out to Catra.

"I found this," Lonnie said.

"How in the world are you still finding stuff after three years?" Catra said as she took the folder from her.

"Have you seen the Fright Zone?" Lonnie said. "There's lots of places to hide stuff. And this one, well, this one I believe was meant not to be found."

Catra looked at the title and felt her breath stop for a moment.

Horde Report SAR-25-103

Final Report on Snowtop Pass Operation

(Aleph Squad of the 1st Horde Long Range Scouts and 1st Squad of 1st Infantry Alpha Squadron SAR Ops)

Catra recognized the format. She'd seen enough reports as a Force Captain to recognize the format and she knew SAR was the designation of the Search and Rescue group. It was the Aleph Squad though that really got her.

"This is Saz's squad," Catra said.

Lonnie nodded.

Catra started to open it before stopping and looking at Lonnie.

"Have you read it?"

"Yes."

"And?"

Lonnie took a deep breath as she said, "They're all listed as lost. They recovered all of the members of Alpha Squadron but only

found one member of Aleph."

"So the others could be…," Catra started to say and then stopped, not wanting to go on.

"It's unlikely," Lonnie said. "There's pictures in there that are… well, they got caught in a really ugly blizzard in Snowtop Pass and the skiffs never left."

Catra held the folder in her hand for a moment longer and then held it out to Lonnie.

"Thanks."

Lonnie took the folder from her after a moment as she said, "You sure?"

"Yeah," Catra said as Adora put a comforting hand on her shoulder. "That's the answer of why she never came back."

"She probably wanted to," Adora said gently.

"Probably," Catra said with a sigh before standing up and walking into their home without another word.

Everyone watched and Dust briefly said, "Should someone go…?" before trailing off.

Lonnie and Adora were both shaking their heads as Lonnie said, "Nope. Let her be."

Adora replied, "I'll check on her in a moment." She reached her hand out for the folder and Lonnie handed it off to her.

"That's your copy if you want it," Lonnie said as Adora started to flip through it. Near the front were pictures of the missing squads, taken from their service records, and Adora thought about how much Saz looked like Catra when she was serious. Thorn was looking over her shoulder and Adora moved a little so she could see a bit better.

"She doesn't look like what I expected," Thorn said.

"What did you expect?" Lonnie said.

Thorn shrugged as Dust moved over to take a look. Adora finally flicked through a little more, reading the text describing the operation and flicked back and forth to the supplemental material. She looked away at the images of the squad members that had been found at the pass and closed the folder.

"Yeah, those aren't easy images," Lonnie replied. Then she turned to look towards the house and the rest did the same. Catra walked out with two small duffel bags and tossed one at Adora's feet.

"Are we going somewhere?" Adora said with a confused look.

"Snowtop," Catra replied.

Two days later, Catra, Melog, and Adora stepped off the public skiff in the little town of Snowtop. The mountains soared over their head and a chilly wind nipped at their face. They could see the slightly lower notch through the mountains that made up the pass and all of it was covered in snow. The town itself was a cute place, full of color and incredibly steep roofed buildings. The skiff landed right next to the town square and so the three of them made their way into that in search of lodgings.

"You sure you don't want our friends along?" Adora said.

"Listen, I just… I just want this minimal," Catra said and then forced a smile on her face. "Besides, we haven't had a trip to ourselves in a while."

"So you pick this?" Adora said with a smirk as they headed towards a hostel that was half buried in the ground.

Catra gave a little half chuckle grunt to acknowledge it but mostly she was trying not to notice all the people staring at them as they walked up the hostel's steps to go inside.

"They're just curious about us," Adora said.

"Stop," Catra said as she pulled the door open.

"I didn't look at Melog," Adora said.

"I'm just saying, stop trying to guess my moods," Catra said as they stepped into the small lobby to be met by an older woman with a big smile. Catra flinched a tiny bit, her ears flicking back for a moment at how close the woman was to her. The woman didn't seem to notice as she greeted them.

"Princess Adora and Princess Catra! My name is Tarn and thank you for choosing the Bread and Butter for your stay!"

"OK, not a princess," Catra said and then heard her tone and took a breath and continued a little less confrontationally. "But thank you for greeting us and uh, don't make a big deal of this?"

"Of course," Tarn said with a lowered voice and a little head nod. "Is there anything I can do for you other than your room?"

"Tell us where to go to rent a vehicle?" Adora said.

"What kind?" Tarn asked.

Catra looked at Adora, feeling like putting it into words would somehow jinx the whole thing but she took a breath and said, "Something that can go up the pass."

Tarn's face clouded a little as she said, "I'm not sure you should go. It's still early in the season you know and it's not fully cleared."

"We want to hike the area around the pass," Catra said. "We're well equipped."

Tarn looked at the minimal luggage both of them were carrying with a doubting look but before she could say anything Adora jumped in, "We're getting more stuff while we're here."

"You should get a guide too," Tarn said after a moment's thought. Then after another pause she said, "At least the weather should be on your side for the next few days but still, there's no guarantees."

"Don't people run up the pass on foot?" Catra said.

"At the height of summer and even then, you have to watch out," Tarn said.

"We'll be careful," Adora replied.

Tarn finally shrugged her shoulders as if to say, "Hey, I tried," and showed them to their room. It was a small private room with a narrow bed that the two of them could just fit into. Tarn showed them the bathroom down the hall and finished up by saying, "Sorry about that, we're an older hostel and haven't quite got the en suite bathrooms yet. You get a discount at the cafe next door and the kitchen is always available, just read the posted rules."

Adora was already tossing her bag on the bed and getting it open to start unpacking a few things when Tarn left and Catra sat on one of the two chairs in the room that sat beside a small square table that was hinged to fold up against the wall for more space. She pulled out a data pad and focused on a map that showed the coordinates from the old Horde SAR report. Adora stopped unpacking and sat down across from Catra.

"Do you want to get a guide?" Adora said.

"I mean, we probably should," Catra said. "How we would even know to trust though?"

"I could ask Frosta," Adora said. "This is part of her kingdom, she should know."

Catra made a face as she said, "Maybe not her."

"She's not still mad at you," Adora said. "It's been three years now."

"OK, but I can still feel that punch," Catra said. "And she's not the warmest towards me."

"Are you trying to make an ice princess pun?" Adora replied.

"No, though I'm not opposed to telling her that sometime," Catra said trying to give a little grin that faltered out. "Seriously though, I know she's not a fan."

"You know, the others like you, Glimmer loves you and Frosta is like Glimmer's little sister," Adora said. "She's probably fine with you and just isn't showing it."

Catra grunted and shook her head as she said, "Let's call asking her Plan Z, alright?"

"You mean Plan B?"

"I picked the letter for a reason," Catra said. "Listen, let's just get some gear, talk to some people, come up with a plan. We can plan, it's what we've trained for."

"OK, OK," Adora said. "We'll go look around."

The first place they went was an outdoor store stuffed with old Horde surplus along with some newer equipment. It ended up being the only place as they immediately figured out that everyone had an opinion of how to go up the pass as well as were more than willing to offer help to some of the most recognized people on Etheria.

"I mean, you can go up there right now," someone said. "It's not so bad and if you just use some common sense, you'll be fine."

An older man made a scoffing noise as he said, "Are you kidding me right now? Listen, no offense to you two, but we're still very much in storm season, even if it's towards the end. They could get trapped up there and there's no way SAR could get to them."

A younger teenager shook her head and said, "She's She-Ra!" She looked at Adora and Catra couldn't help but notice the worship in her eyes as she smiled at her. "You could handle a storm, right!?"

Adora blushed at the attention as she said, "I mean, maybe, but, uh, I want to still be careful."

The younger teenager's friend nudged her as she said, "Why don't you go up there with them? You got your snow buggy after all."

The younger teenager blushed furiously and muttered something that sounded like, "Shut up, shut up, shut up, shut up..." and Catra took pity on her and changed the focus by speaking up.

"Listen, we're not in a rush. We're just following up on some old rumors and we're OK hanging around a little."

The older man sat forward a little as he said, "What rumors?"

Catra immediately regretted speaking up and looked down at Melog who looked up at her with an expression that said Catra was on her own. Adora came to her rescue though as she said, "That the pass is haunted."

This caused a chuckle to go around the crowd. Catra noticed the older man didn't really join in on the chuckle though and noted she wanted to talk to him privately.

"Come on," the owner of the shop said. "We've all heard about that. Weird voices on the wind, strange beings, and that sort. It's nothing like that. It's maybe some bears combined with oxygen deprivation combined and hypothermia. There's plenty to be scared of up there without invoking the supernatural."

"I mean, it's not like it's not possible," Adora said.

"Like Alwyn?" someone said from the back of the little crowd to a round of laughter.

"OK," Adora said, rolling her eyes but smiling, "in my defense, it was super creepy at the moment."

"It can't possible be that bad up there," a woman said who was sitting on a pile of old Horde blankets. Catra wondered how she was managing, considering they were basically sandpaper in her opinion. "After all, that one hermit lives up there."

"You mean… crap, what's their name?" the owner said her face twisting a little in annoyance as she tried to remember and failed. "The hermit-y one, right?"

The woman nodded as she said, "Yeah, them. They've been up there for years. I mean, damn, I think they were up there while the war was still going on, I remember hearing about them when I was a little kid."

The old man spoke up and said, "OK, but that one is from mountain stock. Their people are adapted to high mountains, so maybe don't use them for an example."

"Maybe we can hire them then?" Catra said. "I mean, if they know the area. Does anyone know how to get in contact?"

The owner shook her head as she said, "Naw, I doublt they'd for that. They hardly ever come to town."

"Grumpy as Hordak without his makeup too," the woman on the blankets replied. Both Catra and Adora shot her a look, wondering if she was ex-Horde because of the comment, a phrase some of the troopers said when they were feeling daring and funny. "No, stop looking at me, you don't know me. My partner is ex, I just picked up the phrase from them."

She was grinning when she said it and Adora almost asked who her partner was, that maybe she knew them, when someone came in with mail for the owner. Something about that seemed to puncture the conversation and people began to drift apart and leave the store. The old man left and Catra turned to Adora to whisper, "Get us outfitted, I've got to talk to that guy."

Adora agreed and Catra went out the door, Melog on her heels, after the man. He was only a little down the street when he saw her coming and stopped under an awning on a local tailors shop.

"I thought you might want to talk to me," he said. "You kind of were eyeballing me."

"I just have a question," Catra said.

"Ask," the old man said, almost rudely.

"Why weren't you laughing with the others about the haunted pass thing?"

The old man sighed as he said, "Listen, I used to go up and down that pass all the time. Sometimes for work, hauling stuff into the Northern Reach, sometimes for recreation, but I always, and I mean always, leave an offering at the shrine at the entry to the pass."

"So you think something is up there," Catra said as Melog sat down at her side.

The old man shrugged as he started to say something and then stopped. He looked towards the pass, even though it wasn't visible because it was behind the building they were standing in front of, and then finally turned back to Catra.

"They can laugh all they want but I wouldn't go up there without making an offering," the old man said. "Whether that's silly or not, that's up to you but I'd at least act like you mean it if you listen to me."

"You think it's that hermit?" Catra said.

The old man shook his head as he said, "No, it's not them. I don't know why they're living up there but this has been going on longer than they've been up there."

Catra kicked at a little bit of slush on the ground before she said, "Could you tell me where they are?"

The old man nodded as he said, "Sure. Won't do any good if they don't want to talk but guess they're as good a place to start as any."

Three days later found Catra and Adora stepping out of the tracked truck that they'd rented and filled with supplies that they both thought were a bit overkill but multiple locals had insisted were a necessity if they were going to spend an extended time up the pass. In front of them, on a little turn off from the well made road, was a cairn of rocks stacked a little taller than they were. It was covered in various items, like dolls, glass marbles, coins, pictures of people faded to almost nothing as well as pictures that seemed to have been printed just that day, clothing, and outdoor gear. Sticking out the top of it was a pole with a large glass orb settled on the top. The glass was clear but picked up the colors of the Etherian sky, particularly sharp and clear at this altitude, and so seemed to flicker with colors. The little clearing it was in was surrounded by evergreen trees except for one side that looked towards Snowtop mountain and the top of the pass.

"So, uh, now what?" Adora said.

"Altai," Catra said, mentioning the name of the old man who'd showed them where the hermit lived, "said we need to put something on the shrine. It can be anything, even a rock off the ground, but we need to do it with intent."

"Intent of what?"

"I'm guessing just like we're taking this seriously."

"They race skiffs up this thing in summer."

"And I assume the racers are intent when they visit this."

Adora gave a little snicker but stepped forward. She rummaged in her pocket for a moment, approached the shrine, and placed a

coin on top of a rock at about head level. She stood there for a moment before stepping back.

"Your turn."

Catra didn't know what to put there but stepped up anyway. She stood there for several minutes, aware of Adora starting to shift behind her as she began to get a little bored before Catra finally leaned forward with an extended claw and scratched three letters into the shrine. The stone was tough but Catra managed before nodding at the shrine and stepping back.

"You think that'll count?" Catra said.

"You did seem intent," Adora replied. "I think we're covered."

Catra looked back at the shrine for a moment and then climbed up into the truck and started up the pass. They drove for several hours, passing up through trees into a realm of low scrubby bushes and stones with snow sitting in shadows. They could see the town of Snowtop far below and the peak of Snowtop seemed to loom over them while mountains ran away from them in all other directions.

They missed the tiny path that led up and away from the road that Altai had said was the way to the hermit's cabin and had to make a difficult turn at a rare flat spot on the road and come back to it. They almost missed it a second time, it wasn't very obvious but they finally turned onto the path, barely wide enough for their truck, and went up about a hundred feet before it dead ended into a single footpath.

"Well, I guess we walk," Adora said.

"Glee," Catra said with a little laugh.

They got full packs out of the back of the cargo box and pulled them on along with some extra clothes. The wind was whipping around them and even without it, it was much colder at the altitude they were at compared to where they'd started. They

started walking and within feet they both realized just how much higher they were.

"OK, yeah, it's thin up here," Adora said, taking a deep breath.

"It shouldn't be far," Catra said, breathing deep herself. "It'll be easier coming back.'

"Keep telling ourselves that," Adora said before they both pushed on.

It was almost another hour, even though they didn't cover very far, but the path was steep and the air was thin. It was early afternoon as they walked into a flat area with a small frozen lake and little stone hut up against the shore. The front of the hut had what was obviously a little living area, with a stone fireplace and a bench in front of it, though both had snow on them. The view was absolutely breathtaking but they were both looking at the cabin, wondering if anyone was there.

"Hello!?" Adora finally shouted out and the noise made them both jump a little.

"Want an air horn too?" Catra said as Melog circle around her legs.

"Well, what do you want…," Adora started to say when they both heard a voice from the cabin.

"No visitors!"

They looked at each other before Adora shouted back, "We're looking for a guide! Can you help us!?"

"No! Visitors!"

"I don't think they want visitors," Catra said.

"What was your first clue?" Adora said as she kicked the ground a little before she noticed behind the cabin an object covered with a

tarp and snow. Judging from the profile, they were pretty sure it was an old Horde skiff. "I've got an idea. Hello!? Can we at least rent your skiff!?"

There was silence for a few minutes before the front door came flying open and a satyr came storming out which they did quite well, even with a limp. They were dressed in a motley collection of old Horde cold weather gear and handmade clothing but Catra and Adora both saw the stun baton in their hand and they began to separate a little as Melog went bounding off into the low brush to circle behind the satyr.

"Maybe we should have left," Adora said quietly.

Catra was nodding as she pulled her snow glasses up and pulled the scarf down so she could be more easily seen as she said, "Hey! No need for that! We'll leave you alone!"

Then they both stopped moving as they saw the satyr freeze for a moment, then drop the baton, and sit down heavily on their doorstep.

Snick was not having a good day. They'd woke up to the stove having gone out which meant it was bitter cold in the little hut, their morning wash up had been freezing cold, their leg had been throbbing a bit, and to top it off, they were coming to the end of their food and knew they'd have to go into Snowtop soon, something they didn't exactly enjoy. Then they'd heard the people coming up the pass, then heard them coming up the trail, and they'd sighed and prepared for a round of, "But we're different! We want to talk with the Hermit!"

Then Snick had gone storming outside and one of the peple had pulled down her scarf and Snick was sure that they were face to face with the ghost of their dead friend Saz.

"You alright?" Adora said as she pulled up her snow glasses as well and pulled down the scarf she was wearing.

Then Snick made the connection. Even as isolated as they were, they'd heard of She-Ra and they'd heard of Catra. And then they wished it'd been Saz's ghost instead as they began to weep.

"Shit, making an old person cry was not on my list today," Catra said as she cautiously stepped forward. "Hey, what's going on? Do you need help?"

Snick took a moment to stop the weeping, took a deep breath, and said, "You're hear trying to find out what happened to Aleph squad of the 1st HLRS Squadron aren't you?"

Catra slowly nodded as she said, "How do you know that?"

"I'm Corproal Snick of Aleph squad," Snick said before taking a deep breath. "I'm the only surviving member."

It was Catra's turn to sit down now as Adora came up behind her and put a hand on her shoulder. Melog came out of the brush and laid their head in her lap. Catra and Snick stared at each other for a long time before Snick finally spoke up.

"You look so much like her."

"I know," Catra replied quietly.

There was another prolonged silence before Snick spoke again.

"You want to know what happened, why we never came back for you."

Catra nodded as everything became difficult to see for a moment as tears pooled in her eyes. She scrambled to wipe them clear as Snick started to slowly speak.

"We had big plans to come back for you and... well, start over. There's so much to say but she never stopped thinking about you. I want you to know that, OK? Only her death stopped her from coming back for you, I need you to understand that."

Catra had tears streaming down her face now as she nodded. She tried to say something but found she couldn't speak at first. She swallowed the lump in her throat before finally saying, "What happened? Why didn't you tell me?"

Snick flinched a little as they said, "We went on a patrol, recon, of the town. It was a bad idea." The sentence was said in such a deadpan way, that Catra couldn't help but give a half-laugh, understanding exactly what he meant from her own time in the war. Snick gave a little nod at her and went on. "We were going to establish a spot with all the equipment we'd managed to sneak out and come back for you and then bail. Instead..."

Snick went quiet and Adora said, "We don't have to..."

Snick gave little hand gesture to cut her off before saying, "Yes, we do have to. The weather turned bad and when the weather turns bad up here, you better be in good shelter. We thought we had that but... well, we lost all of the squad we'd brought with us and our commander, Kit, in hours. Your mom and her partner were almost part of that but they... they survived."

Snick was crying quietly and wiped the tears off their face absentmindedly, like they cried enough that it wasn't even something they thought about anymore.

"You said she... you know," Catra said.

Snick nodded as they said, "Yes. We tried to get out. We were going to surrender and then see if we could talk the Princesses into coming in after you. We found our skiffs had been hit by an avalanche, not a big one but enough to smash them up. We couldn't get a radio working so we headed down the pass to Snowtop, to surrender."

Snick went quiet again as Catra ran her hand down Melog's head, over and over, waiting to see what came next. For a moment, she thought they wouldn't keep speaking before they took a deep breath.

"We didn't make it far. Her partner, Basco, was out front going down a slope when she slipped. The ground had lots of new snow on it, it set off an avalanche. We weren't roped up because of the danger of avalanche, but Saz...," Snick took a deep breath and fought back a laughing sob. "She went right after her. Didn't even think about it, I think. Brave. She was so brave." Snick swallowed and went on. "They were both grabbed by the slide and slammed into rocks at the bottom of the slope. Basco was gone, Saz... I tried. She held on but..."

"It was just you," Adora said gently.

"Horde SAR didn't show up until later," Snick said. "And I couldn't go down to Snowtop alone for help because she wouldn't have... well, she didn't anyway."

"And you stayed here," Catra said and though she didn't mean to, the tone had a sharp edge of accusation.

Snick looked at her, their eyes staring straight through her as they said, "No. I buried them, fixed a skiff up as best I could, and came for you a little while later with a few mercenaries I had talked into making a run in with me under false pretenses. The guards at the Fright Zone broke my leg and I barely got back out. I had already found out that the Princess Council didn't exist at that point for the most part and I... I gave up. I stayed here with my friends."

Catra was about to ask what friends they were talking about when she realized what they meant.

"Is she... can you show me where?"

Snick nodded.

"We'll go in the morning."

The next morning found them tromping down the hillside away from the little hut. Neither Adora nor Catra had slept well the night before. The wind had picked up and they both had woken up at various times of the night, sure they'd heard something just

outside their tent that they'd pitched in the lee of Snick's hut. Melog hadn't slept at all, staying up all night looking towards the door of the tent, their soft glow the only light as clouds streamed over the field.

Snick hadn't spoken much but didn't need to do so. It wasn't a long walk before they were at a small meadow below their hut. A little waterfall was frozen as it ran into a small pool before it ran off again downhill. Snick made their way over to a little circle of trees, barely taller than they were, and motioned them both over. Inside the circle was a single mound of stones and Snick stepped forward to place their hand on it, holding it there for a long moment.

"Is this...?" Catra said but couldn't quite finish.

"It's both of them," Snick said. "The ground is hard and... I thought they'd have liked that."

Snick straightened up and stepped back. The three stood in silence for a good long time, no one quite sure what to say. After all this time, Catra had an answer. It wasn't a good one, it wasn't one that made her feel fulfilled and satisfied, but it was the only one that was and she found it didn't hurt as bad as she thought it would.

"Could you... is there anything to tell me about her?"

Snick gave a sad smile as they said, "There's so much to tell you about her. They were my best friends, her and Basco and Kit, and... there's just so much."

Catra found herself feeling jealous of Snick as she realized they knew her mother in a way she never would, in fact knew her at all since Catra didn't have any memories of Saz. Then she saw the look on Snick's face as they looked at the pile of stones and knew that while she might be jealous, she couldn't be angry.

Catra stepped forward to kneel down beside the stones. She tried to think of something to say but words failed her. Anything that

would have mattered was years in the past and whatever was under those stones couldn't respond to her. Melog sat on their haunches beside her, leaning in a little in comfort, and Catra put her arm around them to hug them tight for a moment before standing up with a sigh. Adora put her arm around her and gave her a hug.

"I... I forgot something," Snick said after they'd hugged for a minute. They both turned to look at them, as they rummaged inside their coat. "I've been carrying this for so long that I can't believe I forgot and didn't give it to you yesterday."

Snick came out with a small stuffed mouse. Catra flinched back for a moment and Snick gave a sad smile.

"Well at least you didn't start screaming," they said.

"What is it? I mean, it's a toy but...?" Catra replied.

"It's yours. You used to play with it all the time," Snick said with as they pulled it back. "One night, you just freaked out over it, none of us could figure out what was up, so I held onto it, figured you might want it again."

"And you've had it this whole time?"

Snick nodded as they turned it over and looked at it.

"Yep, this whole time. Honestly, I never thought I'd give it to you and it was just a memory to remember by," Snick said as they placed a hand on the grave. Then they looked Catra in the eye. "But it's yours."

Snick held it out again and Catra carefully took it. She held it, feeling a bit anxious as she still didn't like mice but she was hoping she'd get some feeling, some memory from it. Nothing came about though. Then she looked up and saw Snick watching her and the look on their face said it all.

"It's not mine, not anymore."

She handed the toy back to Snick who took it from her.

"You sure?"

"I'm sure."

Snick wiped at their eyes and tucked the toy back into their pocket. They all stood in awkwardness for a few moments before Adora spoke up.

"Could you... maybe tell us something about her?"

"Like what?" Snick said.

Adora shrugged but Catra said, "Anything."

Snick smiled and began to talk, slowly at first but soon they were telling funny stories, daring stories, and sweet stories about Saz and the rest of Aleph squad. Standing next to the graves, Catra felt like Saz was almost alive for her, for a brief moment. In the early afternoon, they said their good-byes to the grave and began their climb back to the hut.

At the hut, the stories continued, growing out to include Catra and Adora and their stories, including before the war, during the war, and everything after. It rolled long into the night, the three of them sitting close in the hut laughing, and sometimes crying, but sharing like they were old friends.

The next morning, as they stood in front of the hut, Snick said, "Thank you. I haven't remembered them like that for a long time."

"Thank you for telling me," Catra said. "I wish I could have known her."

"Me too," Snick said with a sigh. "It... yeah, me too."

Catra wasn't sure what they had been about to say but she let it go.

"We're going to head home," Catra said after they stood around.

"You're always welcome to come," Adora said.

Snick seemed surprised, Catra did as well.

"I...," Snick said and looked downhill towards the path to the grave. Then they shook their head. "No. This is my home now. I couldn't leave them."

"Is this what they wanted for you?" Adora said, remembering the stories from the night before.

Snick shook their head as they said, "No, it's not but you know, I don't mind it so much, I like the quiet and while they're not here, it's still..."

Catra nodded as she replied, "I get it."

Snick smiled as they said, "And it's not like I can't take the old skiff and catch the public one to come see you, if that's alright."

"Of course," Catra said. "If the hermit doesn't mind, we can do the same."

Snick laughed as they said, "You know, I never set out to be the hermit but I guess it kind of suits me but yeah, I don't mind. Bring those two you kept talking about next time, Glimmer and Bow."

"Deal," Catra said and held her hand out to shake only to be surprised as Snick pulled her into a hug. After the brief moment of startle was over though, she hugged them right back.

Chapter End Notes

It has been about sixteen months since I started this story. It was supposed to be a quick story about Catra and her mom. It obviously did not turn out that way. It's been a journey to

write though! I usually write big stories with a good sized buffer of already written material so something happens, I can just keep posting a chapter a week for a while without worrying.

That didn't happen with this one really. I had a bit of a buffer but it went out the window and I started posting only about once a month or so. Medical issues, which I've talked about elsewhere in the notes and don't feel like re-visiting, really didn't help either.

Now, as is my tradition, I'm going to talk about things that almost happened in the fic but I didn't do or things that came out of nowhere. First, Thorn. She wasn't even thought about but all of a sudden, there she was in the story! I originally thought she was going to be kind of star-struck by Catra but when I was writing her I realized, no, she's going to be a pain in the ass... like Catra. Her showing up actually changed the whole Crimson Waste arc. I had intended to have more in Staed that didn't happen, like Catra actually getting to see the place Saz was from. There's a wall in Staed I never talked about that has the paw prints of every citizen that's lived there going back for generations and I really wanted to have that but it didn't happen. That's alright, I like the way it went.

As to Saz, I almost had it where she lived. I went back and forth on it and you can see me leaving it open in the story, it's not subtle. I just didn't though. In the end, I wanted that bittersweet meeting with Snick instead. I feel bad, I really wanted Saz and Basco to have a happily ever after but so it goes. Catra not taking the mouse toy was something that came out of nowhere as well, I intended to have her take it but that didn't come about. After all, she doesn't remember it, it's just a toy of an animal she doesn't like now. It means way, way more to Snick.

Anyway, thank you for your patience with me as I worked through this. I've said many times that I write for myself but I

post for you so thank you for giving me a reason to post and for reading my stories.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!